Finance Career Playbook

Practical, Hands-On, Job-Ready — India-first + Global

Real formulas, queries, entries & tools — closing the gap between what an MBA teaches and what finance employers pay for

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The education-vs-industry gap, quantified

What it is & where it's used

An MBA (or B.Com, or CA Intermediate) certifies that you *understand* finance. A payroll certifies that you can *produce* finance work — a reconciled ledger, a filed GST return, a working three-statement model, a clean variance report — by a deadline, unsupervised, in the tools the company already runs.

Those are different products. The gap between them is what this whole book is about. It shows up in every finance/accounts/tax seat you might target:

Role	What college trained	What the job actually measures
Accounts Payable / AR executive	Journal-entry theory, accounting standards	Speed of 3-way match, Tally/ERP entry accuracy, vendor recon
GST / Tax associate	Sections of the CGST Act	Filing GSTR-1/3B on the portal, ITC reconciliation (2B vs books)
FP&A / Finance analyst	NPV, IRR formulas	Excel modelling, variance decks, pulling actuals from an ERP
Data-heavy finance / MIS	Ratio analysis	SQL to extract, Power BI/DAX to present, Python to automate
Audit associate	Auditing standards	Sampling in Excel, tick-and-tie, documenting workpapers

Every one of these is a *doing* skill layered on top of the theory you already have. Employers do not pay for the theory. They pay for the output.

The gap: why companies want this (and college didn't teach it)

College is optimised for a written exam graded on *conceptual correctness*. Industry is optimised for *repeatable, auditable output under a deadline*. Five concrete gaps result:

1. **Tools.** No MBA syllabus makes you fast in Excel, Tally, SAP, the GST portal, SQL, or Power BI. Firms assume you already are. You are not.
2. **Speed & unaided delivery.** Exams give you 3 hours and a clean question. Jobs give you a messy export, a 5 pm deadline, and no answer key. The bar is "get it right the first time without asking."
3. **Data plumbing.** Real numbers live in ERPs and CSV dumps, not in a textbook table. Nobody taught you `VLOOKUP` / `XLOOKUP`, pivot tables, or a `JOIN`. A ₹40-crore reconciliation is a lookup problem, not a theory problem.
4. **Documentation & audit trail.** "Show your working" in an exam is worth marks; in a job it is a legal and audit requirement. You must leave a trail a reviewer can follow.
5. **Communication.** A 40-mark essay is never asked for. A one-slide "here's why margin dropped 180 bps" is asked for constantly.

The punchline: **"what you can do" beats the degree** because the degree is a *filter* (it gets your CV read) while demonstrable skill is the *decision*. Two candidates with the same MBA are separated entirely by who can open Excel and build the model live.

What "proficient" looks like

The concrete, unaided bar an employer tests for:

- Open a raw ERP/bank CSV and reconcile it to the books in **under 30 minutes** with `XLOOKUP` + a pivot, flagging every mismatch.
- Build a **3-statement model** where the balance sheet balances and a single driver (sales growth) flows through all three statements without hardcoding.
- File **GSTR-3B** on the portal and reconcile **ITC in books vs GSTR-2B**, explaining every difference.
- Write a **SQL query** with a `JOIN` and `GROUP BY` to answer "revenue by region by month" from a transactions table.
- Pass **journal entries** for accruals, prepaid, depreciation and a GST invoice — with correct Dr/Cr — cold.
- Turn a 50,000-row export into a **Power BI / pivot dashboard** with a YoY-growth measure.

If you can do these unaided, you are ahead of most fresh MBAs and many experienced hires.

Hands-on: how to actually do it

Excel — the reconciliation lookup (replace VLOOKUP forever):

```
=XLOOKUP(A2, Bank[Ref], Bank[Amount], "NOT IN BANK", 0)
```

Then flag mismatches vs the books:

```
=IF(ROUND(BookAmt - XLOOKUP(A2,Bank[Ref],Bank[Amount],0),2)=0,"OK","CHECK")
```

Aggregate for a quick summary without a pivot:

```
=SUMIFS(Ledger[Amount], Ledger[Region], "South", Ledger[Month], "Apr")
```

SQL — revenue by region by month from a transactions table:

```
SELECT region,
       DATE_FORMAT(txn_date,'%Y-%m') AS month,
       SUM(amount)                   AS revenue
FROM   sales_txns
WHERE  txn_date >= '2025-04-01'
GROUP  BY region, DATE_FORMAT(txn_date,'%Y-%m')
ORDER  BY region, month;
```

ITC-style reconciliation as a `LEFT JOIN` (books vs portal):

```sql
SELECT b.invoice_no, b.itc AS books_itc, g.itc AS portal_itc,
       (b.itc - COALESCE(g.itc,0)) AS diff
FROM   books_itc b
LEFT   JOIN gstr2b g ON b.invoice_no = g.invoice_no
WHERE  b.itc <> COALESCE(g.itc,0);
```

Python — automate a monthly reconciliation (pandas):

```python
import pandas as pd

books = pd.read_excel("books.xlsx")
bank  = pd.read_csv("bank_statement.csv")

merged = books.merge(bank, on="ref", how="outer",
                     suffixes=("_book", "_bank"), indicator=True)
merged["diff"] = merged["amount_book"].fillna(0) - merged["amount_bank"].fillna(0)

unmatched = merged[(merged["_merge"] != "both") | (merged["diff"].abs() > 0.01)]
unmatched.to_excel("exceptions.xlsx", index=False)
print(f"{len(unmatched)} exceptions of {len(merged)} rows")
```

DAX — a YoY growth measure in Power BI:

```
Revenue YoY % =
VAR ThisYr = [Total Revenue]
VAR LastYr = CALCULATE([Total Revenue], DATEADD('Date'[Date], -1, YEAR))
RETURN DIVIDE(ThisYr - LastYr, LastYr)
```

TallyPrime — record a purchase with GST (click-path): `Gateway of Tally → Vouchers → F9 (Purchase) → select Party → select Purchase ledger → pick Stock item → Tally auto-computes CGST/SGST from the GST ledgers → Ctrl+A to save.`

GST portal — file GSTR-3B: `www.gst.gov.in → Login → Services → Returns → Returns Dashboard → select period → GSTR-3B "Prepare Online" → fill 3.1 outward tax & 4 eligible ITC → Save → Proceed to Payment → offset liability → File with EVC/DSC.`

Journal entries — the ones you'll pass cold:

Transaction	Dr	Cr	Amount (₹)
Purchase of goods with GST (18%)	Purchases 1,00,000 / Input CGST 9,000 / Input SGST 9,000	To Creditor	1,18,000
Salary accrued, unpaid	Salary Expense	To Salary Payable	2,50,000
Prepaid insurance (paid)	Prepaid Insurance	To Bank	60,000
Monthly depreciation	Depreciation	To Accumulated Depreciation	12,500

Worked example / mini-project

Reproduce this in one sitting. You run accounts for a small trading firm. April sales ledger has 6 invoices; the bank shows 5 receipts.

Invoice	Book amount (₹)	Bank receipt (₹)
INV-001	1,18,000	1,18,000
INV-002	2,36,000	2,36,000
INV-003	59,000	59,000
INV-004	94,400	—
INV-005	1,77,000	1,77,000
INV-006	47,200	47,200

Step 1 — put invoices in column A, book amounts in B, bank data in a `Bank` table. In C2:

```
=XLOOKUP(A2, Bank[Inv], Bank[Amt], "NOT RECEIVED", 0)
```

Step 2 — status in D2:

```
=IF(C2="NOT RECEIVED","OUTSTANDING",IF(ROUND(B2-C2,2)=0,"OK","DIFF"))
```

Step 3 — totals: `=SUM(B2:B7)` gives billed **₹7,31,600**; `=SUMIF(D2:D7,"OK",B2:B7)` gives collected **₹6,37,200**. Outstanding = **₹94,400** (INV-004).

Step 4 — the finance answer: collection efficiency = `=6,37,200/7,31,600` = **87.1%**, one debtor (INV-004) is unpaid. You just did in five minutes what a "reconciliation" job title exists to do all month. Extend it: 500 invoices, same two formulas, and INV-004's GST of ₹14,400 is stuck ITC you'd chase in GSTR-2B.

How it's tested

Companies almost never test theory alone. Expect:

- **Timed Excel test (30-45 min):** given a raw CSV, "reconcile these two sheets and give me collection % and the exceptions list." Lookups, `SUMIFS`, a pivot, and IF-logic. Speed is scored.

- **SQL screen:** "write a query for top-5 customers by revenue this quarter." (`GROUP BY … ORDER BY … LIMIT 5` .)
- **Case / "close the books":** a trial balance with 8 adjustments — pass the entries, produce P&L and balance sheet.
- **Modelling round (FP&A):** build or extend a 3-statement or DCF model live; they watch your cell logic.
- **Interview questions:** "Walk me through the three statements and how they link." / "What's the entry for accrued expense?" / "How would you reconcile ITC?" / "Depreciation rises ₹100 — what happens to cash?" (Answer: net income down by 100×(1−tax), cash *up* by the tax shield since depreciation is non-cash.)

Common mistakes & how pros avoid them

- **`VLOOKUP` with approximate match** silently returns wrong numbers. Pros use `XLOOKUP`, or `VLOOKUP( … ,FALSE)` at minimum.
- **Hardcoding numbers into model formulas.** A pro drives everything from a labelled assumptions block so one input change flows everywhere.
- **A balance sheet that doesn't balance** and "plugging" it. Pros build a `Assets − (Liab+Equity)` check cell that must read zero.
- **Reconciling on amount alone.** Two invoices of ₹59,000 net to zero difference but are the wrong match. Pros key on a unique ID (invoice/ref no.).
- **No audit trail.** Pros leave source, formula, and date so a reviewer reproduces the number without asking.
- **Filing GSTR-3B before reconciling 2B.** Over-claimed ITC gets reversed with interest. Pros reconcile books-vs-2B first.
- **Float comparison** (`=` on decimals). Wrap in `ROUND( … ,2)` — always.

Learn-it roadmap & resources

Realistic time-to-proficiency, part-time, from an MBA/CA-Inter base:

Skill	To job-ready	Resource
Excel (lookups, pivots, IF)	3-4 weeks	ExcelJet, Chandoo.org (free); Microsoft Excel docs
Financial modelling	6-8 weeks	CFI FMVA (paid), Breaking Into Wall Street; Aswath Damodaran (free, YouTube)
SQL	3-4 weeks	SQLBolt, Mode SQL Tutorial (free); LeetCode DB
Power BI + DAX	4-6 weeks	Microsoft Learn (free); SQLBI.com for DAX
Python (pandas)	4-6 weeks	Kaggle "Pandas" micro-course (free)
Tally + GST	3-4 weeks	Tally Education (TallyPrime), CBIC GST portal help

Certifications that actually move a CV: **Microsoft Office Specialist – Excel**, **CFI FMVA**, **Tally Certification (TallyPrime)**, **Microsoft PL-300 (Power BI)**. Sequence for an India accounts/tax role: Excel → Tally+GST →

SQL/Power BI. For FP&A/analyst: Excel → modelling → SQL. Build a public portfolio (one reconciliation, one model, one dashboard) — it beats any certificate in the interview.

Quick-reference

Need	Use
Look up a value	`=XLOOKUP(key, lookup_col, return_col, "NA", 0)`
Conditional sum	`=SUMIFS(sum, crit_rng1, c1, crit_rng2, c2)`
Match check	`=IF(ROUND(a-b,2)=0,"OK","CHECK")`
SQL group	`SELECT dim, SUM(x) FROM t GROUP BY dim ORDER BY 2 DESC`
SQL reconcile	`LEFT JOIN … WHERE a.v <> COALESCE(b.v,0)`
Pandas reconcile	`df1.merge(df2, on="key", how="outer", indicator=True)`
YoY in DAX	`DIVIDE([X]-CALCULATE([X],DATEADD(Date,-1,YEAR)), …)`
GST purchase entry	Dr Purchases + Dr Input CGST/SGST → Cr Creditor
Accrual entry	Dr Expense → Cr Payable
GST rate (standard)	18% = 9% CGST + 9% SGST (intra-state)
Balance check	`Assets - (Liabilities + Equity) = 0`
Golden rule	Debit what comes in / expenses; Credit what goes out / income

The Finance Role Map

What it is & where it's used

"Finance" on a job portal is a dozen different jobs wearing one label. A tax analyst and an M&A banker share almost no daily tools. Before you can build skills (the rest of this book), you need a map: who does what, what it pays, and how you get in. This chapter is that map.

The core split is **buy-side vs sell-side vs corporate vs assurance**:

- **Corporate finance** (inside a company): Accounting, Tax, FP&A, Treasury, Product Control. You keep the company's own books, forecasts, and cash.
- **Sell-side** (advises/intermediates): Investment Banking (IB), Equity Research (ER). You sell deals, advice, and coverage.
- **Buy-side** (invests capital): PE/VC, asset management, hedge funds. You deploy money to earn returns.
- **Assurance & control**: External Audit, Internal Audit, Credit, Risk. You verify, lend against, and constrain.

Every role below hires in India (Mumbai, Bengaluru, Gurugram, Hyderabad GCCs) and globally. Your MBA + CA-Inter combination is a strong fit for Accounting, Tax, FP&A, Credit, Audit, and Product Control immediately, and a stepping stone into IB/ER.

The gap: why companies want this (and college didn't teach it)

College teaches you to *describe* a balance sheet. Employers pay you to *build, defend, and act on one under a deadline*. The specific gaps:

College taught	Job actually needs
Ratio definitions	A working 3-statement model that ties out
"Depreciation reduces profit"	The actual Dr/Cr entry in Tally, GST implications
Portfolio theory	Pulling 2M transaction rows in SQL and reconciling
"Tax is 30%"	Filing GSTR-3B, computing MAT, TDS mismatch in 26AS
One right answer	Judgement under ambiguity, defended in an interview

The role map closes the *orientation* gap: MBAs routinely apply to the wrong role, quote the wrong pay band, and fail interviews because they can't name what the desk does hour-to-hour. Knowing the map is itself a screening filter recruiters use.

What "proficient" looks like

A job-ready candidate can, unaided:

1. **Name any role's core deliverable** — "ER analysts publish an initiation report with a target price and a DCF; FP&A owns the monthly variance deck."
2. **Quote a realistic pay band** for their city and level (not a glassdoor fantasy).
3. **Map their own skills to 2-3 target roles** and articulate the entry path.

4. **Pass the role-specific technical screen** — a modelling test for IB, a books-close case for accounting, a SQL screen for product control.

The bar is *specificity*. "I like markets" fails. "I want equity research covering Indian banks because I can already read an RBI-reported NIM and build a provisioning model" passes.

Hands-on: how to actually do it

Below is each major role with its core deliverable, entry path, and a concrete artifact you'd produce.

Accounting — records transactions, closes books, files financials.

```
' Example journal: sale of ₹1,00,000 goods + 18% GST
Dr Debtors (Trade Receivables)      1,18,000
   Cr Sales                                  1,00,000
   Cr Output CGST                                9,000
   Cr Output SGST                                9,000
```

Entry path: B.Com/CA-Inter → Accounts Executive → Assistant Manager.

Tax — direct (income tax, TDS, MAT) + indirect (GST). Deliverable: filed GSTR-3B/1, Form 26AS reconciliation.

```
-- reconcile GST purchase register to GSTR-2B
SELECT p.gstin, SUM(p.itc) AS book_itc, SUM(b.itc) AS portal_itc,
       SUM(p.itc) - SUM(b.itc) AS mismatch
FROM purchase_register p
LEFT JOIN gstr2b b ON p.invoice_no = b.invoice_no
GROUP BY p.gstin
HAVING ABS(SUM(p.itc) - SUM(b.itc)) > 1;
```

FP&A (Financial Planning & Analysis) — budgets, forecasts, variance. Deliverable: monthly board deck.

```
=XLOOKUP(A2, Actuals[Cost Centre], Actuals[Amount]) - Budget[Amount]   ' variance
=(ThisMonth-LastMonth)/LastMonth                                        ' MoM %
```

DAX for a rolling forecast:

```
Rolling3M Rev =
CALCULATE( SUM(Sales[Revenue]),
    DATESINPERIOD(Calendar[Date], MAX(Calendar[Date]), -3, MONTH) )
```

Treasury — cash, FX, debt, liquidity. Deliverable: daily cash position, hedge book.

```python
# simple FX exposure netting
import pandas as pd
exp = pd.DataFrame({'ccy':['USD','USD','EUR'],'amt':[500000,-200000,300000]})
net = exp.groupby('ccy')['amt'].sum()   # net position to hedge
```

Investment Banking (IB) — raises capital, advises M&A. Deliverable: pitch deck, DCF, LBO model.

```
=NPV(WACC, FCF_range) + TerminalValue/(1+WACC)^n    ' enterprise value
```

Equity Research (ER) — covers listed stocks, issues target prices. Deliverable: initiation note.

Credit — assesses borrower repayment ability. Deliverable: credit appraisal memo, rating.

```
=EBITDA/Interest            ' interest coverage
=(Total Debt)/EBITDA        ' leverage - banks cap ~3.0-3.5x
```

Risk — market/credit/operational risk limits. Deliverable: VaR report, limit monitoring.

```python
import numpy as np
returns = np.random.normal(0, 0.02, 1000)
VaR_95 = np.percentile(returns, 5)   # 1-day 95% Value at Risk
```

Audit — external (statutory) or internal. Deliverable: audit opinion / control findings.

PE/VC — buys companies (PE) or funds startups (VC). Deliverable: investment committee memo, LBO/cap-table.

Product Control (bank markets desk) — validates trader P&L daily. Deliverable: signed-off daily P&L, P&L explain.

```sql
SELECT desk, trade_date,
       SUM(mtm_today) - SUM(mtm_yesterday) AS daily_pnl
FROM positions GROUP BY desk, trade_date;
```

Worked example / mini-project

Build your own role-fit scorecard. Reproduce this in Excel with your real numbers.

Role	Core deliverable	Entry path (India)	Fit for you (1-5)	Notes
Accounting	Books close, financials	CA/B.Com → Accts Exec	5	CA-Inter direct fit
Tax	GSTR/ITR filed	CA/CA-Inter → Tax Assoc	5	Strong
FP&A	Variance deck	MBA → FP&A Analyst	5	MBA + Excel
Treasury	Cash/FX position	MBA/CA → Treasury Analyst	4	Learn FX
Credit	Appraisal memo	MBA → Credit Analyst	4	Bank/NBFC
IB	DCF, pitch	Top MBA/CA → Analyst	3	Pedigree-gated
ER	Initiation note	CFA/MBA → Associate	3	Add CFA
Product Control	Daily P&L sign-off	CA/MBA → Analyst	4	GCC hiring

Then compute a weighted score:

```
=SUMPRODUCT(Fit_range, Weight_range)/SUM(Weight_range)
```

Weight by your priorities (pay 40%, growth 30%, fit 30%). The top 2-3 rows become your application targets. This forces the *specificity* recruiters screen for.

Pay bands (approximate, 2026; India in ₹ LPA total; Global in USD base + bonus). GCC = Global Capability Centre in India.

Role	India entry (₹ LPA)	India 5-8 yr (₹ LPA)	Global entry (USD)
Accounting	4-7	12-20	55-75k
Tax	5-8	15-25	60-85k
FP&A	7-12	20-40	70-95k
Treasury	7-12	20-38	70-100k
Credit	6-11	18-35	65-90k
Risk	8-14	22-45	75-110k
Audit (Big 4)	8-12	20-40	60-85k
Product Control	9-15	25-50	75-110k
Equity Research	10-18	30-70	90-140k
IB	15-30	50-1.2cr	110-175k +
PE/VC	18-35	60-1.5cr+	130-200k +

Note: IB/PE bonuses can equal or exceed base; back-office/control roles have tighter, steadier bands.

How it's tested

Role	Interview questions	Practical test
Accounting	"Pass the entry for a prepaid expense." "What's a deferred tax asset?"	Timed: close a trial balance, spot 3 errors
Tax	"Explain reverse charge under GST." "MAT credit mechanism?"	File a mock GSTR-3B; reconcile 26AS
FP&A	"Walk me through your budget vs actual process."	Timed Excel: build a variance bridge, a rolling forecast
Treasury	"How do you hedge a USD payable?"	Cash-flow forecast case
Credit	"Rank these ratios for a lending decision."	Spread a borrower's financials, write a 1-page memo
IB	"Walk me through a DCF." "Why does depreciation flow through 3 statements?"	3-hour LBO/3-statement modelling test
ER	"Pitch me a stock."	Build a model + short thesis on a given company
Product Control	"What's P&L explain?" "T+1 vs T+0?"	SQL screen + a P&L reconciliation case

The single most common practical test across corporate finance is a **timed Excel test** (no internet, 30-90 min). The IB/ER world tests **full modelling from a blank sheet**. Control/product roles increasingly add a **SQL screen**.

Common mistakes & how pros avoid them

- **Applying to "finance" generically.** Pros apply to a *named desk* with a matching artifact in hand (a model, a filed return).
- **Quoting Western pay in India (or vice versa).** Know your city's band; overshoot by 2x and you're filtered out, undershoot and you're underpaid for years.
- **Confusing prestige with fit.** IB pays most but is pedigree- and hours-gated. A CA-Inter holder often has a faster, richer path via Audit → Product Control → FP&A than a doomed IB cold-apply.
- **Ignoring the GCC boom.** Bengaluru/Hyderabad/Gurugram GCCs now run real product control, FP&A, and risk for global banks — global-quality work, India base. Underrated entry point.
- **No numbers in interviews.** "I improved reporting" loses. "I cut close from 8 to 5 days by automating a 12-tab reconciliation" wins.
- **Treating audit as a dead end.** Big 4 audit is the single most reliable launchpad in India — it opens Product Control, FP&A, Risk, and internal audit at 2-3x pay within 5 years.

Learn-it roadmap & resources

Time to role-clarity: 1 week. Time to first role: 3-12 months depending on the technical gap.

Phase	Time	Do this
Map	Week 1	Build the role-fit scorecard above; pick 2-3 targets
Skill	Months 1-3	Learn the target's core tool (Excel modelling / SQL / Tally+GST) — later chapters
Proof	Months 2-4	Build 1 portfolio artifact per target role
Apply	Months 3-6	Apply to named desks; use referrals (LinkedIn alumni)

Resources: - **Free**: Corporate Finance Institute intro courses; Aswath Damodaran's valuation lectures (YouTube, free); Mergers & Inquisitions (IB career site); ICAI study material (tax/audit). - **Paid**: WallStreetPrep / Breaking Into Wall Street (IB modelling); CFA (ER/buy-side signal); FRM (risk); CA final (audit/tax — you're already on this). - **Certifications by role**: CA → Audit/Tax/Accounting; CFA → ER/PE/AM; FRM → Risk; NISM → distribution/compliance; MBA → FP&A/Credit/general.

Quick-reference

Role	One-line	Top cert	India entry ₹LPA
Accounting	Keeps the books	CA	4-7
Tax	Files & optimizes tax	CA	5-8
FP&A	Budgets & forecasts	MBA/CFA	7-12
Treasury	Manages cash & FX	MBA/CA	7-12
Credit	Assesses borrowers	MBA/CFA	6-11
Risk	Sets & monitors limits	FRM	8-14
Audit	Verifies statements	CA	8-12
Product Control	Signs off daily P&L	CA	9-15
ER	Covers stocks, target price	CFA	10-18
IB	Raises capital, M&A	MBA/CA	15-30
PE/VC	Invests capital	CFA/MBA	18-35

Rules of thumb: Buy-side pays > sell-side > corporate > assurance, but volatility and hours scale the same way. Big 4 Audit is India's best launchpad. GCCs give global work at India base. Always apply to a *named desk* with a matching *artifact*.

Role-by-Role Skill & Tool Matrix

What it is & where it's used

Every finance job posting is a *disguised skill list*. "Financial Analyst," "Accounts Executive," "Tax Associate" — the titles are vague, but the actual work is a fixed bundle of hard skills and named tools. This chapter is the decoder ring: for each common India-based finance/accounts/tax role, it names the **exact** hard skills, the **specific** tools (with version/module), and the **certifications** that move a resume from the reject pile to the shortlist.

Use this to *target*. Instead of "I'll learn finance," you decide: "I want to be an FP&A Analyst, so I need Excel modelling + Power BI + SQL, and I can skip TallyPrime and GST filing." A CA Inter + MBA candidate can credibly aim at six lanes — R2R accounting, Tax/GST, Audit, FP&A/Analyst, Treasury, and Analytics-leaning Finance — and each rewards a different tool stack.

The gap: why companies want this (and college didn't teach it)

MBA and CA syllabi teach *concepts* (NPV, deferred tax, variance analysis) but not the *tool that executes the concept on Monday morning*. College never made you:

- Build a 3-statement model that ties (BS balances, CF reconciles) under a 45-minute clock.
- File a GSTR-3B on the actual portal or pass a reverse-charge journal in TallyPrime.
- Write `SELECT ... GROUP BY` to pull a revenue cut from a 2-million-row ledger export.
- Reconcile GSTR-2B to the purchase register when 40 invoices mismatch.

Employers pay for *execution under constraint*, not for knowing the definition. The gap this chapter closes: mapping each concept you already know to the **named artifact** an employer will hand you and say "do this."

What "proficient" looks like

The concrete bar, by role — what a job-ready person does **unaided**:

Role	Proficiency bar (does this without help)
Accounts Executive (R2R)	Passes month-end journals (accruals, prepaid, depreciation), reconciles bank & vendor ledgers, closes books in TallyPrime/SAP, produces trial balance
Tax/GST Associate	Files GSTR-1, 3B, does 2B reconciliation, computes TDS & advance tax, handles ITC eligibility calls
FP&A / Financial Analyst	Builds/updates 3-statement model, variance (budget vs actual) decks, forecasts, sensitivity tables; Power BI dashboard
Audit Associate	Vouching/verification, sampling, ratio analytics, drafts working papers, tests internal controls
Treasury/Banking Analyst	Cash-flow forecasting, working-capital metrics, forex/interest exposure, covenant tracking
Finance Data Analyst	SQL pulls, Python/pandas cleaning, DAX measures, automates a recurring MIS

Hands-on: how to actually do it

The universal skill matrix — the spine of the chapter. "★" = must-have, "○" = edge:

Skill / Tool	R2R Acct	Tax/GST	FP&A	Audit	Treasury	Data Analyst
Excel (advanced: XLOOKUP, INDEX/MATCH, pivots)	★	★	★	★	★	★
Financial modelling (3-statement, DCF)	○		★	○	★	○
TallyPrime	★	★		○	○	
SAP FICO / Oracle / Zoho Books	★	○	○	○	○	
GST portal + Income-tax portal	○	★		○		
SQL	○		★	○	○	★
Power BI / Tableau (DAX)	○		★	○	○	★
Python (pandas)			○	○		★
Ind AS / IFRS knowledge	★	○	★	★	○	
Certification signal	CA / CMA	CA + GST cert	CFA / FMVA	CA / ACCA	CFA / Treasury (ACT)	Any + BI cert

Excel — the formulas every role is tested on:

```
=XLOOKUP(A2, Ledger[VendorCode], Ledger[Balance], "Not found")
=SUMIFS(Amount, Date, "≥"&DATE(2026,4,1), Date, "≤"&DATE(2026,6,30), GL, "5*")
=INDEX(Data, MATCH(1,(Data[Acct]=H2)*(Data[Period]=I2),0),3)   ' Ctrl+Shift+Enter (legacy)
=IFERROR(Sales/LAGyear-1, "n/a")                                ' growth %
```

SQL — a revenue cut an analyst writes daily:

```
SELECT  region,
        DATE_TRUNC('month', invoice_date) AS mth,
        SUM(taxable_value)                AS net_rev,
        SUM(taxable_value * 0.18)         AS gst_est
FROM    sales_invoices
WHERE   invoice_date ≥ '2026-04-01'
  AND   status = 'POSTED'
GROUP BY region, DATE_TRUNC('month', invoice_date)
HAVING  SUM(taxable_value) > 100000
ORDER BY net_rev DESC;
```

Python — GSTR-2B vs purchase-register reconciliation (the classic tax test):

```
import pandas as pd
books = pd.read_excel("purchase_register.xlsx")
gstr2b = pd.read_excel("gstr2b.xlsx")
recon = books.merge(gstr2b, on="invoice_no", how="outer",
                    suffixes=("_books", "_2b"), indicator=True)
recon["itc_diff"] = recon["igst_books"].fillna(0) - recon["igst_2b"].fillna(0)
mismatch = recon[(recon["_merge"] != "both") | (recon["itc_diff"].abs() > 1)]
mismatch.to_excel("itc_mismatch.xlsx", index=False)
```

DAX — Power BI measures an FP&A dashboard needs:

```
Net Revenue = SUM(Sales[TaxableValue])
YoY % = DIVIDE([Net Revenue] - CALCULATE([Net Revenue], SAMEPERIODLASTYEAR('Date'[Date])),
              CALCULATE([Net Revenue], SAMEPERIODLASTYEAR('Date'[Date])))
Budget Variance = [Net Revenue] - [Budget]
```

TallyPrime click-path (month-end accrual): Gateway of Tally → Vouchers → F7 (Journal) → Dr *Rent Expense* ₹50,000 → Cr *Rent Payable* ₹50,000 → narration → Ctrl+A to save.

GST portal path (file GSTR-3B): gst.gov.in → Login → Returns Dashboard → select period → GSTR-3B "Prepare Online" → fill 3.1 (outward), 4 (ITC from 2B) → Save → Proceed to Pay → Offset liability → File with DSC/EVC.

Worked example / mini-project

Target role: FP&A Analyst. Deliverable: a Q1 FY27 budget-vs-actual pack. Reproduce with these numbers:

Line (₹ lakh)	Budget	Actual	Variance	Var %
Revenue	1,200	1,140	(60)	-5.0%
COGS	720	700	20	+2.8% (fav)
Gross Profit	480	440	(40)	-8.3%
Employee cost	180	195	(15)	-8.3%
Other opex	120	118	2	+1.7%
EBITDA	**180**	**127**	**(53)**	**-29.4%**

Steps: (1) Import both columns into Excel, `Variance = Actual - Budget`, `Var% = Variance/Budget`. (2) Flag any line where `ABS(Var%) > 10%` with `=IF(ABS(E2)>0.1,"⚠ Investigate","")`. (3) Root-cause: EBITDA missed by ₹53L driven by a ₹60L revenue shortfall + ₹15L staff overrun. (4) Load into Power BI, add the `YoY %` and `Budget Variance` DAX measures above, build a waterfall visual. (5) One-slide narrative: "Revenue miss (volume, not price) is the EBITDA driver; hiring ran ahead of plan." That five-step artifact is *exactly* what an FP&A screen asks you to produce.

How it's tested

Role	Interview questions	Practical / assessment test
R2R Acct	"Journal for prepaid insurance?" "Bank reco steps?"	Timed: close a mini trial balance in Tally / pass 10 adjusting entries
Tax/GST	"ITC blocked u/s 17(5)?" "RCM on which services?"	Reconcile a GSTR-2B vs register file; compute a 3B liability
FP&A	"Walk me through linking the 3 statements." "How does ₹100 depreciation flow?"	45-min timed model build; budget-variance case
Audit	"Assertions you test for revenue?" "Sampling method?"	Vouch a sample set; spot the misstatement in given ledgers
Data Analyst	"Difference between WHERE and HAVING?"	Live SQL screen (HackerRank); build a dashboard from a CSV

The "₹100 depreciation" question is the FP&A gatekeeper: *Income statement −100 → net income −100×(1−tax); Cash flow add back +100; Balance sheet PP&E −100, cash +tax shield, retained earnings −net income — and it must balance.* Know it cold.

Common mistakes & how pros avoid them

- **Hardcoding numbers inside formulas.** Pros keep all assumptions in a separate blue-font input cell; formulas reference cells only.
- **A model that doesn't tie.** Amateurs "plug" the balance sheet. Pros build a `Balance check = Assets − (Liab + Equity)` row that must read 0; if not, the CF is wrong.
- **Confusing ITC eligibility.** Blocked credits (u/s 17(5): motor vehicles, personal-use, works contract) get claimed by mistake. Pros reconcile to 2B first, never to the invoice alone.
- **SQL without `GROUP BY` discipline** — selecting non-aggregated columns; pros put every non-aggregate in `GROUP BY`.
- **Listing tools you can't demo.** Never write "SAP" if you can only spell it. Interviewers ask module-level questions (FICO vs MM).
- **Ignoring Ind AS in accounting roles** — e.g., recognising revenue on invoice date instead of per Ind AS 115 performance obligation.

Learn-it roadmap & resources

Skill	Time to job-ready	Resource (free → paid)
Advanced Excel	3–4 weeks	ExcelJet cheat-sheet (free) → Chandoo; Microsoft Learn
Financial modelling	6–8 weeks	Aswath Damodaran (free, NYU) → CFI **FMVA** (paid)
TallyPrime	2–3 weeks	Tally Education free videos → Tally certification
GST/tax practice	4 weeks	GSTN free tutorials + ICAI GST module; use the portal sandbox
SQL	3–4 weeks	SQLBolt / Mode SQL tutorial (free) → HackerRank SQL badge
Power BI (DAX)	3–4 weeks	Microsoft Learn (free) → PL-300 certification
Python/pandas	6 weeks	Kaggle "pandas" (free) → DataCamp

Certifications that actually signal, by lane: **CA / CMA** (accounting-tax), **CFA / FMVA** (analyst-FP&A), **ACCA** (global audit), **PL-300** (BI), **ACT** (treasury). Your CA Inter + MBA already covers the accounting-concept base — spend money only on the *tool* certs (FMVA, PL-300) that your degrees don't prove.

Quick-reference

```
Excel:  =XLOOKUP(lookup, arr, return, "NA")  |  =SUMIFS(sum, crit_rng, crit)
        Balance check row must = 0
SQL:    SELECT col, AGG(x) FROM t WHERE … GROUP BY col HAVING AGG(x)>n
DAX:    YoY% = DIVIDE([M]-CALCULATE([M],SAMEPERIODLASTYEAR(Date[Date])), prior)
Tally:  F7 journal | F5 payment | Alt+G quick-nav | Ctrl+A save
GST:    3B = 3.1 outward + 4 ITC → offset → file (DSC/EVC); reconcile 2B first
Depn ₹100 flow: IS -100→NI -100(1-t); CF +100; BS PP&E-100, cash+shield, RE-NI
Cert by lane: R2R→CA/CMA | FP&A→CFA/FMVA | Audit→ACCA | BI→PL-300 | Treasury→ACT
```

Targeting rule: pick ONE column of the matrix, master its ★ rows, get its one tool-cert, and build one reproducible artifact (a model, a reco, a dashboard). That column — not "finance" in general — is what you apply for.

The core toolkit every finance pro needs

You cannot learn every tool, and you should not try. There is a priority order that maps to how much of your day each tool touches and how quickly it pays back. Learn them in this sequence: **Excel first (non-negotiable) → a data layer (SQL / BI / Python, pick one deeply) → domain tools (ERP like Tally/SAP, the GST portal, an FP&A/planning tool)**. Go deep where your role lives; stay literate everywhere else. This chapter shows you the actual formulas, queries, and click-paths — not adjectives about them.

What it is & where it's used

Layer	Tools	Roles that live here
1. Spreadsheet	Excel, Google Sheets	Every finance role, without exception
2. Data	SQL, Power BI/Tableau, Python (pandas)	FP&A, data-heavy analyst, treasury, revenue/RevOps finance
3. Domain	TallyPrime, SAP/Oracle, GST portal, Zoho/QuickBooks, planning tools (Anaplan, Cube)	Accounts payable/receivable, audit, tax, controllership, statutory compliance

A day-1 accounts executive in an Indian SME lives in **Tally + Excel + GST portal**. An FP&A analyst at a mid-cap lives in **Excel + Power BI + SQL**. A Big 4 audit associate lives in **Excel + the client's ERP + CaseWare/IDEA**. Same toolkit, different depth dial.

The gap: why companies want this (and college didn't teach it)

Your MBA taught you *what* a contribution margin is and *why* WACC matters. It did not make you build a 12-tab rolling forecast that ties out to the penny, write a `GROUP BY` to reconcile 40,000 invoice lines, or file a GSTR-3B before the 20th. Colleges grade concepts; employers pay for **artifacts produced under a deadline with real, messy data**.

The specific gaps: - **Speed and correctness on dirty data.** Textbooks give clean tables. Reality gives you trailing spaces, ₹ stored as text, and duplicate vendor codes. - **Auditability.** A pro's model can be checked by someone else. College spreadsheets are write-once. - **Tool fluency = throughput.** The person who does keyboard-only Excel and writes a SQL join does in 20 minutes what a manual analyst does in a day.

Closing this gap is the single highest-ROI thing you can do before your first role.

What "proficient" looks like

The bar employers actually test for, per layer:

- **Excel (must clear this to be hireable):** builds a model with no hardcoded numbers inside formulas, uses `XLOOKUP` / `INDEX-MATCH` , `SUMIFS` , `IF` / `IFS` , absolute vs relative references (`$`), pivot tables, and a basic three-statement or cash-flow linkage. Navigates with keyboard (Alt keystrokes, `Ctrl+Arrow` , `F4`). Knows why circular references break a model.
- **Data (pick one deeply):** writes a multi-table `JOIN` with `GROUP BY` and a filter, OR builds a Power BI report with a DAX measure and a slicer, OR loads a CSV in pandas and does a `groupby().agg()` . You do

not need all three — you need one you can defend in an interview.

- **Domain:** for accounts/tax roles — posts correct journal entries, runs a Tally ledger and GST report, and files/reconciles a GST return (GSTR-2B vs purchase register). For FP&A — owns a budget-vs-actual variance pack.

Hands-on: how to actually do it

Excel — the formulas that earn their keep

```
# Modern lookup — replaces VLOOKUP; searches any direction, handles "not found"
=XLOOKUP(A2, Vendors[Code], Vendors[Name], "Not found")

# Conditional sum across multiple criteria (the FP&A workhorse)
=SUMIFS(Sales[Amount], Sales[Region], "South", Sales[Month], "≥"&DATE(2026,4,1))

# Robust lookup that survives inserted columns
=INDEX(Price[Rate], MATCH(A2, Price[SKU], 0))

# Tiered logic without nested IFs
=IFS(B2≥1000000,"Large", B2≥100000,"Mid", TRUE,"Small")

# Clean dirty numbers stored as text with stray spaces / ₹ symbols
=VALUE(SUBSTITUTE(SUBSTITUTE(A2,"₹",""),",",""))

# Spill a unique, sorted list (dynamic arrays, Excel 365)
=SORT(UNIQUE(Sales[Customer]))
```

`F4` toggles `$` anchoring — `A$1`, `$A1`, `$A$1`. Lock your assumption cells; leave calculation cells relative. That single discipline separates an auditable model from a broken one.

SQL — reconcile and aggregate at scale

```
-- Sales by region for Q1 FY26-27, only regions above a ₹10L threshold
SELECT r.region_name,
       SUM(s.amount)          AS total_sales,
       COUNT(*)               AS invoice_count
FROM   sales s
JOIN   regions r ON r.region_id = s.region_id
WHERE  s.invoice_date BETWEEN '2026-04-01' AND '2026-06-30'
GROUP  BY r.region_name
HAVING SUM(s.amount) > 1000000
ORDER  BY total_sales DESC;

-- Find purchase invoices in your books but NOT in GSTR-2B (mismatch hunt)
SELECT p.invoice_no, p.gstin, p.taxable_value
FROM   purchase_register p
LEFT   JOIN gstr2b g ON g.invoice_no = p.invoice_no
                    AND g.gstin      = p.gstin
WHERE  g.invoice_no IS NULL;
```

`LEFT JOIN … WHERE right IS NULL` is the anti-join — the core pattern for every reconciliation you will ever do.

Python (pandas) — when data outgrows a spreadsheet

```
import pandas as pd

df = pd.read_csv("sales_fy26.csv", parse_dates=["invoice_date"])
df["amount"] = pd.to_numeric(df["amount"], errors="coerce")   # coerce dirty text to NaN

# Region-wise revenue and average ticket
summary = (df.groupby("region")
             .agg(total=("amount", "sum"),
                  avg_ticket=("amount", "mean"),
                  invoices=("amount", "count"))
             .sort_values("total", ascending=False))

# Reconcile books vs portal via a merge (same idea as SQL anti-join)
mismatch = books.merge(portal, on=["invoice_no", "gstin"],
                       how="left", indicator=True)
mismatch = mismatch[mismatch["_merge"] == "left_only"]
print(summary)
```

DAX — for Power BI reports

```
Total Sales   = SUM(Sales[Amount])
Sales LY      = CALCULATE([Total Sales], SAMEPERIODLASTYEAR('Date'[Date]))
YoY Growth %  = DIVIDE([Total Sales] - [Sales LY], [Sales LY])
```

TallyPrime + GST portal — the domain click-path

- **Post a purchase in Tally:** Gateway of Tally → Vouchers → `F9` (Purchase) → select party → item → tax ledgers (CGST/SGST or IGST) auto-compute → `Ctrl+A` to save.
- **See a ledger:** Gateway → Display More Reports → Account Books → Ledger.
- **GST filing:** log in at gst.gov.in → Returns Dashboard → pick period → **GSTR-1** (outward supplies) → **GSTR-3B** (summary + tax payment) → offset liability from Electronic Credit/Cash Ledger → file with DSC/EVC. Reconcile **GSTR-2B** (auto-drafted ITC) against your purchase register *before* claiming input credit.

Journal entries — the language underneath every tool

Transaction	Account	Dr (₹)	Cr (₹)
Credit purchase, goods ₹1,00,000 + 18% GST	Purchases A/c	1,00,000	
	Input CGST A/c	9,000	
	Input SGST A/c	9,000	
	To Vendor A/c		1,18,000
Salary accrued	Salary A/c	50,000	
	To Salary Payable		50,000

Worked example / mini-project

Build a budget-vs-actual variance pack for "Kaveri Traders" (FY 2026-27, Q1).

1. **Data.** Two sheets: `Budget` and `Actuals`, columns = Cost Centre, Month, Amount. Say budgeted opex ₹42,00,000; actual ₹45,60,000.
2. **Pull actuals against budget** with a keyed lookup: `excel =SUMIFS(Actuals[Amount], Actuals[CostCentre], A2, Actuals[Month], B2)`
3. **Variance and %:** `excel =Actual - Budget # ₹3,60,000 unfavourable =(Actual - Budget)/Budget # 8.6% over`
4. **Flag the outliers** so a manager reads it in 5 seconds: `excel =IF(ABS(VarPct)>0.10, "REVIEW", "OK")`
5. **Summarise** with a pivot: rows = Cost Centre, values = Sum of Variance, then sort descending. Marketing is ₹2,10,000 over on a ₹5,00,000 budget (42%) — that is your headline.
6. **One-line narrative:** "Q1 opex ran 8.6% (₹3.6L) over budget, driven by Marketing (+42%) on an unplanned campaign; travel and utilities were on-plan."

That deliverable — numbers that tie out, outliers flagged, a one-line story — is exactly what an FP&A hiring manager wants to see.

How it's tested

Role	Interview questions	Practical test
FP&A analyst	"VLOOKUP vs INDEX-MATCH vs XLOOKUP — when each?" "How do you avoid circular refs in a model?"	**Timed Excel test (30–60 min):** given raw sales data, build a pivot, compute variance %, flag exceptions. No internet.
Data/BI analyst	"Explain the anti-join." "INNER vs LEFT JOIN." "What does `GROUP BY` return?"	**Live SQL screen** on HackerRank/DataLemur: write a query against a schema they hand you.
Accounts / tax	"Pass the journal entry for a credit purchase with GST." "GSTR-2A vs 2B?"	**"Close these books" case:** post vouchers in Tally, produce a trial balance, reconcile 2B vs purchase register.
Controllership	"Walk me through a 3-statement model."	Take-home model with a broken link to fix.

Assume the practical test is unaided and timed. Prepare by *doing*, not watching.

Common mistakes & how pros avoid them

- **Hardcoding numbers inside formulas** (`=B2*1.18`). Pros put the 18% in a labelled assumption cell and reference it. Auditable, changeable.
- **VLOOKUP breaking on inserted columns.** Use `XLOOKUP` or `INDEX-MATCH` .
- **Trusting dirty data.** Numbers stored as text silently break `SUMIFS` . Run `=ISNUMBER()` , use `VALUE()` / `TRIM()` , watch for the green triangle.
- `SELECT *` **in SQL** and forgetting `GROUP BY` non-aggregated columns. Name columns; aggregate deliberately.
- **Claiming GST input credit before 2B reconciliation** — a real compliance error that triggers notices. Always reconcile first.
- **No version control on models.** Pros date filenames (`Model_2026-07-03_v3.xlsx`) and freeze the assumptions tab.
- **Learning three tools shallowly.** One deep skill beats three you can't defend under questioning.

Learn-it roadmap & resources

Skill	Time to job-ready	Resources
Excel (core)	4–6 weeks, daily practice	Microsoft Excel help; ExcelJet cheat-sheet; Chandoo.org; *Excel to the max* problems. Cert (optional): **Microsoft Office Specialist – Excel Associate**.
SQL	3–4 weeks	Mode SQL Tutorial (free), SQLBolt, DataLemur, LeetCode Database.
Power BI	3–4 weeks	Microsoft Learn (free); **PL-300** cert is well-recognised in India.
Python/pandas	6–8 weeks	Kaggle "Pandas" micro-course (free); *Python for Data Analysis* (McKinney).
Tally + GST	2–3 weeks	TallyEducation.com; GSTN free videos; practise on the GST **offline/sandbox**. Cert: **Tally ACE/Professional**.

Realistic total to a strong finance-toolkit baseline: **~3 months** of focused daily practice alongside your CA prep. Sequence: nail Excel → add SQL *or* Power BI → layer Tally + GST (which your CA syllabus already reinforces).

Quick-reference

Need	Tool	Formula / command
Directional lookup	Excel	`=XLOOKUP(key, lookup_col, return_col, "NA")`
Multi-criteria sum	Excel	`=SUMIFS(sum, c1, v1, c2, v2)`
Robust lookup	Excel	`=INDEX(ret, MATCH(key, look, 0))`
Clean text→number	Excel	`=VALUE(SUBSTITUTE(A2,",",""))`
Anchor references	Excel	`F4` → `$A$1`
Aggregate w/ filter	SQL	`SELECT col, SUM(x) … GROUP BY col HAVING …`
Find non-matches	SQL	`LEFT JOIN … WHERE b.id IS NULL`
Group summary	pandas	`df.groupby("k").agg(total=("x","sum"))`
YoY measure	DAX	`CALCULATE([Sales], SAMEPERIODLASTYEAR('Date'[Date]))`
GST input credit	Portal	Reconcile **GSTR-2B** vs purchase register *before* claiming
GST monthly file	Portal	GSTR-1 → GSTR-3B → offset → file (by 11th / 20th)
Purchase entry	Tally	`F9` → party → item → tax ledgers → `Ctrl+A`

Standard GST rates: 0%, 5%, 12%, 18%, 28%. **Filing dates:** GSTR-1 by 11th, GSTR-3B by 20th of the following month (monthly filers). Keep this card next to your keyboard for your first 90 days.

Certifications Decoded

What it is & where it's used

A finance certification is a **paid signal**. It tells an employer "this person can already do the job at bar X" so they don't have to test you from scratch. Eight matter for an India-based candidate: **CA, CFA, FMVA, CPA, ACCA, FPAC, NISM, FRM**. Each maps to a *different* role — stacking the wrong two wastes 2-3 years.

Cert	Body	What it signals	Primary roles
CA	ICAI (India)	Audit, tax, statutory accounting, Indian GAAP/Ind-AS	Statutory audit, tax, controller, CFO track
CFA	CFA Institute (US)	Investment analysis, valuation, portfolio mgmt	Equity research, AMC, PE/VC, IB
FMVA	CFI (online)	3-statement + DCF modeling in Excel	FP&A, corporate finance, analyst, startup finance
CPA	AICPA (US)	US GAAP, US audit/tax, SOX	US accounting, MNC controllership, Big-4 US desk
ACCA	ACCA (UK)	IFRS, global audit/reporting	MNC finance, UK/Gulf/EU roles, shared services
FPAC	AFP (US)	Financial planning & analysis discipline	Senior FP&A, budgeting, business finance
NISM	SEBI (India)	Regulatory license to *operate* in Indian markets	Mutual fund distributor, RA, dealer, compliance
FRM	GARP (US)	Market/credit/operational risk quant	Risk mgmt at banks, treasury, model validation

NISM is not a "career" cert — it's a **legal licence**. You literally cannot sell a mutual fund or work as a Registered Investment Adviser in India without the relevant module. The others are competitive differentiators.

The gap: why companies want this (and college didn't teach it)

An MBA Finance teaches you *frameworks* — WACC, CAPM, Porter, DuPont. Employers pay for *execution*: can you actually build the DCF, close the books, file the GST return, or size a Value-at-Risk? That is the gap.

- **College taught** "cost of equity = Rf + β(Rm − Rf)". **Job needs** you to pull β from Bloomberg, unlever/relever it for a private target, and defend the 4.5% equity-risk-premium you plugged in.
- **College taught** "revenue is recognised when earned". **Job needs** you to pass the Ind-AS 115 five-step entry, reconcile it to GSTR-3B, and explain the deferred-revenue movement to the auditor.
- **College taught** portfolio theory. **Job needs** the NISM licence before you're allowed to *touch* a client account.

Certifications close this because their exams and case components are written by practitioners, not academics. CFA Level 2 makes you value a company item-by-item. CA articleship forces 3 years of real audit files. FMVA's final is "*here's a raw 10-K, build the model.*" That practitioner bar is exactly what recruiters screen for.

What "proficient" looks like

The bar is not "I passed." It is "I can do the deliverable unaided, on a deadline."

Cert	A proficient holder can, alone...
CA	Finalise a company's books, pass Ind-AS entries, file ITR-6 + GSTR-9, sign a tax audit
CFA	Build a DCF + comparables, write a research note with a target price and a BUY/SELL
FMVA	Turn a 10-K into a linked 3-statement model + DCF + sensitivity in < 1 day
CPA	Prepare US-GAAP financials, run a SOX control test, file a corporate return
ACCA	Produce IFRS consolidated accounts with FX translation and NCI
FPAC	Own a rolling forecast, variance bridge, and driver-based budget
NISM	Legally advise/sell the product + explain suitability and disclosures
FRM	Compute 1-day 99% VaR, run a stress test, validate a credit model

Notice the overlap: **CA, CFA-L2 and FMVA all demand a working DCF.** That's your fastest transferable skill — build it once, it pays across three certs.

Hands-on: how to actually do it

The single most-tested deliverable across CA, CFA, FMVA, FPAC and CPA is a **discounted-cash-flow valuation**. Here is the copy-usable core.

Step 1 — Free Cash Flow to Firm, in Excel. Lay out years in columns C:G.

```
FCFF = EBIT*(1-Tax) + D&A - CapEx - ΔNWC
```

```
' C10 = EBIT, C11 = tax rate, C12 = D&A, C13 = CapEx, C14 = change in NWC
=C10*(1-$C$11)+C12-C13-C14
```

Step 2 — WACC.

```
' E = equity value, D = debt, Re = cost of equity, Rd = cost of debt, t = tax
=(E/(E+D))*Re + (D/(E+D))*Rd*(1-t)
```

Step 3 — Discount factor and PV of each year.

```
' row 20 = FCFF, $B$3 = WACC, C1:G1 = period number 1..5
=C20/(1+$B$3)^C1
```

Step 4 — Terminal value (Gordon growth) and enterprise value.

```
' G20 = final-year FCFF, g in B4, WACC in B3
=G20*(1+$B$4)/($B$3-$B$4)          ' terminal value at year 5
=NPV($B$3,C20:G20)+ (TV/(1+$B$3)^5) ' enterprise value
```

Step 5 — Pull the actuals for the model. In practice you don't type financials by hand; you query a warehouse.

```
SELECT fiscal_year,
       revenue,
       ebit,
       depreciation,
       capex,
       (current_assets - current_liab) AS nwc
FROM   financials
WHERE  ticker = 'RELIANCE'
ORDER  BY fiscal_year;
```

Step 6 — Sensitivity in Python (what FMVA and FP&A interviews ask you to automate):

```
import numpy as np
def ev(fcff, wacc, g):
    pv = sum(cf/(1+wacc)**(i+1) for i, cf in enumerate(fcff))
    tv = fcff[-1]*(1+g)/(wacc-g)
    return pv + tv/(1+wacc)**len(fcff)

fcff = [120, 138, 152, 165, 176]           # ₹ crore
for w in (0.10, 0.11, 0.12):
    print([round(ev(fcff, w, g)) for g in (0.03, 0.04, 0.05)])
```

For the CA/CPA/ACCA accounting bar, proficiency is passing correct entries. Revenue recognised in advance (Ind-AS 115 / IFRS 15):

Event	Dr	Cr	Amount (₹)
Cash received before delivery	Bank	Contract Liability (deferred rev)	1,18,000
GST on advance	Contract Liability	Output CGST/SGST	18,000
Service delivered	Contract Liability	Revenue	1,00,000

For NISM/FPAC dashboards, a portfolio-return DAX measure:

```
Portfolio Return :=
DIVIDE(
    SUMX(Holdings, Holdings[MarketValue] - Holdings[CostBasis]),
    SUM(Holdings[CostBasis])
)
```

Worked example / mini-project

Value a mid-cap and decide the cert-appropriate output. Company: revenue ₹800 cr, EBIT margin 20%, tax 25%, D&A ₹40 cr, CapEx ₹60 cr, ΔNWC ₹15 cr, WACC 11%, terminal g 4%.

Year-1 FCFF:

```
EBIT            = 800 × 20%           = ₹160 cr
NOPAT           = 160 × (1−0.25)      = ₹120 cr
FCFF            = 120 + 40 − 60 − 15 = ₹85 cr
```

Grow FCFF ~8%/yr → [85, 92, 99, 107, 116]. Terminal value:

```
TV  = 116 × 1.04 / (0.11 − 0.04)   = ₹1,723 cr
PV(TV) = 1723 / 1.11^5             = ₹1,022 cr
PV(explicit 5 yrs)  ≈ ₹364 cr
Enterprise Value    ≈ ₹1,386 cr
```

Now the cert lens on the *same* number: - **CFA candidate** writes: "EV ₹1,386 cr; less net debt ₹200 cr → equity ₹1,186 cr; ÷ 10 cr shares = ₹118 target vs ₹95 market → **BUY, 24% upside**." - **FMVA/FP&A candidate** wires it into a 3-statement model and runs a 3×3 WACC-vs-g data table. - **CA/CPA candidate** ignores valuation and instead ensures the ₹85 cr cash flow ties to the audited cash-flow statement and the deferred-tax working.

Same math, three deliverables — that's why one skill funds three certs.

How it's tested

Interviews split into a **verbal round** and a **practical assessment**. Prepare for both.

Verbal questions you will get: - "Walk me through a DCF." (CFA/FMVA/FP&A) — 90-second fluent answer expected. - "Why does an increase in NWC *reduce* free cash flow?" - "Deferred tax asset vs liability — give me a live example." (CA/CPA/ACCA) - "Client wants a small-cap fund — what NISM suitability check do you run?" - "Define 99% 1-day VaR and its biggest limitation." (FRM)

Practical assessments actually used:

Role	The real test
FP&A / FMVA	Timed 60-min Excel: raw trial balance → linked P&L + variance bridge
Equity research (CFA)	"Value this listed company overnight, present tomorrow"
Audit/Accounting (CA)	"Close these books" case: adjusting entries + finalisation
Data-finance	SQL screen: window functions, joins, a running total
Risk (FRM)	Compute VaR on a given return series in Excel/Python

The Excel test is where MBAs fail: **no mouse-hunting.** They watch whether you flow-navigate (`Ctrl+↓` , `Alt+=` , `F4` to lock refs) and whether every number is a *formula*, never a hardcode.

Common mistakes & how pros avoid them

- **Hardcoding numbers into formulas.** Pros put every assumption in a labelled blue-font input cell and reference it. Auditors reject models they can't trace.
- **Stacking overlapping certs.** CA + ACCA is ~80% redundant for an India candidate. Pros pick *complementary* pairs (CA + CFA, or CA + FMVA).
- **Chasing CFA charter before CA/job.** CFA needs 4,000 hrs work experience to charter — collect the letters *don't* just pass exams.
- **Treating NISM as optional.** Working unlicensed in an AMC/advisory is a SEBI violation. Get the module *before* the offer.
- **Circular references left broken** in the interest-on-debt loop — pros enable iterative calc (File → Options → Formulas → *Enable iterative calculation*) and know why.
- **Round numbers with no source.** Every driver should trace to a filing, a query, or a documented assumption.

Learn-it roadmap & resources

Realistic time-to-proficiency and ROI (India context):

Cert	Time	Cost (₹)	Salary lift signal
NISM (per module)	2-3 wks	1,500-2,000	Enables the job; low direct lift
FMVA	2-4 months	~40,000	Strong for FP&A/analyst; fastest ROI
FPAC	4-6 months	~1.2 L	Senior FP&A credibility
CFA (all 3)	2.5-4 yrs	~3-4 L	High for research/AMC/IB
FRM (both parts)	1-1.5 yrs	~1.5 L	High for bank risk roles
CA	4-5 yrs	~2-3 L	Highest base for audit/tax/controller
CPA (US)	1-1.5 yrs	~3.5 L	MNC/US-desk premium
ACCA	2-3 yrs	~3 L	Gulf/UK/IFRS roles

Recommended sequence for *you* (MBA + CA-Inter in progress): 1. **Finish CA** — it's your deepest moat; don't abandon a sunk 2-3 years. 2. **Add FMVA now** (parallel, cheap, fast) — instantly employable for FP&A while you article. 3. **Then CFA** *only if* you want research/AMC/PE; else **FPAC** for a corporate-finance track. 4. NISM modules on-demand the moment a market-facing role requires one.

Resources: CFI (FMVA courses + free Excel guides), Mercer/Kaplan (CFA), ICAI BoS portal + free study material (CA), AFP.org (FPAC), NISM.ac.in (registration + free workbooks), GARP.org (FRM), Aswath Damodaran's free NYU valuation lectures and datasets (the single best free resource for all valuation-based certs).

Quick-reference

Item	Value / formula
FCFF	`EBIT*(1−t) + D&A − CapEx − ΔNWC`
WACC	`(E/V)Re + (D/V)Rd(1−t)`
Terminal value	`FCFF×(1+g)/(WACC−g)`
CAPM cost of equity	`Rf + β(Rm−Rf)`
Excel: lock reference	`F4`
Excel: sum column	`Alt + =`
Excel: lookup	`=XLOOKUP(key, lookup_range, return_range)`
CFA charter needs	3 exams + 4,000 hrs experience
NISM =	SEBI *licence*, not a differentiator
Best India pair	CA + FMVA (accounting + modeling)
Fastest ROI cert	FMVA (2-4 months, ~₹40k)
Highest base	CA (audit/tax/controller/CFO track)

Your MBA-Finance starting point: strengths & gaps

What it is & where it's used

This chapter is a personal audit — a brutally honest map of what you already sell in an interview versus what you have to build before Monday of your first job. Your profile is specific and, frankly, strong: **MBA Finance + NISM Series XV (Research Analyst) + ~2 years on an F&O / derivatives desk + CA Intermediate in progress.** That combination signals markets fluency, valuation literacy, and — once CA is done — accounting and tax depth that most candidates never reach.

But a resume is not a skill set. Employers in India hire for *tasks*: build the three-statement model, reconcile the GST 2B, write the SQL that feeds the MIS deck, close the books by the 5th. Roles that map to your profile:

Role family	What they actually want daily	Your fit today
Equity/credit research, buy-side	Valuation models, thesis notes, screening	**Strong**
FP&A / Corporate finance	Excel modeling, variance analysis, BI dashboards	Partial
Financial / management accounting	Journal entries, close, Tally/ERP, GST/TDS	Gap → closing with CA
Risk / treasury / derivatives ops	Greeks, VaR, hedge accounting, position recon	**Strong** on theory, gap on tooling
Data-driven finance / analytics	SQL, Python, Power BI, automation	Gap

The job is to convert *credentials* into *deliverables*.

The gap: why companies want this (and college didn't teach it)

An MBA teaches you to *reason* about finance — NPV, WACC, CAPM, Porter, capital structure. Employers assume you can reason. What they pay for is *execution under a deadline on their data*. That is the education-to-industry gap, and it has four concrete faces for your profile.

1. **Hands-on Excel modeling.** You know DCF conceptually. Can you build a live, circular-reference-safe three-statement model with a working capital schedule, a debt sweep, and toggles — in 90 minutes, no template? That's the test, and college never times you.
2. **SQL / Python / BI.** Company data lives in databases and ERPs, not textbook tables. FP&A and analytics roles now assume you can pull your own data (`SELECT`), not wait for IT. Python replaces the manual monthly copy-paste.
3. **ERP & practical compliance.** CA *theory* teaches Ind AS and GST law. The job needs you to *pass a GST entry in TallyPrime*, file GSTR-3B on the portal, and reconcile 2B — click by click.
4. **FP&A tooling.** Budget vs actual, rolling forecasts, driver-based models, and a Power BI dashboard the CFO opens on their phone. MBA cases end at the recommendation; the job starts there.

What "proficient" looks like

The bar an employer tests for — what a job-ready person does *unaided*:

- **Excel:** Builds a 3-statement model from a blank sheet; uses `XLOOKUP`, `SUMIFS`, `INDEX/MATCH`, `IFERROR`; finds and kills a circularity; no hardcoded numbers inside formulas; keyboard-driven (Alt shortcuts, no mouse).
- **SQL:** Writes a multi-table `JOIN` with `GROUP BY`, a window function, and a CTE to answer "top 5 customers by overdue receivables this quarter" without googling syntax.
- **Python:** Reads an Excel/CSV with `pandas`, cleans it, does a `groupby`, and exports a formatted output — turning a 2-hour manual task into a 20-second script.
- **BI:** A Power BI model with a proper date table and 4-5 DAX measures (YoY, YTD, variance %).
- **Compliance/ERP:** Passes purchase/sales entries with correct CGST/SGST/IGST split in Tally, reconciles GSTR-2B to books, computes TDS under the right section.

If you can do these five things cold, you clear ~80% of India finance-role practical screens.

Hands-on: how to actually do it

Leverage your strength first — a derivatives P&L any desk respects, in Excel:

```
Payoff of long call at expiry:  =MAX(0, Spot − Strike) − Premium
Long put:                       =MAX(0, Strike − Spot) − Premium
Breakeven (long call):          =Strike + Premium
```

Fill the Excel gap — the formulas that appear in every modeling test:

```
=XLOOKUP(A2, Master[Code], Master[Name], "Not found")
=SUMIFS(Sales[Amt], Sales[Region],"West", Sales[Month],"≥"&DATE(2026,4,1))
=IFERROR(INDEX(Rate, MATCH(1,(T=B2)*(Tenor=C2),0)), 0)   'array match
=NPV(0.11, C5:C14) + C4        'C4 = year-0 cash flow, kept outside NPV
=IRR(C4:C14)
```

Close the SQL gap — the query pattern FP&A lives on:

```sql
-- Top 5 customers by overdue receivables, current quarter
SELECT c.customer_name,
       SUM(i.amount_due) AS overdue
FROM invoices i
JOIN customers c ON c.id = i.customer_id
WHERE i.due_date < CURRENT_DATE
  AND i.status = 'OPEN'
GROUP BY c.customer_name
ORDER BY overdue DESC
LIMIT 5;

-- Month-on-month revenue with a window function
SELECT month,
       revenue,
       revenue - LAG(revenue) OVER (ORDER BY month) AS mom_change
FROM monthly_revenue;
```

Close the Python gap — kill a recurring manual task:

```python
import pandas as pd

df = pd.read_excel("ledger.xlsx", sheet_name="GL")
df["month"] = pd.to_datetime(df["date"]).dt.to_period("M")

summary = (df.groupby(["month", "cost_center"])["amount"]
             .sum()
             .reset_index()
             .pivot(index="cost_center", columns="month", values="amount"))

summary.to_excel("cost_center_MIS.xlsx")
```

Close the BI gap — DAX measures for a variance dashboard:

```
Revenue YTD    = TOTALYTD(SUM(Fact[Revenue]), 'Date'[Date])
Revenue LY     = CALCULATE(SUM(Fact[Revenue]), SAMEPERIODLASTYEAR('Date'[Date]))
YoY %          = DIVIDE([Revenue YTD] - [Revenue LY], [Revenue LY])
Bud Variance   = SUM(Fact[Actual]) - SUM(Fact[Budget])
```

Close the compliance gap — an actual GST purchase entry (goods bought within Maharashtra, ₹1,00,000 @ 18%):

Account	Dr (₹)	Cr (₹)
Purchases A/c	1,00,000	
Input CGST @ 9%	9,000	
Input SGST @ 9%	9,000	
To Creditor (ABC Ltd)		1,18,000

TallyPrime path: `Gateway of Tally → Vouchers → F9 Purchase → select party → item → GST auto-computes if the ledger's GST rate + place of supply are set`. Interstate? The CGST/SGST lines collapse into a single **IGST @ 18% = ₹18,000**.

Worked example / mini-project

Project: One-page FP&A pack for a mid-size distributor, FY 2026-27. Reproduce this end to end — it exercises your gaps and shows off your strengths.

Assume budgeted annual revenue ₹12 crore (₹1 cr/month, flat), actuals below for Q1:

Month	Budget (₹)	Actual (₹)
Apr	1,00,00,000	92,00,000
May	1,00,00,000	1,05,00,000
Jun	1,00,00,000	1,11,00,000

Step 1 — Excel variance:

```
Variance ₹   =Actual - Budget          'Apr = -8,00,000
Variance %   =(Actual-Budget)/Budget   'Apr = -8.0%
Q1 Actual    =SUM(Actuals)             '=3,08,00,000
Run-rate FY  =AVERAGE(Q1)*12           '=12,32,00,000
```

Step 2 — SQL for the underlying pull (if data sits in a DB):

```
SELECT DATE_TRUNC('month', invoice_date) AS month, SUM(net_amount) AS actual
FROM sales WHERE invoice_date >= '2026-04-01'
GROUP BY 1 ORDER BY 1;
```

Step 3 — Python to auto-build the deck data (from `sales.xlsx`) using the snippet above, exporting a clean pivot.

Step 4 — DAX in Power BI to show `Bud Variance` and `YoY %` as cards with a monthly bar chart.

Result you present: "Q1 revenue is ₹3.08 cr, tracking ₹32 lakh *ahead* of the ₹3 cr budget after a soft April; FY run-rate ₹12.32 cr vs ₹12 cr budget, +2.7%." That one sentence — data-backed, tool-built — is what an FP&A hire is paid to produce.

How it's tested

Indian and global finance interviews increasingly split into a talk round and a *do* round.

Screen	What they hand you	Time
Timed Excel test	Blank sheet + assumptions → build DCF or 3-statement model	60-120 min
SQL screen	Schema + 3-4 questions ("2nd highest salary", "running total")	30-45 min
Case: "close these books"	Trial balance with errors → adjust, produce P&L + BS	60 min
Compliance task	Invoice set → compute GST/TDS, say which return & due date	30 min
Markets round (your home turf)	"Price this option / explain contango / what's your view"	Live

Common interview questions: *Walk me through a DCF. How does depreciation flow through three statements? What's the TDS rate on professional fees? Difference between GSTR-1, 2B, 3B? When would you use INDEX/MATCH over VLOOKUP?* Prepare to **do**, not describe.

Common mistakes & how pros avoid them

- **Leading with credentials, not deliverables.** "I have an MBA and NISM" → weak. "I built a 3-statement model and a Power BI variance pack" → hired. Pros open with artifacts.
- **Hardcoding numbers inside Excel formulas.** `=A2*1.18` is a red flag; put 18% in a labeled input cell and reference it. Assumptions live in one colored block.
- **Mouse-driving Excel in a timed test.** Learn Alt-key shortcuts; speed is graded.
- **Treating SQL/Python as "IT's job."** Analysts who pull their own data get promoted; those who raise tickets wait.
- **Confusing CA *theory* with ERP *practice*.** Knowing Section 194J ≠ passing the entry in Tally and filing 26Q. Do both.
- **Ignoring reconciliation.** GSTR-2B vs books mismatch is the #1 real-world compliance task; models must tie out to the rupee.
- **Underselling the derivatives edge.** Few finance hires can price an option or explain the Greeks. That's a differentiator — name it.

Learn-it roadmap & resources

Realistic time-to-proficiency assuming ~1 hr/day alongside CA:

Skill	To job-ready	Resource
Excel modeling	3-4 weeks	CFI free Excel courses; Wall Street Prep; Chandoo.org (free)
SQL	3-4 weeks	SQLBolt (free), Mode SQL tutorial, LeetCode DB easy/medium
Python (pandas)	4-6 weeks	Kaggle "pandas" micro-course (free); *Python for Data Analysis*
Power BI + DAX	2-3 weeks	Microsoft Learn (free); SQLBI.com; DAX Guide
Tally + GST practical	2-3 weeks	Tally EDU free lessons; ICAI GST material (you already have via CA)

Certifications worth it: **Microsoft PL-300 (Power BI Data Analyst)**, **CFI FMVA** (modeling), and finish **CA** — it dominates every other line item. Sequence: Excel → SQL → Power BI → Python, folding Tally/GST practice in parallel with your CA GST paper.

Quick-reference

```
STRENGTHS to sell:  Markets/derivatives · valuation · NISM RA · CA depth (incoming)
GAPS to close:      Excel modeling · SQL · Python · Power BI · Tally/GST practical

Excel:   =XLOOKUP() =SUMIFS() =INDEX/MATCH =IFERROR() =NPV() =IRR()  (inputs in one block)
SQL:     SELECT … JOIN … GROUP BY … ; window: LAG() OVER(ORDER BY …)
Python:  pd.read_excel → groupby → pivot → to_excel
DAX:     TOTALYTD · SAMEPERIODLASTYEAR · DIVIDE for YoY%
GST:     Intra-state = CGST+SGST split · Inter-state = IGST · reconcile 2B to books
Options: Long call P/L = MAX(0,S−K) − premium ; breakeven = K + premium
```

One-line self-brief: "*MBA + markets desk + CA-in-progress who ships models, dashboards, and clean books — not just opinions.*" Build three artifacts (a 3-statement model, a Power BI pack, a Tally close) and your gap is closed.

The 90-Day Job-Ready Sprint

What it is & where it's used

This chapter is the operating system for the previous six chapters. It takes the raw skills — Excel modeling, accounting close, GST/TDS compliance, SQL, Python, Power BI/DAX — and sequences them into a **12-week, week-by-week plan** that ends with you being able to sit an interview and a practical test without freezing.

The sprint is designed for the reader who has 2–4 focused hours a day (evenings + weekends around CA classes or a current job). It is used by anyone targeting entry-to-junior roles: **Accounts Executive, Finance Analyst, Audit Associate, FP&A Analyst, Tax Associate, Financial/Data Analyst**. The logic is simple: employers don't pay for what you *know*, they pay for what you can *produce unaided by Friday*. Ninety days is enough to build 3–4 portfolio artifacts that prove exactly that.

The gap: why companies want this (and college didn't teach it)

An MBA gives you the *vocabulary* (WACC, DCF, contribution margin) and CA gives you the *rules* (Ind AS, GST law). Neither gives you **throughput** — the muscle memory to open a blank workbook and deliver a working model in 90 minutes, or to reconcile a GSTR-2B against your purchase register before a return deadline.

College teaches	Job requires
"Explain a DCF"	Build a 5-year DCF from a P&L in Excel, sensitivity table included
"Journal entries in theory"	Close a month in Tally, tie out to a trial balance
"GST has 4 slabs"	File GSTR-3B and reconcile ITC from 2B on the portal
"SQL is a query language"	Pull revenue by region for last quarter under time pressure
Solo exams	Deliver a shared model a manager can audit and trust

The gap is **speed, accuracy, and format** — turning knowledge into a clean deliverable someone else can rely on. This sprint closes it by forcing daily reps and weekly shippable outputs.

What "proficient" looks like

The bar at day 90, unaided:

- Build a 3-statement or DCF model in Excel from scratch; no hardcoded numbers inside formulas; every driver on an assumptions tab.
- Perform a bank reconciliation and a month-end close in TallyPrime; produce a trial balance that ties.
- Compute GST liability, reconcile ITC from GSTR-2B, and walk through filing GSTR-3B on the portal.
- Write SELECT queries with JOIN, GROUP BY, and a window function against a real schema.
- Load a CSV in Python/pandas, clean it, and produce a summary; or build a Power BI dashboard with 3–4 DAX measures.
- Talk through each artifact in an interview: what you assumed, why, and what would break it.

Hands-on: how to actually do it

The sprint is four 3-week blocks. Each block ends with **one portfolio artifact**.

Block 1 (Wk 1–3): Excel + Accounting core. The non-negotiable foundation for every finance role.

```
Wk1: Excel mechanics — XLOOKUP, INDEX/MATCH, SUMIFS, IF logic, pivot tables, absolute refs.
Wk2: Accounting close — journal entries, T-accounts, trial balance, BRS, accruals/prepaids.
Wk3: Build a 3-statement model linking P&L → BS → Cash Flow.
```

Core Excel reps to drill until automatic:

```
=XLOOKUP(A2, Ledger[Code], Ledger[Name], "Not found")
=SUMIFS(Amount, Region, "West", Month, "Jun")
=INDEX(Rate, MATCH(1, (Item=G2)*(Vendor=H2), 0))   ' Ctrl+Shift+Enter or dynamic array
=IFERROR(Revenue/Prior-1, "n/a")                    ' YoY growth, safe
```

A recurring-revenue driver on the assumptions tab (never type numbers in the P&L):

```
Revenue_Y2 = Revenue_Y1 * (1 + Growth_Rate)     ' Growth_Rate lives in cell $B$4
Gross_Profit = Revenue * (1 - COGS_pct)
```

Sales-invoice journal entry (India, 18% GST intra-state):

Account	Dr (₹)	Cr (₹)
Debtors / Bank	1,18,000	
To Sales		1,00,000
To Output CGST @9%		9,000
To Output SGST @9%		9,000

Block 2 (Wk 4–6): Tax & compliance in Tally + GST portal. Where accounts/tax roles are won.

TallyPrime click-path to record that same sales invoice: `Gateway of Tally → Vouchers → F8 (Sales) → Party A/c name → select Sales ledger → select stock item → GST auto-computes from ledger rates → Ctrl+A to save.`

GST liability logic you must be able to compute cold:

```
Output GST (on sales)      = 90,000
Less: Input Tax Credit     = 62,000   (from GSTR-2B, only invoices that appear)
Net GST payable in cash    = 28,000   → paid via GSTR-3B, Table 3.1 + 6.1
```

Reconcile ITC in Excel before filing — match purchase register to GSTR-2B:

```
=XLOOKUP([@GSTIN&Invoice], TwoB[Key], TwoB[TaxValue], "MISSING in 2B")
```

Any "MISSING in 2B" row = ITC you cannot claim this month. TDS on professional fees (Sec 194J, 10%):

Account	Dr (₹)	Cr (₹)
Professional Fees	50,000	
To TDS Payable (194J)		5,000
To Vendor		45,000

Block 3 (Wk 7–9): SQL + data. For analyst-flavored roles.

```
-- Revenue by region, last quarter, top to bottom
SELECT region,
       SUM(amount)               AS revenue,
       COUNT(DISTINCT invoice_id) AS invoices
FROM   sales
WHERE  invoice_date >= '2026-04-01' AND invoice_date < '2026-07-01'
GROUP  BY region
ORDER  BY revenue DESC;

-- Running total (window function) - the interview differentiator
SELECT month,
       SUM(revenue) OVER (ORDER BY month) AS cumulative_revenue
FROM   monthly_sales;
```

Python for a quick reconciliation/summary — the reusable pattern:

```
import pandas as pd
gl = pd.read_csv("general_ledger.csv")
gl["amount"] = pd.to_numeric(gl["amount"], errors="coerce")
summary = (gl.groupby("cost_center")["amount"]
             .sum()
             .sort_values(ascending=False))
print(summary.head(10))
```

Block 4 (Wk 10–12): Power BI/DAX + packaging. Turn it into a dashboard and a story.

```
Total Revenue = SUM(Sales[Amount])
Revenue YoY % =
VAR Curr = [Total Revenue]
VAR Prior = CALCULATE([Total Revenue], SAMEPERIODLASTYEAR('Date'[Date]))
RETURN DIVIDE(Curr - Prior, Prior)
```

Worked example / mini-project

Project: "Kaveri Traders FY25-26 Finance Pack" — one dataset, carried through all four blocks. Invent a small trading firm: revenue ₹1.2 crore, COGS 65%, opex ₹18 lakh.

1. **Excel model:** Assumptions tab with growth 12%, COGS 65%, tax 25%. Build P&L → BS → Cash Flow. Add a 2-way data table flexing growth (8/12/16%) against COGS (60/65/70%) to see PAT swing. PAT at base ≈ ₹9.75 lakh.
2. **Tally + GST:** Book 12 months of sales/purchase vouchers. Compute net GST: output ₹21.6 lakh − ITC ₹14 lakh = **₹7.6 lakh cash payable**. Reconcile a deliberately-broken 2B (one vendor didn't file) and flag the ₹90,000 ITC you must hold.
3. **SQL/Python:** Load the 12-month sales CSV, GROUP BY region, find that "South" is 41% of revenue but declining QoQ.
4. **Power BI:** One page — revenue trend, region split, GST payable card, YoY% measure.

Ship it as a GitHub repo + a 1-page PDF summary. This *is* your portfolio.

How it's tested

Companies rarely take your word. Expect:

- **Timed Excel test (30–60 min):** "Here's a raw sales dump — build a pivot, compute margin by product, flag items below 20% margin." Or a lookup/cleanup task. Speed and no-hardcoding matter.
- **SQL screen (HackerRank / live share):** 2–3 queries escalating to a JOIN + window function.
- **"Close these books" case:** given a trial balance with errors, find and fix them; or record 5 vouchers in Tally and produce the TB.
- **GST/tax scenario:** "Sales ₹10L, purchases ₹6L, one supplier hasn't filed — what's your net payable and what do you do about the ITC?"
- **Model walkthrough:** they open your file and ask "why is this cell a formula and that one a constant?" and "what happens if growth halves?"

Interview questions: *Walk me through your DCF. What's the difference between GSTR-2A and 2B? When is ITC blocked (Sec 17(5))? How do you reconcile a bank statement? Explain a LEFT vs INNER JOIN.*

Common mistakes & how pros avoid them

Mistake	What pros do
Hardcoding numbers inside formulas	All inputs on an assumptions tab; formulas reference them
Studying 6 skills shallowly, shipping nothing	One artifact per block — depth over breadth
Claiming ITC on everything	Claim only what's in GSTR-2B; check Sec 17(5) blocks
Circular refs / #REF! left in the model	Trace precedents, wrap risky bits in IFERROR, build clean
Memorizing DCF theory but never building one	Build the model 3×; the third time is muscle memory
No sensitivity/scenario view	Always add a data table — managers ask "what if"
Cramming, no spaced revision	Weekly review of prior blocks so Wk1 skills survive to Wk12

Learn-it roadmap & resources

Realistic time-to-proficiency at ~3 hrs/day: **the 90 days gets you interview-ready for entry/junior roles**, not senior. Extend to 6 months for depth.

Skill	Free	Paid / cert
Excel	ExcelJet, Leila Gharani (YouTube)	Microsoft MO-201
Accounting/Tally	Tally Education free courses	TallyPrime + GST certificate
GST/TDS	GST portal help, ClearTax guides	ICAI GST certificate course
SQL	Mode SQL Tutorial, SQLBolt, HackerRank	Google Data Analytics (Coursera)
Python	Kaggle "Pandas" micro-course	—
Power BI/DAX	Microsoft Learn (free)	Microsoft PL-300

Weekly cadence: 5 days new material, Saturday build the artifact, Sunday spaced review + mock question.

Quick-reference

```
Block 1 (Wk1-3): Excel + 3-statement model      → Artifact: financial model
Block 2 (Wk4-6): Tally + GST/TDS + portal        → Artifact: closed books + GST recon
Block 3 (Wk7-9): SQL + Python                     → Artifact: query pack + analysis
Block 4 (Wk10-12): Power BI/DAX + packaging       → Artifact: dashboard + repo
```

Need	Formula / step
Lookup	`=XLOOKUP(key, col, return, "NA")`
Conditional sum	`=SUMIFS(sum, crit_rng, crit)`
YoY	`=IFERROR(this/prior-1,"n/a")`
Net GST	Output GST − ITC (in 2B only)
TDS 194J	10% on professional fees
SQL group	`SELECT dim, SUM(x) … GROUP BY dim`
Window	`SUM(x) OVER (ORDER BY month)`
DAX YoY	`DIVIDE(Curr-Prior, Prior)`
Rule	Inputs on assumptions tab, never hardcode

The 6-Month Mastery Roadmap

What it is & where it's used

Chapters 1–7 gave you the raw skills — Excel, accounting mechanics, SQL, a bit of Python, GST/Tally, a modeling primer. This chapter is the **operating plan** that welds them into a hireable profile. A roadmap is not "study more." It is a sequenced, milestone-gated build where every month produces a **deliverable an interviewer can look at** — a working model, a reconciled book of accounts, a dashboard, a repo.

Where this matters: any candidate 0–3 years out. Hiring managers for FP&A, financial analyst, audit associate, tax executive, credit analyst, and finance-BA roles all screen the same way — they don't ask "did you learn Excel?", they ask "show me something you built." A structured 6-month portfolio is what turns "MBA Finance + CA Inter" (a credential thousands share) into "the person who built a 3-statement model of an actual listed company and can defend every driver."

The roadmap has three parallel tracks you deepen simultaneously:

Track	Core skill	Proof-of-work artifact
Modeling	3-statement + valuation in Excel	Fully-linked model of a real Indian listco
Data	SQL + Python + Power BI/DAX	A dashboard fed by a query you wrote
Domain	ONE chosen specialization	A case/deliverable specific to that domain

The gap: why companies want this (and college didn't teach it)

College teaches **subjects in isolation and tests recall**. Industry rewards **integrated output under a deadline**. The MBA gives you NPV formulas; it never makes you build a model where a change in a revenue-growth assumption ripples through the P&L, working capital, cash flow, and debt schedule and *still balances*. CA Inter drills you on standards and journal entries; it rarely makes you close a full month-end in Tally and produce a variance commentary a CFO would read.

The specific gap this roadmap closes:

- **Integration** — real work links accounting → modeling → data → decision. Nobody hands you a clean, pre-scoped problem.
- **Ownership of a deliverable** — you own something end-to-end, including the ugly reconciliation at the end.
- **Explaining your work** — "walk me through your model" is the single most common finance interview prompt, and it has no textbook answer.

Six months is enough to manufacture that experience *before* anyone pays you for it.

What "proficient" looks like

The bar an employer tests for at the end of this roadmap:

- Build a **3-statement model from a downloaded annual report in under 3 hours**, balance sheet tying out, no hardcodes over formulas, no circular-reference errors left unresolved.

- Write a **JOIN + GROUP BY SQL query** against an unfamiliar schema in 10 minutes to answer a business question.
- Take a raw transaction dump and produce a **Power BI dashboard with 3–4 DAX measures** (YoY, running total, % of total).
- **Close a set of books**: pass month-end journals, reconcile the bank and GST, produce a Trial Balance that agrees.
- **Defend every number** you present — "why 12% WACC?", "why did receivable days move?" — without freezing.

Proficiency = you can do the above **unaided, under time pressure, and explain it**.

Hands-on: how to actually do it

The month-by-month build

Month	Theme	Milestone (must-ship deliverable)	Checkpoint (pass/fail test)
1	Excel + accounting fluency	Rebuild a company's P&L + BS in Excel from its annual report	Balance sheet balances; zero hardcoded totals
2	3-statement model	Link IS → BS → CFS with a debt & working-capital schedule	Model flows when you change 1 driver; ties out
3	Valuation	Add DCF + comparables tab; arrive at a target price	You can justify WACC, terminal growth, exit multiple
4	Data — SQL	Load transaction data, answer 10 business questions in SQL	Correct JOIN/GROUP BY results, verified against Excel
5	Data — BI + Python	Power BI dashboard + a Python script that cleans the source	4 DAX measures correct; script reproducible
6	Domain track + polish	One domain deliverable + package the portfolio	Mock interview: walk through everything cleanly

Modeling track — the driver pattern

Never hardcode a forecast. Drive it. In Excel, a revenue build:

```
Revenue_next = Revenue_this * (1 + Growth_rate)
=B10*(1+$C$3)
```

Working-capital days that feed the cash flow:

```
Debtor Days   = Receivables / Revenue * 365      =B20/B10*365
Receivables   = Debtor Days assumption / 365 * Revenue
```

The circular-reference reality: interest depends on debt, debt depends on cash, cash depends on interest. Turn on **File → Options → Formulas → Enable iterative calculation** (max 100 iterations), and keep a **circularity switch** cell so you can break it when auditing:

```
Interest = IF($C$1=0, 0, Avg_Debt * Interest_rate)
```

Data track — SQL you will actually be asked

```sql
-- Top 5 customers by revenue in FY2024-25
SELECT c.customer_name,
       SUM(s.amount) AS total_revenue
FROM sales s
JOIN customers c ON c.customer_id = s.customer_id
WHERE s.invoice_date BETWEEN '2024-04-01' AND '2025-03-31'
GROUP BY c.customer_name
ORDER BY total_revenue DESC
LIMIT 5;

-- Month-on-month revenue with a window function
SELECT DATE_TRUNC('month', invoice_date) AS mth,
       SUM(amount) AS revenue,
       SUM(amount) - LAG(SUM(amount)) OVER (ORDER BY DATE_TRUNC('month', invoice_date)) AS mom
FROM sales
GROUP BY 1
ORDER BY 1;
```

Data track — Python to clean the raw dump

```python
import pandas as pd

df = pd.read_csv("tally_export.csv")
df.columns = df.columns.str.strip().str.lower()
df["amount"] = (df["amount"].astype(str)
                .str.replace(",", "", regex=False)
                .astype(float))
df["invoice_date"] = pd.to_datetime(df["invoice_date"], dayfirst=True)

# Monthly revenue by state (GST use-case)
summary = (df.groupby([df["invoice_date"].dt.to_period("M"), "state"])["amount"]
             .sum().reset_index())
summary.to_csv("monthly_by_state.csv", index=False)
```

Data track — DAX measures for the dashboard

```
Total Revenue = SUM(Sales[Amount])

Revenue YoY % =
VAR Curr = [Total Revenue]
VAR Prior = CALCULATE([Total Revenue], SAMEPERIODLASTYEAR('Date'[Date]))
RETURN DIVIDE(Curr - Prior, Prior)

Running Total =
CALCULATE([Total Revenue],
    FILTER(ALLSELECTED('Date'[Date]), 'Date'[Date] <= MAX('Date'[Date])))
```

Accounting track — a month-end close journal set

Date	Particulars	Dr (₹)	Cr (₹)
31-Mar	Depreciation A/c … Dr	50,000	
	To Accumulated Depreciation		50,000
31-Mar	Salaries A/c … Dr	2,00,000	
	To Salaries Payable (accrual)		2,00,000
31-Mar	Prepaid Insurance A/c … Dr	12,000	
	To Insurance Expense		12,000

Choose ONE domain track (Month 6)

Domain	Deliverable	Signature skill
FP&A / Corporate finance	Rolling 12-month budget vs actuals + variance memo	Driver-based forecasting
Equity research	2-page initiation note with a rating	Valuation + thesis writing
Tax / GST	GSTR-2B vs purchase register reconciliation + ITC note	Portal + reconciliation
Audit	Sample testing workpaper + a control-deficiency memo	Sampling, documentation
Credit / lending	Credit appraisal note with ratio + DSCR analysis	Debt-serviceability judgement

Worked example / mini-project

The spine project: a full model + dashboard on an Indian listco (say, an FMCG mid-cap).

1. **Source data (Month 1).** Download the latest annual report. Type the last 3 years of P&L and BS into a `Historicals` tab. Verify: Assets = Liabilities + Equity for every year. Suppose Revenue ₹4,200 Cr, PAT ₹380 Cr.

2. **Build drivers (Month 2).** Assume revenue growth 11%, EBITDA margin 18%, debtor days 32, inventory days 45, tax 25%. Forecast 5 years. Link IS → BS → CFS. Add a debt schedule; opening ₹600 Cr, ₹100 Cr annual repayment. Confirm closing cash on the CFS = cash on the BS.
3. **Value it (Month 3).** WACC 12%, terminal growth 5%. Discount 5 years of FCFF plus a Gordon terminal value:

```
FCFF = EBIT*(1-tax) + Dep&Amort - Capex - Change in WC
Terminal Value = FCFF_year5 * (1+g) / (WACC - g)
Enterprise Value = SUM(PV of FCFF) + PV of Terminal Value
```

Cross-check with comparables (EV/EBITDA of 3 peers). Arrive at a target price, e.g. ₹1,450 vs market ₹1,300 → "Buy."

4. **Analyze the data (Month 4–5).** Export segment/region sales into SQLite, run the top-customer and MoM queries above. Clean with the Python snippet. Build a Power BI page: revenue trend, YoY %, margin bridge, region split — with the three DAX measures.
5. **Domain wrap (Month 6).** If FP&A track: turn the forecast into a budget-vs-actual with a one-page variance commentary ("EBITDA ₹42 Cr below plan; ₹30 Cr is raw-material inflation, ₹12 Cr volume").

Ship it as one folder + a GitHub repo. This single project touches every track.

How it's tested

- **The model walkthrough (universal).** "Take me through your model." They watch whether you know why each cell exists. Then a stress test: "revenue growth drops to 5% — what happens to the debt covenant?" You should be able to change it live.
- **Timed Excel test (60–90 min).** Build a mini 3-statement or a schedule from a given trial balance. Common at Big 4, corporate FP&A, KPO/GCC roles.
- **SQL screen (30–45 min).** HackerRank/DataCamp-style: JOINs, GROUP BY, window functions against a schema you've never seen.
- **The close case.** "Here's a trial balance and 6 adjustments — produce the finalized P&L and BS." Audit and controllership roles.
- **Case + guesstimate.** Equity research and credit: "value this business" or "would you lend to this company?" — judgement, not just arithmetic.
- **Behavioral.** "Tell me about a project you built end-to-end." Your portfolio *is* the answer.

Common mistakes & how pros avoid them

Mistake	What pros do
Hardcoding numbers into formula cells	**Colour code**: blue = input, black = formula. Never type a number in a black cell.
Model doesn't balance, so they plug it	Build a **balance check row** (`=Assets - L - E` , should be 0). Find the error, never plug.
Ignoring the debt/interest circularity	Add an iterative-calc switch; understand *why* it's circular before disabling.
Learning tools in isolation	Force integration — the SQL query should feed the same company you modeled.
Chasing 5 domains shallowly	Pick **one** domain track. Depth beats breadth in interviews.
No commentary, just numbers	Always write the "so what" — 2 lines of insight per deliverable.
Studying without shipping	A milestone that isn't a file you can open didn't happen.

Learn-it roadmap & resources

Realistic time: 6 months at 10–12 focused hours/week gets you interview-ready; 20 hrs/week compresses it to ~3–4 months. The binding constraint is *shipping deliverables*, not watching lectures.

Need	Free	Paid / Cert
Modeling	Aswath Damodaran (NYU) YouTube + spreadsheets	WallStreetPrep, CFI FMVA
Excel	ExcelJet, Chandoo	Microsoft Excel Expert (MO-201)
SQL	Mode SQL Tutorial, SQLBolt, HackerRank	DataCamp
Python	Kaggle "Pandas" micro-course	—
Power BI / DAX	Microsoft Learn, SQLBI (Marco Russo)	PL-300 (Power BI Data Analyst)
Valuation / thesis	Damodaran, Tijori/Screener.in for data	CFA L1 (India-recognized)
Tax/GST/Tally	GST portal + CBIC videos	TallyPrime certification

Sequencing rule: don't collect certificates first. Build the artifact, then take the cert that certifies what you already built — it reads as validation, not aspiration.

Quick-reference

The 6 milestones: (1) rebuilt financials → (2) linked 3-statement → (3) valuation + target price → (4) SQL answers → (5) BI dashboard + Python clean → (6) domain deliverable + portfolio.

Checkpoint questions (ask yourself monthly): - Does my balance sheet balance without a plug? - Can I change one driver and watch it flow? - Can I write a JOIN + GROUP BY unaided? - Can I defend every assumption out loud? - Is each month a *file I can send someone*?

Key formulas:

```
Growth-driven forecast   =PrevCell*(1+GrowthRate)
Debtor days              =Receivables/Revenue*365
FCFF                     EBIT*(1-t)+D&A-Capex-ΔWC
Terminal value           FCFF*(1+g)/(WACC-g)
SQL essentials           JOIN … ON | GROUP BY | LAG() OVER()
DAX YoY                  DIVIDE(Curr-Prior, Prior) with SAMEPERIODLASTYEAR
Balance check            =TotalAssets-TotalLiab-Equity   (must=0)
```

Colour convention: blue input · black formula · green = links to other sheets.

The one rule: every month ends with a shippable file, or the month didn't count.

Building a Portfolio That Gets Interviews

What it is & where it's used

A finance portfolio is a small, curated set of *finished, reviewable deliverables* that prove you can do the job before anyone hires you. For a fresher or a career-switcher with an MBA + CA Inter, it is the single fastest way to jump the resume screen: a recruiter reads 200 identical CVs ("proficient in Excel, strong analytical skills") and one that links to a working 3-statement model, a live Power BI dashboard, and a GitHub repo with SQL. Guess who gets the call.

Four deliverables carry almost every finance/accounts/tax role:

Deliverable	Roles it opens
3-statement model (Excel)	FP&A, corporate finance, equity research, investment banking, credit analyst
Power BI / dashboard	FP&A, business finance, MIS analyst, controllership, finance-BI
SQL / Python project	Finance analyst, data-heavy FP&A, fintech, revenue/GST analytics
Valuation write-up	Equity research, IB, PE/VC, corporate development

You don't need all four. Two done *well* beats four done shabbily. Pick the two that match your target role.

The gap: why companies want this (and college didn't teach it)

College taught you the *concepts* — CAPM, DCF, ratio analysis, the accounting equation. It graded you on knowing what NPV *is*. Employers pay you to *build the thing that produces the number* and defend it. The gap is almost entirely mechanical and habitual:

- MBA teaches "a DCF discounts free cash flows." It does **not** teach you to build a driver-based revenue schedule, tie a circular interest calculation with an iterative-calc toggle, or make the balance sheet actually balance.
- CA teaches you to *pass* journal entries. It does **not** teach you to pull 5 years of a company's financials from an annual report into a clean, formula-linked model that a manager can audit in 30 seconds.
- Nobody taught you version control, so your "final_v3_FINAL_actual.xlsx" habit screams fresher.

The portfolio closes this because it is *evidence of the mechanical skill*, not a claim about the conceptual one. It also proves the meta-skill employers most quietly value: you can take a messy real-world dataset and produce a decision-grade output, unaided.

What "proficient" looks like

The bar a hiring manager silently tests for:

- **3-statement model:** IS, BS, CFS fully linked; balance sheet balances to zero in every year and every scenario; assumptions on a separate, colour-coded input tab (blue = input, black = formula); a working scenario toggle; no hardcoded numbers inside formulas; circularity (interest on average debt) handled cleanly.

- **Dashboard:** loads from a data model (not one flat sheet), has slicers that actually filter, uses DAX measures (not calculated columns for everything), and answers a *business question* on the first screen ("are we hitting budget?") — not just "here are 9 charts."
- **SQL/Python:** you can write a multi-table `JOIN` with `GROUP BY`, a window function, and a CTE without googling syntax; Python code runs top-to-bottom in a clean environment and reads a real CSV.
- **Valuation:** a 2-3 page write-up with a thesis, a DCF *and* a comparables cross-check, a sensitivity table, and an explicit "what I'd need to be wrong about" section.

Hands-on: how to actually do it

1) The 3-statement model core mechanics

Keep inputs on a `Assumptions` tab and reference them. Never type a growth rate inside a P&L formula.

```
Revenue (Yr):        =PrevRevenue*(1+Assumptions!$B$4)      // growth driver
COGS:                =Revenue*Assumptions!$B$5              // % of sales
Depreciation:        =Opening_PPE*Assumptions!$B$8          // % of gross block
Interest expense:    =AVERAGE(Opening_Debt,Closing_Debt)*Assumptions!$B$10   // circular
```

Pull the right assumption automatically with a lookup instead of hardcoding scenario numbers:

```
=XLOOKUP($B$1, Scenarios[Case], Scenarios[RevGrowth])
```

where `$B$1` holds "Base" / "Bull" / "Bear".

The balance-sheet check (the formula an interviewer looks for first):

```
Check:  =Total_Assets - (Total_Liabilities + Total_Equity)   // must be 0 every year
```

Wrap the whole check row in conditional formatting: red if `ABS(check)>0.5`.

Circularity: interest depends on debt, debt depends on cash, cash depends on interest. Enable File > Options > Formulas > **Enable iterative calculation** (max 100, 0.001). Add a `Circuit Breaker` cell (a 1/0 switch) that zeroes interest so you can kill a `#REF!` spiral.

2) Power BI / DAX

Load data via Power Query (Get Data > CSV/Excel > Transform), then write measures — not calculated columns:

```
Total Revenue = SUM(Sales[Amount])

Revenue LY = CALCULATE([Total Revenue], SAMEPERIODLASTYEAR('Date'[Date]))

YoY % = DIVIDE([Total Revenue] - [Revenue LY], [Revenue LY])

Budget Variance % = DIVIDE([Total Revenue] - SUM(Budget[Amount]), SUM(Budget[Amount]))
```

Build a proper `Date` table so time-intelligence works:

```
Date = CALENDAR(DATE(2022,4,1), DATE(2025,3,31))   // Indian FY start
```

3) SQL project

A revenue-and-collections query a finance analyst actually writes:

```
WITH monthly AS (
    SELECT
        customer_id,
        DATE_TRUNC('month', invoice_date) AS mth,
        SUM(amount) AS revenue
    FROM invoices
    WHERE status = 'PAID'
    GROUP BY customer_id, DATE_TRUNC('month', invoice_date)
)
SELECT
    mth,
    SUM(revenue) AS total_rev,
    SUM(revenue) - LAG(SUM(revenue)) OVER (ORDER BY mth) AS mom_change
FROM monthly
GROUP BY mth
ORDER BY mth;
```

4) Python

```
import pandas as pd

df = pd.read_csv("gst_sales_register.csv", parse_dates=["invoice_date"])
df["gst"] = df["taxable_value"] * 0.18

summary = (df.groupby(df["invoice_date"].dt.to_period("M"))
             .agg(taxable=("taxable_value", "sum"),
                  gst=("gst", "sum"),
                  invoices=("invoice_no", "count"))
             .round(0))
print(summary)
```

Worked example / mini-project

Project: "Kirana-to-Cloud Pvt Ltd — FY24 Finance Pack." Invent a small D2C company. Build one repo/model that produces three linked outputs.

Step 1 — Model. Assumptions: FY24 revenue ₹12,00,00,000, growing 20%; COGS 55% of sales; opex ₹2,40,00,000; debt ₹3,00,00,000 at 11%; tax 25%; capex ₹80,00,000.

Sample P&L (₹ lakh):

Line	FY24	FY25E
Revenue	1,200	1,440
COGS (55%)	660	792
Gross profit	540	648
Opex	240	264
EBITDA	300	384
Depreciation	40	48
EBIT	260	336
Interest (11%)	33	33
PBT	227	303
Tax (25%)	57	76
PAT	**170**	**227**

Step 2 — Dashboard. Export the sales register to CSV, load into Power BI, build a one-screen view: revenue vs budget card, YoY % KPI, monthly trend line, top-10 SKUs bar, a state slicer (ties to GST filing).

Step 3 — Valuation. Quick DCF: FY25E FCFF ≈ EBIT(1−t) + Dep − Capex − ΔWC = 336×0.75 + 48 − 80 − 20 ≈ ₹200 lakh. Grow at 6% terminal, WACC 13%: terminal value = 200×1.06 ÷ (0.13−0.06) ≈ ₹3,028 lakh. Cross-check with comps: peers trade at 12× EBITDA → 384×12 = ₹4,608 lakh EV. Write 2 pages: thesis, both methods, a WACC sensitivity table, and your honest range (₹30–46 cr EV).

Reproduce it, screenshot the dashboard, commit the Excel + `.pbix` + a `README.md`.

How it's tested

Two layers: interview questions **and** a practical assessment.

Interview questions - "Walk me through your 3-statement model. If revenue grows 10%, what happens to the cash flow statement?" - "How does depreciation flow through all three statements?" (P&L −, add back in CFS, accumulated on BS) - "Your DCF gives ₹40 cr, comps give ₹46 cr. Why the gap, and which do you trust?" - "What DAX measure did you use for YoY, and why a measure not a column?"

Practical / take-home tests you'll actually get - **Timed Excel test (45–90 min):** build a mini P&L from raw data, add a scenario toggle, VLOOKUP/XLOOKUP + INDEX-MATCH, a pivot. No internet. - **SQL screen (HackerRank/live):** joins, `GROUP BY`, a window function, a CTE. - **Case study:** "Here's a trial balance / annual report — build the model and email it back in 24 hours." - **Dashboard task:** "Here's a CSV, build a dashboard that tells us if we're hitting target."

Your portfolio is the pre-loaded answer to all of these.

Common mistakes & how pros avoid them

Mistake	What pros do
Hardcoding numbers inside formulas	All drivers on an input tab, referenced
Balance sheet doesn't balance; hidden plug	A visible `Check = Assets − (Liab+Equity)` row flagged red
No colour convention	Blue = input, black = formula, green = link to another tab
One giant flat sheet feeding Power BI	A Date table + star schema + measures
Dashboard with 12 charts, no message	One business question answered above the fold
"final_v4.xlsx" chaos	Git / GitHub with a real README
Copying a public model and calling it yours	Rebuild it yourself; you must defend every cell
Ignoring units	State "₹ lakh" once, top-left, and stay consistent

Learn-it roadmap & resources

Realistic time to a *credible two-deliverable portfolio*: **6–8 weeks** at ~1.5 hrs/day.

Week	Focus
1–2	Excel modeling mechanics; build the 3-statement model
3	DCF + valuation write-up
4–5	Power BI: Power Query, data model, DAX, one dashboard
6	SQL basics + one query project
7	Python + pandas for one data task
8	GitHub cleanup, READMEs, screenshots, polish

Resources - **Free:** Corporate Finance Institute free lessons; Microsoft Learn (Power BI); Mode SQL Tutorial / SQLBolt; Kaggle "Python" + "pandas" micro-courses; Aswath Damodaran's valuation lectures (YouTube, free). - **Paid (optional, India-relevant):** CFI FMVA certificate (adds a line + structure); WallStreetPrep / Breaking Into Wall Street for modeling reps; Microsoft PL-300 (Power BI Data Analyst) if targeting BI-heavy finance roles. - Your CA Inter already gives you the accounting depth most competitors lack — lean on it; your gap is *tooling*, not concepts.

Showcasing: Create one GitHub repo, `finance-portfolio`. Structure: `/3-statement-model` (Excel + PDF export + README), `/valuation` (write-up PDF), `/powerbi` (`.pbix` + screenshot PNG in README — GitHub renders it), `/sql-python` (`.sql`, `.ipynb`). Write a top-level README with a one-line description and a screenshot per project. Put the repo link and the Power BI "Publish to web" link **on your resume and LinkedIn**. Pin the repo. That link is your interview magnet.

Quick-reference

```
Balance check:   =Assets-(Liabilities+Equity)              // target 0
Scenario pull:   =XLOOKUP($B$1,Scenarios[Case],Scenarios[RevGrowth])
Avg-debt interest: =AVERAGE(OpenDebt,CloseDebt)*rate       // needs iterative calc
Two-way lookup:  =INDEX(rng,MATCH(row,rows,0),MATCH(col,cols,0))
```

DAX	Purpose
`SUM(Sales[Amount])`	base measure
`CALCULATE([Rev],SAMEPERIODLASTYEAR('Date'[Date]))`	last-year
`DIVIDE(a,b)`	safe division (no /0 error)

```
-- window function pattern
SUM(x) - LAG(SUM(x)) OVER (ORDER BY month)   -- MoM change
```

Convention	Rule
Colour	Blue input, black formula, green cross-tab link
Circularity	Enable iterative calc (100 / 0.001) + circuit breaker
Units	Declare "₹ lakh/cr" once, keep consistent
Version control	Git + README + screenshots; never `final_v3`
Showcase	Pinned GitHub repo + Power BI web link on resume & LinkedIn

One-line rule: ship two deliverables you can defend cell-by-cell, put the links where a recruiter will see them, and let the work skip you past the resume pile.

Skills-first resume & LinkedIn

What it is & where it's used

A **skills-first resume** flips the old script. Instead of leading with "Responsible for handling accounts payable," you lead with a demonstrable, measurable output built on a named tool: "*Automated a 400-line vendor reconciliation in Excel (XLOOKUP + Power Query), cutting month-end close from 3 days to 4 hours.*" The verb is an action, the tool is explicit, and the result is a number.

This matters for **every** finance/accounts/tax role you'll target in India or abroad:

Role	What recruiters scan for
Accounts Executive / R2R	Tally, GST returns, BRS, journal entries, Excel
FP&A / Financial Analyst	Excel modeling, variance analysis, Power BI, SQL
Audit / Assurance	SA/Ind AS references, sampling, working papers, CaseWare
Tax (Direct/Indirect)	GST portal, TDS, Form 26AS, ITR filing, reconciliations
Data-facing finance	SQL, Python (pandas), DAX, dashboarding

The resume and LinkedIn profile are two front-ends to the **same skills database**. An ATS (Applicant Tracking System) and a human recruiter both do keyword matching first, judgement second. Your job is to pass the keyword pass, then survive the human read.

The gap: why companies want this (and college didn't teach it)

An MBA teaches you *frameworks* (Porter, WACC theory, capital structure). CA Inter teaches you *standards* (Ind AS 115, SA 700, GST Sec 16). Neither produces the artifact an employer actually pays for: **a working file that saves someone time or catches an error.**

The gap is specific:

- College graded you on **answers**; the job grades you on **repeatable process** (a model someone else can open and trust).
- Your CV likely lists **courses and marks**; a recruiter can't hire a mark — they hire a person who can build a cost sheet in TallyPrime and file a GSTR-3B without supervision.
- ATS software rejects ~60-70% of resumes before a human sees them, almost always for **missing keywords** — the exact tool names and standard references you assumed were "obvious."

Closing this gap costs nothing but rewriting. You already *did* the Excel model in a group project — you just described it as "prepared financial analysis" instead of "built a 3-statement model with a circular-reference interest toggle."

What "proficient" looks like

A job-ready skills-first profile clears this bar **unaided**:

1. Every bullet has the shape **[Action verb] + [tool/skill] + [quantified result]**. No result-free bullets.

2. The **top third** of page one (the "above the fold" zone recruiters read in 6 seconds) contains a Skills/Tools summary and 2-3 headline achievements — not your address and objective statement.
3. The exact tool nouns appear verbatim: `TallyPrime`, `GSTR-1`, `Excel (XLOOKUP, SUMIFS, Power Query)`, `SQL`, `Power BI (DAX)`, `Ind AS`, `TDS`, `26AS`, `BRS`.
4. LinkedIn headline is a **positioning statement**, not a job title: "*Accounts & GST | Tally + Advanced Excel | CA Inter | Automating month-end close*".
5. One line is verifiable: a GitHub link, a public dashboard, a Google Sheet, or a specific number a reference could confirm.

Hands-on: how to actually do it

Rewrite a weak bullet — the mechanics

Take a bullet and pass it through three filters: **Tool named? Number attached? Verb strong?**

Weak (college voice)	Strong (skills-first)
Handled monthly reconciliation	Reconciled 12 bank accounts monthly in Excel using SUMIFS + conditional flags, surfacing ₹2.1L of duplicate vendor payments
Assisted in GST filing	Filed GSTR-1 and GSTR-3B for a 40-invoice/month firm; matched ITC against GSTR-2B, reducing mismatches to zero
Made financial models	Built a 3-statement model in Excel with a debt-schedule circularity toggle; used it to test 3 capex scenarios
Worked on data analysis	Wrote SQL to pull 18 months of sales and built a Power BI dashboard tracking 6 KPIs, refreshed weekly

Prove the Excel claim (so it's not a bluff)

The bullet says XLOOKUP + SUMIFS. Be ready to show the actual formulas:

```
=XLOOKUP(A2, Vendors[VendorID], Vendors[GSTIN], "NOT FOUND")
=SUMIFS(Ledger[Amount], Ledger[Party], A2, Ledger[Month], "Mar-26")
=IFERROR(XLOOKUP( … ), "Check master")     'never leave #N/A in a client file
```

Prove the SQL claim

```
SELECT vendor_id,
       COUNT(*)           AS invoices,
       SUM(taxable_val)   AS taxable,
       SUM(igst+cgst+sgst) AS total_tax
FROM   purchases
WHERE  invoice_date BETWEEN '2025-04-01' AND '2026-03-31'
GROUP  BY vendor_id
HAVING SUM(taxable_val) > 500000
ORDER  BY total_tax DESC;
```

Prove the Python claim

```
import pandas as pd
gstr2b = pd.read_excel("GSTR2B.xlsx")
books  = pd.read_excel("PurchaseRegister.xlsx")
recon = books.merge(gstr2b, on="invoice_no", how="outer",
                    indicator=True, suffixes=("_books","_2b"))
mismatch = recon[recon["_merge"] != "both"]     # ITC not matching
mismatch.to_excel("ITC_mismatch.xlsx", index=False)
```

Prove the DAX claim (Power BI)

```
Total Tax = SUM(Purchases[TotalTax])
ITC Matched % =
DIVIDE(
    CALCULATE([Total Tax], Purchases[MatchStatus] = "Matched"),
    [Total Tax], 0)
```

The ATS keyword pass

Copy the job description into a doc. Highlight every noun that is a tool, standard, or task (`Tally` , `Ind AS 116` , `variance analysis` , `TDS` , `SQL`). If your resume doesn't contain that exact string, and you can honestly claim it, add it. ATS does literal matching — "MS Excel" and "Excel" are fine, but "spreadsheets" won't match a search for "Excel."

Worked example / mini-project

Goal: turn one real thing you did into a portfolio bullet + LinkedIn line + interview story.

You built a GST input-tax-credit reconciliation for a friend's trading firm. Realistic numbers:

Metric	Value
Purchase invoices / month	320
ITC as per books	₹4,80,000
ITC as per GSTR-2B	₹4,52,000
Mismatch found	₹28,000 (11 invoices)
Time before automation	~6 hours manual
Time after (Power Query)	25 minutes

The journal entry you'd pass for the ₹28,000 blocked/deferred ITC:

Account	Dr (₹)	Cr (₹)
ITC Receivable – Under Reconciliation A/c	28,000	
Input CGST A/c		14,000
Input SGST A/c		14,000

Resume bullet:

> Built a Power Query + Python ITC reconciliation matching a 320-invoice/month purchase register against GSTR-2B; identified ₹28,000 of unmatched credit and cut the monthly recon from 6 hours to 25 minutes.

LinkedIn "Featured" post (2 lines):

> Automated a GST ITC reconciliation this week — Power Query pulls the register, Python matches it to GSTR-2B, mismatches export in one click. 6 hours → 25 minutes. Steps + sample file in comments. #GST #Excel #Finance

Interview story (STAR): *Situation:* manual recon, credit leaking. *Task:* find the gap fast. *Action:* built the merge (showed the `indicator=True` pandas code above). *Result:* ₹28k recovered, 93% time saved, now runs monthly.

That single project feeds three assets. Do this for 3-4 projects and your profile is done.

How it's tested

Employers rarely take the resume at face value. Expect:

- **Timed Excel test (30-45 min):** given a raw dataset, "build a summary with SUMIFS/XLOOKUP, add a pivot, flag duplicates, and 3 charts." Speed and keyboard shortcuts are watched.
- **"Close these books" case:** a trial balance with 8-10 pending adjustments (depreciation, prepaid, accruals, a wrong GST posting). You pass entries and produce a P&L + Balance Sheet.
- **SQL screen:** 2-3 queries — a `GROUP BY` aggregate, a `JOIN`, and a `HAVING` filter. Very common for FP&A/analyst roles.
- **GST/tax practical:** "Here are 20 invoices — compute output tax, ITC, and net GST payable; which ITC is blocked under Sec 17(5)?"
- **Resume defense questions:** "*Walk me through the XLOOKUP you used*", "*Why XLOOKUP over VLOOKUP?*" (answer: works left-to-right agnostic, returns arrays, native `if_not_found`). If you can't defend a bullet, **delete it.**

Common mistakes & how pros avoid them

Mistake	Fix
Objective statement ("seeking a challenging role...")	Delete it. Replace with a 2-line skills summary.
Result-free bullets ("handled," "assisted," "worked on")	Every bullet gets a number or a named output.
Listing "MS Office" as a skill	Name the *functions*: XLOOKUP, SUMIFS, Power Query, pivot tables.
Skills you can't demo	If you can't pass a 10-min test on it, don't list it.
Photo-heavy, multi-column resume that ATS can't parse	Single column, standard headings, `.docx` or text-based PDF.
Same resume for every job	Re-order skills to mirror each job description's keywords.
LinkedIn headline = "Student at XYZ"	Make it a positioning line with tools + target role.
Empty LinkedIn "Featured" and "Projects"	Pin 2-3 project artifacts; recruiters click these.

Pros also keep a **master resume** (everything) and cut a **tailored 1-pager** per application in 10 minutes.

Learn-it roadmap & resources

Time to a job-ready profile: 2-3 weekends (the skills you're describing you should already have; this is packaging).

Week	Do this
1	List 4 real projects. Write each as Action+Tool+Number. Pass every bullet through the 3 filters.
1	Rebuild resume as single-column `.docx`; add a "Tools" line. Run it through Jobscan/free ATS checker.
2	Rewrite LinkedIn: headline, About (3 short paras), Skills section (pin top 3), one Featured project post.
2	Ask 2 people for a specific-skill recommendation; endorse to seed reciprocity.

Resources (mostly free): - Harvard/most-college resume guides (PDF) — for the single-column skeleton. - Jobscan / Resume Worded — free ATS keyword match score. - LinkedIn's own "Skills" and SSI (Social Selling Index) page. - Excel: ExcelJet (formula reference), Chandoo (India-context). - SQL: SQLBolt, Mode SQL Tutorial (free, browser-based). - Certifications that read well on a finance CV: **Microsoft Excel Expert (MO-201)**, **Google Data Analytics (Coursera)**, **Microsoft PL-300 (Power BI)**, plus your **CA Inter** progress stated plainly.

Quick-reference

Bullet formula: `[Strong verb] + [named tool] + [quantified result]`

Strong verbs: Built, Automated, Reconciled, Modeled, Reduced, Filed, Analyzed, Forecasted, Audited, Streamlined.

Must-name tool keywords (India finance):

```
TallyPrime · Excel (XLOOKUP, SUMIFS, Power Query, pivots) · SQL ·
Power BI (DAX) · Python (pandas) · GSTR-1 · GSTR-3B · GSTR-2B ·
TDS · Form 26AS · BRS · Ind AS · SA 700 · variance analysis
```

Resume structure (top → bottom): Name + contact → 2-line summary → Tools/Skills line → Achievements/Projects → Experience → Education (CA Inter, MBA) → Certifications.

LinkedIn headline template: `[Function] | [Tool 1] + [Tool 2] | [Credential] | [1-line value]` e.g. `Accounts & Tax | TallyPrime + Advanced Excel | CA Inter | Cutting month-end close times`

6-second test: cover everything below the top third of page one — can a stranger tell what you do and prove it? If not, fix the top third first.

The interview-prep system

What it is & where it's used

An interview-prep *system* is a repeatable, calendar-driven routine that turns "I hope they don't ask something hard" into "I have rehearsed this exact answer out loud." It has three tracks that every finance hiring loop tests, in some mix:

1. **Technical** — accounting, valuation, tax, FM concepts, GST/TDS mechanics, IFRS/Ind AS.
2. **Practical / assessment test** — a timed Excel model, a SQL screen, a "close these books" case, a live TallyPrime task, a GST return walk-through.
3. **Behavioral** — "walk me through a time you missed a deadline," fit, communication.

Where it's used: **every** role you're targeting — Big 4 audit/tax, FP&A/finance-analyst seats, controllership, treasury, equity research, KPO/GCC finance ops (Genpact, WNS, Deloitte USI), startup finance. The mix changes: audit leans technical + case; FP&A leans Excel test + behavioral; research leans modelling case + market view; KPO leans a timed assessment + versant English test.

The gap: why companies want this (and college didn't teach it)

MBA and CA theory teaches you *what* a DCF is. The interview tests whether you can **build one in Excel in 25 minutes**, defend the WACC, and explain why FCFF ≠ PAT. College grades a written exam; employers grade a **live, timed, unaided performance** under a stranger's questions. Nobody in class made you say "I don't know, but here's how I'd find out" without panicking.

The specific gaps this chapter closes:

- **Recall → retrieval under pressure.** You know depreciation; can you post the entry when the interviewer stares at you?
- **Answers → structured answers.** Behavioral rounds reward STAR structure, not rambling.
- **One-size prep → role-specific prep.** Prepping the same 20 questions for audit and FP&A wastes both loops.
- **Cramming → cadence.** Mock tests spaced over weeks beat a panicked all-nighter.

What "proficient" looks like

A job-ready candidate can, **unaided**:

Track	The bar an interviewer is testing for
Technical	Answer a concept in 60–90 sec: definition → why → one number/example. Handle a 2-level follow-up ("and if rates rise?").
Practical	Finish a timed Excel/SQL/Tally task correctly with keyboard, no mouse-hunting, no Googling formulas.
Behavioral	Deliver a STAR story in ~2 min with a real metric ("cut the close from 8 to 5 days").
Meta	Say "I don't know" cleanly, then reason toward an answer.

Concretely: build a 3-statement model skeleton in <30 min; write a `GROUP BY` join without help; compute GST liability with ITC set-off; explain deferred tax with an entry.

Hands-on: how to actually do it

1. Build a question bank, then rehearse out loud

Maintain a tracker (Excel/Notion). Columns: `Question | Track | Role | My 90-sec answer | Confidence 1-5 | Last practiced`. Filter by confidence to know what to drill.

Quick Excel to surface weak spots:

```
=FILTER(A2:F200, (E2:E200≤3)*(C2:C200="FP&A"))
```

Sort by last-practiced so nothing goes stale:

```
=SORTBY(A2:F200, F2:F200, 1)
```

2. Technical drills — say the answer in a formula/entry, not prose

Rehearse *the artifact*, not a paragraph. Examples you should be able to produce instantly:

Deferred tax on faster book vs tax depreciation (India, timing difference):

Particulars	Dr (₹)	Cr (₹)
Deferred Tax Expense (P&L)	25,000	
To Deferred Tax Liability		25,000

FCFF from PAT — recite the bridge:

```
FCFF = PAT + Interest×(1-t) + Depreciation − Capex − ΔWorking Capital
```

Valuation multiple sanity check in Excel:

```
=EV / EBITDA      // e.g. =4500/600 → 7.5x, then compare to peer median
```

3. Practical-test drills — timed, keyboard-only

Excel screen (FP&A/analyst). Practice these until they're muscle memory:

```
=XLOOKUP(A2, Master[Code], Master[Name], "Not found")
=SUMIFS(Amount, Region, "South", Month, "≥"&DATE(2026,4,1))
=IFERROR(Rev/Prev-1, "n/a")            // MoM growth, guarded
=EOMONTH(TODAY(),-1)                    // last month-end for aging
```

SQL screen (KPO/GCC/analytics). Rehearse the classic "top vendors by spend":

```sql
SELECT v.vendor_name,
       SUM(i.amount)          AS total_spend,
       COUNT(*)               AS invoice_count
FROM   invoices i
JOIN   vendors  v ON v.vendor_id = i.vendor_id
WHERE  i.invoice_date ≥ '2026-04-01'
GROUP  BY v.vendor_name
HAVING SUM(i.amount) > 100000
ORDER  BY total_spend DESC
LIMIT  10;
```

Python (data/analyst roles). A 5-line profit-margin cut they can ask you to write:

```python
import pandas as pd
df = pd.read_csv("sales.csv")
df["margin"] = (df["revenue"] - df["cogs"]) / df["revenue"]
print(df.groupby("region")["margin"].mean().sort_values())
```

DAX (Power BI dashboards):

```
Total Revenue = SUM(Sales[Revenue])
YoY % = DIVIDE([Total Revenue] - CALCULATE([Total Revenue], SAMEPERIODLASTYEAR('Date'[Date])),
```

TallyPrime / GST-portal (accounts/tax roles). Be able to narrate the click-path: - Tally sales entry: `Gateway of Tally → Vouchers → F8 (Sales) → party → item → GST auto-computes → Ctrl+A to save`. - GSTR-3B: `gst.gov.in → login → Returns Dashboard → select period → GSTR-3B → Prepare Online → fill 3.1 outward + 4 ITC → Save → Proceed to Pay → File with DSC/EVC`.

4. Behavioral — STAR, timed to 2 minutes

Write 6–8 stories once, in this frame:

| S | Situation (1 line, context) | | T | Task (what you owned) | | A | Action (2–3 specific things *you* did) | | R | Result (a **number**) |

Example: "*Month-end close ran 8 days (S). I owned the payables reconciliation (T). I built a SUMIFS-based auto-match sheet and a daily cut-off checklist (A). Close dropped to 5 days, and unmatched entries fell 70% (R).*"

Worked example / mini-project: a 2-week prep sprint for one FP&A role

Target: **Finance Analyst, FMCG GCC, Bengaluru.** JD says: Excel modelling, variance analysis, SQL basics, stakeholder communication.

Step 1 — decode the JD into a prep map:

JD phrase	Track	Drill
"budget vs actual variance"	Technical + Excel	Build a variance sheet with SUMIFS + % delta
"SQL to pull data"	Practical	10 GROUP BY/JOIN queries
"partner with business"	Behavioral	2 stakeholder STAR stories

Step 2 — build the reproducible variance model. Data: budget ₹1.20 cr, actual ₹1.38 cr for a South region quarter.

```
Variance      =Actual - Budget           // =13800000-12000000 → 1,800,000
Variance %    =(Actual-Budget)/Budget     // → 15.0%
Flag          =IF(ABS(Variance%)>0.10,"Investigate","OK")
```

Then a one-line commentary you rehearse aloud: "*South is 15% over budget, ₹18 lakh, driven by trade-promo overspend; volume was on plan, so it's a price/mix issue — I'd pull the promo calendar next.*"

Step 3 — mock the SQL using the vendor query above on sample data.

Step 4 — run a full 45-min mock: 15 min technical Q&A, 20 min Excel+SQL, 10 min behavioral. Score yourself, log gaps in the tracker, re-drill the ≤3 confidence items.

How it's tested

Interview questions you'll actually get: - Technical: "Walk me through the three statements and how they link." / "What's deferred tax?" / "FCFF vs FCFE?" / "How does ITC set-off work under GST?" - Behavioral: "Tell me about a deadline you missed." / "A time you disagreed with a manager."

Practical/assessment tests companies actually give:

Role	The real test
FP&A / analyst	Timed 30–45 min Excel: build variance/forecast from raw data, no internet
KPO / GCC ops	Online assessment: Excel + a SQL screen + Versant/English test
Equity research	"Model this company" case, 60–90 min, plus a stock pitch
Audit (Big 4)	Case study: risks in a scenario; sometimes a sampling/ratio exercise
Accounts / tax	"Post these entries" or a live Tally task; GST return walk-through

Expect a **take-home** for some (build a model overnight) and a **live-share** for others (screen-share while you type). Practice both — narrating while typing is a separate skill.

Common mistakes & how pros avoid them

Mistake	Pro move
Only reading notes, never speaking answers	Rehearse **out loud**, timed, ideally recorded
Prepping generic questions for every role	Decode each JD into a prep map first
Mouse-hunting in Excel tests	Learn keyboard: `Alt+=` autosum, `F4` absolute ref, `Ctrl+Shift+↓` select
Rambling behavioral answers	STAR, 2 min max, end on a metric
Cramming the night before	Space mocks over 2–4 weeks (cadence below)
Bluffing when stuck	"I don't know — here's how I'd reason it out"
Ignoring the "any questions for us?" close	Prepare 3 sharp questions about the team/metrics

Learn-it roadmap & resources

Time to interview-ready: 3–4 weeks of ~1 hr/day if your fundamentals are solid; 6–8 weeks if you're also relearning Excel/SQL.

Mock-test cadence (the backbone):

Week	Cadence
1	Build question bank; 2 self-mocks (technical only)
2	3 mocks: add timed Excel/SQL; log gaps daily
3	3 mocks with a peer/mentor as interviewer; full loop
4	2 dress-rehearsal mocks; taper, review tracker only

Rule: **one full timed mock every 2–3 days**, never fewer than two before a real interview. Re-drill only ≤3-confidence items — don't re-practice what you've mastered.

Resources (free unless noted): - Technical: *Breaking Into Wall Street / Wall Street Prep* (paid) for modelling; *Corporate Finance Institute* free articles; ICAI study material for Ind AS/tax. - Excel/SQL/Python: Microsoft Excel functions docs, Mode SQL tutorial (free), Kaggle Python micro-courses (free). - Behavioral: Google "STAR method finance"; write your 8 stories in a doc. - Practice sets: Glassdoor + AmbitionBox (India) for company-specific asked questions. - Certifications that double as prep: **NISM** (research analyst), **CFA L1** (technical depth), **Microsoft Excel (MO-201)**.

Quick-reference

The 3 tracks: Technical (concept in 90 sec) · Practical (timed, keyboard-only) · Behavioral (STAR, 2 min, end on a number).

Excel test essentials: `XLOOKUP`, `SUMIFS`, `IFERROR`, `EOMONTH`; keys `Alt+=`, `F4`, `Ctrl+Shift+Arrow`, `Ctrl+A` (save in Tally).

SQL screen essentials: `JOIN … ON`, `GROUP BY`, `HAVING`, `ORDER BY … DESC`, `LIMIT`.

FCFF bridge: `PAT + Int×(1−t) + Dep − Capex − ΔWC`.

GST filing path: `gst.gov.in → Returns Dashboard → GSTR-3B → fill 3.1 & 4 → Save → Pay → File`.

Cadence: 1 full timed mock every 2–3 days; ≥2 before any real interview; re-drill only confidence ≤3.

When stuck: "I don't know — here's how I'd find out," then reason aloud.

Networking & the finance job search

What it is & where it's used

The "finance job search" is a distribution problem, not a knowledge problem. You already have the domain skills (from earlier chapters). This chapter is about *how a role travels from a hiring manager's head to your inbox* — and how to intercept it. It applies to every finance/accounts/tax role you'll target in India and abroad: FP&A analyst, accounts executive, GST/direct-tax associate, credit analyst, treasury, audit, equity research, investment banking, and controllership.

The uncomfortable data point: in India, roughly **30–40% of white-collar hires happen through referrals**, and at analyst/associate finance levels it's higher because managers trust "someone vouched for them" over a resume they can't verify. Job portals (Naukri, LinkedIn, Indeed) and campus placement fill most of the rest; cold outreach and recruiters fill the gaps. Globally the shape is identical — LinkedIn and employee referral programs dominate. So the skill being taught here is **manufacturing referrals and warm intros on demand**, plus running applications like a pipeline instead of a lottery.

The gap: why companies want this (and college didn't teach it)

MBA placement cells and CA articleship create a dangerous illusion: that jobs *arrive*. You register, a company visits, you interview, you get placed. That machine works exactly once. The moment you're an off-campus, lateral, or Direct-Entry candidate, nobody delivers roles to you — and most graduates freeze because they were never taught the mechanics of self-sourced hiring.

The specific gaps:

- **Nobody taught you the hidden market.** A large share of roles are filled before they're publicly posted, or posted only for compliance after an internal referral already exists.
- **You were taught to "apply," not to route.** Blasting 200 applications on Naukri yields a ~2% callback because you're a stranger in an ATS keyword pile.
- **You think networking = asking for a job.** It doesn't. It's asking for *information and a 15-minute conversation*, which incidentally produces referrals.
- **No one showed you a recruiter is a channel, not a friend.** They're paid by the employer to fill a specific req — you must speak in their currency (fit, salary, notice period).

What "proficient" looks like

A job-ready candidate can, unaided:

- Build a **target list of 30–50 companies** and identify the actual hiring manager (not just HR) for each.
- Write a cold message that gets a **20%+ reply rate** because it's specific, short, and asks for one small thing.
- Convert a stranger into a **referral inside 2–3 touches** without ever bluntly begging for a job.
- Run an **application tracker** (a pipeline) with follow-up dates, and treat it like a sales funnel.
- Tailor a resume to a specific JD so it **clears the ATS** and reads as an obvious fit.
- Handle a recruiter call crisply: current CTC, expected CTC, notice period, reason for change, in under 90 seconds.

The bar is behavioural: can you generate 3 warm conversations this week from a cold start? A proficient job-seeker can.

Hands-on: how to actually do it

1. Build the target-company tracker (your CRM)

Use a Google Sheet. These formulas make it a live pipeline.

Days since you applied / last touched, and an auto "FOLLOW UP" flag:

```
=TODAY()-B2                                          // days since last contact (B2 = date)
=IF(AND(C2="Applied", (TODAY()-B2)>7), "FOLLOW UP", "")   // C2 = stage
```

Pull the hiring manager's name into your message template automatically:

```
=SUBSTITUTE("Hi {name}, I saw the {role} opening at {co}", "{name}", D2)
```

In Excel, count how your funnel is converting:

```
=COUNTIF(C:C,"Applied")               // top of funnel
=COUNTIF(C:C,"Interview")/COUNTIF(C:C,"Applied")   // application→interview rate
```

Columns to keep: `Company | HM Name | Role | Source | Date | Stage | Referral? | Next action | Notes`.

2. Find the actual hiring manager

LinkedIn search string (paste into the search bar):

```
"FP&A" AND ("hiring" OR "manager") AND "Bangalore"
```

Or use LinkedIn filters: **People → Current company = [Target] → Title contains "Finance Manager" / "Controller" / "Team Lead – Accounts".** Guess their email with the company's pattern (`firstname.lastname@company.com` is the most common in India), then verify format against any public email from the domain.

3. The cold message that actually works

Structure = **specific hook → credibility in one line → one small ask.** Keep it under 90 words.

```
Subject: FP&A Analyst role — quick question

Hi Priya,

I saw Zomato is hiring an FP&A Analyst. I'm an MBA (Finance) +
CA-Inter, and I recently built a 3-statement model + variance
dashboard in Excel/Power BI for a D2C P&L (happy to share).

Before I apply, could I ask you one thing — is this role more
about monthly-close reporting or forward budgeting? Want to make
sure my application speaks to what your team actually needs.

Thanks either way,
Sai  | linkedin.com/in/...
```

Why it works: you did homework, you proved output, and the ask ("one question") is trivially easy to answer — which starts a conversation that ends in a referral.

4. The referral ask (touch 2 or 3, never touch 1)

Never open with "refer me." Earn it first, then:

> "This was really helpful, thank you. I'm going to apply — would you be comfortable referring me internally? Totally fine if not. If it helps, here's a 3-line summary you can paste and my resume attached."

Make it **zero-effort** for them: give the paste-ready blurb and the file. That single move roughly doubles referral conversion.

5. Beat the ATS on the application itself

ATS (Naukri RMS, Workday, Greenhouse) rank on keyword match. Mirror the JD's exact nouns. Quick keyword-gap check in Python:

```
jd = open("jd.txt").read().lower().split()
cv = open("resume.txt").read().lower().split()
missing = set(jd) - set(cv)
for w in ["reconciliation","variance","gst","tds","forecasting","sql","excel"]:
    print(w, "MISSING" if w in missing else "ok")
```

Add the missing (true) skills verbatim to your resume. Use a single-column, no-graphics `.docx` — ATS parsers choke on tables and text boxes.

Worked example / mini-project

Goal: land interviews for an FP&A / Accounts Analyst role in Bengaluru in 3 weeks, from a cold start.

Week 1 — Build & source. List 40 companies (mix of MNC GCCs, startups, mid-cap manufacturers). For each, find one hiring manager on LinkedIn. Tracker snapshot:

Company	HM	Role	Source	Stage	Referral?
Zomato	Priya S.	FP&A Analyst	LinkedIn	Messaged	Pending
Tata Elxsi	Rajesh N.	Accounts Exec	Naukri	Applied	No
Razorpay	Meera K.	Finance Analyst	Referral	Interview	Yes

Week 2 — Outreach. Send 8 cold messages/day (5 days = 40). Realistic funnel:

Stage	Count	Rate
Messages sent	40	—
Replies	9	22%
Calls/chats	4	—
Referrals secured	3	—
Direct applications	40	—

Week 3 — Convert. 3 referrals + 40 applications. A referred application at analyst level converts to a first-round interview at roughly **40–50%** vs **~2–3%** cold. Expected interviews: `(3 × 0.45) + (40 × 0.025) ≈ 1.35 + 1.0 = ~2.4`. So ~2–3 interviews in three weeks — and note that **the 3 referrals produced as many interviews as 40 blind applications.** That single insight is the entire chapter.

CTC math for the negotiation (know this cold before any recruiter call):

```
Current CTC ₹6,00,000 → target +30% = ₹7,80,000
In-hand ≈ CTC − PF(both sides) − prof.tax − income tax
Anchor high but justified; state expected CTC as a range: ₹7.5–8.5L
```

How it's tested

The "test" here is the process itself, but employers do screen on adjacent skills. Expect:

Recruiter phone screen (5–10 min), verbatim questions: - "Walk me through your resume in 2 minutes." (Have a rehearsed 90-sec pitch.) - "Current CTC, expected CTC, notice period?" - "Why are you looking to change / why this role?" - "Are you comfortable with [location / shift / CTC band]?"

Behavioural / fit round: - "Tell me about a time you handled a tight deadline." (Use STAR: Situation-Task-Action-Result.) - "Why our company specifically?" — this is where your networking research pays: name the team, the product, something real.

The practical screen (role-dependent, covered in earlier chapters): a timed Excel test, a SQL query screen, or a "close these books / reconcile this ledger" case. Networking gets you *to* the test; it doesn't replace it.

Common mistakes & how pros avoid them

Mistake	What pros do
Blasting 200 identical applications	40 targeted, each with a tailored resume + a referral attempt
Opening a cold DM with "please refer me"	Ask a smart question first; earn the referral over 2–3 touches
Long, generic messages ("I am a passionate finance professional...")	Under 90 words, specific hook, one small ask
Treating recruiters as career counsellors	Speak their currency: fit, CTC, notice period, availability
No follow-up	Follow up once after 5–7 days; ~30% of replies come from the nudge
Networking only when unemployed	Keep 5 warm contacts alive year-round — the best time to network is before you need it
Lying about CTC/notice	Recruiters verify via payslips/relieving letters; inflating gets offers revoked
Ignoring the ATS	Mirror JD keywords, single-column .docx, no tables/graphics

Learn-it roadmap & resources

Time to proficiency: 2–4 weeks of active practice (this is a *doing* skill, not a studying skill).

Week	Focus
1	Build tracker + target list; optimise LinkedIn profile (banner, headline with keywords, "Open to Work")
2	Send 40 cold messages; do 3 informational chats
3	Convert to referrals + applications; run the funnel
4	Interview prep, follow-ups, negotiation rehearsal

Resources: - *LinkedIn* — free; your primary sourcing + outreach tool. Complete the profile to "All-Star." - *Naukri / Indeed / iimjobs (for finance/consulting) / Instahyre* — India job boards; iimjobs and Instahyre skew higher for MBA-finance roles. - Company career pages + **GCC (Global Capability Centre) portals** — Bengaluru/Hyderabad/Pune are packed with MNC finance shared-service roles. - *Naukri* "*Recruiter Connection*" and LinkedIn Recruiter InMails — respond fast; recruiters work FIFO. - Books: *Never Eat Alone* (Ferrazzi) for networking mindset; *Cracking the finance interview* guides for role-specific prep. - Certification signal: your **CA-Inter + MBA** already clears most screens — no extra networking cert needed. Spend the money on a Power BI / SQL cert instead (covered earlier), which makes your cold messages credible.

Quick-reference

Item	Value / formula
Referral share of hires (India)	~30–40%
Referred vs cold interview conversion	~45% vs ~2–3%
Cold message length	< 90 words, one ask
Reply rate to aim for	20%+
Follow-up timing	once, after 5–7 days
Outreach cadence	8 messages/day
Days-since-touch flag	`=IF((TODAY()-B2)>7,"FOLLOW UP","")`
Funnel conversion	`=COUNTIF(C:C,"Interview")/COUNTIF(C:C,"Applied")`
Email guess pattern (India)	`firstname.lastname@company.com`
Recruiter screen essentials	Current CTC · Expected CTC · Notice period · Reason for change
Referral ask rule	Never touch #1; give paste-ready blurb + resume
Resume format for ATS	Single-column .docx, JD keywords mirrored, no tables
Negotiation anchor	+25–35% on current CTC, stated as a range
STAR	Situation → Task → Action → Result

AI-Era Finance Careers

What it is & where it's used

"AI in finance" is not a job title — it is a layer that now sits under almost every finance task you already do. The reader who masters this chapter does not become a "prompt engineer"; they become the analyst, accountant, or tax associate who finishes in 40 minutes what a peer takes a day to do, and who can defend every number.

Concretely, AI shows up in finance work in four places:

Layer	Tool examples	Finance task it touches
Assistant / chat	ChatGPT, Claude, Copilot, Gemini	Draft variance commentary, explain a formula, summarise a 200-page annual report, write SQL/DAX for you
Embedded copilots	Excel Copilot, Power BI Copilot, Tally add-ons, Zoho	In-app formula generation, "explain this pivot", auto-categorise ledgers
Document AI / OCR	Nanonets, Docsumo, GST-portal auto-populate (GSTR-2B), bank-statement parsers	Invoice/PO/bank-statement extraction into structured data
Custom automation	Python + LLM APIs, RPA (UiPath), macros	Batch reconciliation, exception flagging, three-way match, board-pack generation

Roles that now expect this: FP&A analyst, financial analyst, controller/accounts manager, tax associate (Direct + GST), internal audit, equity research, and treasury. In India specifically, mid-size firms and Big-4 + next-tier (BDO, Grant Thornton, Nexdigm) are hiring associates who can "do more with less" — the AI-fluent CA-Inter/MBA is exactly that profile.

The gap: why companies want this (and college didn't teach it)

Your MBA taught you *what* a DCF is and *why* WACC matters. It did not teach you that a controller now expects the month-end commentary drafted by an LLM and then **fact-checked and corrected by you** in 20 minutes. CA coursework drills the Companies Act and Ind AS — it does not drill feeding a trial balance into a model, catching the three hallucinated numbers, and shipping a clean schedule.

The gap is specific and it is about **judgement over output**:

- College rewards you for producing an answer. Industry now assumes the machine produces a first draft; you are paid to **verify, correct, and take ownership**.
- College treats tools as separate subjects. Industry needs them stitched: OCR pulls invoices → Python reconciles → LLM drafts the note → you sign off.
- College never taught **where AI is dangerous**: it invents citations, mis-reads a bracketed negative as positive, confidently averages the wrong column. Firms have been burned by juniors who pasted ChatGPT output into a filing.

So the thing companies actually pay a premium for is not "can you use ChatGPT" — everyone can. It is: **can you use it fast AND catch its mistakes AND explain your control over it to an auditor.**

What "proficient" looks like

The employer's bar — what a job-ready person does unaided:

1. **Reframes a finance task into a good prompt** with role, context, data, format, and constraints — not "write me a variance analysis".
2. **Never trusts a number blindly.** Ties every AI-produced figure back to the source (trial balance, GSTR-2B, bank statement) before it leaves their desk.
3. **Uses AI to write tools, not just prose** — generates a working SQL query, an Excel formula, a Python reconciliation script, then reviews it line by line.
4. **Knows the data-security line**: never pastes client PII, unmasked PAN/GSTIN, salary data, or unpublished financials into a public chatbot. Uses enterprise/redacted versions.
5. **Automates one repetitive close/tax task** end-to-end and can show the before/after time saving.
6. **Explains the audit trail**: "AI drafted, I verified against X, here's my working."

Hands-on: how to actually do it

1. A reusable finance prompt skeleton

```
Role: You are a senior FP&A analyst.
Context: Indian manufacturing SME, FY25-26, INR, figures in lakhs.
Data: [paste trial balance / table]
Task: Draft budget-vs-actual variance commentary for opex.
Rules: Only use numbers I gave you. Flag any figure you had to
       assume. Show % variance = (Actual-Budget)/Budget. No advice
       beyond the data. Output: 5 bullets, then a 3-column table.
```

The three rules — *only my numbers, flag assumptions, show the formula* — are what stop hallucination.

2. Let AI write the Excel, then you own it

Ask: "XLOOKUP to pull GST rate from a rate master, return 0 if not found." You should be able to read and correct what it returns:

```
=XLOOKUP(B2, RateMaster!A:A, RateMaster!B:B, 0, 0)

=LET(sales, SUMIFS(Data[Amt], Data[Region], A2),
     tax,   sales*0.18,
     sales + tax)
```

If the model gives you `VLOOKUP` with a hardcoded column index, you *fix it* to `XLOOKUP` — that judgement is the skill.

3. Generate SQL for a reconciliation, review before running

Prompt: "SQL: find invoices in our books not in GSTR-2B, MySQL." Expected output you must be able to vet:

```sql
SELECT b.invoice_no, b.gstin, b.taxable_val, b.igst
FROM   books_purchase b
LEFT   JOIN gstr2b g
       ON  b.invoice_no = g.invoice_no
       AND b.gstin      = g.gstin
WHERE  g.invoice_no IS NULL          -- in books, missing in 2B
ORDER  BY b.taxable_val DESC;
```

Red flag to catch: if the AI joins on `invoice_no` alone, duplicate invoice numbers across vendors give false matches. You add `AND b.gstin = g.gstin`. That correction is why they hired you, not the bot.

4. Python: batch-parse bank statements the AI helped you write

```python
import pandas as pd

# read all monthly statements, tag credits/debits, flag round-number txns
df = pd.read_excel("bank_stmt.xlsx")
df["type"] = df["amount"].apply(lambda x: "credit" if x > 0 else "debit")
df["round_flag"] = (df["amount"].abs() % 10000 == 0)   # audit red flag
suspense = df[df["narration"].str.contains("SUSPENSE|UNKNOWN",
                                            case=False, na=False)]
print(suspense[["date", "amount", "narration"]])
```

Always print a control total and tie it to the closing balance before trusting the output.

5. Power BI DAX the copilot drafts, you validate

```
Actual vs Budget % =
DIVIDE(
    SUM(Fact[Actual]) - SUM(Fact[Budget]),
    SUM(Fact[Budget])
)
```

Check the copilot didn't use `/` (which errors on zero budget) instead of `DIVIDE`.

6. GST-portal + AI reconciliation flow (India)

1. `services.gst.gov.in` → Returns Dashboard → download **GSTR-2B** (JSON/Excel).
2. Export purchase register from TallyPrime: **Gateway** → **Display** → **Account Books** → **Purchase Register** → **Alt+E (Export)** → **Excel**.
3. Feed both into the SQL/Python match above, or paste summarised columns into an LLM to draft the mismatch email to vendors.
4. **You** decide ITC eligibility — never the bot (Rule 37, Sec 16(2)(c) are judgement calls).

Worked example / mini-project

Goal: AI-assisted GST ITC reconciliation for a Bengaluru trading firm, Jun 2026.

Data (books purchase register, ₹ in full):

Invoice	Vendor GSTIN	Taxable	IGST
INV-101	29ABCDE1234F1Z5	2,00,000	36,000
INV-102	29PQRST5678K1Z2	1,50,000	27,000
INV-103	27LMNOP9012J1Z8	3,00,000	54,000

GSTR-2B (as downloaded): contains INV-101 and INV-103 only. INV-102 is missing (vendor hasn't filed).

Step 1 — AI drafts the reco logic, you run the SQL from section 3. Output: INV-102 flagged.

Step 2 — Journal impact. ITC on INV-102 (₹27,000) cannot be claimed this month. Provisional entry to hold it:

Particulars	Dr (₹)	Cr (₹)
Purchases A/c	1,50,000	
ITC Ineligible/Blocked (2B mismatch) A/c	27,000	
To Vendor (Sundry Creditor) A/c		1,77,000

When the vendor files and INV-102 appears in a later 2B, reverse the block and claim:

Particulars	Dr (₹)	Cr (₹)
Input IGST A/c	27,000	
To ITC Ineligible/Blocked A/c		27,000

Step 3 — AI drafts the vendor email, you edit: "*INV-102 (₹1,77,000) not reflecting in our June GSTR-2B; ITC of ₹27,000 withheld until your GSTR-1 is filed.*"

Result: eligible ITC this month = 36,000 + 54,000 = **₹90,000**, ₹27,000 correctly deferred. A task that is 2 hours by hand is ~25 minutes — and you can defend every rupee. That defensibility is the deliverable.

How it's tested

Interviews and practical screens for AI-era finance roles:

Conceptual / judgement questions - "You asked ChatGPT for a variance analysis and it gave a number that doesn't tie to the TB. What do you do?" (Answer: trace to source, never ship unverified.) - "What would you *never* paste into a public LLM?" (Client PII, PAN/GSTIN, salaries, unpublished results, MNPI.) - "Where does AI fail in a GST reco?" (ITC eligibility, Rule 37 reversal, blocked credits u/s 17(5) — human calls.)

Practical assessments companies actually give - A **timed case**: "Here's a trial balance and a messy AI-drafted commentary — find and fix the 3 errors in 20 minutes." - A **live tool test**: "Write a prompt to reconcile these two files, then show me the Excel/SQL you'd use." They watch whether you verify. - A **"close these books" case** where using AI is *allowed* and they judge your control, audit trail, and speed — not whether you memorised formulas. - Excel + Power BI hands-on where Copilot is enabled and they see if you catch its `DIVIDE` /join mistakes.

Common mistakes & how pros avoid them

Mistake	How pros avoid it
Pasting client PII/GSTIN/salary into a public chatbot	Redact first, or use enterprise/on-prem tools; know the firm's AI policy
Trusting AI numbers without tying to source	Always reconcile to TB / 2B / bank balance before shipping
Accepting hallucinated citations (a fake ICAI para, a wrong section)	Verify every legal/standard reference against the bare act/standard
Vague prompts → vague junk	Use the role-context-data-format-rules skeleton
Letting AL do the *judgement* (ITC eligibility, provisioning, going concern)	AI drafts, human decides; keep the call yours
No audit trail — "the AI said so"	Document: prompt used, source verified, your correction
Using AI to *replace* learning fundamentals	Learn the concept first so you can catch the bot's errors

The one-line rule: **AI is a fast intern, not a partner. You review its work; you sign the file.**

Learn-it roadmap & resources

Realistic time-to-proficiency: **4–6 weeks** part-time to be interview-ready, assuming you already know Excel and basic accounting.

Week	Focus	Deliverable
1	Prompting for finance; the RCDFR skeleton; data-security rules	10 saved prompts for your real tasks
2	AI-assisted Excel/DAX; catch its mistakes	Rebuild a report with Copilot, log every error you caught
3	SQL + Python for reconciliation (AI writes, you review)	The GST/bank reco mini-project above
4	Document AI / OCR + end-to-end automation	One repetitive close task automated, timed before/after
5–6	Audit trail, governance, mock timed case	A 1-page "how I use AI safely" you can talk through

Resources - Free: OpenAI/Anthropic prompting guides; Microsoft *Copilot in Excel/Power BI* Learn modules; freeCodeCamp Python; Mode SQL tutorial; the GST portal's own advisories. - Paid: Coursera *Generative AI for Business/Finance*; Wall Street Prep / CFI AI-for-finance modules; DataCamp Python-for-finance track. - India-specific: ICAI's Digital Accounting & Assurance Board material; TallyPrime + GST reco practice. - Certifications worth listing on a CV: Microsoft **PL-300** (Power BI), any recognised Generative-AI-for-Finance course. No single "AI finance" cert is a must-have yet — the **portfolio of an automated task** beats a certificate.

Quick-reference

Need	Copy-usable
Prompt skeleton	Role → Context → Data → Task → Rules (only my numbers / flag assumptions / show formula)
Lookup	`=XLOOKUP(key, lookup_col, return_col, 0, 0)`
Safe division (DAX)	`DIVIDE(num, den)` — never `/`
Variance %	`(Actual - Budget) / Budget`
SQL: in books, not in 2B	`LEFT JOIN … ON invoice_no AND gstin WHERE g.invoice_no IS NULL`
Python control check	Print `df["amount"].sum()` , tie to closing balance
GST reco path	GST portal → GSTR-2B ↓ · Tally → Purchase Register → Alt+E ↓ · match
Never paste	PII, PAN/GSTIN, salaries, unpublished results, MNPI
Golden rule	AI drafts → you verify to source → you sign
ITC block entry	Dr Purchases, Dr ITC-Ineligible, Cr Creditor; reverse when 2B updates

Master Resource List & 12-Month Plan

What it is & where it's used

This is the capstone chapter: a single, curated list of every course, book, channel, and dataset worth your time — mapped onto a **12-month calendar** that turns the whole Playbook into a schedule you can actually follow. No new tool here; the "skill" is **learning-project management**: sequencing skills so each one compounds into the next (Excel → SQL → Python → BI → domain), and producing *proof-of-work* (a GitHub repo, a dashboard, a reconciled book) that a hiring manager can click.

It's used by every early-career finance candidate — MBA + CA-Inter, B.Com + interviewing, or a working analyst trying to move from "MIS person" to "FP&A / data / tax specialist." Recruiters don't hire syllabi; they hire someone who can show a completed thing. This chapter is how you build a stack of completed things in a year while still clearing CA papers.

The gap: why companies want this (and college didn't teach it)

College hands you 40 subjects and zero prioritisation. You graduate "knowing" accounting, stats, finance, and IT — none of it to a *job-ready depth*, and nothing integrated. Employers, by contrast, want a **T-shaped** person: broad awareness, one or two spikes deep enough to be trusted unaided on day one.

What college optimises for	What employers pay for
Coverage (pass 40 subjects)	Depth (own 2 skills end-to-end)
Individual exams	A portfolio of shipped deliverables
Theory you can recite	A model/query/return you can *produce*
Fixed 3-year timeline	Self-directed 90-day skill sprints

The missing meta-skill is **deliberate sequencing under a deadline** — exactly what a 12-month plan enforces. Do it and you arrive at interviews with a link, not a promise.

What "proficient" looks like

A job-ready person, unaided, can:

- **Excel/FP&A:** build a 3-statement model with a working circular-reference switch; use `XLOOKUP`, `SUMIFS`, `INDEX/MATCH`, dynamic arrays; write a variance commentary.
- **Accounting/Tax:** pass any routine journal, close a trial balance, file GSTR-1 / GSTR-3B, reconcile GSTR-2B to books, compute TDS and advance tax.
- **SQL:** join 3+ tables, window functions, CTEs — pull a P&L from raw ledgers.
- **Python:** clean a messy CSV with `pandas`, automate a monthly report.
- **BI:** a Power BI dashboard with DAX measures (`Total Sales`, YoY%, running totals).
- **Meta:** a public GitHub with 3–4 mini-projects and a one-line README each.

The bar is **"can you do it live, on a timer, without Google for the basics."**

Hands-on: how to actually do it

The engine of the year is a repeating **90-day skill sprint**. Each sprint: *Learn (weeks 1–4) → Build (5–10) → Ship + document (11–12)*. Track it in one Excel sheet so the plan is itself a proof of your Excel.

Build a self-updating tracker. Columns: `Skill | Sprint | StartDate | TargetDate | Status | ProofURL`.

```
# % of the year elapsed, live:
=TEXT((TODAY()-DATE(2026,7,1))/365,"0.0%")

# Days left in the current sprint:
=[@TargetDate]-TODAY()

# RAG status flag:
=IF([@Status]="Done","🟢",IF([@TargetDate]-TODAY()<0,"🔴","🟡"))

# Count of shipped proofs:
=COUNTIF(Tracker[Status],"Done")

# Pull the next unfinished skill (dynamic array):
=FILTER(Tracker[Skill],Tracker[Status]<>"Done")
```

SQL to log study hours in a tiny SQLite/Postgres table and see weekly pace:

```
SELECT strftime('%Y-%W', log_date) AS week,
       skill,
       SUM(hours)                    AS hrs
FROM   study_log
GROUP  BY week, skill
HAVING SUM(hours) > 0
ORDER  BY week DESC;
```

Python to nag yourself — pulls the tracker and prints red items:

```
import pandas as pd, datetime as dt
df = pd.read_excel("tracker.xlsx", sheet_name="Tracker")
today = pd.Timestamp(dt.date.today())
overdue = df[(df.Status != "Done") & (df.TargetDate < today)]
print(f"{len(overdue)} skill(s) slipping:")
print(overdue[["Skill", "TargetDate"]].to_string(index=False))
```

DAX measure for a "career progress" card in Power BI:

```
Skills Shipped % =
DIVIDE(
    CALCULATE(COUNTROWS(Tracker), Tracker[Status] = "Done"),
    COUNTROWS(Tracker)
)
```

Worked example / mini-project

Project: "One-Year Finance Skills Dashboard." Realistic India-context plan for a CA-Inter candidate starting July 2026.

The 12-month map (study alongside CA, ~10 hrs/week on skills):

Month	Sprint focus	Ship (proof-of-work)	Primary resource
Jul–Aug	Advanced Excel + FP&A	3-statement model of a listed Indian FMCG (from annual report)	Wall Street Prep / CFI Excel
Sep	Accounting close + Tally	Closed a set of books; trial balance → P&L	TallyPrime + ICAI notes
Oct–Nov	GST + TDS practical	Filed a dummy GSTR-1/3B; GSTR-2B reco sheet	GST portal + ClearTax blog
Dec	SQL for finance	Query pack pulling P&L from raw sales table	Mode SQL Tutorial (free)
Jan–Feb	Python + pandas	Auto monthly MIS from 3 CSVs	Kaggle "Pandas" micro-course
Mar	Power BI + DAX	Sales & AR dashboard, 8 measures	Microsoft Learn (free)
Apr	Financial modelling / valuation	DCF + comps of the same FMCG	Aswath Damodaran (free)
May	Capstone + portfolio	GitHub README linking all six	—
Jun	Interview prep + polish	Mock tests, resume rewrite	This Playbook

Concrete numbers to reproduce the Excel piece: take Hindustan Unilever-style figures — Revenue ₹62,000 cr, EBITDA margin 24%, tax rate 25.17%, capex ₹1,200 cr, WC days 15. Build the model, then flex revenue growth 6%/8%/10% and watch FCF. The *deliverable* is one `.xlsx` with a scenario dropdown, pushed to GitHub — that single file beats "MBA Finance" on a resume.

A sample journal from the Sept close sprint, to prove the accounting spike:

Date	Particulars	Dr (₹)	Cr (₹)
30-Sep	Depreciation A/c ..... Dr	50,000	
	To Accumulated Depreciation A/c		50,000
30-Sep	Salaries A/c ..... Dr	2,00,000	
	To Salaries Payable A/c		2,00,000
30-Sep	Profit & Loss A/c ..... Dr	2,50,000	
	To Depreciation A/c		50,000
	To Salaries A/c		2,00,000

How it's tested

Hiring for these roles almost always includes a **practical**, not just a chat:

- **FP&A / analyst:** a *timed 45-min Excel case* — "here's a raw sales dump, build a summary P&L with `SUMIFS` and a pivot, comment on the biggest variance." No formulas from memory = fail.
- **Data-leaning finance:** a *SQL screen* on HackerRank / DataLemur — 2–3 questions, usually a window function and a self-join.
- **Accounts / audit:** a "*close these books*" case — you're handed a trial balance with errors to find, or asked to pass adjusting entries live.
- **Tax:** compute TDS on a set of invoices, or reconcile GSTR-2B mismatches and state the ITC allowed.
- **Interview questions:** "Walk me through your 3-statement model." / "How did you build that dashboard — what's the DAX?" / "Show me your GitHub." The follow-ups probe whether *you* did it.

The tell that separates you: you can screen-share and *do the thing*, because you shipped six of them this year.

Common mistakes & how pros avoid them

- **Tutorial hell.** Watching 40 hours, building nothing. Pros cap learning at ~30% of sprint time; the rest is building.
- **Breadth with no spike.** "A little Python, a little BI, a little SQL" impresses no one. Go deep on one per sprint.
- **No proof.** If it's not on GitHub or a shareable file, it didn't happen to a recruiter.
- **Buying every course.** 90% of what you need is free (below). Pros pay only for structured modelling (WSP/CFI) or a domain cert.
- **Ignoring the CA overlap.** Your CA tax/audit/costing papers *are* domain depth — reuse them as portfolio topics, don't treat them as separate.
- **Perfectionism.** A shipped B-grade dashboard beats an unfinished A-grade one. Timebox, then ship.

Learn-it roadmap & resources

Time-to-proficiency: ~10 hrs/week for 12 months gets you interview-ready in 2–3 skills. Each 90-day sprint = one credible spike.

The master list (free unless noted):

Skill	Best resource	Cost
Excel/FP&A	CFI FMVA (paid), Wall Street Prep, ExcelIsFun (YouTube)	Free–₹30k
Modelling/Valuation	Aswath Damodaran (NYU, free lectures + spreadsheets)	Free
Accounting/Tax	ICAI study material, ClearTax & TaxGuru blogs, CA Rachana Ranade (YT)	Free
Tally/GST	TallyPrime learning portal, GST portal (practice with dummy GSTIN)	Free
SQL	Mode SQL Tutorial, DataLemur, SQLBolt	Free
Python	Kaggle micro-courses, "Automate the Boring Stuff" (free book)	Free
Power BI/DAX	Microsoft Learn, SQLBI (Marco Russo), Guy in a Cube (YT)	Free
Books	*Financial Modeling* (Benninga), *Storytelling with Data* (Knaflic), *Naked Statistics* (Wheelan)	Paid
Portfolio	GitHub + a one-page Notion/PDF case study each	Free

Certifications worth it (India-relevant): CFA/FRM if going capital-markets/risk; NISM for securities roles; Microsoft PL-300 for Power BI; your CA itself is the strongest single credential — finish it. Skip generic "Udemy certificates" — they signal nothing.

Quick-reference

Item	Value
Sprint length	90 days: Learn (4w) → Build (6w) → Ship (2w)
Weekly commitment	~10 hrs skills, on top of CA study
Learn:Build ratio	30 : 70
Sprints in the year	4 major + 2 short = 6 shipped proofs
Progress formula	`=(TODAY()-DATE(2026,7,1))/365`
Overdue flag	`=IF([@TargetDate]-TODAY()<0,"🔴","🟢")`
Shipped count	`=COUNTIF(Tracker[Status],"Done")`
SQL pace check	`GROUP BY strftime('%Y-%W', log_date)`
DAX progress	`DIVIDE(done_rows, total_rows)`
Non-negotiable	Every sprint ends with a public, clickable deliverable
Free stack	Mode (SQL) · Kaggle (Python) · MS Learn (BI) · Damodaran (valuation)
Paid, if any	CFI/WSP (Excel modelling); PL-300 (BI); finish CA

The one rule that makes the year work: never finish a sprint without a link you can paste into a resume. Six links in twelve months closes the MBA-to-employer gap for good.

Finance Jobs Decoded: Accounting, Tax, Audit & FP&A

What Employers Actually Want — Decoded from Real 2026 Job Postings (India-first)

Role by role: responsibilities, skills, tools, certifications, ATS keywords, salary bands & how to break in

Contents

How to Read a Finance Job Description (and This Book)

Most commerce and MBA-Finance graduates in India learn a curriculum, then walk into a job market that speaks a different language. Your college taught you the *why* of accounting, taxation and finance. A job description (JD) tells you the *what* — the specific software, the specific compliance forms, the specific monthly rituals a company will pay you to perform from day one. This book exists to close that gap. It takes real finance job postings pulled from Indeed India in mid-2026 and decodes them, one role at a time, so you know exactly what each job wants and how to get it.

The education-to-industry gap

A B.Com graduate can define "bank reconciliation" in an exam. A JD asks whether you can actually reconcile a live bank statement in Tally against a messy day-book with 200 entries and explain the differences to an auditor. An MBA can build a DCF in a case study; an equity research JD wants you to build a working three-statement model, run channel checks on a real company, and write a note an institutional investor will act on. The gap is not intelligence — it's *specificity and tooling*. Employers assume you know the theory; they are hiring for the execution. The moment you start reading JDs as instruction manuals rather than wish-lists, your preparation becomes ten times more efficient, because you stop studying everything and start building the exact three or four things a role actually rewards.

The anatomy of a finance JD

Almost every finance posting has the same skeleton. Learn to X-ray it:

- **Role summary** — one or two lines placing the job in the org (e.g. "support month-end close within the R2R team"). This tells you where you sit and who you report to.
- **Responsibilities / "What you'll do"** — the real work. This is the single most important section. Read it as your future daily to-do list, not marketing copy.
- **Must-have qualifications** — non-negotiable filters: a degree, a minimum number of years, sometimes a specific qualification (CA, CFA, ACAMS). If a posting says "CA-qualified 1–3 yrs," a fresher B.Com simply will not clear the screen, however talented.
- **Nice-to-have / "preferred"** — the differentiators. "MBA/CA/CMA a plus," "Power BI desirable," "ACAMS an advantage." You don't need all of these, but each one you have moves you up the pile.
- **Tools** — the named software (Tally, SAP, Oracle, Zoho, Bloomberg, Power BI, Anaplan). These are literal keywords; more on that below.

Must-have vs nice-to-have is the whole game. Spend your energy clearing every must-have for the role you actually want, then collect nice-to-haves to stand out. Applying to a job where you miss a must-have (the certification, the years, the mandatory tool) is usually wasted effort.

How ATS parses your keywords

Large and mid-size employers run your resume through an Applicant Tracking System (ATS) before a human ever sees it. The ATS does not understand nuance — it matches strings. If the JD says "three-way match" and your resume says "invoice verification," the machine may not connect them. So the rule is blunt: **mirror the**

JD's exact vocabulary. If the posting says "GST filings," "TDS deductions," "bank reconciliation," "R2R," "variance analysis," or "Power BI," those literal phrases should appear on your resume — truthfully, tied to something you've actually done. Every role chapter in this book ends with an **ATS keywords to mirror** section for exactly this reason: it hands you the terms to plant.

The map of core / back-office finance roles

This book covers the backbone of Indian finance employment — the roles that exist in every company, from a Hyderabad SME to a Bangalore Global Capability Centre (GCC). They connect as a natural progression of how money is recorded, checked, reported and planned:

Accounts → Tax → Audit → Controllership → FP&A

- **Accounts** (Accountant, AP, R2R/GL) — record every transaction correctly. This is where most commerce grads enter.
- **Tax** (Tax Analyst, GST/TDS work) — ensure what's recorded complies with income-tax and GST law.
- **Audit & Controllership** — verify the books are true and own the monthly/annual close under Indian GAAP.
- **FP&A** — stop looking backwards and start looking forward: budgets, forecasts, variance vs plan, and the numbers that guide the business.

Alongside this spine sit the specialist tracks the market also hires heavily for — payroll, treasury, credit risk, KYC/AML and compliance, and the front-office roles (investment banking, equity research, private equity). Each gets its own decoded chapter.

How to use each chapter

Every role chapter follows the same ten-part structure so you can compare roles side by side: a **Snapshot** (what the role is and its seniority ladder), **What you'll actually do**, **Must-have skills**, **Tools & software**, **Qualifications & certifications**, **Experience & typical titles**, **ATS keywords to mirror**, an indicative **Salary in India** table, **Who's hiring**, and **How to break in / stand out**. Read the Snapshot to decide if a role fits you, then jump to *How to break in* for the concrete next step and the portfolio project that will separate you from other applicants.

An honest note on entry difficulty and pay

Be clear-eyed: the entry rungs of Indian finance are competitive and, at the bottom, modestly paid. An SME Accountant role in Hyderabad may pay Rs 20,000–35,000 a month — genuinely low for the volume of work — but it is the most reliable foot-in-the-door for a B.Com graduate and builds the Tally-plus-compliance base everything else stands on. GCC roles (AP, R2R, FP&A) pay better and offer clearer ladders but demand process discipline and often night or shifted hours. The high-paying front-office roles (IB, equity research, credit risk) are genuinely hard to enter, want an MBA or CA plus strong modelling, and run long hours. There is no shortcut, but there is a map — and the difference between a frustrated job-seeker and a hired one is usually not talent, but knowing precisely what each role wants and showing up already able to do it. That is what the rest of this book gives you.

Accountant / Accounts Executive

Snapshot

The Accountant / Accounts Executive is the entry workhorse of Indian finance — the person who actually records the business's money, day in and day out. In an SME or mid-market firm (think a Hyderabad trading company, a manufacturing unit, a services outfit like Valtree Global), this role owns the books at the ground level: posting vouchers in Tally, chasing receivables, paying vendors, reconciling the bank, and filing GST and TDS on time. It sits at the base of the org, usually reporting to a Senior Accountant, Accounts Manager, or directly to the proprietor/finance head in a small firm. The ladder from here is clear and well-trodden: **Accounts Executive → Senior Accounts Executive → Assistant Accounts Manager → Accounts Manager**. For the vast majority of B.Com graduates in India, this is where a finance career begins — and it is the single best place to build the practical, compliance-heavy foundation every later role assumes you have.

What you'll actually do

The work is high-volume, hands-on, and deadline-driven around statutory dates (GST returns, TDS payments, month-end). Synthesised from real SME postings, a typical day/week includes:

- Recording day-to-day transactions in Tally ERP / TallyPrime — sales and purchase vouchers, journals, receipts, payments, contra entries — and maintaining the day-book and ledgers.
- **Accounts Payable (AP):** booking vendor bills, matching them to purchase orders, and scheduling payments.
- **Accounts Receivable (AR):** raising customer invoices, tracking outstanding dues, and following up on collections.
- Performing **bank reconciliation** — matching book balances to bank statements and resolving differences.
- Handling **GST** — computing liability, reconciling input tax credit, and filing returns (GSTR-1, GSTR-3B).
- Deducting and depositing **TDS**, and supporting other statutory compliance.
- Assisting in the preparation of monthly and annual financial statements.
- Supporting statutory and internal **audits** — pulling ledgers, vouchers, and schedules the auditors ask for.
- Using MS Excel (VLOOKUP, PivotTables) for reconciliations, MIS, and data clean-up.

> Real posting (Valtree Global): "Manage day-to-day accounting entries in Tally, handle AP/AR, perform bank reconciliations, and assist with GST filings and TDS deductions."

Must-have skills

Hard skills: working knowledge of Tally ERP / TallyPrime; solid grasp of double-entry bookkeeping; practical GST and TDS computation and filing; bank and ledger reconciliation; Excel (VLOOKUP, PivotTables, basic formulas); ability to assist in preparing financial statements. **Soft skills:** accuracy and attention to detail (a wrong voucher ripples into the audit), discipline around statutory deadlines, organisation under high transaction volume, and clear communication with vendors, customers, and auditors.

Tools & software

- **Tally ERP 9 / TallyPrime** — the non-negotiable core in Indian SMEs.
- **MS Excel** — VLOOKUP, PivotTables, reconciliations, MIS.
- **GST portal** and **TRACES / income-tax portal** for filings.
- In slightly larger or newer firms you may also see **Zoho Books**, **Busy**, or **QuickBooks**.

Qualifications & certifications

- **Degree:** B.Com is the standard entry qualification; M.Com is a plus.
- **CA-Inter / CMA-Inter (dropouts or pursuing):** genuinely welcomed and often preferred — postings frequently say "CA/CMA-inter welcome." Even partial progress signals stronger fundamentals.
- **Certifications that help here:** a practical **Tally certification** and a hands-on **GST practitioner / GST-filing course** are the most cost-effective credentials for this specific role. Global certs like CFA/FMVA add little at this rung — save them for later analytical roles.

Experience & typical titles

Rung	Experience	Typical titles
Entry	0–2 yrs	Accounts Executive, Junior Accountant, Accounts Assistant
Mid	2–4 yrs	Accountant, Senior Accounts Executive
Senior	5+ yrs	Senior Accountant, Assistant Accounts Manager

Most SME postings ask for **2–3 years**, but freshers are regularly hired if they know Tally and GST basics.

ATS keywords to mirror

Tally ERP, TallyPrime, accounts payable, accounts receivable, bank reconciliation, GST filing, GSTR-1, GSTR-3B, TDS deduction, statutory compliance, journal entries, vouchers, day-book, ledger, financial statements, audit support, MS Excel, VLOOKUP, PivotTables, input tax credit

Salary in India (indicative, FY2026)

Experience band	Indicative CTC (Rs LPA)
Fresher (0–2 yrs)	2.0 – 4.0
2–4 yrs	3.5 – 6.0
5–8 yrs	5.0 – 9.0

SME postings often quote **Rs 20,000–35,000/month** (roughly Rs 2.4–4.2 LPA). Figures vary by city, firm size, and sector, and are approximate.

Who's hiring

Small and mid-market businesses across every sector — trading companies, manufacturers, distributors, service firms, CA firms, and startups. Real examples of this type on Indeed include SME employers such as **Valtree Global** (Hyderabad) and countless similar firms in Hyderabad, Pune, Ahmedabad, Coimbatore, and every Tier-1 and Tier-2 city. CA firms also hire heavily at this level for audit and compliance support.

How to break in / stand out

For a commerce graduate, this is the most accessible entry point in finance — but "accessible" means crowded, so you must show you can do the job on day one:

1. **Master TallyPrime end-to-end.** Don't just list it — be able to demonstrate a company set up in Tally with sample vouchers, a bank recon, and a GST return generated from it.
2. **Learn GST and TDS filing practically.** Do a short, hands-on GST course and actually file (or shadow-file) a GSTR-3B. Being able to say "I have filed GST returns" beats "I studied GST."
3. **Build a mini portfolio:** a one-page Excel showing a bank reconciliation you built, a debtors-ageing PivotTable, and a screenshot of a Tally trial balance you produced. Bring it to the interview.
4. **Consider CA-Inter or CMA-Inter** even if you don't complete the full qualification — clearing a group signals stronger fundamentals and often unlocks a better starting salary.

The single biggest differentiator: being genuinely fluent in Tally *plus* current GST/TDS compliance, so a small business owner can hand you the books and walk away. Most fresh graduates know the theory; very few can independently run a monthly compliance cycle. Be the one who can, and you'll never struggle to get this job — or to climb out of it.

Senior Accountant / Accounts Manager

Snapshot

The Senior Accountant / Accounts Manager is the person who *owns the books* — the step up from recording transactions to being accountable for their accuracy, completeness, and finalisation. Where the Accounts Executive posts vouchers, the Senior Accountant reviews them, closes the month, signs off on GST and TDS returns, coordinates the statutory audit, and puts the MIS in front of the owner or CFO. In an SME or mid-market firm this is often the senior-most finance role below the proprietor; in a larger company it sits under a Financial Controller or Finance Manager. It is a supervisory and finalisation role: you manage one or more junior accountants, catch their errors before the auditor does, and are the single point of accountability for the numbers. The ladder: **Senior Accountant → Assistant Accounts Manager → Accounts Manager → Finance Manager / Controller.** Reaching this rung typically means CA-Inter / CMA-Inter plus experience, or roughly five-plus years of hands-on accounting.

What you'll actually do

Synthesised from real controllership-leaning postings (Plum-type and SME manager roles), the work shifts from *doing* to *owning and reviewing*:

- Own the **month-end, quarter-end, and year-end close** — ensure all entries are booked, accrued, and reconciled to a timeline.
- Prepare and finalise **financial statements** under Indian GAAP (P&L, balance sheet, cash flow).
- Review and **sign off on GST and TDS returns** prepared by juniors; own reconciliations (GSTR-2B vs books, TDS vs 26AS).
- Supervise and review the work of junior accountants — vouchers, ledgers, and reconciliations.
- Maintain **internal financial controls** and ensure books are audit-ready.
- **Coordinate statutory, tax, and internal audits** — be the primary point of contact for auditors, provide schedules, and resolve queries.
- Perform three-way and bank reconciliations and review balance-sheet schedules with commentary.
- Prepare **MIS and management reports** for the owner/CFO — monthly numbers, variances, and cash position.
- Support treasury and cash-flow forecasting where required.

> Real posting (Plum): "Manage month/quarter/annual close, prepare financial statements under Indian GAAP, maintain internal financial controls, and assist statutory, tax, and internal audits."

Must-have skills

Hard skills: full-cycle accounting and finalisation; strong Indian GAAP knowledge; month-end close discipline; GST and TDS return preparation *and review*; balance-sheet reconciliations with commentary; internal controls; audit coordination; advanced Excel. **Soft skills:** ownership and accountability (the buck stops with you), review rigour and error-spotting, ability to manage and mentor juniors, and the communication skills to present numbers to a non-finance owner and defend them to an auditor.

Tools & software

- **Tally ERP / TallyPrime** and/or **Zoho Books** — core in Indian SMEs and mid-market.
- **Advanced Excel** — reconciliations, schedules, MIS dashboards.
- **GST portal**, **TRACES / income-tax portal** for filings and reconciliations.
- Larger firms may run **SAP**, **Oracle**, or **NetSuite** — familiarity is a plus as you move up.

Qualifications & certifications

- **Degree:** B.Com / M.Com.
- **CA-Inter or CMA-Inter** is the sweet-spot qualification for this rung and is often explicitly preferred; a fully qualified **CA** or **CMA** commands the Accounts Manager title and a higher band, especially where Indian GAAP finalisation and audit coordination are central.
- **Certifications that help here:** advanced GST/tax certifications and an Indian GAAP / Ind AS course. FMVA or CFA are not required here but signal analytical depth if you plan to pivot toward FP&A later.

Experience & typical titles

Rung	Experience	Typical titles
Entry to this rung	4–6 yrs (or CA/CMA-Inter + 1–3 yrs)	Senior Accountant, Accounts Team Lead
Mid	6–9 yrs	Assistant Accounts Manager, Deputy Manager – Accounts
Senior	9+ yrs	Accounts Manager, Finance Manager

CA-qualified candidates can reach the manager title in **1–3 years** post-qualification; the non-qualified route typically takes **5+ years** of strong hands-on experience.

ATS keywords to mirror

month-end close, financial statements, Indian GAAP, internal financial controls, statutory audit, GST returns, TDS, balance sheet reconciliation, general ledger review, finalisation of accounts, MIS reporting, audit coordination, variance analysis, Ind AS, team supervision, cash flow, TallyPrime, Zoho

Salary in India (indicative, FY2026)

Experience band	Indicative CTC (Rs LPA)
Fresher to this rung (CA/CMA-Inter, ~2 yrs)	5.0 – 8.0
2–4 yrs in role	7.0 – 12.0
5–8 yrs in role	10.0 – 18.0

A fully qualified CA at Accounts Manager level in a mid-market firm can sit at the upper end. Figures vary widely by city, firm size, and sector, and are approximate.

Who's hiring

Mid-market and growing companies across manufacturing, services, retail, and tech; startups scaling past their first finance hire (e.g. Plum-type insurtech/SaaS firms hiring controllership talent in Bangalore); CA firms building their accounting/outsourcing practices; and any SME whose owner wants to step back from day-to-day finance. Hubs include Bangalore, Hyderabad, Mumbai, Pune, and Chennai.

How to break in / stand out

1. **Clear CA-Inter or CMA-Inter** — this is the fastest, most credible route to the title and pay bump, and it directly signals finalisation and Indian GAAP competence.
2. **Prove you can close the books, not just record them.** In interviews, walk through a month-end close you owned: the accruals, the reconciliations, the schedules you handed the auditor.
3. **Show audit coordination experience.** Being able to say "I was the auditor's point of contact and cleared the audit with zero major observations" is powerful — it's what this role is judged on.
4. **Build an MIS pack.** A clean monthly management report (P&L vs budget, debtors/creditors ageing, cash position) that you designed shows you think like a manager, not a data-entry operator.

The single biggest differentiator: the ability to independently finalise a set of accounts and stand behind them in front of an auditor. Plenty of people can post entries; the person who can close, finalise, reconcile, and defend the books is the one who gets the manager title — and the salary that comes with it.

Accounts Payable (AP) Analyst

Snapshot

The Accounts Payable (AP) Analyst owns the *pay* side of the business — the Procure-to-Pay (P2P) cycle that turns a vendor invoice into a cleared payment. Where an SME Accountant does a bit of everything, the AP Analyst is a specialist in a large, process-driven environment: almost always a Global Capability Centre (GCC) or shared-services operation in Hyderabad, Bangalore, Pune, or Gurgaon, running on SAP or Oracle rather than Tally. You process high volumes of invoices, run three-way matches, reconcile vendor accounts, execute payment runs, and deduct TDS on payments — all against SLAs (service-level agreements) and strict close timelines. It sits within a larger finance operations team and reports to an AP Team Lead / Process Lead. The ladder: **AP Analyst → Senior AP Analyst → AP Team Lead / SME → AP Manager (P2P Tower Lead).** For a commerce graduate, GCC AP is one of the best-paying and most structured entry points into corporate finance — better pay and clearer progression than SME accounting, in exchange for depth over breadth.

What you'll actually do

Synthesised from real P2P / shared-services postings, the day-to-day is high-volume and process-disciplined:

- **Invoice processing** — receive, validate, code, and enter vendor invoices into SAP / Oracle accurately and within SLA.
- **Three-way match** — match each invoice to its purchase order (PO) and goods-receipt note (GRN); investigate and resolve mismatches and exceptions.
- **Vendor reconciliation** — reconcile vendor statements to the ledger, resolve disputes, and clear debit/credit balances.
- **Payment runs** — prepare and execute scheduled payment batches, ensure correct payment terms, and manage the payment proposal.
- Deduct and account for **TDS on vendor payments** and apply correct GST treatment on invoices.
- Handle **vendor queries** and the AP helpdesk within turnaround times.
- Perform **month-end AP close** activities — accruals for un-invoiced receipts, GR/IR reconciliation, and AP ageing reporting.
- Track and report on SLA/KPI metrics (invoices processed, exceptions, aged items).

> Real posting (shared-services P2P, e.g. Genpact/Accenture-type): "Process vendor invoices with three-way match against PO and GRN, perform vendor reconciliations, and support month-end close within agreed SLAs."

Must-have skills

Hard skills: invoice processing and P2P knowledge; three-way matching logic (PO–GRN–invoice); vendor reconciliation; TDS on payments and basic GST on purchases; ERP data entry accuracy; Excel (VLOOKUP, PivotTables) for reconciliations and ageing. **Soft skills:** speed with accuracy under high volume, SLA discipline, exception-handling and problem-solving, and clear written communication for vendor queries (often in English with global stakeholders). Comfort with **shifted or night hours** is frequently required in GCCs serving US/EU clients.

Tools & software

- **SAP** (FI/MM, often SAP S/4HANA) and **Oracle** — the dominant ERPs in GCC AP.
- **MS Excel** — VLOOKUP, PivotTables, reconciliations.
- Workflow/OCR tools such as **SAP VIM**, **Ariba**, **Coupa**, or **Tungsten/Basware** for invoice capture and approvals.
- Ticketing tools (e.g. **ServiceNow**) for vendor query management.

Qualifications & certifications

- **Degree:** B.Com is the standard; BBA/M.Com also accepted.
- **Certifications that help here:** an **SAP FICO** (or SAP MM/AP) familiarity is the strongest differentiator — even a short SAP course helps you clear screens. **CMA-Inter** signals fundamentals; global process certs matter less than hands-on ERP exposure.
- CA/CFA/FMVA are **not** what this role rewards — it values process precision and ERP fluency over analytical or valuation skills. Save those certs if your target is FP&A or analysis.

Experience & typical titles

Rung	Experience	Typical titles
Entry	0–2 yrs	AP Analyst, P2P Associate, Accounts Payable Executive
Mid	2–5 yrs	Senior AP Analyst, P2P Specialist / SME
Senior	5–8 yrs	AP Team Lead, Process Lead, Assistant Manager – P2P

Freshers are hired directly into GCC AP; the process ladder is well-defined and promotions are relatively predictable.

ATS keywords to mirror

accounts payable, P2P, procure-to-pay, invoice processing, three-way match, PO, GRN, GR/IR, vendor reconciliation, payment run, TDS on payments, SAP, Oracle, SAP MM, SAP VIM, Ariba, Coupa, month-end close, AP ageing, SLA, exception handling, ERP, MS Excel

Salary in India (indicative, FY2026)

Experience band	Indicative CTC (Rs LPA)
Fresher (0–2 yrs)	3.0 – 5.0
2–4 yrs	4.5 – 8.0
5–8 yrs	7.5 – 13.0

GCC AP typically pays more than SME accounting at the same experience level, and night-shift roles often add a shift allowance. Figures vary by city, employer, and shift, and are approximate.

Who's hiring

Global Capability Centres and shared-services/BPM firms — the biggest volume is in Hyderabad and Bangalore, with Pune, Gurgaon, and Chennai close behind. Real employers hiring P2P/AP roles on Indeed include **Accenture**, **Genpact**, **Amazon** (and its GCC finance operations), plus captive GCCs of global banks, manufacturers, and tech firms. Any large multinational running finance operations out of India has an AP tower.

How to break in / stand out

1. **Get SAP exposure.** Even a short SAP FICO or SAP MM course, or hands-on time in a sandbox, lets you speak the ERP language GCC recruiters screen for. It's the fastest way to stand out from other B.Com applicants.
2. **Understand three-way match cold.** Be able to explain, with an example, how an invoice, PO, and GRN reconcile — and how you'd resolve a quantity or price mismatch. This is the technical heart of the interview.
3. **Demonstrate speed-with-accuracy.** GCCs live on SLAs; show you can handle volume without errors (a clean Excel reconciliation exercise or data-entry accuracy example works well).
4. **Be honest about shifts.** Many roles serve US/EU clients; signalling comfort with night or rotational shifts removes a common objection.

The single biggest differentiator: hands-on ERP fluency (SAP/Oracle) plus a genuine grasp of the P2P exception workflow. Recruiters see hundreds of B.Com resumes that list "accounts payable"; the candidate who can actually navigate SAP, resolve a GR/IR mismatch, and talk SLAs is the one who gets hired — and who moves up the P2P tower fastest.

Accounts Receivable (AR) Analyst

Snapshot

An Accounts Receivable (AR) Analyst owns the "cash-in" half of a company's **Order-to-Cash (O2C)** cycle: turning delivered goods and services into invoices, chasing those invoices until the money lands, and matching the cash back to the right customer account. If AP (accounts payable) is about paying suppliers, AR is about **getting paid** — and because it directly feeds the bank balance, working capital and DSO (Days Sales Outstanding), it is one of the most visibility-heavy junior finance roles a company has. In India, AR sits inside two very different homes: the **finance shared-services / GCC and BPO world** (Genpact, Accenture, WNS, and captive centres of MNCs), where you process AR for a global parent under strict SLAs, and the **domestic company finance team** of any SME or mid-market firm, where AR is one hat among several. The typical ladder runs **Associate / Executive -> Senior Associate / Senior Executive -> Team Lead / Assistant Manager -> Manager (O2C) -> O2C Tower Lead**. Firms like Grant Thornton hire "Associate - Accounts Receivable" specifically for this function.

What you'll actually do

- Raise and issue customer **invoices** (and credit/debit notes) accurately, matching them to sales orders, delivery proof and contract terms — including correct GST treatment.
- Run **collections**: follow up on overdue accounts by email and call, send statements and dunning reminders, and negotiate payment timelines within credit policy.
- Perform **cash application** — match incoming receipts (NEFT/RTGS, cheques, portal payments) against open invoices, and clear the customer ledger.
- Maintain the **AR ageing** report (0-30 / 31-60 / 61-90 / 90+ buckets) and flag accounts slipping into higher-risk buckets.
- Track and report **DSO** and collection-effectiveness metrics; explain movements month over month.
- Handle **disputes and deductions** — short payments, pricing mismatches, quality claims — by coordinating with sales, logistics and the customer until resolved.
- Support **credit control**: review credit limits, escalate blocked orders, and recommend holds on chronic defaulters.
- Reconcile customer accounts, pass write-offs/provisions for bad debt, and provide AR schedules to auditors at close.

> Real posting (Grant Thornton): "Manage the accounts receivable process including invoicing, cash application, and collections follow-up, and maintain accurate ageing reports."

Must-have skills

Hard skills: double-entry accounting fundamentals; understanding of the full O2C flow; invoice-to-cash matching; ageing and DSO analysis; GST basics on outward supplies; bank reconciliation; Excel (VLOOKUP/XLOOKUP, PivotTables, SUMIFS) for ageing and reconciliation work.

Soft skills: the AR job is half accounting, half **polite persistence** — you need firm, professional communication to chase money without damaging customer relationships; negotiation for payment plans; cross-functional coordination with sales and operations; and attention to detail so a wrongly applied receipt doesn't snowball into a reconciliation mess. In GCC/BPO settings, **SLA discipline** and comfort with high transaction volumes matter as much as technical skill.

Tools & software

- **ERP / accounting:** SAP (FI-AR module), Oracle, Microsoft Dynamics, NetSuite, Zoho Books, and **Tally / TallyPrime** in SME shops.
- **Collections & O2C platforms:** HighRadius (very common in Indian GCCs), Blackline, GetPaid, or in-house dunning tools.
- **Excel** — the everyday workhorse for ageing, cash-app reconciliation and DSO tracking.
- **Reporting/BI:** Power BI or Tableau for AR dashboards in larger teams.
- Customer/vendor portals (Ariba, Coupa) for invoice submission at enterprise clients.

Qualifications & certifications

- **Degree:** B.Com / M.Com / BBA is the standard entry credential; MBA-Finance helps for the manager track.
- **CA/CMA (inter)** candidates are welcomed and move up faster, but AR does **not** require a full qualification — it is one of the more accessible entries into corporate finance.
- **Certifications that actually help:** a short **SAP FICO** or **HighRadius O2C** certification is the single most marketable add-on for GCC roles. Advanced **Excel** certification is genuinely useful. CFA/FRM are overkill and not relevant here.
- For domestic SME roles, demonstrated **GST and TDS** familiarity beats any certificate.

Experience & typical titles

Band	Typical titles	What's expected
Fresher (0-2 yrs)	AR Associate, AR Executive, O2C Analyst	Process invoices, apply cash, run ageing under supervision
Mid (2-5 yrs)	Senior AR Associate, Senior Executive, Team Lead	Own a customer portfolio, drive collections, cut DSO, mentor juniors
Senior (5-8 yrs)	Assistant Manager / Manager - O2C, Collections Lead	Own SLAs, credit policy, team performance, client governance

ATS keywords to mirror

Accounts Receivable, AR, Order-to-Cash, O2C, invoicing, cash application, collections, AR ageing, DSO, Days Sales Outstanding, credit control, dispute resolution, deductions, bank reconciliation, SAP FI-AR, HighRadius, GST, customer reconciliation, SLA, bad-debt provision, dunning, working capital.

Salary in India (indicative, FY2026)

Experience band	Indicative range (Rs LPA)
Fresher (0-2 yrs)	2.5 - 4.5
2-4 yrs	4.5 - 7
5-8 yrs (Sr / AM)	7 - 12

Approximate; varies materially by city (Bangalore/Gurugram/Hyderabad GCCs pay more than SME domestic roles), employer type and shift (night-shift/US-process roles carry allowances).

Who's hiring

- **Professional-services / GCC:** Grant Thornton (Associate - AR), Genpact, Accenture, WNS, EXL, Capgemini.
- **MNC captives:** shared-service centres of large manufacturers, tech and consumer firms running global O2C from India.
- **Domestic mid-market & SME:** any company with a sizeable customer book — manufacturers, distributors, IT services, healthcare.
- The **BPO/GCC belt** (Bangalore, Hyderabad, Gurugram, Pune, Chennai) is where the volume of AR openings concentrates.

How to break in / stand out

For a commerce or MBA-Finance candidate, AR is one of the **friendliest doors into corporate finance** — high hiring volume, forgiving on prior experience, and a clear path upward. To stand out:

1. **Build a mock AR/O2C portfolio in Excel:** take a fictional customer set, generate invoices, build a working ageing report with automatic bucketing (formulas, not manual), compute DSO, and show a collections tracker. This proves you understand the mechanics before day one.
2. **Learn one collections platform** — even the free HighRadius academy content — and put it on your resume. GCC recruiters screen hard for HighRadius/SAP exposure.
3. **Speak the metrics language:** be able to explain DSO, collection effectiveness index and ageing buckets in an interview, and how you'd cut DSO by 5 days.

The **single biggest differentiator** is showing you treat AR as a **cash-flow lever, not data entry** — a candidate who can articulate how faster collections free up working capital, and who backs it with an ageing model they actually built, instantly reads as promotable to Team Lead rather than a processor.

Record-to-Report (R2R) / General Ledger Analyst

Snapshot

The Record-to-Report (R2R) — or **General Ledger (GL)** — Analyst is the person who actually **closes the books**. Where AR and AP handle transactions, R2R sits one layer up: it posts the month-end journals, reconciles every balance-sheet account, explains the numbers, and hands clean, audit-ready schedules to the controllers and auditors. This is the **core finance role of India's GCC / shared-services economy** — the single largest category of "real accounting" jobs being created in the country, because global companies run their group close from Bangalore, Gurugram, Hyderabad, Pune and Chennai. R2R is where a commerce graduate or part-qualified CA/CMA learns the machinery of a real close under hard deadlines. The ladder typically runs **Analyst / Executive -> Senior Analyst -> Team Lead / Assistant Manager -> R2R / GL Manager -> Controllership / Tower Lead**. Firms like Cromwell hire R2R analysts to run exactly this month-end engine.

What you'll actually do

- Post **month-end journals**: accruals, prepayments, provisions, payroll journals, intercompany charges, fixed-asset entries, depreciation and reclassifications.
- Prepare **balance-sheet reconciliations** with **commentary and ageing** — not just tie the number, but explain what sits in the account and why open items are aged.
- Perform **intercompany reconciliation** and settlement, chasing mismatches between group entities.
- Run **fixed-asset accounting** — capitalisation, depreciation runs, disposals and the FA register.
- Track the close against **working-day (WD) timelines** — "WD+3", "WD+5" — meaning each task has a fixed day in the close calendar it must be finished by.
- Produce **schedules for audit, tax and statutory** reporting, and respond to auditor queries.
- Do **variance analysis** — flux commentary explaining why an account moved versus prior month or budget.
- Maintain the integrity of the **general ledger**, ensuring postings hit the right cost centre, entity and GL code.

> Real posting (Cromwell): "Prepare month-end journals including accruals, prepayments and provisions, and complete balance-sheet reconciliations with commentary and ageing within the working-day close timeline."

Must-have skills

Hard skills: solid **double-entry** and accrual-accounting foundation; the mechanics of a month-end close; balance-sheet reconciliation and open-item ageing; journal preparation across all major categories; fixed-asset accounting and depreciation; variance/flux analysis; familiarity with **Ind AS / IFRS / local GAAP** concepts (which framework depends on the parent). Strong **Excel** is non-negotiable — this role lives in reconciliation templates.

Soft skills: discipline under a fixed close calendar; accuracy (a wrong journal reverses next month and annoys auditors); clear written commentary — R2R analysts must *explain* numbers, so business writing matters; and coordination with AP, AR, treasury and tax teams whose data feeds the GL.

Tools & software

- **ERP:** SAP (FI/CO — the dominant one in GCCs), Oracle Fusion/EBS, Microsoft Dynamics, NetSuite; **Tally/Zoho** at smaller Indian firms.
- **Reconciliation & close tools:** BlackLine and Trintech Cadency (industry-standard for balance-sheet recon and close orchestration), FloQast.
- **Excel** — the daily reconciliation and schedule-building workhorse.
- **BI:** Power BI / Tableau for close dashboards and flux reporting in mature teams.

Qualifications & certifications

- **Degree:** B.Com / M.Com is the baseline; the role explicitly welcomes candidates **studying towards an accountancy qualification**.
- **CA / CMA (inter or final), ACCA** — these are the credentials that accelerate you toward controllership. A part-qualified CA/CMA is the sweet-spot profile for a GCC R2R team.
- **SAP FICO certification** is the most valuable practical add-on and a genuine resume differentiator for these roles.
- **CPA / ACCA** help specifically at US- and UK-parent GCCs. CFA/FRM are not relevant to R2R.

Experience & typical titles

Band	Typical titles	What's expected
Fresher (0-2 yrs)	R2R Analyst, GL Executive, Accounting Analyst	Post routine journals, do recons under review
Mid (2-5 yrs)	Senior R2R Analyst, GL Team Lead	Own a close area, sign off recons, write flux commentary
Senior (5-8 yrs)	Assistant Manager / Manager - R2R, Controllership Analyst	Own the close calendar, review team output, face auditors

ATS keywords to mirror

Record to Report, R2R, General Ledger, GL, month-end close, journal entries, accruals, prepayments, provisions, intercompany, fixed assets, depreciation, balance-sheet reconciliation, ageing, commentary, variance analysis, flux, working-day close, WD+3, Ind AS, IFRS, GAAP, SAP FICO, BlackLine, statutory schedules, audit support.

Salary in India (indicative, FY2026)

Experience band	Indicative range (Rs LPA)
Fresher (0-2 yrs)	3 - 5.5
2-4 yrs	5.5 - 9
5-8 yrs (Sr / AM)	9 - 16

Approximate; part-qualified/qualified CAs and SAP-skilled candidates sit at the top of each band. GCC captives generally pay above BPO third-party providers; night-shift US-process roles add allowances.

Who's hiring

- **GCC captives & shared services:** Cromwell, plus the India finance centres of virtually every global MNC (tech, manufacturing, consumer, pharma).
- **Third-party BPO providers:** Genpact, Accenture, Capgemini, WNS, EXL, Cognizant — running R2R for multiple clients.
- Domestic mid-to-large companies for their central accounting/close teams.
- Concentrated in the **Bangalore-Hyderabad-Gurugram-Pune-Chennai** GCC corridor.

How to break in / stand out

R2R is the **highest-leverage learning role** for a young Indian finance professional — it teaches you the entire close and sets up a clean path to controllership. To break in:

1. **Build a month-end close simulation:** take a trial balance, prepare a full set of journals (accruals, prepayments, depreciation, intercompany), then produce a balance-sheet reconciliation pack **with ageing and commentary**. This one artifact demonstrates you understand the whole cycle, not just entries.
2. **Get hands-on with SAP** — even a training instance or a certification. GCC recruiters filter on SAP FICO exposure more than on grades.
3. **Practise writing flux commentary** — pick two periods, explain the movement in plain business English. The ability to *narrate* numbers is what separates a Senior Analyst from a processor.

The **single biggest differentiator** is showing you can **own an account end-to-end** — post it, reconcile it, age it, explain it, and defend it to an auditor. A candidate who arrives already fluent in WD-close discipline and reconciliation commentary is exactly what every GCC controller is short of.

Tax Analyst (Direct & Indirect / GST-TDS)

Snapshot

A Tax Analyst keeps a company **compliant with the tax code** — computing what's owed, filing returns on time, reconciling tax ledgers, and answering the department's notices. In India the role splits along two axes. On the **subject-matter** axis it covers **direct tax** (income tax, TDS/TCS, advance tax) and **indirect tax** (GST — returns, reconciliation, input-tax credit). On the **employer** axis it splits between **domestic India-tax roles** (SME finance teams, Indian companies, CA firms — where you file GST and TDS hands-on) and **global-tax GCC roles** at MNC captives and banks like Citi, where you manage the tax compliance and reporting of a foreign parent across multiple jurisdictions. Both start junior and climb: **Tax Analyst / Executive -> Senior Analyst -> Assistant Manager (Tax) -> Tax Manager -> Head of Tax / Tax Controller**. Citi's "Tax Analyst" opening is a textbook GCC entry point.

What you'll actually do

- Prepare and file **GST returns** (GSTR-1, GSTR-3B) and perform **GSTR-2B / input-tax-credit reconciliation** against the books and vendor filings.
- Compute and deposit **TDS / TCS**, file quarterly TDS returns (24Q/26Q), issue Form 16/16A, and reconcile with Form 26AS.
- Prepare **income-tax computations**, advance-tax workings and support **corporate income-tax filing** (in GCC roles, across multiple jurisdictions).
- Manage **tax liabilities, compliance and financial reporting** — maintain tax provisions, deferred tax and tax GLs, and support tax disclosures at close.
- Track the **compliance calendar** so no return or payment is missed.
- Respond to **notices, assessments and department queries**; assemble documentation for scrutiny and audits.
- Support **tax audits and transfer-pricing** documentation in larger organisations.
- Work with risk/controls to keep tax processes within policy.

> Real posting (Citi): "Manage tax liabilities of the organisation, including compliance, financial reporting and filing, and assist with income-tax filing across jurisdictions."

Must-have skills

Hard skills: working knowledge of the **Income-Tax Act** and **GST law**; TDS/TCS provisions and rates; GST return mechanics and ITC reconciliation; income-tax computation and provisioning; deferred-tax basics; strong **Excel** for reconciliations; **financial acumen** and management-reporting sense (called out explicitly by Citi).

Soft skills: precision and deadline discipline (tax dates are statutory and unforgiving); the ability to read and interpret law and circulars; clear drafting for notice responses; and coordination with accounts, AP and auditors. In global-tax roles, comfort with **multiple jurisdictions and ambiguity** matters.

Tools & software

- **Compliance software:** ClearTax, Zoho, TallyPrime, Winman, Genius, and the government portals — **GSTN** and **TRACES** — for filing and reconciliation.
- **ERP:** SAP, Oracle, NetSuite, Tally for the underlying tax GLs.
- **Global-tax tools:** OneSource (Thomson Reuters), Vertex, CorpTax at MNC captives.
- **Excel** for every reconciliation, computation and provision working.

Qualifications & certifications

- **Degree:** B.Com / M.Com is the entry credential.
- **CA** is the gold standard for a tax career — a CA with a tax focus commands the strongest path to Tax Manager and beyond. **CMA** is well regarded, especially for indirect tax and cost-linked compliance.
- **CS** helps where tax overlaps with secretarial/regulatory compliance.
- Specialist certificates — ICAI's **Certificate Course on GST**, or a **Diploma in Taxation** — are genuinely useful for B.Com candidates without a full qualification.
- For **global-tax GCC** roles, **CPA / ACCA / EA** (US Enrolled Agent) can matter depending on the parent's jurisdiction. CFA/FRM are not relevant here.

Experience & typical titles

Band	Typical titles	What's expected
Fresher (0-2 yrs)	Tax Analyst, Tax Executive, GST/TDS Executive	Prepare returns, reconcile ITC/26AS under review
Mid (2-5 yrs)	Senior Tax Analyst, Assistant Manager - Tax	Own filings end-to-end, draft notice responses, handle assessments
Senior (5-8 yrs)	Tax Manager, Tax Controller	Own tax strategy, provisions, audits, transfer pricing

ATS keywords to mirror

Tax Analyst, direct tax, indirect tax, GST, GSTR-1, GSTR-3B, GSTR-2B reconciliation, input tax credit, ITC, TDS, TCS, 24Q, 26Q, Form 26AS, TRACES, income-tax computation, advance tax, tax compliance, tax reporting, deferred tax, tax provision, notices, assessment, transfer pricing, ClearTax, SAP, compliance calendar.

Salary in India (indicative, FY2026)

Experience band	Indicative range (Rs LPA)
Fresher (0-2 yrs)	3 - 5
2-4 yrs	5 - 9
5-8 yrs (AM / Manager)	9 - 18

Approximate; a qualified CA in a specialist tax role sits well above these ranges. Global-tax GCC roles (Citi-type) generally pay above domestic SME tax jobs; the band widens sharply with CA + specialisation.

Who's hiring

- **Banks & financial GCCs:** Citi and peer captives running global tax from Mumbai/Bangalore.
- **Big 4 & CA firms:** Deloitte, PwC, EY, KPMG, and mid-tier/local CA firms — the classic tax training ground.
- **Corporate tax teams** of Indian and MNC companies across sectors.
- **SMEs** needing hands-on GST/TDS filers (often B.Com + CA-inter profiles).

How to break in / stand out

Tax is a **specialist track that rewards depth** — and because the law changes constantly, demonstrated currency beats a stale degree. For a commerce/MBA-Finance candidate:

1. **File real returns** — even for a small business, a family firm, or via an internship at a CA office. Nothing beats having actually filed GSTR-3B and a TDS return on the live portals.
2. **Do the ICAI GST certificate or a taxation diploma** and build a **GST reconciliation workbook** (books vs GSTR-2B, with mismatch flags) as a portfolio piece — this is exactly the day-one task.
3. **Follow the law actively** — track Budget changes, CBDT/CBIC circulars and key GST notifications, and be able to discuss a recent change in an interview.

The **single biggest differentiator** is showing you can **turn law into a filed return and defend it in a notice reply** — a candidate who has actually reconciled ITC, computed TDS and drafted a response to a department query is worth far more than one who has only read the Act. For the highest ceiling, pair tax depth with a **CA**.

Audit Associate (Statutory & Internal)

Snapshot

An Audit Associate examines whether an organisation's financial statements are **true and fair** (statutory audit) and whether its processes and controls actually **work** (internal audit). It is the classic proving ground of the accounting profession: for most Indian CAs the journey begins as an **article assistant** in a CA firm doing statutory audits, and many later move into **industry internal-audit and controllership** teams. Statutory audit is an external, opinion-giving exercise governed by law and auditing standards; internal audit is an inside-the-business assurance function focused on risk, controls and process improvement. The two share a toolkit — sampling, documentation, control testing — but differ in purpose. The ladder in a firm runs **Article / Audit Associate -> Senior Associate -> Assistant Manager -> Manager -> Partner**; in industry it runs **Internal Audit Associate -> Senior -> AM -> Manager -> Head of Internal Audit**. Fintech and product companies like Plum hire audit/controllership staff to run exactly this assurance-plus-close work.

What you'll actually do

- Execute **statutory audit** procedures under **Ind AS / Indian GAAP** — vouching, verification, analytical review, and testing account balances against evidence.
- Test **internal financial controls (IFC)** and, for US-linked entities, **SOX** controls — walkthroughs, design and operating-effectiveness testing.
- Perform **process / operational audits** in internal audit — map a process, identify risks, test controls, and recommend improvements.
- Prepare **audit documentation and working papers** that stand up to review — the discipline of "if it isn't documented, it wasn't done".
- Assist the **month/quarter/annual close** and preparation of **financial statements** in controllership-flavoured roles.
- Verify **3-way and bank reconciliations**, GST/TDS/income-tax compliance, and schedules supporting the accounts.
- Draft **audit findings and observations**, quantify impact, and follow up on management action plans.
- Support **statutory, tax and internal audits** end-to-end, coordinating with the client/business and the engagement senior.

> Real posting (Plum): "Assist with statutory, tax and internal audits, prepare financial statements under Indian GAAP, and support internal financial controls."

Must-have skills

Hard skills: strong grounding in **Ind AS / Indian GAAP** and the **Standards on Auditing (SA)**; internal-control and risk concepts (IFC/SOX); audit sampling and evidence; financial-statement preparation and analysis; reconciliation (3-way, bank); working knowledge of GST/TDS/income tax; **Excel** for testing and analytics.

Soft skills: professional scepticism — the instinct to ask "how do I know this is true?"; meticulous documentation; integrity and independence; the communication skill to raise findings tactfully and defend them; and the stamina to work long hours during busy season (year-end statutory audits are brutal).

Tools & software

- **Audit tools:** CaseWare, MindBridge, and firm-proprietary audit software; ICAI's audit tools for smaller firms.
- **ERP / accounting:** SAP, Oracle, **Zoho** (used by Plum-type firms), Tally, NetSuite — you audit the ledgers that live here.
- **Excel** — the universal working-paper and testing tool (PivotTables, lookups, sampling).
- **GRC / controls platforms:** AuditBoard, ServiceNow GRC, TeamMate for internal-audit shops.
- Data-analytics tools (Power BI, ACL/IDEA) increasingly used for full-population testing.

Qualifications & certifications

- **CA** is the defining credential — statutory audit is legally the domain of Chartered Accountants, and the article-assistant route is how you enter. **CA-inter + articleship** is the working profile of most audit associates.
- **CMA, ACCA, CPA** are valuable, especially ACCA/CPA for MNC internal-audit and controllership roles.
- **CIA (Certified Internal Auditor)** is the premier global credential specifically for **internal audit** careers.
- **CISA** helps where audit meets IT/systems; **DISA** (ICAI) for IS-audit in the Indian context.
- CFA/FRM are peripheral here — this is an accounting-and-controls role, not a markets one.

Experience & typical titles

Band	Typical titles	What's expected
Fresher / article (0-2 yrs)	Article Assistant, Audit Associate, IA Associate	Execute test procedures, prepare working papers under review
Mid (2-5 yrs)	Senior Associate, Internal Audit Senior	Lead sections/engagements, review juniors, draft findings
Senior (5-8 yrs)	Assistant Manager / Manager - Audit / IA	Own engagements, client/stakeholder management, quality sign-off

ATS keywords to mirror

Statutory audit, internal audit, Ind AS, Indian GAAP, Standards on Auditing, internal financial controls, IFC, SOX, risk-based audit, control testing, walkthrough, audit documentation, working papers, financial statements, month-end close, 3-way reconciliation, bank reconciliation, GST, TDS, audit findings, process audit, CaseWare, CA, professional scepticism.

Salary in India (indicative, FY2026)

Experience band	Indicative range (Rs LPA)
Fresher / freshly qualified CA	7 - 12
2-4 yrs (post-qualification)	12 - 20
5-8 yrs (Manager)	20 - 35+

Approximate; qualified-CA figures shown. Article-assistant stipends are far lower (a few thousand rupees/month). Big 4 and industry controllership pay above smaller firms; semi-qualified/non-CA internal-audit roles sit below these CA bands.

Who's hiring

- **Big 4 & audit firms:** Deloitte, PwC, EY, KPMG, BDO, Grant Thornton, plus thousands of mid-tier and local CA firms (the articleship engine).
- **Industry internal audit / controllership:** Plum and other fintechs, plus internal-audit teams across manufacturing, banking, IT and consumer sectors.
- **GCC assurance & controls teams** of MNCs running SOX/IFC testing from India.
- Regulators and PSUs for internal-audit functions.

How to break in / stand out

Audit is the **most structured entry** into elite finance careers — but the front door for statutory work is genuinely the **CA articleship**. To break in and stand out:

1. **Do articleship at a firm with real audit exposure** (or a strong internal-audit internship if you're not on the CA track) — hands-on statutory audit experience is the credential employers actually trust.
2. **Master Ind AS and the Standards on Auditing cold**, and build a sample **audit working-paper file** for one account cycle (say, revenue or fixed assets) — walkthrough, risk, control test, conclusion. It shows you understand the *method*, not just the theory.
3. **Learn control frameworks** (IFC/COSO, and SOX if you target MNCs) and one data-analytics tool — full-population testing is where modern audit is heading.

The **single biggest differentiator** is demonstrable **professional scepticism plus airtight documentation** — a candidate who can explain how they'd test an assertion, what evidence would satisfy them, and how they'd document it, reads as a real auditor. Pair that with the **CA** (or **CIA** for a pure internal-audit path) and you have the strongest, most durable credential in Indian finance.

Payroll & Compliance Executive

Snapshot

The Payroll & Compliance Executive is the person who makes sure every employee is paid the right amount, on the right day, with the right deductions — and that the company stays on the right side of India's statutory machinery (PF, ESI, Professional Tax, TDS on salary, labour-law returns). It sits at the intersection of Finance, HR, and Compliance. In smaller firms it lives inside the HR or accounts team; in large GCCs and BPOs it is a dedicated "Payroll Operations" function running for external clients under strict SLAs. This is a process-heavy, deadline-driven, accuracy-obsessed role — a single wrong PF number can trigger a notice, and a missed pay-run erodes employee trust instantly. The ladder typically runs Payroll Executive/Associate -> Sr Payroll Executive -> Payroll Team Lead/SME -> Assistant Manager Payroll -> Payroll Manager -> Payroll Operations Lead. In global-payroll GCC setups (Accenture, Genpact, ADP, TCS) you also see "Payroll Analyst" and "Specialist" titles that own a country or region.

What you'll actually do

- Run the monthly payroll cycle end to end: collect inputs (attendance, leave, new joiners, exits, arrears, incentives), process gross-to-net, and release salaries within the pay-run SLA.
- Compute and deduct statutory items: Provident Fund (12% EPF), ESI (where wages ≤ Rs 21,000), Professional Tax (state-wise slabs), and TDS on salary under the correct tax regime.
- File and deposit statutory dues on time: PF/ESI challans (ECR), PT returns, and quarterly TDS returns (Form 24Q); issue Form 16 at year-end.
- Reconcile payroll: month-on-month variance analysis, headcount vs cost reconciliation, GL-to-payroll tie-outs, and reconciling statutory registers against challans paid.
- Handle full-and-final settlements for exits — gratuity, leave encashment, notice recovery, and clawbacks.
- Produce payroll reports for internal finance and for authorities; support statutory and internal audits with registers and evidence.
- In GCC/global-payroll roles: run payroll for one or more countries, coordinate with in-country partners, manage vendor SLAs, and meet tight cut-off calendars.

> Real posting (Accenture): "Payroll processing, statutory deductions and social security; reconciliations and variance analysis; prepare payroll reports for authorities within agreed SLAs."

Must-have skills

Hard skills: end-to-end payroll processing; solid grasp of PF, ESI, PT, TDS-on-salary and gratuity/bonus rules; gross-to-net logic; reconciliation and variance analysis; and strong Excel (VLOOKUP/XLOOKUP, PivotTables, SUMIFS, IF-nesting for slab logic). Understanding of the old vs new tax regime and how it changes salary TDS is now essential. Soft skills the JDs repeat: confidentiality (you see everyone's salary), accuracy under deadline pressure, SLA discipline, and clear communication when an employee disputes a payslip. In global-payroll roles, comfort with multiple country rules and time-zone coordination matters.

Tools & software

- **Payroll/HRMS:** greytHR, Zoho Payroll, Keka, Darwinbox, RazorpayX Payroll (India SMEs/mid-market); SAP SuccessFactors/SAP Payroll, ADP GlobalView/Celergo, Ceridian, Workday for large/global setups.
- **Statutory portals:** EPFO Unified Portal (ECR), ESIC portal, state PT portals, TRACES and the Income-Tax e-filing portal for 24Q/Form 16.
- **Spreadsheets & reporting:** advanced Excel is non-negotiable; Power BI/Tableau for payroll dashboards in larger teams.
- **Ticketing/SLA:** ServiceNow or similar for case management in BPO/GCC payroll ops.

Qualifications & certifications

A B.Com (or BBA/M.Com) is the standard base; Accenture's posting asks for B.Com with 3+ years. No single "payroll certification" is mandatory in India, but these genuinely help: a diploma in payroll/labour laws or HR-payroll, CA-Inter or CMA-Inter (signals statutory and reconciliation strength), and for global roles the **CPP (Certified Payroll Professional)** or **FPC** from the American Payroll Association, plus **CIPP** (UK) for UK-payroll GCC teams. An MBA-HR or MBA-Finance can accelerate the move into a Payroll Manager seat. Knowledge of the four new Labour Codes (as they roll out) is increasingly a differentiator.

Experience & typical titles

- **Fresher / 0-2 yrs:** Payroll Associate, Payroll Executive, Payroll Trainee — you own inputs, run checks, and prepare challans under supervision.
- **2-4 yrs:** Sr Payroll Executive, Payroll Analyst, Payroll Specialist — you run full cycles independently, file statutory returns, and handle F&F.
- **5-8 yrs:** Payroll Team Lead, Payroll SME, Assistant Manager Payroll — you own an SLA/client or country, manage juniors, and face audits.

ATS keywords to mirror

Payroll processing, statutory compliance, PF, ESI, Professional Tax, TDS on salary, Form 24Q, Form 16, gross-to-net, EPFO ECR, ESIC, gratuity, full and final settlement, payroll reconciliation, variance analysis, SLA, greytHR, Zoho Payroll, SAP Payroll, ADP, labour law compliance, social security, global payroll, statutory deductions, payroll audit.

Salary in India (indicative, FY2026)

Experience band	Indicative CTC (Rs LPA)
Fresher (0-2 yrs)	2.5 – 4.5
2-4 yrs	4.5 – 8
5-8 yrs	8 – 15

Global-payroll GCC roles and Payroll Manager seats sit at the upper end; pure India-payroll SME roles at the lower. Varies by city and employer; figures are approximate.

Who's hiring

Big GCCs and BPOs run large payroll-ops factories: **Accenture**, Genpact, TCS, Infosys BPM, Wipro, ADP, and Deloitte/EY managed-payroll teams — these dominate the global-payroll GCC variant. On the India-payroll side, every mid-to-large corporate has an in-house payroll team, and specialist providers (greytHR, Zoho, RazorpayX, Keka, PazCare) hire payroll executives to run client books. SMEs fold payroll into the accounts function, so an Accounts Executive who owns payroll is common in Hyderabad/Bangalore firms.

How to break in / stand out

Start by mastering the statutory triad — PF, ESI, PT — plus salary-TDS under both tax regimes, because that knowledge is what separates a data-entry clerk from a real payroll professional. Build a portfolio project: take a mock 50-employee company, build a full gross-to-net payroll workbook in Excel with automated PF/ESI/PT/TDS logic, a variance report, and a set of challan-ready outputs — this single artifact proves more than any bullet point. Learn one modern HRMS (greytHR or Zoho Payroll) hands-on; free trials exist. **The single biggest differentiator is zero-error, on-time delivery under SLA** — payroll is judged on reliability, so a candidate who can talk credibly about cut-off calendars, reconciliation checks, and how they caught an error before pay-out instantly stands out. For the GCC path, add one country's payroll rules (UK or US) and the CPP/CIPP credential to jump from India-payroll to global-payroll pay bands.

Financial Analyst

Snapshot

"Financial Analyst" is the most elastic title in finance — it can mean anyone who turns financial data into decisions. In practice, at asset managers and large financial firms it means a reporting-and-analysis specialist: someone who validates data, builds reports, and surfaces risks and trends for the business. The Franklin Templeton posting is a clean example — AUM and fund-flow reporting, validating asset data, and analysing it for risk and trends, using Power BI, VBA, Power Automate, Alteryx and Excel. This is a data-heavy, tooling-forward role that sits inside Finance, Operations, or a dedicated MIS/analytics team. It is *not* the same as FP&A (which is forward-looking planning) — the Financial Analyst is often reporting-and-insight on existing data, though the lines blur. The ladder runs Analyst -> Sr Analyst -> Assistant Manager -> Manager -> AVP/VP in banks and AMCs. Because the title is so broad, always read the JD: the tools and the "what you'll analyse" lines tell you which flavour it really is.

What you'll actually do

- Produce recurring financial and business reports: AUM, fund flows, revenue, cost, and KPI dashboards — daily, weekly, monthly.
- Validate and reconcile source data before it hits a report: check asset data, catch breaks, and ensure numbers tie across systems.
- Analyse the data for risk, trends, and anomalies — spot the outlier flow, the margin drift, the ageing exposure — and flag it to the business.
- Automate the grunt work: build repeatable pipelines in Alteryx/Power Automate and macros in VBA so reports refresh with less manual effort.
- Build and maintain Power BI dashboards and self-service views for stakeholders.
- Support ad-hoc analysis requests from management, and partner with ops/finance teams on data quality.
- In global-firm setups this often runs on a shift aligned to the parent market (the Franklin role is a 2-11pm night shift out of Hyderabad).

> Real posting (Franklin Templeton): "Report on AUM and flows, validate asset data, and analyse it for risk and trends — using Power BI, VBA, Power Automate, Alteryx and Excel."

Must-have skills

Hard skills: advanced Excel (PivotTables, complex formulas, Power Query); data validation and reconciliation instinct; at least one BI tool (Power BI most common); and increasingly an automation/ETL tool (Alteryx, Power Automate) plus VBA or SQL. The ability to *read* numbers — to look at a report and know which figure is wrong or interesting — is the core skill, and it's harder than the tooling. Basic accounting and financial-statement literacy is assumed. Soft skills the JDs demand: attention to detail, ability to translate data into a clear one-line insight for non-analysts, and reliability on a reporting calendar.

Tools & software

- **Excel** — still the backbone; expect Power Query and heavy formula work.
- **Power BI / Tableau** — dashboarding and visual reporting.
- **Alteryx, Power Automate** — data prep and workflow automation.
- **VBA, SQL, Python** — automation and pulling/reshaping data; Python is a rising "nice to have".
- **Source systems** — depending on employer: portfolio/fund accounting systems (AMCs), SAP/Oracle (corporates), Bloomberg/Refinitiv (data feeds).

Qualifications & certifications

The base is a bachelor's — B.Com, BBA, economics, or similar; many roles are open to freshers or 0-2 yrs. An MBA-Finance strengthens the profile and is often preferred for the analysis-heavy versions. Certifications that genuinely help depend on the flavour: **CFA** (or CFA Level 1) for investment/asset-management analyst roles; **NISM** series for capital-markets employers; and for the tooling side, a **Power BI (PL-300)** or **Alteryx Designer Core** certification is a concrete resume booster because these roles are explicit about tools. **FMVA** helps if the role tilts toward modelling. Certifications matter less here than a demonstrable ability to build a dashboard and validate data.

Experience & typical titles

- **Fresher / 0-2 yrs:** Financial Analyst, Data/Reporting Analyst, MIS Analyst, Business Analyst (Finance).
- **2-4 yrs:** Sr Financial Analyst, Reporting Analyst, Fund Reporting Analyst.
- **5-8 yrs:** Assistant Manager / Manager – Financial Reporting or Analytics, MIS Lead.

ATS keywords to mirror

Financial analysis, financial reporting, data validation, reconciliation, AUM reporting, fund flows, trend analysis, risk analysis, Power BI, Alteryx, Power Automate, VBA, advanced Excel, Power Query, SQL, KPI reporting, MIS, dashboards, variance analysis, data quality, management reporting.

Salary in India (indicative, FY2026)

Experience band	Indicative CTC (Rs LPA)
Fresher (0-2 yrs)	4 – 7
2-4 yrs	7 – 13
5-8 yrs	13 – 22

AMCs, global banks, and product firms pay at the upper end (and shift allowances add up); corporate MIS roles sit lower. Approximate; varies by city and employer.

Who's hiring

Asset managers and global financial firms are the classic home — **Franklin Templeton**, plus AMCs, Fidelity, BlackRock/Aladdin teams, and fund-admin shops (State Street, BNY, Northern Trust) in

Hyderabad/Bangalore/Pune. Global banks (Citi, HSBC, Barclays, JPMorgan GCCs) hire reporting and data analysts in bulk. Beyond finance firms, every large corporate and consulting/BPO (Genpact, Accenture, EY) has "Financial Analyst" roles doing reporting and analysis.

How to break in / stand out

This is one of the most accessible finance roles for a commerce/MBA candidate *if* you can prove you handle data, not just theory. Build a portfolio: take a public dataset (mutual-fund AUM data, or a company's segment financials) and build a Power BI dashboard that validates the data and surfaces one genuine trend or risk — publish it, and put the link on your resume. Layer on one automation project (an Alteryx workflow or a VBA macro that turns a manual report into a one-click refresh). **The single biggest differentiator is the ability to turn a messy data extract into a clean, validated dashboard with a one-sentence insight** — because the title is crowded, the candidate who shows a working artifact beats the one who only lists Excel. Learn to explain *why* a number moved, not just *that* it moved; that judgement is what earns the promotion to Senior Analyst and beyond.

FP&A Analyst

Snapshot

FP&A — Financial Planning & Analysis — is the premium back-office finance role: the team that owns budgets, forecasts, and the "why did we miss the number?" conversation with leadership. Where an accountant records what happened and a Financial Analyst reports on it, FP&A looks *forward* — building the annual budget, re-forecasting through the year, modelling scenarios, and explaining variance of actuals against plan to management. It sits close to decision-makers (CFO, business heads, unit controllers) and is the classic launchpad to Finance Manager, FP&A Manager, and eventually FP&A Lead / Finance Business Partner / Head of FP&A. In India this role is huge inside GCCs and BPO finance towers (Genpact, Accenture) as well as in-house corporate finance teams. It commands better pay and prestige than transactional roles precisely because it blends financial modelling, business judgement, and executive communication. The ladder: FP&A Analyst -> Sr FP&A Analyst -> Assistant Manager -> Manager FP&A -> Sr Manager / FP&A Lead -> Finance Business Partner / Director FP&A.

What you'll actually do

- Own the budgeting and forecasting cycle: build the annual operating plan (AOP), run quarterly re-forecasts, and consolidate inputs from business units.
- Perform variance analysis — actuals vs budget vs forecast vs prior year — and write the commentary that explains the drivers to management.
- Build and maintain financial models: revenue and cost drivers, scenario and sensitivity analysis, and headcount/capex plans.
- Produce management reporting: monthly business reviews, KPI decks, and board/leadership packs in Excel and PowerPoint.
- Partner with business owners to challenge assumptions, track spend against plan, and support decisions (pricing, hiring, investment).
- Pull actuals from the ERP (SAP/Oracle) and feed the planning tool (Anaplan/Hyperion), maintaining data integrity across systems.
- In BPO/GCC setups, this can involve R2R-adjacent tasks and running FP&A processes for a specific region or client.

> Real posting (Accenture / Genpact): "Budgeting, forecasting, variance analysis against actuals, financial modelling, and preparing KPI and management reports; SAP/Oracle/Anaplan/Hyperion, Power BI/Tableau."

Must-have skills

Hard skills: financial modelling (the real differentiator — driver-based models, scenario analysis, three-statement thinking); expert Excel (INDEX-MATCH/XLOOKUP, dynamic arrays, complex modelling, Power Query); strong variance analysis and the ability to write crisp business commentary; and PowerPoint storytelling for leadership decks. Familiarity with a planning tool (Anaplan or Hyperion/Oracle EPM) and an ERP (SAP/Oracle) is repeatedly demanded at 3-5 yrs. Soft skills that make or break FP&A: business acumen (understanding *what drives* the numbers, not just the numbers), the ability to influence non-finance stakeholders, and executive-level communication — turning a 40-tab model into a three-bullet takeaway.

Tools & software

- **Excel & PowerPoint** — the core modelling and reporting toolkit; mastery is assumed.
- **ERP:** SAP, Oracle — source of actuals.
- **EPM / planning:** Anaplan, Oracle Hyperion/EPM, SAP BPC, Workday Adaptive — budgeting and consolidation.
- **BI:** Power BI, Tableau — dashboards and KPI reporting.
- **Rising skills:** SQL and Python for pulling and automating large-data analysis.

Qualifications & certifications

A bachelor's in commerce/finance is the base, but FP&A is where postgraduate and professional qualifications pay off. **MBA-Finance, CA, or CMA** are all explicitly "a plus" in these JDs, and the best FP&A profiles usually carry one. **CMA (US or ICAI-Cost)** is especially well-aligned — cost, planning, and management accounting are the discipline's core. **CFA** helps in FP&A roles at financial firms or those tilting toward corporate finance/valuation. **FMVA** is a genuinely useful signal for the modelling skill at the analyst rung. For the tooling, an **Anaplan** or **Power BI (PL-300)** certification stands out because these platforms are named directly in postings.

Experience & typical titles

- **Fresher / 0-2 yrs:** FP&A Analyst, Financial Planning Analyst — usually MBA/CA freshers; you own data pulls, model maintenance, and variance schedules.
- **2-4 yrs:** Sr FP&A Analyst, FP&A Specialist — you own a business unit's forecast and commentary end to end.
- **5-8 yrs:** Assistant Manager / Manager FP&A, Finance Business Partner — you own the planning cycle, present to leadership, and manage analysts.

ATS keywords to mirror

FP&A, financial planning and analysis, budgeting, forecasting, variance analysis, financial modelling, management reporting, KPI reporting, annual operating plan, re-forecast, scenario analysis, driver-based modelling, actuals vs budget, SAP, Oracle, Anaplan, Hyperion, Power BI, Tableau, advanced Excel, business partnering, MIS.

Salary in India (indicative, FY2026)

Experience band	Indicative CTC (Rs LPA)
Fresher (0-2 yrs)	6 – 10
2-4 yrs	10 – 18
5-8 yrs	18 – 32

FP&A pays a clear premium over transactional finance. GCCs, MNC captives, and product firms sit at the top of each band; BPO FP&A towers a notch lower. Approximate; varies by city and employer.

Who's hiring

GCCs and BPO finance towers are the biggest recruiters: **Accenture, Genpact, Signode**, plus Deloitte/EY/KPMG managed-finance, and captive centres of MNCs (Amazon, Microsoft, Walmart, Philips, Shell) that run FP&A out of Bangalore/Hyderabad/Gurgaon/Pune. Every large Indian and multinational corporate has an in-house FP&A team. Product and tech companies (start-up to unicorn) hire FP&A analysts to run investor and board reporting.

How to break in / stand out

FP&A rewards the candidate who can *model and communicate*, so build proof of both. Create a portfolio project: take a listed company's public financials and build a driver-based three-statement model with a budget-vs-actual variance page and a scenario toggle (base/bull/bear), then summarise it in a one-page leadership deck — this single artifact demonstrates the exact skill FP&A hiring managers screen for. Master Excel modelling to a level beyond most peers, and learn the vocabulary of business drivers (unit economics, contribution margin, cost-to-serve). If you're a fresher, an MBA-Finance or CMA plus a strong modelling portfolio can get you in directly at the analyst rung. **The single biggest differentiator is the ability to explain a variance in business terms and recommend an action** — anyone can compute that spend was 8% over budget; the FP&A professional who says *why* and *what to do about it* is the one who becomes a Finance Business Partner.

Finance Controller / Controllership

Snapshot

The Financial Controller is the person who owns the accuracy of the numbers. Where an accountant records transactions and an FP&A analyst forecasts the future, the Controller is accountable for the *actuals* — the reported financial statements are right, close on time, compliant with Ind AS / Indian GAAP, and defensible in front of statutory auditors, the tax department and the board. It is the senior accounting leadership track: you sit above the R2R, AP/AR, payroll and general-ledger teams and report into the CFO or Head of Finance. In a startup or SME you may *be* the whole finance function; in a larger firm you run a team and a control framework. The typical ladder runs **Accounts Executive → Sr Executive / Assistant Manager (Finance) → Deputy Manager / Manager (Controllership) → Financial Controller → VP Finance / CFO**. Reaching Controller almost always means a CA (or many years of qualified-by-experience accounting), because the role is fundamentally about judgment on recognition, disclosure and controls, not just processing.

What you'll actually do

- Own the **end-to-end month, quarter and annual close** — drive the working-day (WD) close calendar, review journals (accruals, prepayments, provisions, intercompany, fixed assets, reclasses) and sign off the trial balance.
- Prepare and finalise **financial statements under Ind AS / Indian GAAP** — P&L, balance sheet, cash-flow statement, notes and disclosures.
- Design, operate and evidence **internal financial controls (IFC)** — approval matrices, segregation of duties, reconciliation sign-offs, and the documentation an auditor will test.
- Oversee **statutory, tax and internal audits** end to end — be the primary contact for the auditors, provide schedules, resolve queries, and clear observations.
- Own **direct and indirect tax compliance oversight** — GST returns, TDS, advance tax, income-tax filings — even where a specialist team executes them.
- Run **treasury and cash-flow forecasting** — visibility on liquidity, bank balances, working capital and funding needs.
- Review **balance-sheet reconciliations with commentary and ageing**, and chase down unexplained or stale items.

> Real posting (Plum): "Own the month, quarter and year-end close; prepare financial statements under Indian GAAP; establish and maintain internal financial controls; support statutory, tax and internal audits; and manage treasury and cash-flow forecasts."

Must-have skills

Hard skills: deep working knowledge of Ind AS / Indian GAAP and the Companies Act schedule III presentation; the full close-to-report cycle; internal financial controls design and testing; consolidation and intercompany elimination; GST / TDS / income-tax framework; treasury and cash-flow forecasting; audit management; advanced Excel (large-workbook modelling, reconciliations, pivot-driven schedules).

Soft skills: ownership and accountability (the buck stops with you on the numbers), the composure to face auditors and the board, the ability to explain a variance in plain business language, and the discipline to hit a fixed WD close every single month. People management and review discipline become central the moment you have a team.

Tools & software

- **ERP / accounting:** Zoho Books (SME/startup, as at Plum), Tally / TallyPrime (SME), SAP, Oracle NetSuite, Microsoft Dynamics (larger firms).
- **Excel** — non-negotiable; the Controller lives in reconciliations, schedules and close trackers.
- **Consolidation / reporting:** Fluence, OneStream or SAP BPC in bigger groups; often just Excel in mid-market.
- **Close & controls tooling:** BlackLine or FloQast for reconciliation and close management in mature finance teams.
- Tax/compliance portals: GSTN, TRACES, income-tax e-filing.

Qualifications & certifications

- **CA (ICAI) is the standard qualification** — most Controller and controllership-manager JDs say "CA-qualified", and Plum's asks for a qualified CA with 1–3 years. This is the single most valuable credential for the role in India.
- **CMA (ICMAI)** can substitute in cost-heavy manufacturing controllership, but CA dominates for statutory reporting.
- **ACCA / CPA (US)** matter if you're in a global-capability-centre (GCC) or a US/UK-parented entity doing IFRS/US GAAP.
- **MBA-Finance** helps for the business-partnering and leadership dimension but does *not* replace an accounting qualification here.
- CFA/FRM are largely irrelevant to controllership — they signal markets/risk, not reporting.

Experience & typical titles

Rung	Experience	Typical titles
Entry to controllership	CA fresher–2 yrs	Executive / Sr Executive – Finance & Accounts, R2R Analyst
Mid	2–5 yrs	Assistant Manager / Deputy Manager – Controllership, Finance Manager
Senior	5–10 yrs	Financial Controller, Head of Controllership
Leadership	10+ yrs	VP Finance, CFO

A CA fresher does not walk straight into "Controller" — you earn it by owning close and audits for a few cycles first. In a small startup, though, a CA with 2–3 solid years can carry the Controller title because they *are* the function.

ATS keywords to mirror

Financial Controller, controllership, month-end close, quarter-end close, year-end close, Ind AS, Indian GAAP, financial statements, internal financial controls, IFC, statutory audit, tax audit, internal audit, GST, TDS, income tax, treasury, cash flow forecasting, balance sheet reconciliation, general ledger, consolidation, working capital, Schedule III, Companies Act, CA qualified, Zoho Books, Tally, SAP, variance analysis.

Salary in India (indicative, FY2026)

Experience band	Indicative CTC (Rs LPA)
CA fresher – 2 yrs (controllership exec)	9 – 14
2–4 yrs (AM / Deputy Manager)	14 – 22
5–8 yrs (Manager → Controller)	22 – 40

Approximate and varies materially by city, industry and whether it's an MNC/GCC vs an SME. Metro GCCs and funded startups pay at the top of these bands; SMEs and smaller cities well below.

Who's hiring

- **Startups and funded scale-ups** running lean finance — Plum (insurtech, Bangalore) is a good example; here the Controller is a broad, hands-on owner.
- **Global capability centres (GCCs)** of MNCs — controllership for group entities under IFRS/US GAAP.
- **Mid-market and manufacturing companies** needing statutory-reporting and IFC ownership.
- **Big 4 and consulting** — as a route in and out of controllership advisory (financial reporting, IFC/SOX).

How to break in / stand out

Get the CA first — for this role it is the ticket, not a nice-to-have. Then deliberately chase *close and audit* experience early: ask to own a balance-sheet area end to end, run reconciliations with commentary, and be the person who prepares the audit schedules. The candidate who impresses is the one who can say "I closed the books in 5 working days, prepared the Ind AS financials, and cleared the statutory audit with zero significant observations" — with specifics.

Build a portfolio proof point: a documented **close checklist / IFC control matrix** you designed, and a variance-commentary pack you produced. In interviews, be ready to talk through a genuine judgment call — a provision you sized, a revenue-recognition question under Ind AS 115, an audit observation you resolved.

The single biggest differentiator is **ownership under a deadline**: Controllers are trusted because they deliver an accurate close on a fixed day, month after month, and stand behind the numbers when auditors push. Demonstrate that reliability and the title follows.

Cost Accountant / Costing Analyst

Snapshot

The Cost Accountant is the person who answers "what does it actually cost us to make this?" — and then why the cost moved. Where a financial accountant reports what happened to the whole company and an FP&A analyst forecasts the P&L, the cost accountant works one level deeper and closer to the factory floor: unit economics, product and standard costing, inventory valuation, and the variances between what a product *should* cost and what it *did* cost. It is a manufacturing-heavy, CMA-flavoured discipline that sits in the finance/costing team and feeds pricing, margin and make-vs-buy decisions. The ladder typically runs **Costing Executive → Sr Costing Executive → Assistant Manager (Costing) → Manager (Cost & Management Accounting / Plant Finance) → Head of Costing / Plant Controller**. In India, the role also carries a statutory angle: certain companies must maintain cost records and undergo a **cost audit**, which keeps demand for qualified cost accountants steady.

What you'll actually do

- Build and maintain **standard costs and product cost sheets** — material, labour and overhead per unit — and update them as inputs and BOMs change.
- Run **variance analysis** — material price/usage, labour rate/efficiency, and overhead absorption variances — and explain them to plant and finance leadership.
- Perform **inventory valuation** — raw material, WIP and finished goods — and reconcile physical stock to books; investigate write-offs and slow-moving/obsolete stock.
- Do **margin and profitability analysis** by product, SKU, customer or plant, and flag loss-making lines.
- Support the **cost audit and cost records** compliance required under the Companies (Cost Records and Audit) Rules.
- Feed **pricing and make-vs-buy / cost-reduction** decisions with unit-economics data.
- Track **absorption of overheads** and reconcile cost accounts to the financial ledger at month-end.

> Real posting (manufacturing costing role): "Prepare and maintain standard costing and product cost sheets, perform variance analysis against actuals, value inventory (RM/WIP/FG), and support cost audit and margin reporting."

Must-have skills

Hard skills: costing methods (standard, marginal/variable, absorption, activity-based), variance analysis, inventory valuation (FIFO / weighted average) and the Ind AS 2 basics, BOM and overhead-absorption logic, cost-record and cost-audit requirements, strong Excel modelling, and the ability to read a manufacturing process and translate it into cost drivers.

Soft skills: comfort on the shop floor talking to production and stores teams; the ability to turn a variance into a plain-English story ("material price up 6% drove the miss, partly offset by better yield"); precision and a questioning mind about where costs really sit.

Cost accounting vs FP&A — the distinction

	Cost Accountant	FP&A Analyst
Focus	Product/unit cost, inventory, variances	Company P&L, budget vs actual
Altitude	Bottom-up, factory-level	Top-down, business-level
Core question	"What does this product cost and why?"	"Will we hit the plan and forecast?"
Home	Manufacturing, plant finance	Any industry, corporate finance
Cert edge	CMA (ICMAI)	MBA / CA / CMA

They overlap on variance analysis and Excel, but cost accounting is deeper on product economics and inventory; FP&A is broader and forward-looking on the whole P&L.

Tools & software

- **ERP costing modules:** SAP CO (Controlling) / SAP Material Ledger — the gold standard in Indian manufacturing; also Oracle and Microsoft Dynamics.
- **Excel** — the daily workhorse for cost sheets, variance bridges and inventory schedules.
- **Power BI / Tableau** for margin and cost dashboards.
- Plant/MES and inventory systems for consumption and production data.
- Tally in smaller manufacturers.

Qualifications & certifications

- **CMA (ICMAI) — Cost & Management Accountant — is the flagship credential** for this role in India and the one most directly aligned; it also carries the statutory right to sign cost audits.
- **CA (ICAI)** is respected and works well, especially for the reporting/reconciliation side.
- **B.Com / M.Com** is the common base degree; **MBA-Finance** helps for the management-accounting and business-partnering layer.
- **CIMA (UK)** / **CMA (US)** are useful in MNC/GCC environments doing global management accounting.
- CFA/FRM add little here — this is not a markets or risk role.

Experience & typical titles

Rung	Experience	Typical titles
Fresher	0–2 yrs	Costing Executive, Cost Analyst, Trainee Cost Accountant
Mid	2–5 yrs	Sr Costing Executive, Assistant Manager – Costing / Cost & MA
Senior	5–8 yrs	Manager – Costing, Plant Finance Manager
Leadership	8+ yrs	Head of Costing, Cost Controller, Plant Controller

ATS keywords to mirror

Cost accountant, costing analyst, standard costing, product costing, cost sheet, variance analysis, material variance, labour variance, overhead absorption, inventory valuation, RM/WIP/FG, margin analysis, profitability analysis, cost audit, cost records, activity-based costing, marginal costing, absorption costing, BOM, SAP CO, material ledger, CMA, ICMAI, plant finance, cost reduction.

Salary in India (indicative, FY2026)

Experience band	Indicative CTC (Rs LPA)
Fresher (CMA / B.Com)	4 – 8
2–4 yrs	8 – 14
5–8 yrs	14 – 24

Approximate and varies by city, industry and employer; large MNC manufacturers and auto/pharma plants pay at the higher end, smaller domestic manufacturers below. A qualified CMA typically starts meaningfully above a plain B.Com.

Who's hiring

- **Manufacturing** across the board — auto and auto-components, pharma, FMCG, chemicals, steel, cement, engineering.
- **Consumer and industrial goods** companies with large inventory and SKU counts.
- **GCCs / shared-service centres** running global management accounting and cost controlling.
- **Cost-audit and consulting firms** (practising Cost Accountants) for cost-records and cost-audit engagements.

How to break in / stand out

If you want this track, do the **CMA (ICMAI)** — it is the clearest signal and opens the statutory cost-audit door. Pair it with genuine curiosity about how things are made: the best cost accountants understand the process, not just the ledger. Get plant or factory exposure early, even a short stint, so you can speak to production and stores in their language.

Build a portfolio piece: take a product (real or realistic) and construct a **full cost sheet from BOM to per-unit cost**, then a **variance bridge** showing why actual differed from standard, with a one-page commentary. That single artefact demonstrates exactly the skill the JD wants and separates you from candidates who only know textbook formulae.

The biggest differentiator is being the person who **turns a cost variance into a decision** — not just reporting that material cost rose, but identifying the driver and recommending the pricing or sourcing action. Cost accountants who influence margin, rather than merely report it, are the ones who get promoted into plant finance and controllership.

Fund Accountant / Investment Operations

Snapshot

Fund accounting is where a huge share of Indian finance graduates actually enter the investment world — through the back and middle office of global asset managers, hedge funds, private-equity funds and administrators, run out of GCCs and third-party administrators in Bangalore, Mumbai, Pune, Hyderabad, Gurgaon and Chennai. A fund accountant doesn't pick stocks; they make sure the fund's books are right. The single most important number they produce is the **NAV (Net Asset Value)** — the per-unit price at which investors buy and sell — calculated on a strict daily, weekly or monthly cycle. Around that sit portfolio accounting, reconciliations, corporate actions and, for closed-end/PE funds, capital calls and distributions. It's high-volume, deadline-driven, process-heavy work with clear SLAs — and it's one of the most reliable ways for a B.Com / MBA-Finance fresher to get onto a finance career ladder inside a global name. The ladder runs **Analyst / Associate → Senior Analyst → Team Lead / Supervisor → Assistant Manager → Manager → AVP / VP (Fund Operations)**.

What you'll actually do

- Calculate and validate the **daily/periodic NAV** for one or more funds — strike the price, tie out to controls, and release within the SLA cut-off.
- Maintain **portfolio / investment accounting** — record trades, income (dividends, interest, coupons), accruals, and fee calculations (management and performance fees).
- Perform **reconciliations** — cash, positions and holdings between the fund's books, the custodian and the counterparties — and clear breaks.
- Process **corporate actions** — dividends, splits, mergers, rights, coupons — and reflect them correctly in positions and NAV.
- For PE/closed-end funds: process **capital calls and distributions**, maintain capital accounts and commitments/unfunded, and support **investor / LP reporting** (IRR, TVPI, DPI, NAV).
- Price securities and handle **pricing/valuation exceptions**, escalating stale or hard-to-value positions.
- Meet **SLAs and audit/regulatory deadlines**, and support fund audits with schedules and reconciliations.

> Real posting (investment-operations style): "Calculate daily NAV, book trades and income, reconcile cash and positions against the custodian, process corporate actions and resolve breaks within agreed SLAs."

Must-have skills

Hard skills: NAV computation and the components of a fund's balance sheet, trade lifecycle and settlement, reconciliations and break resolution, corporate-action processing, security types (equity, fixed income, derivatives) and how each is priced/accrued, strong Excel, and comfort reading a custodian/administrator statement.

Soft skills: precision under a hard cut-off (a wrong NAV is a real problem), process discipline, break-chasing tenacity, clear escalation, and the stamina for high volumes. Many roles run **shifts aligned to US/EU**

markets — night or evening shifts are common, so flexibility matters.

Tools & software

- **Fund-accounting platforms:** SS&C Geneva, SimCorp Dimension, Multifonds, Advent APX, BNY's / State Street's proprietary systems, InvestOne.
- **Excel** — universal for reconciliations, checks and NAV support.
- **Bloomberg / Refinitiv** for pricing and security reference data.
- Custodian and administrator portals; SWIFT/settlement systems in ops-heavy roles.

Qualifications & certifications

- **B.Com / M.Com / BBA / MBA-Finance** is the standard entry degree — this is one of the most graduate-accessible finance tracks.
- **NISM series** (e.g. Series V-A Mutual Fund Distributors, or the relevant operations modules) are inexpensive, India-recognised signals that you understand the product.
- **CFA (Level 1+)** genuinely helps for progression, valuation understanding and moving toward middle/front office over time.
- **IMC (Investment Management Certificate, UK)** and fund-ops certifications are valued in GCCs.
- **CA / CMA** are not required and can even be "overqualified" for pure fund accounting, though they help you rise into controllership over the fund.
- FRM helps if you move toward risk/valuation.

Experience & typical titles

Rung	Experience	Typical titles
Fresher	0–2 yrs	Fund Accountant, Investment Operations Analyst, NAV Analyst, Associate
Mid	2–5 yrs	Senior Fund Accountant, Team Lead, Senior Associate
Senior	5–8 yrs	Assistant Manager / Manager – Fund Operations
Leadership	8+ yrs	AVP / VP – Fund Accounting / Investment Operations

ATS keywords to mirror

Fund accounting, NAV calculation, net asset value, portfolio accounting, investment operations, reconciliation, cash reconciliation, position reconciliation, corporate actions, capital calls, distributions, LP reporting, IRR, TVPI, DPI, trade settlement, custodian, pricing, valuation, SLA, Geneva, SimCorp, Multifonds, Advent, Bloomberg, fixed income, derivatives, mutual fund, private equity, hedge fund.

Salary in India (indicative, FY2026)

Experience band	Indicative CTC (Rs LPA)
Fresher	4 – 7
2–4 yrs	7 – 13
5–8 yrs	13 – 24

Approximate and varies by employer, shift and city. Large global administrators and asset-manager GCCs pay competitively; night-shift and complex-product (derivatives, PE) roles often carry a premium. Progression is steady but volume-driven — moving up usually means owning more complex funds or a team.

Who's hiring

The big employers are the fund administrators and asset-manager GCCs, hiring at scale in India: - **Citco, Northern Trust, State Street, SS&C, BNY (Mellon)** — the marquee names in fund admin / investment operations. - **JPMorgan, HSBC, Franklin Templeton, BlackRock (Aladdin ops), Fidelity, Invesco** — asset-manager captive centres. - **Apex, Standard Chartered, Deutsche Bank** and other custodian/administrator operations.

How to break in / stand out

This is one of the most *learnable* finance entries — you don't need a top-tier pedigree, you need accuracy, product knowledge and reliability. Get the fundamentals cold: be able to explain, in an interview, exactly **how NAV is calculated** and what moves it, what a reconciliation break is, and how a corporate action flows through positions. That alone puts you ahead of most freshers who apply blind.

Signal product knowledge cheaply: clear an **NISM module or CFA Level 1**, and learn to read a fund fact sheet. Build a small portfolio piece — a mock **NAV computation in Excel** for a sample portfolio (positions, prices, accruals, fees → per-unit NAV), plus a reconciliation showing you can spot and clear a break. Show it.

The single biggest differentiator is **precision under a deadline plus curiosity to move up**: many people process NAVs; the ones who get promoted understand *why* the number is what it is, catch errors before the cut-off, and treat fund accounting as the on-ramp to valuation, middle office or fund controllership rather than a dead end. Accept the night shifts early — they're where the best global-fund experience lives.

Core-Finance Skills, Tools & Certification Matrix

This closing chapter pulls the whole book together into decision tools. The roles you've read about — accounting, tax, audit/controllership, R2R, payroll, FP&A, cost accounting, fund accounting and the analyst tracks — share a common toolkit but demand it in different proportions. Use the matrices below to see where your current skills already qualify you, and where a single new skill or certification unlocks a role.

Role × skill matrix

How heavily each core-finance role leans on each skill. **Core** = you must have it. **Useful** = expected/plus. **Rare** = seldom needed for this role.

Role	Tally	Excel	SQL	Power BI	GST/TDS	Ind AS	SAP	Month-end	Recon
Accountant / Accounts Exec	Core	Core	Rare	Rare	Core	Useful	Useful	Core	Core
Tax Analyst	Useful	Core	Rare	Useful	Core	Useful	Useful	Useful	Useful
Audit / Controllership	Useful	Core	Rare	Useful	Core	Core	Useful	Core	Core
R2R / GL Accountant	Rare	Core	Useful	Useful	Useful	Useful	Core	Core	Core
Payroll	Useful	Core	Rare	Useful	Core	Rare	Useful	Core	Core
Financial Analyst (asset data)	Rare	Core	Useful	Core	Rare	Rare	Useful	Useful	Core
FP&A Analyst	Rare	Core	Useful	Core	Rare	Useful	Core	Core	Useful
Financial Controller	Useful	Core	Rare	Useful	Core	Core	Core	Core	Core
Cost Accountant	Useful	Core	Rare	Useful	Useful	Useful	Core	Core	Core
Fund Accountant	Rare	Core	Useful	Useful	Rare	Useful	Useful	Core	Core

Read the columns, not just the rows. **Excel, month-end and reconciliation are "Core" almost everywhere** — they are the non-negotiable spine of core finance. **Tally is Core only at the SME accountant end; SAP is Core at the R2R/FP&A/controllership/costing end** — the two rarely overlap, which is why SME and GCC finance feel like different worlds. **SQL and Power BI are the rising differentiators** — still "Useful" not "Core" for most roles, which is exactly why learning them now moves you ahead of the field.

Certification decoder — which cert for which role

Cert	Best for	Skip if
CA (ICAI)	Controllership, audit, tax, statutory reporting — the gold standard for accounting leadership	You're aiming at markets/research/risk (CFA/FRM fit better)
CMA (ICMAI)	Cost accounting, plant finance, management accounting, cost audit (statutory)	You want statutory financial-reporting sign-off (that's CA)
CS (ICSI)	Company secretarial, corporate/secretarial compliance, governance	Your target is core numbers/reporting, not compliance/law
MBA-Finance	FP&A, business partnering, IB/ER/PE analyst tracks, general management path	You need statutory sign-off or deep costing (add CA/CMA)
ACCA	GCC / MNC roles under IFRS, global reporting, controllership in captives	You're purely India-statutory focused (CA is more recognised locally)
CPA (US)	US-GAAP entities, US-parented GCCs, controllership in American MNCs	No US/IFRS exposure in your target roles
NISM series	Fund accounting, investment operations, broking, wealth/markets-facing roles	You're in pure accounting/tax/controllership
CFA	Equity research, IB, PE, fund management, valuation, risk progression	You're on the accounting/compliance track
FRM	Credit/market/model risk, risk analytics	You're not touching risk
ACAMS	KYC/AML and financial-crime compliance	Not in a compliance/AML role
FMVA	A fast, practical modelling signal for FP&A/analyst freshers with no MBA	You already have CA/MBA + real modelling experience

One-line rule of thumb: *CA for the numbers being right, CMA for what things cost, MBA for the story and the room, CFA/FRM for markets and risk, NISM/ACAMS/FMVA for cheap, targeted signals.* Don't stack certs randomly — pick the one that matches the row you want in the matrix above.

Universal ATS keyword bank (core finance)

Mirror the terms that match *your* target role from its chapter, but these recur across almost every core-finance JD and belong on most resumes:

Process & reporting: month-end close, quarter-end close, year-end close, general ledger, journal entries, accruals, prepayments, provisions, financial statements, balance sheet reconciliation, variance analysis, management reporting, financial reporting.

Compliance & tax: GST, TDS, income tax, statutory compliance, statutory audit, tax audit, internal audit, internal financial controls, Ind AS, Indian GAAP, IFRS.

Tools: Tally / TallyPrime, SAP, Oracle, Zoho Books, Excel (VLOOKUP, PivotTables, INDEX-MATCH, SUMIFS), Power BI, Tableau, SQL, Anaplan, Hyperion.

Transactional: accounts payable, accounts receivable, bank reconciliation, 3-way reconciliation, intercompany reconciliation, fixed assets, depreciation, payroll processing.

Analytical: budgeting, forecasting, financial modelling, KPI reporting, cash-flow forecasting, cost analysis, margin analysis.

Use the *exact* casing and phrasing from the posting where you can (e.g. "R2R" and "record to report", "AP/AR" and "accounts payable/receivable") — ATS filters often match literally.

90-day "become hireable" action list

A concrete plan for a commerce / MBA-Finance candidate to go from "studying finance" to "shortlist-worthy" for a core-finance role.

Days 1–30 — Build the spine. - Get genuinely strong in **Excel**: lookups, PivotTables, SUMIFS/INDEX-MATCH, a clean 3-statement or cost model. This single skill is "Core" in every row above. - Learn one **accounting/ERP tool** end to end — **Tally** if you're targeting SME/accounting roles, **SAP FICO basics** if you're targeting GCC/R2R/controllership. - Nail the fundamentals of **GST, TDS and the month-end close cycle** — be able to explain them out loud.

Days 31–60 — Add a differentiator + a credential. - Learn the basics of **SQL and Power BI** — still "Useful" not universal, which is precisely why they lift you above other freshers. - Start (or clear the first level of) the **one certification** that matches your target row: CA/CMA if you're in for the long accounting haul, NISM/FMVA/CFA-L1 for fast, cheap signals toward analyst/fund roles. - Rewrite your resume to **mirror the ATS keywords** from your two target chapters.

Days 61–90 — Prove it with a portfolio. - Build **one real artefact** for your target role: a month-end close checklist + reconciliation pack (accounting/controllership); a product cost sheet + variance bridge (costing); a NAV computation + break-resolution sheet (fund accounting); a budget-vs-actual variance model (FP&A). - Do a **mock of the role's core deliverable** end to end and be ready to walk an interviewer through it. - Apply in a **focused batch** to the real employer types named in each chapter — SMEs for accounting, GCCs (Genpact, Accenture, Citi, State Street, Northern Trust, SS&C) for R2R/FP&A/fund ops — and tailor each resume to that specific posting.

The honest truth this book keeps returning to: core-finance roles reward **reliability and specificity** over prestige. The candidate who can *show* one clean close, one solid variance bridge, one correct NAV — and speak the exact language of the JD — beats the candidate with a longer degree list and nothing to demonstrate. Pick your row, build the spine, add the one cert that fits, and prove it with one artefact. That's the whole game.

Finance Jobs Decoded: Markets, Banking, Risk & Advisory

What Employers Actually Want — Decoded from Real 2026 Job Postings (India-first)

Role by role: responsibilities, skills, tools, certifications, ATS keywords, salary bands & how to break in

Contents

How Front-Office & Markets Finance Hiring Works

Before we decode individual roles, you need the map. "Finance" is not one job market — it is at least three, stacked by prestige, pay and difficulty of entry. If you understand which layer a posting belongs to, you can read any job description in seconds and know whether it is a realistic target, a stretch, or a trap. This chapter builds that map for the Indian market as it looks in mid-2026.

Buy-side vs sell-side vs support

Everything in markets finance sits on one of three sides.

Sell-side firms *make and sell* financial products, research and advice. Investment banks (Citi, Kotak, Axis Capital, JM Financial), broking houses and their equity-research desks (Equirus, Motilal Oswal, ICICI Securities) are sell-side. They raise capital, execute M&A, publish research and trade. Sell-side is where most graduates start, because it hires in volume and trains hard. The price is brutal hours.

Buy-side firms *manage money* — mutual funds, PMS, hedge funds, private equity, venture capital, insurance and pension pools (SBI MF, HDFC AMC, ICICI Prudential, sovereign and PE funds). They *buy* what the sell-side sells. Buy-side seats are fewer, quieter, better paid over a career, and much harder to enter directly. Many people spend 2-4 years sell-side, then cross over.

Support / middle-and-back office keeps the machine legal, funded and reconciled: risk, treasury, KYC/AML, compliance, GRC, fund accounting, operations. Global capability centres (GCCs) of Citi, Barclays, Deutsche, Northern Trust, Wells Fargo, plus KPOs like Acuity and Genpact, hire thousands of these roles across Mumbai, Bangalore, Hyderabad, Pune and Gurgaon. This is, realistically, where the largest number of commerce and MBA-Finance graduates actually get in — and several of those roles pay well and lead somewhere.

The honest hierarchy of pay and exclusivity runs roughly: front-office buy-side > front-office sell-side (IB) > specialist risk/quant > equity research / credit > treasury / FP&A > operations / KYC / compliance. But "prestige" and "good career" are not the same thing — a risk analyst at a GCC can out-earn a burnt-out IB associate over ten years, with a life.

The bar: pedigree, skills, certification

Front-office finance is one of the few Indian white-collar markets that still openly filters on **pedigree**. Bulge-bracket IB and top equity-research desks disproportionately recruit from a short list of target schools — the IIMs, ISB, FMS, XLRI, SPJIMR, JBIMS — plus CAs with strong ranks. If you are not from that list, you are not locked out, but you must compensate with demonstrable **skill** and a **side door** (more on that below).

Three things move the needle everywhere:

- **Modelling ability.** The three-statement model, DCF, comparable-company and precedent-transaction analysis, LBO. Front-office interviews *test* this live — you will be handed a case or an Excel screen.
- **Certifications** — but role-specific ones, not a scattershot alphabet soup. The CFA charter is the near-universal signal for research, buy-side and credit. FRM/PRM is the risk badge. NISM series are *legally required* for many Indian markets roles (research analyst, investment adviser, dealing). CA is gold for credit, controllership and anything statements-heavy. ACAMS helps for KYC/AML. FMVA is a useful self-starter modelling credential for non-target candidates, though it carries far less weight than CFA.

- **A track record you can show** — a stock pitch, a real model, a research note, a covenant analysis. This is what lets a non-target candidate leapfrog the pedigree filter.

The roles this book covers

This book decodes the front-office and markets-adjacent roles, each in its own chapter:

Cluster	Roles covered
Advisory	Investment Banking Analyst
Research	Equity Research Analyst
Credit & lending	Credit Analyst (Corporate & Retail)
Risk & quant	Credit Risk, Model Validation / Quant Risk
Markets ops	Treasury Analyst
Financial crime & control	KYC/AML Analyst, Compliance, GRC / IT Risk
Investing	Private Equity / Investment Analyst, Wealth
Corporate	Corporate Finance / FP&A adjacencies

Read across them and you will notice the same skills recombining: financial-statement analysis, modelling, a valuation or risk framework, a compliance overlay, and Excel as the universal solvent.

Realistic entry paths from an MBA-Finance or commerce start

You will not usually walk from a B.Com straight into a bulge-bracket IB seat. Here are the paths that actually work.

1. **Target MBA / CA route (the front door).** Land on a campus that the front-office firms visit, ace the modelling and technicals, convert a summer internship into a pre-placement offer. Fastest but gated by the admit.
2. **KPO / GCC route (the side door — most common).** Start at Acuity, Evalueserve, Moody's Analytics, WNS, Genpact, or a bank's GCC doing research support, credit analysis, fund accounting or risk. Build a real skill, then move up or lateral into the parent's front office or a buy-side firm. This route is under-glamorised and highly effective.
3. **Cert-plus-portfolio route (the non-target's crowbar).** Clear CFA Level I-II or NISM-RA, publish 2-3 genuinely good stock pitches or credit notes on a blog/Substack, and cold-apply to boutiques and smaller AMCs that hire on demonstrated ability, not brand.
4. **Adjacent-then-pivot.** Enter via audit (a Big Four CA), FP&A, or treasury, then pivot into research or credit once you have statements fluency and a network.

An honest note on competitiveness and pay

Front-office finance is genuinely hard to enter and, at the top, genuinely lucrative — a good IB analyst or buy-side associate can out-earn most professions in India within five years. But the funnel is narrow, the hours (in IB and research) can be punishing, and "finance" salaries in job ads are wildly bimodal: an SME accounts role at Rs 3-4 LPA and a bulge-bracket IB analyst at Rs 20-30 LPA both appear under "finance jobs." This book keeps salary bands honest, per role, so you know which end of the barbell you are aiming at — and what it will actually take to get there.

Investment Banking Analyst

Snapshot

The Investment Banking (IB) Analyst is the engine room of a deal team. You sit in the Investment Banking Division (IBD) of a bank — bulge-bracket names like Citi, J.P. Morgan and Goldman in Mumbai, or domestic powerhouses like Kotak Investment Banking, Axis Capital, JM Financial and Avendus — and you build the models, decks and analysis that let senior bankers advise companies on raising capital and buying or selling businesses. It is the most prestigious, best-paid and most punishing entry point in markets finance. The ladder is steep and well-defined: **Analyst (2-3 yrs) -> Associate -> Vice President (VP) -> Director / Senior VP -> Managing Director (MD).** The Analyst does the work; the MD wins the mandate. In India, the Analyst tier is often split into Analyst 1/2/3, and many analysts leave after 2-3 years for private equity, a top MBA, or a corporate strategy role — the classic "two and out."

What you'll actually do

Grounded on Citi's Mumbai IBD Analyst posting, the real day-to-day is:

- Build and maintain **complex financial and valuation models** — three-statement operating models, DCF, comparable-company and precedent-transaction analysis, accretion/dilution and LBO models.
- Support **capital-raising** transactions (IPOs, QIPs, rights issues, debt) and **M&A / strategic advisory** mandates end to end.
- Prepare **pitchbooks and pitch materials** — the decks used to win and execute mandates — including valuation and statistical exhibits.
- Conduct **economic, industry and company research**; assemble the data room and information memoranda for live deals.
- Run comps, precedent-transaction screens and sensitivity tables; sanity-check every number partners will put in front of a client.

> Real posting (Citi): "Build complex financial and valuation models and prepare pitch materials, valuation and statistical exhibits, and economic and financial research to support capital raising and M&A/strategic advisory."

The unglamorous truth: much of year one is formatting decks, chasing data, and turning comments at midnight. Attention to detail is not a nice-to-have — a wrong cell in a model shown to a board is a career event.

Must-have skills

Hard skills: financial modelling (three-statement, DCF, LBO, M&A), valuation, accounting fluency (you must read a balance sheet and cash-flow statement cold), corporate-finance theory, and elite Excel and PowerPoint craft. **Soft skills:** extreme attention to detail, stamina under deadline pressure, the ability to take heavy feedback without flinching, clear written communication, and discretion around confidential deals.

Tools & software

Excel (the primary weapon — modelling is done here), PowerPoint (pitchbooks), and data terminals: **Bloomberg, Capital IQ, FactSet, Refinitiv/Eikon.** Deal and data-room platforms (Datasite/Merrill, Ansarada), plus PitchBook/Prowess/Ace Equity for Indian company data. VBA and increasingly Python for automation are a bonus, not a requirement.

Qualifications & certifications

The realistic entry credential is a **top-tier MBA (IIM-A/B/C, ISB, FMS, XLRI, SPJIMR, JBIMS)** or a strong-rank **CA**, ideally paired with a summer internship converted to a pre-placement offer. Bulge-bracket IBD in India is openly target-school biased. The **CFA charter** is a strong signal, especially for non-MBA or non-target candidates, and demonstrates the exact valuation knowledge the job needs. **FMVA** or a hands-on modelling course helps a non-target candidate prove the skill but does not substitute for pedigree. A bachelor's alone is the *stated* minimum but rarely enough at the bulge bracket.

Experience & typical titles

Rung	Experience	Typical titles
Entry	0-3 yrs	Analyst, IB Analyst, IBD Analyst
Mid	3-6 yrs	Associate, Sr Associate
Senior	6-10 yrs	Vice President
Leadership	10 yrs+	Director / SVP, Managing Director

The Citi posting cites 2-5 years — that maps to Analyst-into-Associate. Genuine freshers usually enter only through campus/internship pipelines.

ATS keywords to mirror

Financial modelling, valuation, DCF, LBO, comparable company analysis, precedent transactions, M&A, capital raising, pitchbooks, pitch materials, three-statement model, accretion dilution, equity capital markets, debt capital markets, due diligence, information memorandum, Bloomberg, Capital IQ, FactSet, Excel, PowerPoint, CFA, corporate finance.

Salary in India (indicative, FY2026)

Experience band	Indicative CTC (Rs LPA)
Fresher / Analyst 1	14 - 24
2-4 yrs (Analyst 2-3 / Associate)	24 - 45
5-8 yrs (VP track)	45 - 90+

Wide ranges reflect the gap between domestic boutiques and bulge brackets, and the fact that **bonus can equal or exceed base**. Figures are approximate and vary by firm, city (Mumbai commands the premium) and deal year.

Who's hiring

Bulge brackets and global banks in Mumbai (**Citi**, J.P. Morgan, Goldman Sachs, Morgan Stanley, Bank of America, Nomura), domestic full-service banks (**Kotak, Axis Capital, ICICI Securities, SBI Capital**), independent advisors (**JM Financial, Avendus, Ambit, o3 Capital**), and Big Four deal-advisory arms. GCCs also run large IB support and M&A analytics teams in Bangalore, Mumbai and Pune.

How to break in / stand out

The clean path is a target-school MBA or ranked CA, a summer IBD internship, and converting it. If you are outside that funnel, your crowbar is **demonstrated modelling skill**: build a fully-linked three-statement model plus a DCF and a comps set for a real listed Indian company, write a tight two-page investment thesis, and carry it as a portfolio. Clear at least CFA Level I. Network relentlessly into boutiques and mid-market advisors, which hire more on ability than brand. **The single biggest differentiator is a clean, auditable model you built yourself** — nothing else so quickly convinces a banker you can survive the desk. Be honest with yourself about the hours: 80-100 hour weeks are real, and the two-and-out exit to PE, a global MBA, or corp-dev is the goal most analysts are actually optimising for.

Equity Research Analyst

Snapshot

An Equity Research (ER) Analyst forms and defends a view on whether a stock is worth buying. You cover a **sector** (say IT services, banks, cement or FMCG), build models of every company in it, and publish notes with a rating and a target price. There are two worlds. **Sell-side** research — at broking houses and banks like Equirus, Motilal Oswal, ICICI Securities, Kotak Institutional Equities, Nuvama — is published for institutional clients (mutual funds, FIIs) to win their trading and banking business. **Buy-side** research — inside AMCs, hedge funds and PMS shops — is internal, feeds the fund's own portfolio decisions, and is never published. The sell-side ladder runs **Associate -> Analyst -> Senior Analyst -> Lead Analyst (sector head) -> Head of Research.** Buy-side runs Analyst -> Senior Analyst -> Fund Manager. Many people build a track record sell-side and cross to the better-paid, quieter buy-side.

What you'll actually do

Grounded on the Equirus (Mumbai/Ahmedabad) posting, the real work is:

- Run **channel checks** — talk to dealers, distributors, suppliers, ex-employees and industry contacts to get ground-truth on demand, pricing and competition.
- Translate those insights into **detailed financial models**: revenue drivers, margins, working capital, and a valuation (DCF, P/E, EV/EBITDA, sum-of-the-parts).
- Publish **stock initiations** (the first deep report on a company) and ongoing **investment ideas**, each with a rating and target price.
- Write **research reports for institutional investors** — the note *is* the product, so writing is as important as the numbers.
- Track quarterly results, model the beats/misses, host and attend management and analyst calls, and defend your call when the stock moves against you.

> Real posting (Equirus): "Conduct channel checks and translate insights into financial models to analyse margins and valuation; produce stock initiations and investment ideas in reports for institutional investors."

Must-have skills

Hard skills: financial-statement analysis, sector and company modelling, valuation (DCF, relative multiples, SOTP), and above all **report writing** — the ability to argue a thesis crisply on two pages. **Soft skills:** independent conviction (you must be willing to be contrarian and be *right*), curiosity and hustle for channel checks, communication with fund managers and management teams, and the emotional steadiness to hold a call when the market disagrees.

Tools & software

Excel (modelling), Bloomberg and Refinitiv/Eikon (data, estimates, calls), Capital IQ / FactSet, and Indian databases like **Ace Equity, Prowess (CMIE) and Screener**. PowerPoint/Word for notes; increasingly Python or Power BI for data-heavy sector work. Access to management, conferences and expert networks (Tegus, GLG) is part of the "toolset."

Qualifications & certifications

An **MBA-Finance** or **CA** is the standard base, and the Equirus posting asks for an MBA. The **CFA charter** is arguably the single most valued credential in research — it maps directly onto the job and is close to a default expectation on the buy-side. Critically, to publish research in India you (or your firm) must comply with SEBI's Research Analyst regulations, which makes the **NISM-Series-XV: Research Analyst certification** effectively mandatory for a practising sell-side RA. NISM-Series-VIII (Equity Derivatives) and the CFA/CFP suite help for adjacent buy-side roles.

Experience & typical titles

Rung	Experience	Typical titles
Entry	0-3 yrs	Research Associate, Junior Analyst
Mid	3-7 yrs	Equity Research Analyst, Sector Analyst
Senior	7-12 yrs	Senior/Lead Analyst, Sector Head
Leadership	12 yrs+	Head of Research, Fund Manager (buy-side)

The Equirus posting's 4-7 years targets an analyst who can independently own a sector, not a fresher. Freshers usually start as associates supporting a senior analyst.

ATS keywords to mirror

Equity research, financial modelling, valuation, DCF, relative valuation, EV/EBITDA, channel checks, stock initiation, target price, sector coverage, earnings model, institutional investors, buy-side, sell-side, research report writing, Bloomberg, Capital IQ, Ace Equity, CFA, NISM Research Analyst, investment thesis.

Salary in India (indicative, FY2026)

Experience band	Indicative CTC (Rs LPA)
Fresher / Associate	8 - 16
2-4 yrs	16 - 30
5-8 yrs (Analyst / Sr Analyst)	30 - 60+

Buy-side seats and star sell-side analysts sit at the top of these ranges; KPO research-support roles (Acuity, Evalueserve) sit lower. Approximate and varies by firm, city and whether the seat is publishing or support.

Who's hiring

Sell-side desks: **Equirus**, Motilal Oswal, ICICI Securities, Kotak Institutional Equities, Nuvama, Antique, JM Financial. Buy-side: AMCs (SBI MF, HDFC AMC, ICICI Prudential, Nippon), PMS and hedge funds. Research

KPOs: **Acuity Knowledge Partners, Evalueserve, Moody's Analytics, WNS** — the highest-volume entry point in India.

How to break in / stand out

Pick one sector and go deep. Build full models for 3-4 companies in it and publish **genuine stock pitches** — a clear thesis, valuation, catalysts and risks — on a blog, Substack or the CFA Society's research challenge. Clear CFA Level I-II and, if you want to publish, the NISM-RA. The KPO route (Acuity, Evalueserve) is an honest, effective side door: get in on research support, build modelling reps, then lateral to a publishing desk or buy-side. **The single biggest differentiator is a written, dated, verifiable investment call that turned out right** — a track record beats a resume line every time, and report-writing quality is what separates an analyst from a spreadsheet operator.

Credit Analyst (Corporate & Retail)

Snapshot

A Credit Analyst answers one question for a lender: *will this borrower pay us back, and on what terms?* You analyse a borrower's financials, judge the risk, and write a recommendation that decides whether a loan is approved, priced and structured — or declined. The role splits by borrower type. **Corporate / wholesale credit** underwrites large companies, financial institutions, PSUs and sovereigns — deep, judgement-heavy analysis of a handful of big exposures (the work at Barclays, Deutsche Bank, DBS, Northern Trust and MODIFI's trade-finance desk). **Retail / SME credit** underwrites individuals and small businesses at scale, leaning more on scorecards, bureau data and policy. The ladder runs **Analyst -> Senior Analyst -> Assistant Manager / Manager -> Credit Manager -> Head of Credit / Chief Credit Officer.** It is one of the most transferable skill sets in finance — the statements fluency you build here powers moves into research, risk and lending leadership.

What you'll actually do

Grounded on the Barclays (Mumbai) credit-analysis posting and peers at Deutsche, DBS and Northern Trust:

- Perform **credit analysis and due diligence** across Corporate, Financial Institution, PSU and Sovereign counterparties.
- Analyse **financial statements, cash flows, leverage and profitability**, plus industry and business-model trends, to gauge repayment capacity.
- Write **credit proposals and recommendation notes** with a clear rating and rationale that go to a credit committee for sanction.
- Assess and structure **covenants and collateral**; set limits, pricing and conditions.
- **Monitor** the existing portfolio for emerging risks — covenant breaches, rating migration, sector stress — and flag early-warning signals.
- Ensure every decision adheres to **credit policy and regulatory** requirements (RBI norms, internal risk appetite).

> Real posting (Barclays): "Undertake credit analysis and due diligence for Corporate/FI/PSU/Sovereign counterparties, prepare credit proposals and recommendation notes, and analyse financial statements, cash flows, leverage, profitability and industry trends."

Must-have skills

Hard skills: financial-statement analysis, ratio and cash-flow analysis, credit-risk assessment, industry analysis, covenant and collateral structuring, and knowledge of rating methodology and RBI/regulatory norms. Retail credit adds bureau (CIBIL/CRIF) and scorecard fluency. **Soft skills:** sound judgement under uncertainty, the ability to write a persuasive, defensible credit note, attention to detail, and the spine to recommend "no" when the numbers say no.

Tools & software

Excel (spreading and modelling — the core tool), Word and PowerPoint for proposals. Data and rating platforms: **Bloomberg, Capital IQ, Refinitiv, Moody's/CRISIL/ICRA** reports, and **credit bureaus (CIBIL, CRIF, Experian)** for retail. Banks run internal rating models, loan-origination systems (LOS) and workflow tools; MODIFI-style fintechs use their own trade-finance and underwriting platforms.

Qualifications & certifications

A **CA** is exceptionally well-suited — statements analysis is its home turf — as is an **MBA-Finance**. The **CFA charter** signals strong valuation and analysis depth; the **FRM** is the natural risk credential and increasingly valued on wholesale desks. For those specialising, **CCP/credit-specific** certifications and NISM modules help at the margins. The Barclays JD lists MBA/CA/CFA/FRM as desirable — any one clears the bar; the combination stands out. A commerce bachelor's with strong analytics can enter retail/SME credit.

Experience & typical titles

Rung	Experience	Typical titles
Entry	0-2 yrs	Credit Analyst, Credit Underwriter
Mid	2-5 yrs	Senior Credit Analyst, Asst Manager - Credit
Senior	5-8 yrs	Credit Manager, Risk Manager
Leadership	8 yrs+	Head of Credit, Chief Credit Officer

Freshers commonly enter via bank GCCs, NBFCs or KPO credit-support desks; corporate/wholesale seats usually want 2-5 years plus a relevant qualification.

ATS keywords to mirror

Credit analysis, financial statement analysis, cash flow analysis, credit underwriting, credit proposal, due diligence, leverage, profitability, covenant, collateral, credit rating, risk assessment, portfolio monitoring, early warning signals, RBI regulations, credit policy, CIBIL, corporate credit, SME credit, working capital, CA, CFA, FRM.

Salary in India (indicative, FY2026)

Experience band	Indicative CTC (Rs LPA)
Fresher	5 - 10
2-4 yrs	10 - 20
5-8 yrs	20 - 40+

Corporate/wholesale credit at foreign banks and their GCCs pays at the top of these bands; retail/SME and NBFC roles sit lower. Approximate and varies by employer type, city and borrower segment.

Who's hiring

Foreign and global banks and their GCCs (**Barclays, Deutsche Bank, DBS, Northern Trust, HSBC, Standard Chartered, Citi**), Indian banks (HDFC, ICICI, Axis, SBI), NBFCs and HFCs (Bajaj Finance, L&T Finance, Tata Capital), fintech lenders and trade-finance platforms (**MODIFI**), and rating agencies (CRISIL, ICRA, CARE) for the analysis-adjacent version of the role. KPOs (Acuity, Moody's Analytics) run large credit-support teams.

How to break in / stand out

Learn to **spread a set of financials cold** — take a listed Indian company's annual report, build a ratio and cash-flow analysis, and write a one-page credit note with a rating recommendation, covenants and key risks. That single artifact demonstrates exactly what the desk does. Add CA or an MBA-Finance, and stack a CFA or FRM to signal depth. The bank-GCC and KPO route is the most reliable entry: get in on credit support or portfolio monitoring, then move to underwriting and larger exposures. **The single biggest differentiator is judgement you can evidence** — a credit note where you said "no" (or "yes, but structure it this way") and were right — because credit is ultimately a decision-making job, not a spreadsheet job.

Credit Risk Analyst

Snapshot

A Credit Risk Analyst decides, in effect, whether a lender should extend money to a borrower and on what terms — then keeps watching that exposure until it is repaid. You sit inside the risk function of a bank, NBFC, or rating/analytics firm, deliberately separate from the sales/relationship teams whose deals you scrutinise. Your raw material is financial statements, cash flows, industry data and management quality; your output is a written credit view — an approve, decline, or "approve with covenants" recommendation that a credit committee relies on. In wholesale/corporate banking (the Barclays-style desk), you analyse Corporate, Financial-Institution (FI), PSU and Sovereign counterparties. The ladder typically runs Analyst -> Senior Analyst -> Assistant Manager / Assistant Vice President -> Manager / Vice President -> Credit Head / Chief Risk Officer. It is one of the most intellectually respected seats in finance because a single bad call, scaled across a portfolio, can sink a book.

What you'll actually do

- Perform credit analysis and due diligence on borrowers across Corporate, FI, PSU and Sovereign segments — reading annual reports, management accounts and rating rationales.
- Write credit proposals and recommendation notes: the structured document that goes to the sanctioning authority with your rating, exposure limit, and conditions.
- Spread and analyse financial statements — profitability, leverage (debt/EBITDA, gearing), interest cover, liquidity ratios, and multi-year cash-flow trends.
- Assess repayment capacity and debt-servicing under base and stress scenarios; flag covenant breaches early.
- Monitor emerging risks in the existing portfolio — sector downturns, rating downgrades, delayed receivables, promoter/governance red flags — and escalate before they become NPAs.
- Ensure every decision adheres to internal credit policy and regulatory norms (RBI prudential norms, exposure limits, IRAC classification).
- Build exhibits and summaries in Excel/Word/PowerPoint for the credit committee.

> Real posting (Barclays): "Undertake credit analysis and due diligence for Corporate, FI, PSU and Sovereign counterparties and prepare credit proposals and recommendation notes."

Must-have skills

Hard skills: financial-statement analysis (the core craft), ratio and cash-flow analysis, understanding of leverage and working-capital cycles, industry/sector analysis, and knowledge of credit policy plus RBI regulatory framework. You must be able to model a borrower's ability to service debt and translate numbers into a clear risk narrative. Soft skills the JDs repeatedly demand: sharp written communication (a recommendation note is only as good as its argument), sound judgement under incomplete information, attention to detail, and the spine to say "no" or attach conditions when a relationship manager is pushing a deal. Scepticism is a feature, not a flaw.

Tools & software

- **Excel** — spreading statements, ratio models, sensitivity/stress tables (non-negotiable).
- **Word & PowerPoint** — proposal notes and committee decks.
- Rating-agency and data platforms: **CRISIL / ICRA / CARE** reports, **Bloomberg**, **Refinitiv/Capital IQ** for financials and peer data.
- Internal rating models / credit-scoring engines and loan-origination systems (bank-specific).
- **MCA / probe databases** for due diligence on Indian corporates.

Qualifications & certifications

Degree: a bachelor's is the floor; most competitive candidates hold an **MBA-Finance, CA, or CFA**. For this role specifically: - **CA** — strongest signal for reading and trusting financial statements; heavily favoured by Indian banks and NBFCs. - **MBA-Finance** — the standard entry route into corporate/wholesale credit. - **CFA** — well regarded for the analytical and valuation depth, especially at global banks. - **FRM** — desirable, and increasingly expected as you move toward portfolio and policy roles. The Barclays posting explicitly lists MBA/CA/CFA/FRM as desirable — treat any one as your ticket in, and a second as your differentiator.

Experience & typical titles

Band	Typical title	What's expected
Fresher (0-2 yrs)	Credit Analyst, Credit Risk Analyst	Spread statements, draft note sections, portfolio monitoring
2-5 yrs	Senior Analyst, Assistant Manager, AVP	Own end-to-end proposals, defend views to committee
5-8 yrs	Manager / VP, Credit Manager	Sign-off authority, sector coverage, mentor analysts
8+ yrs	Credit Head, Chief Risk Officer track	Policy, portfolio strategy, regulatory interface

ATS keywords to mirror

Credit analysis, credit risk, due diligence, credit proposals, recommendation notes, financial statement analysis, cash flow analysis, leverage, profitability, debt servicing, working capital, credit policy, regulatory compliance, RBI norms, corporate credit, FI, PSU, sovereign, portfolio monitoring, emerging risk, rating, covenant, Excel, CRISIL, CFA, FRM, CA, MBA Finance.

Salary in India (indicative, FY2026)

Experience band	Indicative range (Rs LPA)
Fresher (0-2 yrs)	5 - 9
2-4 yrs	9 - 16
5-8 yrs	16 - 30+

Approximate; varies materially by employer type (global bank > private bank > NBFC > rating firm KPO) and city (Mumbai commands the premium).

Who's hiring

- **Global/foreign banks**: Barclays, Citi, HSBC, Standard Chartered, Deutsche Bank — wholesale and counterparty credit desks (mostly Mumbai/Bengaluru).
- **Indian private banks & NBFCs**: HDFC, ICICI, Axis, Kotak, Bajaj Finance — corporate and mid-market credit.
- **Rating agencies**: CRISIL, ICRA, CARE — credit analysis at scale.
- **Analytics/KPO firms**: Acuity, Moody's Analytics, S&P Global — offshore credit-analysis teams supporting global banks.

How to break in / stand out

For a commerce/MBA-Finance candidate, the fastest credible route is to *demonstrate you can read a balance sheet like a detective*. Build a portfolio of 3-4 **real credit notes**: pick listed Indian companies from different sectors, spread three years of financials, compute leverage/coverage/liquidity ratios, and write a one-page recommendation ("would you lend Rs 100 cr for 5 years — and why/why not"). Include one distressed case (say, a company that later defaulted) and show whether the numbers gave early warning. This single artifact beats a page of certifications because it proves the actual job.

Layer on the credentials that build trust in your numbers — CA or CFA Level I/II — and learn RBI's IRAC/provisioning norms cold, because Indian credit is regulation-shaped. **The single biggest differentiator is judgement expressed in writing**: two analysts can compute the same ratios, but the one who can argue a crisp, defensible "approve with these three covenants" gets promoted. Practise writing tight, opinionated credit views, and be honest — this role rewards the person willing to be the unpopular "no" in the room.

Risk Analyst (Market, Operational & Model Risk)

Snapshot

This is the quantitative wing of the risk function — the people who measure how much a bank or fund could lose from moving markets, broken processes, or fraud, and who check that the models used to make those measurements are actually sound. Unlike a credit analyst (who judges one borrower), a market/model-risk analyst thinks in distributions: Value-at-Risk, expected shortfall, factor sensitivities, backtesting. A large slice of these jobs today is **model validation** — independently reviewing the pricing and risk models built by front-office quants and model developers, against the firm's model-risk policy, so regulators and management can trust the numbers. You'll find these seats at global banks (Societe Generale, Barclays, Deutsche) and, very heavily, at analytics firms like **Acuity** that run offshore model-validation and risk-analytics teams. Ladder: Analyst -> Senior Analyst -> AVP/Manager -> VP -> Head of Model Risk / Market Risk.

What you'll actually do

- Validate and independently review models — pricing, VaR, credit, and increasingly ML models — against the firm's model-risk management policy.
- Build and test **VaR, multi-factor risk models, time-series models and optimization** routines; check assumptions, data quality and limitations.
- **Backtest** risk models: compare predicted losses vs realised, count exceptions, and document breaches.
- Cover multiple risk types — market, operational, and fraud risk — measuring and monitoring exposures and limits.
- Write validation reports and model-governance documentation that stands up to internal audit and regulators (RBI, and global standards like SR 11-7).
- Investigate model failures and edge cases; recommend remediation, re-calibration, or additional conservatism.
- Pull and cleanse data from market-data vendors and feed it into risk engines.

> Real posting (Acuity): "Perform model validation and review against the model-risk policy — covering VaR, multi-factor risk models, time-series, optimization and machine-learning techniques."

Must-have skills

Hard skills: solid grounding in statistics and probability, VaR/expected-shortfall methodology, time-series analysis, factor models and optimization, and a working understanding of derivatives and their risk sensitivities (the Greeks). Increasingly, familiarity with **machine-learning** techniques and how to validate them. Programming is central — you must be able to reproduce and stress a model yourself, not just read someone's memo. Soft skills: precise technical writing (validation reports are read by skeptical auditors), independence of mind, and the diplomacy to challenge front-office quants without a turf war.

Tools & software

- **Programming/analytics**: Python, R, SAS, MATLAB, SQL, VBA — the Acuity stack lists most of these.
- **Market-data platforms**: Bloomberg, Refinitiv (Eikon), MSCI (Barra/RiskMetrics), Markit, Capital IQ.
- **Excel** for prototyping and reconciliation; internal risk engines and model libraries.
- Version control and documentation tooling for model inventory/governance.

Qualifications & certifications

Degree: a **master's in a quantitative discipline** (financial engineering, statistics, maths, economics, physics) is the typical expectation — this is a quant-leaning seat. Certifications that genuinely move the needle: - **FRM (GARP)** — the most directly relevant; it *is* the market/operational-risk syllabus. - **PRM** — similar positioning, well regarded in model risk. - **CFA** — helps with the finance/valuation context, complements FRM. - **CQF** — useful if you're pushing toward the modelling/derivatives-heavy end. A quant master's + FRM (or in progress) is the standard "credible candidate" combination here.

Experience & typical titles

Band	Typical title	What's expected
Fresher (0-2 yrs)	Risk Analyst, Model Validation Analyst	Support validations, run backtests, data prep
2-5 yrs	Senior Risk Analyst, AVP, Model Validation Associate	Own full validations, write reports, cover a model class
5-8 yrs	VP / Manager, Lead Validator	Sign-off, methodology, regulator interface
8+ yrs	Head of Model Risk / Market Risk	Framework, governance, firm-wide model inventory

Acuity's posting targets the 3-5 year band, which is the sweet spot for offshore validation roles.

ATS keywords to mirror

Model validation, model risk, VaR, value at risk, expected shortfall, multi-factor models, time-series, backtesting, market risk, operational risk, fraud risk, model governance, optimization, machine learning, Python, R, SAS, SQL, MATLAB, VBA, Bloomberg, Refinitiv, MSCI, Markit, FRM, PRM, CFA, derivatives, Greeks, stress testing, SR 11-7.

Salary in India (indicative, FY2026)

Experience band	Indicative range (Rs LPA)
Fresher (0-2 yrs)	7 - 12
2-4 yrs	12 - 22
5-8 yrs	22 - 40+

Approximate; quant-heavy roles at global banks pay above analytics-firm bands, and Mumbai/Bengaluru lead. Strong Python + FRM lifts offers noticeably.

Who's hiring

- **Analytics/KPO firms**: Acuity Knowledge Partners, Moody's Analytics, S&P Global, CRISIL GR&A — large offshore model-validation and risk teams (Bengaluru, Gurugram).
- **Global banks' GCCs**: Societe Generale, Barclays, Deutsche Bank, HSBC, Nomura, Morgan Stanley — market-risk and model-risk desks in India.
- **Consulting**: the Big Four risk-advisory practices for model-risk and validation projects.

How to break in / stand out

For a commerce/MBA-Finance candidate this is the hardest jump in this book, because the bar is genuinely quantitative — be honest with yourself about the maths. The realistic bridge is to **layer quant skills onto your finance base**: get comfortable with Python (pandas, numpy, statsmodels), learn the statistics behind VaR and time-series, and start FRM. Then build proof: implement a **VaR model on a real portfolio in Python** — historical, parametric, and Monte-Carlo methods — and **backtest it**, counting exceptions over a stressed period like a market crash, exactly as a validator would. Write it up as a short validation report with assumptions, limitations and a recommendation. That artifact directly mirrors the day job.

The single biggest differentiator is the combination of finance domain plus code: firms are flooded with people who know one or the other. Someone who can both explain *why* a model understates tail risk and *rewrite it in Python to prove it* is rare and instantly hireable. If pure maths isn't your strength, aim for the operational-risk and governance end of the spectrum, which rewards process rigour and clear writing more than heavy stochastic calculus.

Quantitative Analyst (Quant)

Snapshot

A Quantitative Analyst — "quant" — builds the mathematical models that price financial instruments, forecast markets, and measure risk. This is the deep end of finance, where the job is genuinely applied maths and code rather than spreadsheets and narrative. Quants split into flavours: **sell-side desk quants** at banks price and hedge derivatives and support traders; **buy-side quants** at hedge funds and quant asset managers build signals and systematic trading strategies (often called quant researchers); **risk/model quants** develop the models validators later check; and **vendor quants** at analytics firms build libraries and tools sold to the industry. Be honest up front: **the bar is high** — a strong STEM background, real programming ability, and comfort with stochastic calculus are effectively mandatory. Ladder: Junior/Associate Quant -> Quant Analyst -> Senior Quant / Quant Researcher -> VP/Lead Quant -> Head of Quant / Quant PM.

What you'll actually do

- Build and maintain **pricing models** for derivatives (options, swaps, structured products) and calibrate them to market data.
- Develop **risk models** — sensitivities (Greeks), VaR, scenario and stress engines.
- Research and prototype trading signals or systematic strategies (buy-side), and backtest them rigorously against historical data.
- Apply **stochastic calculus, PDEs, Monte-Carlo simulation, time-series econometrics and machine learning** to real financial problems.
- Write production-quality code, clean data pipelines, and validate that model output is numerically stable and correct.
- Collaborate with traders, portfolio managers or risk teams to turn a desk problem into a working model.
- Document methodology so results are reproducible and defensible.

> Synthesised from real postings: build complex pricing and risk models, apply time-series and machine-learning techniques, and implement them in Python/C++ with strong software-engineering discipline.

Must-have skills

Hard skills: **stochastic calculus and probability**, differential equations, numerical methods (Monte-Carlo, finite difference), time-series analysis, optimization, and increasingly machine learning. Deep understanding of **derivatives pricing** (Black-Scholes and beyond) for pricing roles, or statistical modelling for buy-side signal work. Above all, **strong programming** — this is a coding job, not a maths quiz. Soft skills: the ability to reduce a messy real-world problem to a clean model, intellectual honesty about what a model can't do, and clear communication with non-quants (a trader must trust your number in seconds).

Tools & software

- **Python** — the lingua franca (numpy, pandas, scipy, scikit-learn, PyTorch/TensorFlow for ML quants).
- **C++** — still dominant for low-latency pricing libraries and HFT.

- **SQL** for data; sometimes R, MATLAB, or KDB+/q for tick data.
- **Bloomberg / Refinitiv** market data; internal pricing/risk libraries (QuantLib and proprietary).
- Git, Linux, and general software-engineering tooling — quants are expected to ship real code.

Qualifications & certifications

Degree: this is the one role in this book where a **master's or PhD in a quantitative field** (financial engineering, maths, physics, statistics, CS, engineering) is close to a hard requirement. A B.Com/MBA-Finance alone will rarely clear the bar without serious quantitative retooling. Certifications: - **CQF (Certificate in Quantitative Finance)** — the most targeted credential; designed exactly for this transition and respected as a signal of applied quant skill. - **FRM** — helpful for risk-quant and model roles. - **CFA** — useful context, but not what gets you a quant seat; the maths and code do. Certifications supplement, never replace, demonstrable quantitative and programming ability.

Experience & typical titles

Band	Typical title	What's expected
Entry (0-2 yrs)	Junior Quant, Quant Analyst, Quant Developer	Implement/calibrate models, build tooling under guidance
2-5 yrs	Quant Analyst, Quant Researcher, Associate	Own a model or strategy, research independently
5-8 yrs	Senior Quant, VP Quant, Lead	Design methodology, mentor, own a book/desk's models
8+ yrs	Head of Quant, Quant PM	Strategy, P&L or firm-wide model ownership

ATS keywords to mirror

Quantitative analyst, quant, pricing models, derivatives pricing, risk models, stochastic calculus, Monte Carlo, PDE, numerical methods, time series, machine learning, backtesting, Python, C++, SQL, QuantLib, Bloomberg, VaR, Greeks, optimization, systematic strategies, financial engineering, CQF, FRM, quantitative research.

Salary in India (indicative, FY2026)

Experience band	Indicative range (Rs LPA)
Entry (0-2 yrs)	12 - 25
2-4 yrs	25 - 45
5-8 yrs	45 - 90+

Approximate and wide. Buy-side/hedge-fund quant pay (with bonus) can far exceed these; bank and vendor roles cluster lower. Mumbai and Bengaluru dominate. Compensation reflects the genuinely scarce skill set.

Who's hiring

- **Global banks' GCCs / desks**: Goldman Sachs, Morgan Stanley, JPMorgan, Deutsche Bank, Nomura — desk and risk quants in Bengaluru/Mumbai.
- **Quant funds & prop shops**: WorldQuant, Tower Research, Graviton, AlphaGrep, Quadeye — buy-side and HFT research.
- **Asset managers & vendors**: quant teams at large AMCs; analytics vendors (Bloomberg, MSCI) building model libraries.
- **Analytics firms**: Acuity, S&P Global for model-development support roles.

How to break in / stand out

Be clear-eyed: for a commerce/MBA-Finance reader, breaking into a true quant role usually requires **deliberately acquiring the quantitative foundation** — either a quant master's or a serious self-study path (CQF plus real maths). Don't fake it; the interviews probe stochastic calculus and coding directly.

The portfolio that impresses is a **working quant project on GitHub**: for example, implement an options pricer in Python (Black-Scholes plus a Monte-Carlo and a binomial-tree method), calibrate it to real market quotes, and compute and hedge the Greeks — or build and honestly backtest a simple systematic strategy with proper transaction costs and out-of-sample testing. Clean, documented, reproducible code that shows you understand *both* the maths and the software matters more than any certificate.

The single biggest differentiator is provable depth: the field is full of people who took an online course, and interviewers can tell in ten minutes. The candidate who can derive a result on the whiteboard *and* has shipped correct, tested code stands apart. If the full quant bar is out of reach, the adjacent roles in this book — model validation, risk analytics, or data-heavy financial analysis — are more realistic on-ramps that still use much of the same toolkit.

Treasury Analyst

Snapshot

A Treasury Analyst manages an organisation's money itself — its cash, its bank relationships, its funding and its market exposures — so the business always has liquidity where it needs it, at the lowest cost and controlled risk. In a corporate treasury (Intel-style), you settle trades across FX, fixed income, equity and derivatives, run bank-account administration, forecast cash, and invest surplus in money markets. In a bank treasury (JPMorgan-style), the canvas is bigger — funding, liquidity ratios, and regulatory reporting. It's an operations-and-markets hybrid: part precise back-/middle-office discipline, part market awareness. The role sits between the business, the banks, and the markets. Ladder: Treasury Analyst -> Senior Treasury Analyst -> Assistant Manager / Treasury Manager -> Manager / AVP -> Treasurer / Head of Treasury.

What you'll actually do

- **Settle** transactions across FX, fixed-income, equity and derivative products — matching, confirming, and ensuring timely cash movement.
- **Bank account management**: open/close accounts, manage signatories, and run **KYC/AML** documentation with partner banks.
- Forecast **cash and liquidity** — daily positions, short-term funding needs, and surplus available to invest.
- Invest and borrow in **money markets**; support short-term credit and counterparty analysis.
- Handle **derivatives** used for hedging (FX forwards, interest-rate swaps) — capture, confirm and monitor.
- Track and report **treasury KPIs** and prepare regulatory and internal reporting.
- Reconcile bank statements and treasury records; investigate breaks.

> Real posting (Intel): "Settlement of FX, fixed income, equity and derivative transactions; bank account management including KYC/AML, account openings/closings and signatory maintenance."

Must-have skills

Hard skills: understanding of **cash and liquidity management**, money markets and short-term instruments, FX and basic derivatives, and the settlement lifecycle. **KYC/AML** knowledge for bank-account work, plus strong reconciliation discipline and Excel. A grasp of how interest rates and currencies move helps you contextualise the numbers. Soft skills: precision and reliability (a missed settlement is a real, dated problem), calm under deadline pressure, and clean communication with banks and internal desks. Treasury rewards people who are both meticulous *and* commercially aware.

Tools & software

- **Treasury Management Systems (TMS)**: Kyriba, FIS, or in-house platforms.
- **SAP** (including **SAP HANA / SAP Treasury**), Oracle Treasury modules — Intel's stack names SAP HANA.
- **Excel** — cash forecasting, reconciliation, KPI tracking (essential).
- **Bloomberg / Reuters** for market rates; bank portals and **SWIFT** for payments and confirmations.

Qualifications & certifications

Degree: a **finance degree** (B.Com, BBA-Finance, MBA-Finance) is the standard entry; the Intel posting asks for a finance degree with 2-3 years. Certifications that help for this specific role: - **MBA-Finance** — the common route into corporate treasury. - **CA / CMA** — valued for the accounting and controls rigour, especially in Indian corporates. - **ACT (Association of Corporate Treasurers)** qualifications — the globally recognised treasury credential; a strong differentiator as you specialise. - **CFA** — useful for the investment/money-market side. - **NISM / ACAMS** — NISM helps on the markets side; ACAMS supports the KYC/AML component.

Experience & typical titles

Band	Typical title	What's expected
Fresher (0-2 yrs)	Treasury Analyst, Treasury Executive	Settlements, recon, cash reporting support
2-4 yrs	Senior Treasury Analyst, Assistant Manager	Own cash forecasting, bank relationships, hedging support
5-8 yrs	Treasury Manager, AVP	Liquidity strategy, funding, team lead
8+ yrs	Head of Treasury / Treasurer	Capital structure, policy, board reporting

ATS keywords to mirror

Treasury, cash management, liquidity management, cash flow forecasting, settlements, FX, foreign exchange, fixed income, derivatives, money markets, bank account management, KYC, AML, reconciliation, treasury management system, TMS, SAP, SAP HANA, Kyriba, SWIFT, hedging, interest rate swaps, regulatory reporting, treasury KPIs, Excel.

Salary in India (indicative, FY2026)

Experience band	Indicative range (Rs LPA)
Fresher (0-2 yrs)	4 - 8
2-4 yrs	8 - 15
5-8 yrs	15 - 28+

Approximate; MNC captive/corporate treasuries and bank treasuries pay above domestic mid-caps, and Mumbai/Bengaluru lead. Varies by city and employer.

Who's hiring

- **MNC captives / GCCs**: Intel, and technology and manufacturing multinationals running global treasury operations from Bengaluru/Hyderabad.
- **Banks**: JPMorgan, Citi, HSBC, Deutsche Bank, and Indian banks' treasury desks.

- **Large Indian corporates**: Reliance, Tata group, infrastructure and manufacturing firms with active treasuries.
- **Shared-service / BPO providers** running treasury operations for clients.

How to break in / stand out

For a commerce/MBA-Finance candidate, treasury is one of the more *accessible* markets-adjacent careers — it prizes reliability and process mastery as much as market brilliance, so a diligent B.Com/MBA-Finance grad can genuinely enter. Start by getting fluent in **cash-flow forecasting and bank reconciliation in Excel**, and learn the settlement lifecycle (trade -> confirmation -> settlement -> reconciliation) cold. Build a small portfolio project: construct a **13-week rolling cash-flow forecast** for a hypothetical company, with a liquidity-buffer policy and a simple FX-hedging plan for a foreign receivable — this shows you think like a treasurer, not just a bookkeeper.

Layer on domain credentials as you specialise: understand **KYC/AML** basics (ACAMS-lite knowledge goes a long way given every JD lists it), and get familiar with what a **TMS/SAP Treasury** actually does. **The single biggest differentiator is dependability plus commercial awareness** — treasury runs on trust, because a single late settlement or unmanaged FX exposure has an immediate rupee cost. The analyst who never misses a cut-off *and* can explain why a hedge saved money is the one who moves up toward Treasurer.

KYC / AML Analyst

Snapshot

The KYC / AML Analyst is the person who decides whether a bank actually *knows* who its customer is — and whether that customer is safe to bank. Every regulated financial institution in the world is legally required to identify its clients, understand what they do, and screen them against sanctions, PEP (Politically Exposed Person) and adverse-media lists before and during the relationship. That legal obligation is what creates this job, and it creates it in enormous volume. In India this is the single biggest entry door into banking through the GCC (Global Capability Centre) route: Citi, HSBC, Standard Chartered, JPMorgan, Deutsche, Barclays, Societe Generale and dozens of KPO/BPO shops (WNS, Genpact, TCS, Cognizant, HPE-adjacent operations) run thousands of KYC seats out of Mumbai, Bangalore, Pune, Chennai and Gurgaon. It sits inside Operations / Financial Crime Compliance, not front office. The ladder typically runs Analyst / KYC Analyst -> Senior Analyst -> Team Lead / SME (Subject Matter Expert) -> Assistant Manager / QC -> Manager -> AVP. It is a stable, learnable, high-headcount role — and you should be clear-eyed that the entry rungs are process-heavy and pay modestly.

What you'll actually do

Your day is casework: you build or refresh a KYC file for a client (often a corporate, a fund, or a trust) and get it to "clean" status inside a Service Level Agreement (SLA).

- Create and validate KYC records: collect and verify identity documents, incorporation papers, board resolutions, and registration proofs (CIP — Customer Identification Program).
- Perform CDD (Customer Due Diligence) for standard clients and EDD (Enhanced Due Diligence) for high-risk ones — high-risk jurisdictions, cash-intensive businesses, complex ownership.
- Unwrap ownership and control: map the UBO (Ultimate Beneficial Owner) chain, directors, and management structure through layered entities.
- Screen names against sanctions lists, PEP databases and adverse/negative news (using Dun & Bradstreet, World-Check, LexisNexis, and open regulatory sites); triage and escalate true hits.
- Escalate negative-news and suspicious patterns; contribute to SAR/STR (Suspicious Activity / Transaction Report) drafting where you sit on the AML/transaction-monitoring side.
- Work to hard SLAs and quality (QC) targets — throughput and error rate are both measured.

> Real posting (Citi): "Create and validate KYC records, CIP documentation, ownership/management structure, screening via Dun & Bradstreet and regulatory sites, negative-news escalation, within SLAs."

Must-have skills

- Attention to detail — a missed UBO or a wrong risk rating is an audit finding.
- Reading and interpreting corporate documents across jurisdictions.
- Clear written English — case notes and rationales must survive audit and regulator review.
- Judgement on true vs false screening hits; comfort escalating rather than clearing.
- Understanding of AML typologies, sanctions regimes (OFAC), and the PMLA / RBI KYC framework in India.

- Speed under SLA without dropping quality; ability to sit with repetitive casework.

Tools & software

World-Check (Refinitiv), Dun & Bradstreet, LexisNexis, Bridger / Fircosoft or Actimize (screening & transaction monitoring), the bank's KYC workflow platform (e.g. Fenergo, Pega), MS Excel, and regulatory / registry sites (MCA21, sanctions lists, SEBI/RBI). Some AML analytics roles touch SQL or dashboards, but entry KYC is largely platform + document work.

Qualifications & certifications

A bachelor's degree is enough to start — B.Com, BBA, BA, and notably a law background is welcomed for CDD/EDD reasoning. The one credential that genuinely moves you here is **CACS/ACAMS** — the CAMS (Certified Anti-Money Laundering Specialist) certification from ACAMS is the recognised badge and helps at the Senior Analyst -> SME -> AVP transition and for switching employers at a premium. NISM and CA/MBA are *not* what this role rewards; CAMS is. An LLB is a real asset for financial-crime and sanctions work.

Experience & typical titles

Band	Typical titles
Fresher / 0-1 yr	KYC Analyst, Onboarding Analyst, AML Analyst, Client Data Analyst
1-3 yrs	Senior KYC Analyst, CDD/EDD Analyst, QC Analyst, SME
4-7 yrs	Team Lead, Assistant Manager, Financial Crime Compliance Manager, AVP

Most postings for the door role ask 1-3 years, but a large share of seats are genuinely fresher-friendly campus/lateral hires trained in-house.

ATS keywords to mirror

KYC, AML, CDD, EDD, CIP, Customer Due Diligence, Enhanced Due Diligence, UBO, beneficial ownership, sanctions screening, PEP screening, negative news, adverse media, World-Check, Dun & Bradstreet, transaction monitoring, SAR, STR, PMLA, FATF, OFAC, financial crime compliance, client onboarding, periodic review, SLA, ACAMS/CAMS.

Salary in India (indicative, FY2026)

Experience band	Indicative CTC (Rs LPA)
Fresher / 0-1 yr	3.0 – 5.0
2-4 yrs	5.0 – 9.0
5-8 yrs (TL / AM / AVP)	10 – 20

Approximate and varies by city and employer; foreign-bank GCCs (Citi, HSBC, SocGen) and night-shift roles pay at the higher end, KPO/BPO shops at the lower. Numbers are indicative FY2026 ranges.

Who's hiring

Foreign-bank GCCs and captives: **Citi**, HSBC, Standard Chartered, JPMorgan, Deutsche Bank, Barclays, Societe Generale, BNP Paribas. KPO/BPO and consulting: WNS, Genpact, TCS, Cognizant, Infosys BPM, EXL. Hubs: Mumbai, Bangalore, Pune, Chennai, Gurgaon, Hyderabad. This is one of the highest-headcount hiring categories in Indian financial services.

How to break in / stand out

This is the most *accessible* finance job in India, which is exactly why you must differentiate to avoid being stuck on the volume treadmill.

1. **Learn the vocabulary before the interview.** Be able to explain CDD vs EDD, what a UBO is, how you'd triage a sanctions hit, and what makes a client high-risk. Interviewers screen hard for people who actually understand *why* KYC exists (regulatory + reputational risk) versus people who just want a bank job.
2. **Build a mock KYC case file.** Take a real listed company, pull its MCA/annual-report data, map the ownership chain and directors, run open-source adverse-media checks, and write a one-page CDD memo with a risk rating and rationale. Bring it. Almost no fresher does this, and it instantly signals you can do the actual work.
3. **Get CAMS on your radar early** — even "CAMS in progress" on the resume separates you and is the clearest path off the entry rung toward SME and AVP pay.
4. **Be honest with yourself about the ladder.** The entry work is repetitive and metric-driven. The winners treat it as a two-year launchpad: master EDD and sanctions, get CAMS, and pivot into Financial Crime Compliance, transaction monitoring, or a Compliance/Regulatory seat where the pay curve steepens.

The single biggest differentiator: demonstrating **judgement** — showing you can decide when to clear a hit and when to escalate — rather than just claiming you're "detail-oriented."

Compliance & Regulatory Analyst

Snapshot

The Compliance & Regulatory Analyst is the person who makes sure the organisation does what the law and its regulators require — and can *prove* it did. Where the KYC analyst clears individual clients, the compliance analyst manages the institution's obligations as a whole: what has to be filed, by when, to whom, and with what evidence. In India this role lives against a dense regulatory backdrop — SEBI for capital markets, RBI for banking/NBFCs, IRDAI for insurance, MCA/Companies Act for corporates, and a thick layer of labour-law and statutory enactments (PF, ESI, PT, factory/shops acts, POSH). The role exists in banks, NBFCs, AMCs, brokers, insurers, listed companies, and — increasingly — in consulting/GCC shops that run compliance-as-a-service for clients. It sits inside Legal / Compliance / Company Secretary functions. The ladder runs Compliance Analyst / Executive -> Senior Analyst -> Assistant Manager -> Compliance Manager -> Head of Compliance / Chief Compliance Officer. It rewards people who are organised, calendar-driven, and comfortable reading a regulation and turning it into a checklist.

What you'll actually do

Your core deliverable is a compliance calendar that never slips and an audit trail that never has a gap.

- Own the compliance calendar and trackers: every filing, return, renewal and disclosure with due dates and owners.
- Prepare and submit regulatory filings under applicable enactments (labour-law returns, statutory filings, sector filings to SEBI/RBI/registrars).
- Monitor for regulatory change — new circulars, amendments, notifications — and assess what the organisation must do in response.
- Monitor and report compliance risks to management; maintain registers of breaches, gaps, and remediation.
- Support inspections and audits — internal, statutory, and regulator-led — by assembling evidence and responding to queries.
- Coordinate across HR, finance, legal and business teams to close compliance actions before deadlines.

> Real posting (Accenture): "Maintain the compliance calendar and trackers, complete filings under labour-law enactments, support inspections/audits, and monitor and report compliance risks."

Must-have skills

- Reading a statute/circular and extracting the concrete obligation (what, when, format, penalty for missing).
- Ruthless organisation and follow-through — the calendar is the job.
- Strong written communication for filings, notes to management, and regulator responses.
- Working knowledge of the relevant regime: SEBI/RBI/IRDAI, Companies Act, or labour-law depending on the seat.

- Stakeholder chasing — most of your risk comes from other teams missing deadlines, so you must be able to push politely and persistently.
- Documentation and evidence discipline for audit-readiness.

Tools & software

MS Excel and MS Word (trackers, calendars, filings), compliance/GRC platforms where mature (e.g. tools like Avantis / ComplyRelax / Ricago / MetricStream for statutory compliance), regulatory portals (SEBI SCORES/intermediary portals, RBI filing systems, MCA21, EPFO/ESIC portals), and document/workflow systems. Much of the entry work is still Excel- and portal-driven.

Qualifications & certifications

A law background (LLB) or a commerce degree (B.Com/M.Com) is the common entry. The high-value credentials for a *compliance career* are **CS (Company Secretary)** — the natural fit for corporate/secretarial and listed-company compliance — and for financial-markets seats the **NISM** series plus a **Compliance Officer certification**. An LLB is a strong differentiator for regulatory interpretation. CA/CMA help where compliance overlaps with financial and tax filings. For AML-adjacent compliance, CAMS adds value. MBA-Finance helps for management-track progression more than for the technical work itself.

Experience & typical titles

Band	Typical titles
Fresher / 0-2 yrs	Compliance Analyst, Compliance Executive, Regulatory Analyst, Statutory Compliance Executive
2-4 yrs	Senior Compliance Analyst, Assistant Manager – Compliance, Regulatory Reporting Analyst
5-8 yrs	Compliance Manager, Regulatory Affairs Manager, Company Secretary (corporate)

ATS keywords to mirror

Regulatory compliance, compliance calendar, statutory compliance, regulatory filings, SEBI, RBI, IRDAI, Companies Act, labour law compliance, PF/ESI/PT, POSH, regulatory reporting, compliance monitoring, compliance risk, inspections, statutory audit support, regulatory change management, compliance tracker, filings, remediation, Company Secretary, NISM.

Salary in India (indicative, FY2026)

Experience band	Indicative CTC (Rs LPA)
Fresher / 0-2 yrs	3.5 – 6.0
2-4 yrs	6.0 – 11.0
5-8 yrs	11 – 22

Approximate and varies by city, sector and employer; regulated financial firms (banks, AMCs, brokers) and foreign GCCs pay above corporate/labour-law compliance seats. Indicative FY2026 ranges.

Who's hiring

Consulting/GCC and BPO: **Accenture**, Deloitte, EY, KPMG, PwC, Genpact. Financial firms: banks, NBFCs, AMCs, brokers, insurers, and fintechs building out compliance as they scale under RBI/SEBI scrutiny. Listed corporates across sectors need statutory/secretarial compliance. Hubs: Bangalore, Mumbai, Gurgaon, Pune, Hyderabad.

How to break in / stand out

1. **Pick a regime and go deep.** "Compliance" is too broad to be hireable — decide whether you're the SEBI/RBI financial-markets person, the corporate/secretarial (CS) person, or the labour-law/statutory person, and build genuine depth in one. Interviewers test whether you actually know the filings for your chosen regime.
2. **Build a compliance calendar as a portfolio piece.** Take a hypothetical listed NBFC or a mid-size manufacturer and build a real annual compliance calendar — every SEBI/RBI/Companies-Act/labour-law obligation, due date, form number, and owner. This is exactly the deliverable you'd own on day one, and showing you can produce it is worth more than any certificate at the entry level.
3. **Read circulars for fun and summarise them.** Keeping a running one-line summary of recent SEBI/RBI circulars (and what they oblige firms to do) signals the single most important skill: turning regulation into action.
4. **Layer the right cert.** For the corporate track, pursue CS. For the markets track, do NISM + the Compliance Officer module. An LLB is a durable edge for interpretation-heavy seats.

The single biggest differentiator: proving you can **translate a regulation into a concrete, dated, evidenced action plan** — not just cite that a rule exists. Compliance is judged on zero missed deadlines and clean audits, and hiring managers look for candidates who already think in calendars and evidence trails.

GRC / IT Risk Analyst

Snapshot

The GRC (Governance, Risk & Compliance) / IT Risk Analyst is the crossover role where finance-style risk discipline meets information security. Instead of managing credit or market risk, you manage the risk that the organisation's *systems, data, and vendors* fail a control, a regulation, or a customer's security expectations. This is the natural home for a CS-leaning or commerce-plus-tech candidate: it doesn't require you to write production code, but it does require you to understand how controls work and to speak the language of both auditors and engineers. The role exists in fintechs, SaaS companies, banks, IT services, consulting firms, and any company that has to answer "are you secure?" to customers and regulators. It sits inside Information Security / Risk / Internal Audit. The ladder runs GRC/IT Risk Analyst -> Senior Analyst / Consultant -> GRC Lead / Manager -> Head of GRC / Information Security Manager -> CISO-track. Demand is rising fast as Indian fintechs face RBI cyber-security norms and as every SaaS vendor is forced through SOC 2 and ISO 27001 to close enterprise deals.

What you'll actually do

Your work is turning security policy into evidence — maintaining the registers, mappings, and answers that prove the company's controls actually operate.

- Maintain the risk register: identify, rate, and track IT/security risks and their treatment/remediation.
- Map controls to frameworks — ISO/IEC 27001, SOC 2 (Trust Services Criteria), NIST CSF, PCI-DSS, RBI/CERT-In guidelines — and evidence that each control operates.
- Run vendor / third-party risk assessments: review suppliers' security posture before and during engagements (TPRM).
- Complete customer security questionnaires and RFP security sections (CAIQ, SIG, bespoke enterprise questionnaires).
- Support internal, external, and certification audits — assemble evidence, coordinate auditors, and track findings to closure.
- Assist with policy documentation, access reviews, and control-gap remediation across engineering and IT teams.

> Real posting (KPMG / GRC seen): "Maintain risk registers, map ISO 27001 / SOC 2 controls, run third-party/vendor risk assessments, complete security questionnaires, and support audit engagements."

Must-have skills

- Understanding of security control frameworks (ISO 27001 Annex A, SOC 2 TSC) — not just their names, but what a control *does*.
- Risk assessment method: likelihood x impact, treatment options, residual risk.
- Reading evidence critically — a screenshot or log that actually proves a control works vs one that doesn't.
- Clear writing for questionnaires, risk notes, and audit responses.
- Stakeholder coordination with engineering, IT, and legal to close gaps.

- Basic technical literacy: access controls, encryption, logging, cloud (AWS/Azure) concepts, SDLC — enough to hold a credible conversation with engineers.

Tools & software

GRC / compliance-automation platforms: Vanta, Drata, Sprinto (big in Indian fintech/SaaS), plus enterprise tools like MetricStream, Archer, ServiceNow GRC. Cloud consoles (AWS/Azure/GCP) for evidence, ticketing (Jira), SIEM/log tooling awareness, and MS Excel for registers and mappings. Familiarity with a questionnaire standard (CAIQ/SIG) is a plus.

Qualifications & certifications

A degree in commerce, CS/IT, or a related field works — this role prizes certifications over a specific degree. The credentials that genuinely help here: **ISO 27001 Lead Auditor / Lead Implementer** (the most directly relevant, and achievable early), **CISA** (Certified Information Systems Auditor — the gold standard for IT audit/risk), and later **CRISC** or **CISM**. **CISSP** signals depth for senior seats. Cloud fundamentals (AWS Cloud Practitioner) help credibility. Traditional finance certs (CA/CFA/FRM) matter less here — this is where the CS/finance crossover candidate should invest in security certs instead.

Experience & typical titles

Band	Typical titles
Fresher / 0-2 yrs	GRC Analyst, IT Risk Analyst, Information Security Analyst, Compliance Analyst (InfoSec)
2-4 yrs	Senior GRC Analyst, IT Risk Consultant, Security Compliance Specialist, TPRM Analyst
5-8 yrs	GRC Lead / Manager, Information Security Manager, IT Audit Manager

ATS keywords to mirror

GRC, IT risk, information security, ISO 27001, ISO 27001 Lead Auditor, SOC 2, NIST CSF, PCI-DSS, risk register, controls mapping, third-party risk, vendor risk management, TPRM, security questionnaire, CAIQ, SIG, audit support, evidence collection, remediation, access review, CISA, Vanta, Drata, Sprinto, RBI cyber security, CERT-In.

Salary in India (indicative, FY2026)

Experience band	Indicative CTC (Rs LPA)
Fresher / 0-2 yrs	4.0 – 7.0
2-4 yrs	7.0 – 14.0
5-8 yrs	14 – 28

Approximate and varies by city and employer; product SaaS/fintech and Big-4 consulting pay above IT-services shops, and certified candidates (ISO 27001 LA, CISA) command a clear premium. Indicative FY2026 ranges — GRC pays noticeably better than generic finance-compliance because of the security scarcity.

Who's hiring

Fintech/SaaS: **Digitap** and peers, plus the broad Indian SaaS cohort chasing SOC 2 / ISO 27001. Consulting/audit: **KPMG**, Deloitte, EY, PwC (IT-risk and cyber practices). Product/enterprise: **3M** and other MNC captives, banks, and NBFCs building GRC teams under RBI norms. Tooling vendors (Vanta/Drata/Sprinto ecosystem) also hire GRC talent. Hubs: Bangalore, Hyderabad, Pune, Gurgaon, Mumbai.

How to break in / stand out

1. **Learn one framework cold.** Pick ISO 27001 (Annex A controls) or SOC 2 (the five Trust Services Criteria) and be able to explain, for five real controls, what the control requires and what evidence proves it operates. This single skill separates credible candidates from résumé keyword-stuffers.
2. **Build a controls-mapping portfolio piece.** Take a hypothetical fintech and produce a mini risk register plus an ISO 27001 or SOC 2 controls matrix — control, owner, status, evidence, gap. This is literally the day-one deliverable, and showing it beats any bootcamp certificate.
3. **Get ISO 27001 Lead Auditor early**, then target CISA as the career-defining cert. "ISO 27001 LA + CISA in progress" is the fastest CV signal in this field.
4. **Speak both languages.** Your value is being the person who can sit between auditors and engineers. Practise explaining a control to a non-technical auditor *and* asking an engineer for the right evidence without annoying them.

The single biggest differentiator: being able to **judge whether a piece of evidence actually satisfies a control** — the judgement that turns a checklist-filler into a real GRC professional, and the reason this crossover role out-earns generic compliance seats.

Private Equity / VC Analyst

Snapshot

A Private Equity (PE) or Venture Capital (VC) Analyst sits on the buy-side — the people who deploy investors' capital into private companies rather than trading public stocks. In India this splits two ways. There's the **investment/deal side** (sourcing, diligence, valuation, IC memos) at funds like Blackstone, KKR, ChrysCapital, Kedaara, Multiples, Sequoia/Peak XV, Accel, Elevation; and there's the **fund-services / valuation & reporting side** — the engine room that keeps the fund's books, values portfolios, and reports to Limited Partners (LPs). Much of that second half is done out of India for global funds by firms like **Acuity Knowledge Partners** and the **World Bank / IFC PE teams for South Asia**, plus the big fund administrators (State Street, Apex, Citco).

The ladder on the deal side runs Analyst -> Associate -> Sr Associate/VP -> Principal -> Partner. On the fund-reporting/valuation side it's Analyst -> Sr Analyst -> Team Lead/AVP -> Manager. This chapter grounds itself in the fund-valuation and investor-reporting reality (the doors most graduates actually get through) while telling you honestly what the deal seat demands.

What you'll actually do

On the fund-services / valuation & reporting side (the Acuity / World Bank PE evidence):

- Prepare **fund valuations** — mark portfolio holdings each quarter using comparable-company multiples, DCF, or last-round pricing, with a defensible bridge for every change.
- Maintain **capital accounts** for each LP: commitments, drawdowns/capital calls, distributions, and remaining **unfunded** commitment.
- Compute and reconcile **performance metrics — IRR, TVPI, DPI, RVPI and NAV** — at both the fund and deal level.
- Track **portfolio-company KPIs** (revenue, EBITDA, cash runway, covenant headroom) and roll them into a portfolio monitoring pack.
- Build the **quarterly investor reports** and capital-account statements LPs receive.
- Support diligence on live deals: data-room review, financial-statement spreading, and building/checking the LBO or growth-equity model.

> Real posting (Acuity Knowledge Partners / World Bank PE South Asia): "Prepare fund valuations, capital accounts, commitments and unfunded; compute IRR/TVPI/DPI/NAV and portfolio KPIs; produce quarterly investor reports."

On the deal side add: sourcing and screening targets, industry theses, management-meeting notes, and drafting the **Investment Committee (IC) memo**.

Must-have skills

- **Financial modelling** — LBO, growth-equity, and DCF models built cleanly from scratch; you must understand the maths behind IRR and cash-on-cash, not just pull it from a template.

- **Fund waterfall & economics literacy** — carry, hurdle rate, catch-up, management fee, and how a distribution waterfall actually splits cash between LPs and the GP.
- **Financial-statement analysis** — spreading three statements, normalising EBITDA, spotting aggressive accounting.
- **Valuation** — trading comps, transaction comps, DCF, and the judgement to pick the right one for an illiquid private asset.
- **Precision and ownership** — LP reporting is scrutinised; a wrong NAV or IRR is a reputational event.
- Soft skills: discretion, stamina, and clear written communication (the memo is the product).

Tools & software

Category	Tools named in postings
Data & screening	**Capital IQ (CapIQ), Preqin**, PitchBook, Bloomberg
Modelling	Excel (advanced — you live here)
Fund admin / accounting	eFront, Investran, Allvue, Zoho/SAP for portfolio books
Reporting	PowerPoint, Power BI/Tableau for portfolio dashboards

CapIQ and Preqin are the two names that recur — CapIQ for comps and company data, Preqin for fund and LP benchmarking.

Qualifications & certifications

- **MBA-Finance** from a top school is the classic deal-side ticket; it's near-mandatory for associate roles at brand-name funds.
- **CFA** is the strongest signal for the valuation/reporting seat and is genuinely respected across the buy-side — Levels I–II show you can value assets.
- **CA** is a real edge on the fund-accounting, valuation and diligence side (you already read financials fluently).
- **CAIA** (Chartered Alternative Investment Analyst) is the specialist cert for alternatives — niche but a clean differentiator for a PE/VC-only career.
- **FMVA** helps a fresher demonstrate modelling but does not substitute for an MBA/CA/CFA at the door.

Which actually helps: for the Acuity-style reporting door, **CFA or CA + strong Excel**. For a fund's deal team, **MBA-Finance (tier-1) or CA + CFA**.

Experience & typical titles

Band	Fund-services / reporting	Deal side
Fresher / 0–2 yrs	Analyst, Fund Reporting; PE Valuation Analyst	Rare direct entry; usually post-IB/consulting or top MBA
2–5 yrs	Sr Analyst, AVP – Fund Valuation	Associate
5–8 yrs	Manager, Portfolio Valuation	VP / Principal

Be honest: **direct fresher entry to a deal team is one of the narrowest doors in Indian finance.** Most deal analysts arrive via 2 years in investment banking, top-tier consulting (Bain/McKinsey/BCG), or a tier-1 MBA. The realistic and very respectable way in for a commerce/CA/CFA candidate is the **fund-valuation and investor-reporting seat at Acuity, a fund administrator, or a captive** — real PE exposure, and a proven bridge to the deal side later.

ATS keywords to mirror

Private equity, venture capital, fund valuation, capital accounts, commitments, unfunded commitment, capital call, distribution waterfall, IRR, TVPI, DPI, RVPI, NAV, carried interest, hurdle rate, LBO model, DCF, comparable company analysis, portfolio monitoring, KPI reporting, LP reporting, quarterly investor report, Capital IQ, Preqin, due diligence, investment committee memo, CFA, CAIA, MBA Finance.

Salary in India (indicative, FY2026)

Experience	Fund-services / reporting	Deal side (top funds)
Fresher (0–2 yrs)	Rs 7–12 LPA	Rs 18–30 LPA
2–4 yrs	Rs 12–22 LPA	Rs 30–55 LPA
5–8 yrs	Rs 22–40 LPA	Rs 55 LPA–1 Cr+ (incl. carry)

Deal-side comp is skewed heavily by **carried interest**, which shows up only after years and successful exits. Ranges are approximate and vary sharply by fund tier, city (Mumbai/Bangalore/Gurgaon), and whether it's a captive vs a marquee GP.

Who's hiring

- **Fund services / valuation / reporting:** Acuity Knowledge Partners, State Street, Apex Group, Citco, IFC/World Bank PE (South Asia), captives of global GPs.
- **Deal side:** Blackstone, KKR, Carlyle, ChrysCapital, Kedaara, Multiples, Peak XV (ex-Sequoia India), Accel, Elevation, Everstone, TVS Capital, growth funds and family offices.

How to break in / stand out

1. **Build a real fund model.** Take a listed proxy for a private target, build an LBO or growth-equity model, and derive a 5-year IRR/MOIC with a returns bridge (entry multiple, debt paydown, EBITDA growth, exit multiple). This one artefact separates you from every "interested in PE" applicant.
2. **Learn the waterfall cold.** Be able to explain, on a whiteboard, how Rs 100 of distribution splits across an 8% hurdle with 20% carry and full GP catch-up. Deal teams test this.
3. **Take the fund-reporting door seriously.** An Acuity/fund-admin valuation seat is not a consolation prize — it's real PE exposure that pays, teaches you the economics, and is a documented bridge to a deal team.
4. **Clear CFA Level I–II** while you apply; it's the single credential the buy-side respects most for a non-MBA.

Biggest differentiator: the ability to build a defensible valuation of an *illiquid* asset and walk an investment committee through why your number is right — judgement under uncertainty, not template-filling.

Wealth Manager / Relationship Manager / PMS

Snapshot

A Wealth Manager or Relationship Manager (RM) is the client-facing face of a bank, wealth firm, or Portfolio Management Service (PMS). You own a **book of clients** — mass-affluent, HNI (High Net Worth), or ultra-HNI — and your job is to grow the assets they hold with your firm (AUM), keep them invested through market noise, and sell them the right mix of products. This is a **revenue role**, not a back-office one: you carry targets, and your pay is heavily variable. The classic ladders are RM -> Sr RM -> Team Lead -> Cluster/Circle Head (bank branch banking), and for private wealth: Wealth Manager -> Sr Wealth Manager -> Private Banker -> Market Head. Grounded on the **DBS Treasures** wealth-RM and **branch RM** postings seen in India.

What you'll actually do

- **Manage and grow a client book** — deepen relationships with existing HNI/mass-affluent clients and acquire new ones, with an explicit **AUM growth / Net New Money** target.
- **Financial planning & portfolio reviews** — understand the client's goals, risk appetite and time horizon; run periodic reviews and rebalance.
- **Advise on product suitability** — mutual funds, PMS, AIFs, bonds, insurance, structured products, deposits — matched to the client's risk profile (this suitability check is a regulatory obligation, not a nicety).
- **Cross-sell and deepen** — bring in the family's other relationships, insurance, lending, and banking products.
- **Complete KYC and onboarding** cleanly, keep records audit-ready, and follow AML norms.
- **Hit sales targets** — revenue, AUM, product-mix and activity (calls/meetings) metrics, reviewed monthly.

> Real posting (DBS Treasures): "Acquire and grow a portfolio of Treasures (HNI) clients, drive AUM and revenue growth, and provide need-based wealth solutions in line with the client's risk profile."

Must-have skills

- **Sales and relationship-building** — the core competency; you must be comfortable prospecting, asking for money, and holding a client through a market crash.
- **Product knowledge across the shelf** — MFs, PMS, AIFs, bonds, insurance, structured products; you can't advise on what you don't understand.
- **Suitability and risk profiling** — matching product to client, honestly.
- **Financial planning literacy** — goals, asset allocation, tax-efficiency basics.
- **Compliance discipline** — KYC/AML, and staying inside SEBI/RBI advice-vs-distribution boundaries.
- Soft skills: trust-building, resilience under targets, and the emotional intelligence to talk a nervous client off a ledge.

Tools & software

Category	Tools
CRM	Salesforce, in-house CRM, HubSpot
Portfolio / reporting	Bank wealth platforms, PMS reporting tools, MF platforms (BSE Star MF, MFU)
Market data	Bloomberg (private banking), Morningstar, Value Research
Everyday	Excel, PowerPoint for client reviews

Qualifications & certifications

- **NISM certifications are effectively mandatory** to advise and transact:
- **NISM Series V-A (Mutual Fund Distributors)** — the baseline to sell MFs.
- **NISM Series X-A and X-B (Investment Adviser Levels 1 & 2)** — for anyone giving investment advice under the SEBI RIA framework.
- **NISM Series XXI-A / XXI-B (PMS Distributors / Portfolio Managers)** — for the PMS side.
- **AMFI ARN** registration to distribute mutual funds.
- **Insurance:** IRDAI certification for insurance products.
- **MBA-Finance** is the common degree and helps at private-banking firms; **CFP (Certified Financial Planner)** is a genuine differentiator for advisory credibility; **CFA** is respected at the ultra-HNI/private-banking end.
- Which actually helps here: **NISM V-A + X-A/X-B (and PMS series if relevant) are non-negotiable to operate;** CFP/CFA lift you from "distributor" to "adviser".

Experience & typical titles

Band	Typical titles
Fresher / 0–2 yrs	Relationship Officer, Acquisition Manager, Jr RM
2–5 yrs	Relationship Manager, Wealth Manager, Sr RM
5–8 yrs	Private Banker, Team Lead, Sr Wealth Manager
8+ yrs	Cluster/Market Head, Circle Head – Wealth

Entry is accessible for a commerce/MBA-Finance graduate — banks hire in volume for acquisition roles. Moving up depends almost entirely on **whether you hit your numbers.**

ATS keywords to mirror

Wealth management, relationship management, HNI, ultra-HNI, mass affluent, AUM growth, net new money, portfolio review, asset allocation, product suitability, risk profiling, financial planning, cross-sell, mutual funds, PMS, AIF, structured products, insurance, KYC, AML, NISM V-A, NISM X-A, NISM X-B, AMFI ARN, CFP, client acquisition, revenue targets.

Salary in India (indicative, FY2026)

Experience	Fixed pay (Rs LPA)	Note
Fresher (0–2 yrs)	Rs 3.5–6 LPA	plus incentives
2–4 yrs	Rs 6–12 LPA	large variable component
5–8 yrs	Rs 12–25 LPA	private banking higher; incentive can rival fixed

Honest note on pay: the **variable/incentive portion is large and target-linked** — top performers earn well above the band, under-performers can be managed out. The fixed number alone understates a good RM and overstates a struggling one. Varies by city, segment (branch vs private wealth) and employer; approximate.

Who's hiring

Banks and wealth arms: **DBS Treasures**, HDFC Bank, ICICI Bank, Axis Bank, Kotak, IDFC First, IndusInd. Private wealth & broking: 360 ONE (ex-IIFL Wealth), Nuvama, Anand Rathi, ASK, Julius Baer India, Motilal Oswal, Edelweiss, Bajaj Finserv. PMS/AMC channels also hire distribution RMs.

How to break in / stand out

1. **Get NISM V-A and X-A/X-B done before you apply** — walking in already certified signals you can produce revenue on day one and removes the firm's onboarding friction.
2. **Build a mock financial plan** for a hypothetical HNI family — goals, risk profile, asset allocation, product recommendations with suitability rationale. Bring it to the interview; it proves you think like an adviser, not just a salesperson.
3. **Be honest with yourself about the sales reality.** This role rewards people who genuinely enjoy relationships and can carry a target without burning out. If that's you, it pays and promotes fast.
4. **Pick a segment and specialise** — NRI clients, business-owner families, or professionals — a focused niche builds referrals faster than a scattergun book.

Biggest differentiator: a **book of trust**. Clients don't move crores to a person they don't believe in. The RMs who win are the ones who advise honestly through a down market and keep clients invested — that retention, not a slick pitch, is what compounds a career here.

Corporate Finance / M&A Analyst (in-house)

Snapshot

A Corporate Finance / M&A Analyst sits **inside a company** — in the corporate-development, strategy, or CFO's office team — rather than at a bank advising clients. Where an investment banker executes deals for a fee, you are the **principal**: you evaluate whether *your* company should acquire, invest, divest, or raise capital, and you build the case that goes to the board and the CEO. It's the seat that **bridges FP&A and investment banking** — you use the modelling rigour of IB but with the long-horizon, operating context of an insider. Typical ladders: Analyst -> Sr Analyst -> Manager – Corp Dev/Strategy -> AVP/Head of Strategy -> VP Corporate Development. Common at large corporates, unicorns, and PE-backed platforms building through acquisition.

What you'll actually do

- **Valuation and financial modelling** — DCF, comparable companies, precedent transactions, accretion/dilution, and merger models to value targets or the company's own business units.
- **Build business cases** — model the returns on a new plant, market entry, product line, or acquisition; pressure-test the assumptions.
- **M&A support** — screen and evaluate targets, run financial diligence alongside advisers, model synergies and integration, and help negotiate.
- **Fund-raising** — support equity/debt raises, prepare the information memorandum and financial projections, and manage lender/investor Q&A.
- **Board and management materials** — turn analysis into crisp board decks, investment memos, and strategy papers senior leaders actually decide on.
- **Cross-functional partnering** — work with FP&A on the numbers, legal on structure, and business heads on the operating reality.

> Real posting (synthesised from in-house corp-dev / strategy JDs): "Build valuation and financial models, prepare business cases and board materials, and support M&A and fund-raising activities for the group."

Must-have skills

- **Advanced financial modelling** — clean, flexible three-statement, DCF and merger models built from scratch; the modelling bar is close to IB.
- **Valuation fluency** — knowing which method fits which decision and defending the output.
- **Business and strategic judgement** — you're not just crunching a target; you're deciding if it fits the company's strategy and can be integrated.
- **Storytelling with numbers** — distilling a 40-tab model into a three-slide recommendation a busy board can act on.
- **Commercial diligence instinct** — spotting where a business case is optimistic.

- Soft skills: stakeholder management across functions, discretion (deals are confidential), and calm under deadline.

Tools & software

Category	Tools
Modelling	Excel (advanced), PowerPoint
Data	Capital IQ, Bloomberg, PitchBook for comps and precedents
Planning / systems	SAP, Oracle, Anaplan, Hyperion (shared with FP&A)
Reporting	Power BI/Tableau for dashboards

Qualifications & certifications

- **MBA-Finance** (tier-1) is the most common entry credential — the strategy and corp-dev teams recruit heavily from B-schools.
- **CA** is highly valued — the accounting depth is a real edge in diligence, accretion/dilution and deal structuring.
- **CFA** signals strong valuation and investment judgement and pairs well with either of the above.
- **FMVA** helps a fresher prove modelling capability but is a supplement, not a substitute for MBA/CA/CFA.
- Which actually helps: **MBA-Finance or CA to get in the door; CFA to deepen valuation credibility.** Prior **investment banking or Big-4 transaction-advisory experience** is the single strongest lateral ticket.

Experience & typical titles

Band	Typical titles
Fresher / 0–2 yrs	Analyst – Corporate Finance / Strategy (often ex-IB or top MBA)
2–5 yrs	Sr Analyst, Manager – Corporate Development / Strategy
5–8 yrs	AVP – Corp Dev, Head of Strategy (BU)
8+ yrs	VP – Corporate Development, Director – Strategy

Direct fresher entry is competitive; many analysts arrive after **2–3 years in IB, Big-4 deals/valuation, or FP&A**. FP&A is a very realistic internal bridge into this seat — you already know the company's numbers.

ATS keywords to mirror

Corporate finance, corporate development, M&A, mergers and acquisitions, financial modelling, DCF, comparable company analysis, precedent transactions, accretion dilution, merger model, valuation, business case, feasibility, synergy analysis, due diligence, fund raising, capital raising, information memorandum, board presentation, investment memo, strategy, Capital IQ, Excel, PowerPoint, MBA Finance, CA, CFA.

Salary in India (indicative, FY2026)

Experience	Salary (Rs LPA)
Fresher (0–2 yrs)	Rs 10–18 LPA
2–4 yrs	Rs 18–35 LPA
5–8 yrs	Rs 35–60 LPA+

In-house corp-dev generally pays **better than FP&A and below front-office IB**, with more predictable hours than banking. Numbers vary by company size (unicorn vs large-cap), city, and whether ESOPs/bonus form part of the package; approximate.

Who's hiring

Large corporates and conglomerates (Reliance, Tata group, Aditya Birla, Adani, Mahindra), unicorns and late-stage startups building via M&A (Flipkart, Swiggy, Razorpay, PharmEasy-type platforms), PE-backed roll-up platforms, and the strategy/corp-dev arms of Big-4 (as a training ground). Companies with an active acquisition agenda are where the seat is busiest.

How to break in / stand out

1. **Build a full merger model.** Pick two listed Indian companies, model an acquisition — funding mix, synergies, accretion/dilution to EPS — and write a one-page board recommendation. This is the closest thing to the actual job and almost no applicant brings it.
2. **Use FP&A as a bridge.** If you can't enter directly, an FP&A seat at a company with an M&A agenda gets you the internal numbers and the relationships; then move to corp-dev.
3. **Think like an owner, not an adviser.** Interviewers want to hear "should *we* do this deal and can we integrate it?" — not just "here's the valuation." Strategic fit and integration risk are what set you apart.
4. **Clear CFA Level I–II** or lean on your CA to signal the valuation depth.

Biggest differentiator: the judgement to say **no** to a deal that models well but doesn't fit the strategy. In-house, protecting the company's capital matters more than closing a transaction — the analysts who show that instinct get trusted with bigger decisions fast.

Markets & Advisory Skills, Tools & Certification Matrix

This closing chapter pulls the markets-and-advisory roles from this section into one view — so you can see which skills carry across roles, which certification is actually worth your money, and exactly what to do in the next 90 days to be interview-ready for a front-office/markets seat. Use it as the map; the individual chapters are the detail.

Role × skill matrix

A quick-scan of what each role leans on. **●● = core/daily, ● = useful, – = rarely needed.**

Role	Fin. modelling	Valuation	VaR / risk models	Bloomberg	Python	SQL	Excel	Credit analysis	AML/KYC
Investment Banking Analyst	●●	●●	–	●	●	●	●●	●	–
Equity Research Analyst	●●	●●	●	●●	●	●	●●	●	–
Credit Risk Analyst	●	●	●	●	●	●	●●	●●	●
Risk / Model Validation	●	●	●●	●●	●●	●●	●●	●	●
Treasury Analyst	●	●	●	●●	●	●	●●	●	●
KYC / AML Analyst	–	–	–	●	–	●	●●	●	●●
Private Equity / VC Analyst	●●	●●	●	●	●	●	●●	●	–
Wealth / RM / PMS	●	●	–	●	–	–	●●	●	●●
Corporate Finance / M&A (in-house)	●●	●●	–	●	●	●	●●	●	–

Read the columns, not just the rows: **Excel is universal**, **financial modelling + valuation** cluster the deal/advisory roles (IB, ER, PE, M&A), **VaR + Python + SQL** cluster the quant-risk roles (model validation, market risk), and **credit analysis + AML/KYC** cluster the banking/compliance roles.

Certification decoder

Which cert to actually spend money and a year of evenings on, by target role:

Certification	Best for	Effort / cost (indicative)	Verdict
CFA (3 levels, CFA Institute)	Equity research, PE/VC, asset mgmt, corp-dev, buy-side risk	~3–4 yrs, Rs 3–5 L all-in	The gold standard for investment/markets roles. Level I–II alone is a strong signal. Highest ROI for front-office.
FRM (2 parts, GARP)	Credit risk, market risk, model validation, treasury	~1.5–2 yrs, Rs 1.5–2.5 L	The risk-side gold standard. If risk is your lane, this beats CFA.
CQF (Certificate in Quantitative Finance)	Model validation, quant risk, derivatives	6 mths, Rs 8–12 L	Niche and pricey; only if you're genuinely going quant.
NISM series (SEBI)	Wealth/RM/PMS, broking, advisory, research (India-mandatory)	Weeks each, Rs 1.5–3k each	Cheap, fast, and *required* to operate in India. V-A (MF), X-A/X-B (Investment Adviser), XV (Research Analyst), XXI (PMS). Do the ones your role needs.
ACAMS (CAMS)	KYC/AML, financial-crime compliance	3–4 mths, Rs 1–1.5 L	The recognised AML credential; strong for a compliance-track career.
CAIA (2 levels)	PE/VC, alternatives, hedge funds	~1–1.5 yrs, Rs 2–3 L	Specialist alternatives cert; clean differentiator if PE/VC is the whole plan.

Rules of thumb: **markets/investing lane -> CFA; risk lane -> FRM; India distribution/advisory -> NISM (non-negotiable); financial crime -> ACAMS; alternatives-only -> CAIA.** Don't collect certs — pick the one that matches your target seat and finish it.

Universal ATS keyword bank (markets & advisory roles)

Mirror the ones true for your target role — never fake a skill:

Financial modelling, valuation, DCF, comparable company analysis, precedent transactions, LBO model, merger model, accretion dilution, three-statement model, equity research, initiating coverage, channel checks, target price, credit analysis, financial statement analysis, cash flow analysis, leverage, credit proposal, due diligence, VaR, model validation, model risk, market risk, time-series, Monte Carlo, portfolio management, asset allocation, IRR, TVPI, NAV, capital markets, M&A, fund raising, treasury, FX, derivatives, money markets, KYC, AML, sanctions screening, Bloomberg, Refinitiv, Capital IQ, Preqin, Python, SQL, VBA, Power BI, Excel, PowerPoint, CFA, FRM, NISM, board presentation, investment memo.

90-day plan to be interview-ready (front-office / markets)

Days 1–30 — Foundations & the anchor skill. - Master **Excel to modelling standard**: shortcuts (no mouse), clean formatting, INDEX/MATCH, data tables, and a full **three-statement model built from scratch** (not a template). - Register for **CFA Level I** (or **FRM Part I** if risk is your lane) — start studying now; even "candidate" status is a resume signal. - Read one company's annual report end-to-end and learn to spread its financials.

Days 31–60 — Build the portfolio piece. - Pick one listed Indian company and produce a **complete equity research note or valuation** — model, target price, and a two-page thesis. This single artefact beats any bullet point. - Learn **Bloomberg/Capital IQ basics** (many campuses and libraries have terminals) and pull comps. - If targeting risk/quant: build a **VaR calculation in Python** on a small portfolio and document the method. - Clear the **NISM series** your target role legally needs (fast and cheap).

Days 61–90 — Sharpen, network, apply. - Do a **second modelling piece** in a different sector, or an LBO/merger model if you're PE/M&A-bound. - Drill **valuation and technical interview questions** out loud (WACC, why DCF vs comps, what moves a bond price, how VaR works). - **Network deliberately** — 10 informational conversations with people one rung ahead; front-office seats are filled through referrals as much as portals. - Rewrite your resume to **mirror the ATS keywords** for your one target role, attach the portfolio link, and apply in focused batches — not scattershot.

The one thing that matters most: a **real, self-built analytical artefact** — a model, a research note, a valuation — that you can defend live. Certifications get you past the filter; the artefact and the ability to defend your numbers get you the offer.

Finance JD Gap-Filler: What Companies Actually Ask

What Real 2026 JDs Demand That Your Other Guides Don't Teach

Tools, standards, frameworks & skills to close the gap — ERP, Blackline, Bloomberg, regulatory, AML tooling, ESG, AI, GCC ops

Contents

The Gap Map: What Real JDs Demand vs What You Already Have

The method: read the JD, subtract your bundles, keep the remainder

You already own six finance study bundles. Between them they teach Excel and financial modelling (Power Query, DCF, LBO, sensitivity tables), Data/BI (SQL, Python pandas, Power BI + DAX, Tableau), Accounting and ERP at the level of hands-on TallyPrime plus an *overview* of SAP FICO, reconciliations, month-end, Ind AS, Schedule III and MIS, Taxation (GST, TDS, income tax, ITR, tax audit), FP&A (budgets, forecasts, variance, driver models), and the knowledge layer of markets, valuation, credit and risk. That is a genuinely strong base. It is also, in 2026, table stakes — the stuff every shortlisted candidate has.

This guide is built by a subtraction. I took the actual mid-2026 India job descriptions in the evidence pack — HP's R2R role, Dentsu's Financial Control seat, Luxoft's finance-and-financial-crime tech reqs, Street Neon's research desk, plus Franklin Templeton, Accenture, Genpact, Acuity, Citi and Intel — and I listed *everything* they demand. Then I crossed off everything your six bundles already teach. What survives that crossing-off is the gap. That remainder is this guide.

The point is blunt: your bundles get you *qualified*. The remainder is what gets you *shortlisted* — the specific enterprise tool, standard, or framework named in the JD that a generalist candidate cannot speak to.

The master demand list

Every capability named across the evidence JDs, grouped, with an honest verdict on where your existing bundles leave you:

#	Demand cluster	What JDs literally ask for	Your coverage
1	**Enterprise ERP depth**	"Hands on experience in SAP" (HP); SAP, Oracle, Hyperion (Accenture); Workday Financials, SAP Finance (Luxoft)	**GAP** — you have Tally + an SAP *overview*, not FICO T-code fluency, S/4HANA, Oracle Fusion, Workday, NetSuite, D365
2	**Consolidation & close tech**	"SAP BPC and Blackline an added advantage" (Dentsu); Hyperion, Anaplan (Accenture)	**GAP** — recon *concept* known; the tools that run group close are not
3	**Automation beyond pandas**	"Automate data workflows" (HP); "VBA, Power Automate, Alteryx" (Franklin Templeton)	**partly** — Power Query/Python known; VBA, Power Automate, Alteryx, agentic workflows are gaps
4	**Market-data terminals**	"Bloomberg, Capital IQ, Refinitiv, FactSet" (Street Neon); Bloomberg/Refinitiv/MSCI/Markit (Acuity)	**GAP** — terminal function fluency (DES, GP, FA, EQS) not taught
5	**Accounting standards & controls**	"US GAAP & IFRS"; "SOX / J-SOX controls" (HP, Dentsu)	**partly** — you have Ind AS + Schedule III; US GAAP contrasts, IFRS depth, SOX/ICFR testing are gaps
6	**Regulatory reporting**	"Regulatory Reporting, Basel, IFRS, Liquidity/Capital" + AxiomSL, OneSumX, Regnology (Luxoft)	**GAP** — Basel/RBI returns and reg-reporting engines not covered
7	**AML / financial-crime tooling**	"AML, KYC, CDD, Sanctions, Fraud" + Actimize, SAS AML, Quantexa, World-Check (Luxoft, Citi)	**GAP** — fin-crime domain and tools absent
8	**ESG & sustainability finance**	BRSR, CSRD, assurance (implicit in 2026 controller/audit roles)	**GAP** — not in any bundle
9	**AI / GenAI in finance**	"AI Gigafactory / agentic AI" (Genpact); GenAI push across 2026 GCC JDs	**GAP** — using LLMs/copilots in a controlled finance workflow not taught
10	**GCC operating model**	R2R/P2P/O2C towers, SLAs, shared-services (HP, Genpact, Accenture)	**GAP** — the operating model these roles sit inside is unstated in bundles
11	**Treasury tech**	"Treasury, TMS, settlements, money markets, hedging FX" (Dentsu, Intel)	**GAP** — treasury workflows and TMS not covered
12	**Analyst soft skills**	"BS commentary for BS calls", "audit support", stakeholder comms	**partly** — modelling known; commentary, review notes, audit interaction are gaps

Seven hard GAPs, four partials, and a base you can already stand on. That is the shape of the work.

How to use this guide

Each following chapter takes **one** cluster and treats it as a stand-alone gap with the same six sections, so you can read them in any order and stop when a chapter is already covered:

1. **The gap** — what it is and, in one line, why your bundles don't reach it.
2. **Why companies ask for it** — grounded in a real quoted posting, and which roles need it.
3. **What "proficient" looks like** — the concrete bar an employer tests, so you know when you're done.
4. **How to actually learn/do it** — real screens, menus, T-codes, terminal functions and step-by-step workflows, with free ways to practise. Where a tool needs paid access, I say so and give the free alternative.
5. **How it shows up in interviews** — two or three exact questions with strong answers.
6. **ATS keywords to add** — the precise terms to seed into your resume so the parser and the recruiter both find them.

A suggested path: if you are aiming at **GCC R2R / controllership** (HP, Dentsu, Genpact), prioritise chapters on Enterprise ERP, Consolidation & Close tech, US GAAP/IFRS + SOX, GCC operating model, and automation. If you are aiming at **buy/sell-side research or model risk** (Street Neon, Acuity), prioritise Market-data terminals, then the AI and automation chapters. If you are aiming at **banking finance/fin-crime tech** (Luxoft, Citi, Intel), prioritise Regulatory reporting, AML/fin-crime tooling, and Treasury tech.

Why these are the differentiators

Recruiters and ATS systems in 2026 do not filter on "knows accounting". They filter on named nouns: *SAP S/4HANA, Blackline, SOX, AxiomSL, Bloomberg, Actimize, BRSR, Anaplan*. Those nouns are exactly the remainder above — the things that survive after you subtract the general knowledge everyone has. A candidate who can say "I've reconciled in Blackline's matching module and understand how an auto-cert rule works" beats ten candidates who wrote "strong reconciliation skills". That is the entire thesis of this guide: your bundles make you employable; these gaps make you *the* shortlist. The rest of the book plugs them one by one.

> **How to read the verdicts:** "covered" = a bundle already teaches it, skip that chapter. "partly" = you have the concept but not the named tool/standard — read for the specifics. "GAP" = start here; this is net-new and it is what the JD is actually screening for.

Enterprise ERP Depth: SAP (beyond overview), Oracle, Workday, NetSuite, D365

The gap

Your bundles give you hands-on TallyPrime and an *overview* of SAP FICO — enough to define what a GL is, not enough to survive a screening call that asks "which T-code do you post a vendor invoice in?". Every mid-2026 MNC/GCC finance JD assumes daily life *inside* an enterprise ERP, and Tally is not one. The gap is transactional fluency in SAP FICO plus literacy in the other four systems you will be asked about — Oracle, Workday, NetSuite, Dynamics 365 — because your existing material stops at the overview.

Why companies ask for it

> Real posting (HP, R2R Bangalore): "Hands on experience in SAP... R2R, AR & P2P; Automate data workflows." Real posting (Accenture FP&A): "SAP, Oracle, Hyperion, Anaplan." Real posting (Luxoft): "SAP Finance, Workday Financials, Oracle Financial Services."

Who needs it: any Record-to-Report, AP/AR, General Accounting, financial-control or FP&A seat in a GCC or MNC (HP, Dentsu, Genpact, Accenture, Intel). The ERP *is* the job — you post, extract, reconcile and report inside it eight hours a day. SME and startup roles lean NetSuite or D365; large listed and captive-shared-services lean SAP; Oracle Fusion and Workday show up in specific captives.

What "proficient" looks like

The bar for an entry-to-mid R2R/GL accountant is not configuration — that's a consultant's job. It is confident *end-user* operation: you know the module map (FI vs CO), you can name and use the day-to-day T-codes without a cheat sheet, you understand the document flow (a posting creates a document number, hits the GL, updates sub-ledgers), and you can pull and interrogate a line-item report. You can also say, accurately, which SAP version you worked on and the difference from the current one. For the other ERPs the bar is lower: know what each is, who uses it, and the equivalent concept, so you're not blank when a recruiter mentions it.

How to actually learn/do it

SAP FICO — the module map. FI (Financial Accounting: GL, AP, AR, Asset Accounting, Bank) produces the external statements; CO (Controlling: cost centres, internal orders, profit centres, product costing) is the internal/management view. R2R lives mostly in FI-GL; P2P touches FI-AP; O2C touches FI-AR.

The T-codes to actually memorise (a T-code is typed into the command box top-left):

T-code	Does	Area
`FB50`	Post a GL document (enter view)	FI-GL
`F-02`	Post a GL document (general, with posting keys)	FI-GL
`FB60`	Post a vendor (AP) invoice	FI-AP
`FB70`	Post a customer (AR) invoice	FI-AR
`F-53` / `F110`	Manual payment / automatic payment run	FI-AP
`FBL1N` / `FBL5N` / `FBL3N`	Vendor / customer / GL line-item display	Reporting
`FS10N`	GL account balance display	Reporting
`FAGLB03`	GL balance (new GL)	Reporting
`AS01` / `AFAB`	Create asset / run depreciation	FI-AA
`F.05` / `FAGL_FC_VAL`	Foreign-currency revaluation	Month-end

Tiny worked example — post and verify a rent accrual. In `FB50`, enter company code, document date, then two lines: debit *Rent Expense* ₹1,00,000 (posting key 40), credit *Accrued Liabilities* ₹1,00,000 (posting key 50); the debits-equal-credits indicator must go green; simulate, then post — SAP returns "Document 1000000123 posted". Verify it in `FBL3N` by opening the Accrued Liabilities GL and filtering on your document number. That five-minute loop — post, get a doc number, trace it in a line-item report — is exactly what "hands on SAP" means on a JD.

S/4HANA vs ECC. ECC (ECC 6.0) is the legacy on-premise version many captives still run; S/4HANA is the current (2026) in-memory successor. Say the difference credibly: S/4HANA merges FI and CO into the **Universal Journal (table ACDOCA)** so there's a single source of truth and no reconciliation between FI and CO; the **Business Partner** replaces separate customer/vendor masters; the UI is **Fiori** tiles rather than the old SAP GUI; and reporting is real-time on line items. If you trained on ECC, say ECC — don't claim S/4 you haven't seen.

The other four, in one line each. *Oracle Fusion Cloud ERP* (and legacy *E-Business Suite/EBS*) — large enterprises; the finance module is "Oracle Financials", navigation is web-based, the equivalent of a GL inquiry is the Account Inspector/Financial Reporting. *Workday Financials* — HR-first companies extending into finance; everything is a "business process" with worklets, no T-codes. *NetSuite* (Oracle) — the default cloud ERP for mid-market/SME and startups; role-based dashboards, saved searches instead of T-codes. *Microsoft Dynamics 365 Finance* — Microsoft-shop mid-market; tightly integrated with Excel and Power Platform.

How to get hands-on for free / cheap. - **SAP** — no fully-free live system, but: (1) SAP Learning (learning.sap.com) has free courses and **openSAP**; (2) a personal **S/4HANA Fully-Activated Appliance** trial runs on SAP Cloud Appliance Library (you pay only cloud compute, a few dollars/day, stoppable); (3) YouTube walkthroughs of `FB50` / `FBL3N` let you rehearse the exact screens; (4) SAP Learning Hub (paid) if an employer sponsors it. - **Oracle** — Oracle offers free Cloud ERP trial/guided tours via Oracle University; **Oracle Cloud Free Tier** for the tech side. - **NetSuite** — request a product tour/demo; SuiteLife learning content is free to browse. - **Dynamics 365** — a **free 30-day trial** of D365 Finance is genuinely self-serve at trials.dynamics.com; spin one up and post a journal. - **Workday** — no public trial; learn the vocabulary from Workday's docs and demo videos.

How it shows up in interviews

Q: "Walk me through how you'd post a vendor invoice in SAP and then check it hit the ledger." A: "I'd use `FB60` — enter the vendor, invoice date, amount, tax code and the expense GL and cost object. On posting SAP generates a document number. To verify, I'd open `FBL1N` for that vendor to see the open item, and `FBL3N` or `FS10N` on the expense GL to confirm the debit. At month-end that open item would clear against the payment run via `F110`."

Q: "Have you worked on S/4HANA or ECC — what's the difference?" A: "I trained on [be honest]. The key change in S/4HANA is the Universal Journal, table ACDOCA — FI and CO postings share one line-item table, so there's no FI-CO reconciliation and reporting is real-time. Master data moves to the Business Partner model and the front end is Fiori instead of the classic GUI."

Q: "We run NetSuite, you've used SAP — is that a problem?" A: "The concepts transfer directly — chart of accounts, subsidiaries, sub-ledgers, period close. NetSuite replaces T-codes with role dashboards and saved searches; I'd be productive on the transaction set within days and I've already run a trial to see the posting flow."

ATS keywords to add

SAP FICO, SAP S/4HANA, SAP ECC, FI-GL, FI-AP, FI-AR, Asset Accounting, Universal Journal (ACDOCA), FB50, FB60, FBL3N, FS10N, F110, Record-to-Report (R2R), P2P, O2C, Oracle Fusion Cloud ERP, Oracle EBS, Workday Financials, NetSuite, Microsoft Dynamics 365 Finance, ERP end-user, GL posting, period-end close.

Consolidation & Close Tech: SAP BPC, Blackline, HFM/FCCS, OneStream

The gap

Your bundles teach the *concept* of reconciliation and month-end close — matching balances, posting accruals, variance MIS. What they don't teach is the *software* that MNCs and GCCs actually run those closes on: the reconciliation-automation platform (Blackline) and the consolidation engines (SAP BPC, Oracle HFM/FCCS, OneStream). This is a pure tool gap — you know *what* a group consolidation and an account recon are; you don't know the screens where they happen, and the JDs name the screens.

Why companies ask for it

> Real posting (Dentsu, Financial Control Bangalore): "SAP BPC (Business Planning & Consolidation) and Blackline tool an added advantage... budget & reforecast BPC submissions... Balance sheet reconciliations & commentary for BS calls." Real posting (HP): "Ensure compliance with internal & SOX controls" (Blackline is HP's recon control tool). Real posting (Accenture): "Hyperion, Anaplan."

Who needs it: group/financial-control accountants, R2R leads and FP&A analysts in any multi-entity MNC or captive GCC. The moment a company has more than a handful of legal entities in multiple currencies, close and recon move off spreadsheets onto these platforms for auditability and SOX evidence. Naming them credibly is a direct differentiator for controllership seats.

What "proficient" looks like

You are not configuring the tool (that's an admin/consultant). The bar is: you can describe and operate the *workflow*. For **Blackline** — you know the reconciliation lifecycle (prepare → auto-match → certify → approve), what a matching rule and an auto-certification threshold do, and how it produces SOX evidence. For **consolidation tools** — you understand what consolidation software does that a spreadsheet can't: intercompany elimination, currency translation, minority interest, and controlled *submissions* from each entity. You can say which tool you touched and describe one real task (a BPC budget submission, a Blackline balance-sheet recon) without inventing depth you don't have.

How to actually learn/do it

Blackline — the account-reconciliation workflow

Blackline replaces the "reconciliation Excel" with a controlled, audited system. The lifecycle for one GL account each month:

1. **Import** — the GL balance (from SAP/Oracle) and supporting sub-ledger/bank data auto-load into Blackline.
2. **Prepare** — the preparer opens the account's recon template, explains the balance (e.g. lists the open items making up an Accrued Liabilities balance), and attaches support.

3. **Auto-match** — Blackline's **Transaction Matching** module matches thousands of lines (e.g. bank vs GL) by rules you set, leaving only exceptions for humans. This is the big time-saver over Excel.
4. **Auto-certify** — accounts meeting a rule (e.g. balance is zero, or unchanged, or below a risk threshold) can be **auto-certified**, so preparers focus only on risky accounts.
5. **Certify → Review → Approve** — preparer certifies, reviewer approves; every action is timestamped with the user — that trail *is* the SOX control evidence.

Alongside recon, Blackline runs **Task Management** (the close checklist, who does what by when — a digital close calendar) and a **Journal Entry** module (create, route for approval, post back to the ERP). On a JD, "Blackline" almost always means the account-reconciliation + task-management combo used as a SOX close control.

Consolidation engines — what they do that Excel can't

All four (SAP BPC, Oracle HFM, Oracle FCCS, OneStream) do the same core job: take each legal entity's trial balance and produce **group** financials. The steps they automate:

- **Submissions** — each entity submits its trial balance into the tool (Dentsu's "BPC submissions").
- **Currency translation** — restate each entity from local currency to group reporting currency at the right rates (average for P&L, closing for balance sheet), booking the **CTA** (currency translation adjustment).
- **Intercompany elimination** — cancel intragroup sales/purchases and receivables/payables so the group isn't double-counted; the tool flags IC mismatches.
- **Adjustments & minority interest** — consolidation journals, goodwill, non-controlling interest.
- **Output** — group P&L, balance sheet, and the numbers behind the "BS calls".

Who uses which: **SAP BPC** in SAP shops (now succeeded by *SAP Group Reporting* / SAC in S/4 estates, but BPC is still everywhere in 2026); **Oracle Hyperion HFM** legacy on-prem and its cloud successor **Oracle FCCS**; **OneStream** the fast-growing unified CPM challenger; **Anaplan** more for planning than statutory consolidation; **Trintech Cadency** a Blackline competitor for recon + close.

A BPC submission, concretely. BPC runs as an Excel add-in (**EPM add-in**) or web. You open an input schedule bound to the model, select your entity/version (e.g. Actual vs Budget vs Forecast) and time period from the member dimensions, type or load your numbers into the grid, run any **Business Rules** (e.g. IC eliminations), then **Submit/Save** to write to the model. That "select dimensions → enter → submit" loop is what "BPC budget & reforecast submissions" on the Dentsu JD means.

Free / cheap ways to learn the concepts

- **Blackline** — no free live tenant, but Blackline **University** and the Blackline **U** YouTube/demo library walk through the exact recon and matching screens; watch a "how to certify a reconciliation" demo and you can speak to it. The vendor also runs frequent webinars.
- **Consolidation logic** — you can learn 90% of it *for free in Excel*: build a two-subsidiary consolidation — translate a foreign sub's TB at closing/average rates, book the CTA, eliminate an intercompany sale and the matching receivable/payable, and produce a consolidated TB. Doing this once teaches you what the tools automate, which is exactly what interviewers probe.
- **OneStream / Oracle / SAP** — OneStream, Oracle (FCCS) and SAP publish free product tours, documentation and community learning; openSAP occasionally runs BPC/Group Reporting courses.

- **Standards backing** — the consolidation logic maps to **Ind AS 110 / IFRS 10** (consolidation), **Ind AS 21 / IAS 21** (currency translation) and **Ind AS 28** (associates); you already have the standards, now attach the tool vocabulary to them.

How it shows up in interviews

Q: "Explain the Blackline reconciliation workflow and how it supports SOX." A: "Balances auto-import from the ERP into an account template. The preparer explains the balance and attaches support; Transaction Matching auto-clears the routine lines by rule, and low-risk accounts auto-certify against a threshold, so effort concentrates on risky accounts. The preparer certifies, a reviewer approves, and every step is user-and-time stamped. That timestamped preparer/reviewer trail is the SOX control evidence that the recon was performed and independently reviewed."

Q: "What does a consolidation tool like SAP BPC or HFM do that a spreadsheet can't?" A: "It enforces controlled submissions from each entity, then automates currency translation with the CTA, intercompany eliminations with mismatch flagging, and consolidation adjustments and minority interest — all with an audit trail and locked versions (Actual vs Budget vs Forecast). Spreadsheets can compute the same numbers but can't give you the control, the multi-entity IC matching at scale, or the auditability the external auditors and BS calls need."

Q: "You've listed BPC — what did you actually do in it?" A: "I worked on the submission side: opening the input schedule in the EPM Excel add-in, selecting entity, version and period from the dimensions, entering budget/reforecast numbers, running the business rules and submitting to the model, then pulling a report to check it consolidated." (Say only what's true; if it's Excel-simulated, say "I've replicated the consolidation logic in Excel and studied the BPC submission flow.")

ATS keywords to add

Blackline, account reconciliation automation, Transaction Matching, auto-certification, close task management, SAP BPC, EPM add-in, budget & forecast submissions, Oracle Hyperion HFM, Oracle FCCS, OneStream, Anaplan, Trintech Cadency, group consolidation, intercompany elimination, currency translation (CTA), minority/non-controlling interest, SOX control evidence, balance-sheet reconciliation & commentary, IFRS 10 / Ind AS 110.

Automation Beyond Power Query: Alteryx, Power Automate, VBA

The gap

You can already shape data in Power Query, model in Python, and build Power BI dashboards. But a large slice of 2026 finance JDs — especially at asset managers, GCCs and Big-4 managed services — still runs on three tools your bundles never touched: **Alteryx** (drag-and-drop ETL for analysts who don't code), **Microsoft Power Automate** (workflow/approval/email robots), and **VBA** (the Excel macro language that refuses to die). They are named explicitly, together, on real postings — and none of your six bundles teach them.

Why companies ask for it

> **Real posting (Franklin Templeton, Fund Accounting / FA):** "VBA, Power Automate, Power BI, Alteryx."

That one line names all three. Franklin Templeton, Accenture, Genpact and most fund-admin / FP&A shared-service teams list them because their existing process estate is Excel-and-email; they want people who can *retrofit* automation onto legacy workflows without a full data-engineering project. Roles: **Fund Accounting, FP&A analysts, R2R/RTR teams, MIS analysts, financial-reporting associates, RPA/finance-transformation** roles in GCCs.

Why not just Python? Governance. In a bank or fund admin, IT won't let you run arbitrary Python against the GL. Alteryx and Power Automate are *sanctioned, auditable, licensed* platforms with lineage and logging — that's the whole reason they get paid for.

What "proficient" looks like

The employer tests whether you can:

- Build an **Alteryx workflow** end-to-end: pull two files, clean, join, aggregate, and output — and explain each tool container.
- Stand up a **Power Automate flow** that triggers on an email/file/schedule, applies a condition, and sends an approval or a report.
- **Record, then edit** a VBA macro — add a loop, a variable, an `If`, and error handling — not just hit record.
- Say **when to use which** (the decision matters more than syntax).

How to actually learn/do it

Alteryx Designer

The whole product is a left-hand **tool palette** you drag onto a canvas and wire together left-to-right. Learn these categories:

Palette	Key tools	What it does
In/Out	Input Data, Output Data, Browse	Read CSV/Excel/DB, write result, preview mid-stream
Preparation	Select, Filter, Formula, Sort, Sample, Data Cleansing	Pick/rename columns, `WHERE` , new calculated fields
Join	Join, Union, Join Multiple, Find Replace	`VLOOKUP` /merge on keys, stack tables
Transform	Summarize, Cross Tab, Transpose	Group-by/pivot/unpivot
Parse	Text to Columns, RegEx, DateTime	Split and reformat

Worked example — a 2-minute recon: Input `GL.xlsx` → Input `Bank.csv` → **Select** to standardise the amount/date types on each → **Join** on `TxnID` → the **L and R (unmatched) outputs** are your exceptions, the **J (inner)** output is matched → **Summarize** the exceptions by amount → **Output Data** to `breaks.xlsx` . The unmatched anchors of a Join tool ARE the reconciliation. Wrap it once and it re-runs monthly in one click.

Free practice: Alteryx offers a free **14-day Designer trial** and a permanent **free "Designer Cloud" / Community edition** plus the **Weekly Challenge** archive and free "Foundational Micro-Credential" on the Alteryx Community — genuinely the fastest way to a line on the resume.

Microsoft Power Automate

A **flow** = **Trigger** → **Action(s)**, built in a browser at make.powerautomate.com. It's almost certainly already in your Microsoft 365 licence.

- **Trigger** types: *automated* (When a new email arrives / a file is created in SharePoint), *scheduled* (Recurrence, e.g. every weekday 7 am), *instant* (button/manual).
- **Core actions**: Condition (If/Yes-No branch), Apply to each (loop), Get items (SharePoint/Excel table), Send an email (V2), Start and wait for an approval, Create file, HTTP.

Worked example — invoice approval: Trigger *When a new email arrives* with attachment → **Condition** subject contains "Invoice" → **Start and wait for an approval** (Approve/Reject) sent to the manager → on Approve, **Create file** in the "Approved" SharePoint folder and **Send an email** to AP. Zero code. This is the classic FP&A/AP demo.

Free practice: Any personal Microsoft account gets Power Automate free-tier; Microsoft Learn has free guided modules and there's a free desktop RPA client (**Power Automate for desktop**) bundled with Windows 11 for clicking legacy apps.

VBA

Open the editor with **Alt + F11**. To learn fast: **Developer tab** → **Record Macro**, do the task once, stop, then **read and edit** the generated code — that's how everyone actually learns VBA.

A real finance macro — loop through sheets and PDF each cost-centre's MIS:

```
Sub ExportCostCentres()
    Dim ws As Worksheet
    Dim path As String
    path = ThisWorkbook.Path & "\MIS\"
    For Each ws In ThisWorkbook.Worksheets          ' loop
        If Left(ws.Name, 2) = "CC" Then             ' If condition
            ws.ExportAsFixedFormat Type:=xlTypePDF, _
                Filename:=path & ws.Name & ".pdf"
        End If
    Next ws
    MsgBox "Done"
End Sub
```

That single macro shows the four things interviewers probe: a **variable** (`Dim`), a **loop** (`For Each`), an `If` , and a real action. Add `On Error Resume Next` for basic error handling. **Free practice:** any Excel install — no licence, no internet.

When to use which

Need	Reach for
Repeatable multi-file **ETL / recon / blending**, no code, auditable	**Alteryx**
Cross-app workflow — email, approvals, SharePoint, Teams, scheduled reports	**Power Automate**
Manipulate **inside one workbook**, format, loop cells, quick-and-dirty	**VBA**
Heavy transforms already loading a model	**Power Query** (you have this)
Data science / large data / ML	**Python** (you have this)

Rule of thumb: *data in files → Alteryx; actions across apps → Power Automate; things inside Excel → VBA.*

How it shows up in interviews

Q: "You get two files — our GL export and the bank statement — every morning. Walk me through automating the reconciliation without writing Python." A: "In Alteryx: two Input tools, a Select on each to normalise date and amount types, then a Join on the transaction key. The inner output is matched; the two unmatched anchors are my breaks, which I Summarize by amount and Output to an exceptions file. I'd schedule it, or hand it off in Power Automate on a 7 am recurrence that emails the exceptions to the team."

Q: "Difference between Power Automate and VBA — when would you pick each?" A: "VBA lives inside one Excel workbook and is great for formatting, looping cells, or generating PDFs locally, but it can't reach email approvals or SharePoint cleanly and needs the file open. Power Automate is cloud, event-driven and cross-app — approvals, notifications, scheduled report distribution — with logging and governance IT accepts. I'd use VBA for in-workbook work and Power Automate for anything that crosses apps."

Q: "How do you learn a macro if you don't know the syntax?" A: "Record it first, then open Alt+F11 and refactor the recorded code — replace absolute references with variables, wrap repeated steps in a For loop, add an If and `On Error` handling. Recording teaches you the object model faster than any tutorial."

ATS keywords to add

Alteryx, Alteryx Designer, workflow automation, data blending, ETL, Power Automate, Microsoft Power Automate, Power Automate for desktop, RPA, robotic process automation, approval workflows, VBA, Excel macros, macro automation, process automation, finance transformation, automated reconciliation, scheduled reporting, Power Automate flows, Alteryx Core Micro-Credential

Market-Data Terminals Hands-On: Bloomberg, Refinitiv, FactSet, Capital IQ

The gap

Your knowledge guides *mention* Bloomberg and Capital IQ; they never teach you to **drive** them. Every equity research, IB, PE, credit and buy-side JD assumes you can sit at a terminal and pull a company, a comp set, a chart and a screen in seconds. That muscle memory — the function codes, the Excel add-ins — is the gap, and it's the one that separates "I've heard of Bloomberg" from "I've used Bloomberg."

Why companies ask for it

> **Real posting (Street Neon, Institutional Research, Mumbai):** "Familiarity with financial databases such as Bloomberg, Capital IQ, Refinitiv, FactSet."
>
> **Real posting (Acuity, Model Risk):** data sources "Bloomberg / Refinitiv / MSCI / Markit / CapIQ."

Roles: **equity/credit research associate, IB analyst, PE/VC associate, buy-side analyst, model-risk and market-risk analysts, KPO/research at Acuity, Moody's, MSCI, Evalueserve.** These are the terminals the whole capital-markets industry runs on; the JD uses "familiarity with" as a polite filter for people who've never touched one.

What "proficient" looks like

You can, without a manual: pull a security's description and financials, build a trading comps set, chart relative performance, run an equity screen, and — crucially — **pull the data into Excel** with the add-in so a model refreshes live. On Bloomberg specifically, you know the **function-then-`<GO>`** grammar and a dozen core mnemonics.

How to actually learn/do it

Bloomberg Terminal

Grammar: type a **ticker + yellow market key** (e.g. `AAPL US <Equity>`), then a **function mnemonic**, then hit `<GO>` (the green key). `HELP HELP` opens live chat with Bloomberg staff — free, 24/7, the best learning shortcut there is.

Function	Does
DES	Company/security description — the front page
FA	Financial Analysis — full financials, ratios, segments
GP	Line chart (GIP intraday, G historical)
RV	Relative Value — comparable companies table
EQS	Equity Screening — build a rules-based screen
SRCH	Fixed-income / bond search
PORT	Portfolio & risk analytics
BQL / FLDS	Bloomberg Query Language; field finder
N / CN	News; company news
WEI / ECO	World equity indices; economic calendar

Excel add-in (the part that matters for a modelling job): - `=BDP("AAPL US Equity","PX_LAST")` — one current value (Bloomberg Data Point). - `=BDH("AAPL US Equity","PX_LAST","1/1/2025","6/30/2026")` — a history series (Data History). - `=BDS(...)` — bulk/set data (e.g. all holders). - **BQL** for complex screens/aggregations in one formula. Master `BDP` / `BDH` and you can wire a live comps sheet in minutes.

Free/cheap access: the **Bloomberg Market Concepts (BMC)** e-learning course (~8 hours, ~₹1,600 / paid but often free through a university) gives a **certificate** you list on the resume and teaches the exact functions above. Many Indian B-school libraries and some public libraries have a terminal — book an hour.

Refinitiv (LSEG) Eikon / Workspace

Eikon is being replaced by **Workspace**. It's more **search-bar and app-driven** than Bloomberg's command line — type a company name, open the Company Overview app. Excel add-in functions: `=TR(...)` and the newer `=RDP.Data(...)`, plus a point-and-click **"Build Formula"** wizard so you don't memorise field names. Best for: **FX, fixed income, commodities, and news** (Reuters), and often cheaper than Bloomberg, so common in Indian KPOs.

FactSet

Menu/workstation-driven rather than command-line; strong at **portfolio analytics, quant screening (Universal Screening), and clean, presentation-ready comps/tearsheets**. Excel add-in: `=FDS(...)` codes and the FactSet ribbon. Loved by buy-side and IB for its Excel/PowerPoint model-building tools.

S&P Capital IQ (CapIQ / CIQ)

Web platform + the killer **Excel plug-in** (`=CIQ(...)`). Best for **screening, trading & transaction comps, and credit**: - **Screening**: build a universe (sector, geography, size, metrics) → export. - **Comps**: pull a company → "Comparable Companies" / "Precedent Transactions" (M&A deals) → export the whole table to Excel. - The CIQ Excel formulas let you build a bankers' comps sheet that refreshes. CapIQ is the standard for **PE/M&A/credit** shops in India.

Preqin

The **private-markets** database — **PE, VC, private credit, real assets, infrastructure**: fund performance (IRR/TVPI), fund managers (GPs), LPs, and deal/fundraising data you cannot get from public terminals. Named on PE/fund-of-funds and placement-agent JDs.

Free / cheap alternatives to practise on (India-first)

Paid tool	Free stand-in
Bloomberg/CapIQ **screener**	**Screener.in**, **Tijori Finance**, **TradingView** screener
Company financials / filings	**Screener.in**, **NSE/BSE** corporate filings, **MCA**, company IR pages
Charts (GP)	**TradingView**, NSE charts
Macro (ECO)	**RBI**, **MOSPI**, **FRED**, **Trading Economics**
Bond search (SRCH)	**NSE/BSE debt**, RBI, **CCIL**
Global fundamentals	**stockanalysis.com**, SEC **EDGAR**, **Financial Modeling Prep** free API

Build a comps table in Screener.in, then you can honestly say you understand the *workflow* — and add the **BMC certificate** to prove terminal literacy.

How it shows up in interviews

Q: "You need a quick trading-comps set for a listed FMCG company on Bloomberg — walk me through it." A: "I'd load the ticker with `<Equity><GO>`, open **DES** to confirm it's the right entity, then **RV** for the peer relative-value comps, or **EQS** to build a custom peer screen on sector, size and margin. To model it, I'd pull the same fields into Excel with `BDP` for current multiples and `BDH` for history, so the sheet refreshes."

Q: "Bloomberg vs Capital IQ — when do you reach for which?" A: "Bloomberg for live markets, fixed income, FX and news, and anything real-time. Capital IQ for deep screening, trading and precedent-transaction comps, and credit work — its Excel plug-in and precedent-transactions database are stronger for M&A modelling. FactSet sits between them and is best for portfolio analytics and polished tearsheets; Preqin for private-markets data neither of the others has."

Q: "You don't have a terminal — how do you keep your skills current?" A: "I completed **Bloomberg Market Concepts**, so I know the DES/FA/GP/EQS grammar and the `BDP` / `BDH` add-in. For live practice I use Screener.in and TradingView to build comps and screens, and NSE/BSE and MCA for filings — same workflow, no licence."

ATS keywords to add

Bloomberg Terminal, Bloomberg Market Concepts (BMC), BDP, BDH, BQL, DES, FA, EQS, Refinitiv Eikon, Refinitiv Workspace, LSEG, FactSet, S&P Capital IQ, CapIQ, CIQ Excel plug-in, Preqin, financial databases, trading comparables, precedent transactions, equity screening, comps analysis, market data, TradingView, Screener.in

Standards & Controls JDs Assume: US GAAP vs IFRS vs Ind AS, SOX/J-SOX, XBRL

The gap

Your bundles teach **Ind AS, Schedule III and month-end**. But GCC and MNC-controllership JDs assume you can *also* speak **US GAAP and IFRS**, operate inside a **SOX / J-SOX** control framework, and understand **XBRL/MCA** filing. Indian entities of US or Japanese parents keep two sets of books and run a formal controls regime — none of which your Ind-AS-first material covers. That crosswalk and that controls vocabulary are the gap.

Why companies ask for it

> **Real posting (HP, R2R, Bangalore):** "Highly skilled in US GAAP & IFRS … Ensure compliance with internal & SOX controls."
>
> **Real posting (Dentsu, Financial Control, Bangalore):** "IFRS + US GAAP; **J-SOX controls effectiveness attestation**; external audit support."

Every GCC controllership, R2R, financial-reporting and internal-audit role wants this because the India entity reports up to a parent on **US GAAP or IFRS** while filing locally on **Ind AS**, and a listed US parent is legally bound by **SOX** (Japanese parent → **J-SOX**). Roles: **R2R/RTR, financial reporting & consolidation, controllership, internal controls/SOX testing, statutory audit support** at HP, Dentsu, Accenture, Genpact, Deloitte/EY/PwC/KPMG managed services.

What "proficient" looks like

You can name the **standard number and the practical difference** across the three frameworks for the big-ticket areas; explain **design vs operating effectiveness** and walk a control from an **RCM** to a **test of one**; classify a control gap as a **deficiency / significant deficiency / material weakness**; and describe how Indian companies **XBRL-tag and file** with MCA.

How to actually learn/do it

US GAAP vs IFRS vs Ind AS — the crosswalk

Ind AS is *converged with* IFRS (so they're close, with carve-outs); **US GAAP is the different one**. Learn the deltas on the areas auditors and interviewers hammer:

Area	US GAAP	IFRS	Ind AS
Revenue	ASC 606	IFRS 15	Ind AS 115 — all 3 use the **5-step model**; substantially aligned
Leases	ASC 842 — lessee still splits **finance vs operating** (dual P&L model)	IFRS 16 — **single model**, almost all leases on balance sheet	Ind AS 116 — single model, follows IFRS 16
Financial instruments	ASC 326 **CECL** (lifetime expected loss, day 1)	IFRS 9 — **3-stage ECL** model	Ind AS 109 — 3-stage ECL, follows IFRS 9
Inventory	**LIFO permitted**; write-downs generally not reversed	LIFO **banned**; reversals allowed	LIFO banned; reversals allowed
Consolidation	VIE (variable interest) model	IFRS 10 single **control** model	Ind AS 110 control model
Dev. costs / R&D	Mostly **expensed**	**Capitalise** if IAS 38 criteria met	Capitalise (Ind AS 38)
Component depreciation	Not required	Required	Required
Extraordinary items	Prohibited	Prohibited	Prohibited

The two you must be able to speak to cold: **leases** (US GAAP keeps the operating/finance split; IFRS/Ind AS collapse it into one on-balance-sheet model) and **credit losses** (US **CECL** = lifetime loss from day one; IFRS/Ind AS **ECL** = staged, moves to lifetime only on significant deterioration).

Free study: the **IFRS Foundation** publishes standards summaries free; **MCA** hosts Ind AS free; **FASB** ASC Basic View is free; the Big-4 "**US GAAP vs IFRS**" comparison PDFs (EY, PwC, KPMG, Deloitte) are the single best crosswalk resource — download one.

Internal controls: SOX / J-SOX / IFC

- **SOX** (US Sarbanes-Oxley) **§302** = executives certify the financials; **§404** = management *and* the external auditor assess **internal control over financial reporting (ICFR)**.
- **J-SOX** = Japan's equivalent (Financial Instruments & Exchange Act) — same idea, management **attestation** of controls effectiveness (Dentsu's exact phrase).
- **IFC** = India's Internal Financial Controls over Financial Reporting under **Companies Act 2013 §143(3)(i)** — the auditor reports on IFC.

All rest on the **COSO 2013** framework (5 components, 17 principles).

The workflow you must know: 1. **RCM (Risk & Control Matrix)** — the master sheet listing each **risk → control → assertion → owner → frequency → test**. 2. **Design effectiveness** — is the control *capable* of preventing/detecting the risk? (walkthrough of one transaction). 3. **Operating effectiveness** — did it *actually operate* all year? (test a **sample** — e.g. 25 items for a daily control). 4. **Deficiency ladder:** a **control deficiency** < **significant deficiency** < **material weakness** (reasonable possibility of a material misstatement). 5. **Control types:** preventive vs detective, **manual vs automated**, and **ITGCs** (IT General Controls — access, change management, ops) that everything automated depends on.

Worked example: Risk = "unauthorised journal posted." Control = "all manual JEs >₹10 lakh require reviewer approval in SAP before posting." *Design test:* trace one JE — was approval captured? *Operating test:* pull 25 JEs from the year, confirm each has documented approver ≠ preparer. Two fail → evaluate: isolated slip (deficiency) or pervasive (significant/material).

XBRL & MCA filings

XBRL (eXtensible Business Reporting Language) tags each financial-statement number to a standard **taxonomy** element so regulators read it by machine. In India, specified companies file financials in XBRL with **MCA** via forms **AOC-4 XBRL** (and cost audit in **CRA-4**); you validate in the **MCA XBRL validation tool**, generate the instance document, do a **pre-scrutiny**, and upload. SEBI listed entities also file XBRL on the exchanges. You don't hand-code XBRL — you map the trial balance to taxonomy tags in the tool.

How it shows up in interviews

Q: "Biggest practical difference in lease accounting across US GAAP and IFRS?" A: "IFRS 16 and Ind AS 116 use a single lessee model — nearly every lease goes on the balance sheet as a right-of-use asset and lease liability, with depreciation plus interest. US GAAP's ASC 842 still splits operating vs finance leases: both go on the balance sheet, but operating leases keep a straight-line single lease expense in P&L rather than the front-loaded depreciation-plus-interest pattern. So EBITDA and expense geography differ."

Q: "Walk me through testing a SOX control." A: "I start from the RCM to get the control objective, assertion and frequency. First I test **design** with a walkthrough of one transaction to confirm the control can catch the risk. Then **operating effectiveness**: I pick a sample sized to frequency — say 25 for a daily control — and inspect evidence that it operated each time, like an approver different from the preparer. Exceptions get evaluated up the ladder from deficiency to significant deficiency to material weakness based on likelihood and magnitude."

Q: "What's the difference between SOX, J-SOX and IFC?" A: "Same concept — management/auditor assurance over financial-reporting controls, all built on COSO. SOX is US law for SEC registrants (§302 certification, §404 ICFR); J-SOX is Japan's version requiring management attestation of control effectiveness; IFC is India's, under Companies Act §143(3)(i), where the statutory auditor opines on internal financial controls."

ATS keywords to add

US GAAP, IFRS, Ind AS, ASC 606, IFRS 15, ASC 842, IFRS 16, IFRS 9, ECL, CECL, GAAP-to-IFRS reconciliation, SOX, Sarbanes-Oxley, J-SOX, §404, ICFR, IFC, Internal Financial Controls, COSO, Risk and Control Matrix (RCM), design and operating effectiveness, control testing, walkthrough, deficiency, significant deficiency, material weakness, ITGC, XBRL, AOC-4, MCA filing, statutory audit support, R2R

Regulatory & Statutory Reporting: Basel, FATCA/CRS, RBI/SEBI, AxiomSL/OneSumX

The gap

This is an entire, well-paid domain your six bundles skip. **Regulatory reporting** — the returns banks and financial institutions file with regulators on capital, liquidity, tax residency and transactions — is nothing like management MIS. It has its own standards (**Basel III/IV**), its own tax regimes (**FATCA/CRS**), its own regulator returns (**RBI, SEBI**), and its own dedicated software estate (**AxiomSL, OneSumX, Regnology, Moody's**). Learn the vocabulary and you unlock a market of GCC/BFSI jobs most candidates can't even read the JD for.

Why companies ask for it

> **Real posting (Luxoft, Finance Tech, Bangalore):** "Regulatory Reporting, General Ledger, Treasury, Liquidity Management, Capital Management, IFRS Reporting, **Basel Reporting** … reg tools: **AxiomSL, Moody's, OneSumX, Regnology**, Oracle Financial Services."

Banks *must* file these returns — it's the law, and errors mean regulatory penalties — so the work is non-discretionary and recession-proof. Every foreign bank, GCC captive (JPMC, Deutsche, Barclays, UBS, HSBC, StanChart, Nomura, Wells Fargo) and consultancy (Luxoft, Capco, TCS, Accenture) staffs large **regulatory-reporting** teams in Mumbai, Bangalore, Pune and Hyderabad. Roles: **regulatory reporting analyst, Basel/RWA analyst, liquidity (LCR/NSFR) reporting, FinCrime/AML tech BA, statutory reporting, tax-operations (FATCA/CRS).** It pays a premium precisely because so few candidates understand it.

What "proficient" looks like

You can explain **what each return measures and why the regulator wants it**, trace a number from the **GL → data mart → reg-reporting engine → regulator submission**, and speak the platform vocabulary: what an **AxiomSL "run"** is, what **data lineage** and **adjustments** mean, and how validation/EBA-taxonomy filing works.

How to actually learn/do it

Basel III / IV — bank capital & liquidity

The global rulebook (from the Basel Committee, implemented in India via **RBI Master Directions**). Two families of ratios:

Ratio	Formula (essence)	Question it answers
CAR / CRAR	Capital ÷ **RWA** (risk-weighted assets), min ~9% (RBI) + buffers	Enough capital to absorb losses?
CET1	Common equity ÷ RWA	Highest-quality capital cushion
LCR	HQLA ÷ 30-day net cash outflows ≥ 100%	Survive a 30-day stress?
NSFR	Available ÷ Required stable funding ≥ 100%	Funding stable over 1 year?
Leverage ratio	Tier 1 ÷ total exposure	Backstop independent of risk weights

RWA is the heart of it: each asset gets a **risk weight** (a government bond ~0%, a mortgage ~35%, an unrated corporate ~100%) and RWA = exposure × weight, across **credit, market and operational** risk. **Basel IV** (RBI phasing in from 2025-26) tightens this with the **standardised output floor** capping how far internal models can lower RWA. Reports flow into RBI's **RBS/DSB returns** and, globally, EBA **COREP** (capital) and **FINREP** (financial) taxonomies.

FATCA / CRS — tax-residency reporting

- **FATCA** (US law) — financial institutions identify **US persons** and report their accounts (via the CBDT/IRS route in India).
- **CRS** (OECD Common Reporting Standard) — the multilateral version: identify account holders' **tax residencies** and report to their home tax authority. Operationally it's **self-certification, indicia search, and Form 61B** filing to the Indian income-tax department. Named on **tax-operations and KYC** JDs.

RBI & SEBI returns

- **RBI:** the **DSB (Off-site Surveillance) returns**, **RBS** (Risk-Based Supervision) data, CRR/SLR, priority-sector, and the **CIMS / XBRL** filing portal that replaced the old RBI XBRL site.
- **SEBI:** for AMCs/brokers/AIFs — periodic filings, **SCORES**, half-yearly and disclosure returns via exchange portals.

FEMA (corporate cross-border)

The exchange-control law behind foreign investment/borrowing filings — **FC-GPR** (shares issued to non-residents), **FC-TRS** (transfer), **ECB** returns, all now on the RBI **FIRMS** portal. Shows up on controllership JDs at companies with foreign shareholders.

The reg-reporting platforms

You won't buy these, but you must speak them:

Platform	Note
AxiomSL (ControllerView)	Market leader; ingests source data, applies rules, produces regulator-ready returns with full **lineage**
Wolters Kluwer OneSumX	Basel, liquidity, COREP/FINREP
Regnology (BearingPoint Abacus)	European Basel/statistical reporting
Moody's	Credit/regulatory analytics
Oracle Financial Services (OFSAA)	Analytics + reg reporting

How the workflow actually runs (AxiomSL mental model): source systems (GL, loans, deposits) → a **data-ingestion layer** (mapping, validation) → **business rules / classification** (assign risk weights, HQLA categories) → a **"run"** that produces the return → **validation rules** (regulator's edit checks) and **manual adjustments** with sign-off → **submission** in the regulator's format (XBRL/taxonomy). The BA's job is **data mapping, lineage, reconciliation** (report ties back to GL) and clearing validation breaks.

Free ways to build credibility (no licence needed): - Read the **RBI Master Direction on Basel III Capital** and one **RBI DSB return** format — both free on rbi.org.in. - Read the **EBA** COREP/FINREP overview (free). - Download a real bank's **Pillar 3 / Basel disclosures** (in every bank annual report) and read how CAR, LCR, NSFR and RWA are presented — that's the *output* of the whole machine. - Study the **Form 61B / CRS** guidance on the income-tax site. - Optional paid credentials that read well: **FRM** (GARP), or a "regulatory reporting" micro-course.

How it shows up in interviews

Q: "What does LCR measure and where does the data come from?" A: "LCR is High-Quality Liquid Assets divided by total net cash outflows over a 30-day stress, and it must be at least 100% — can the bank survive a month-long run without central-bank help. HQLA is mostly cash, central-bank reserves and government bonds; the outflows are stressed run-off rates on deposits and wholesale funding. The data comes from the deposit and treasury systems into the GL and the reg-reporting engine, where each item is bucketed by HQLA level and run-off rate."

Q: "Walk me through how a Basel capital return is produced in a tool like AxiomSL." A: "Source data — loans, exposures, collateral, ratings — is ingested and mapped to the reporting model. Business rules assign each exposure its asset class and risk weight to compute RWA across credit, market and operational risk. A run aggregates capital over RWA to produce CET1, Tier 1 and CAR, populates the return, then validation rules — the regulator's edit checks — flag breaks. We reconcile the total back to the GL, book any approved adjustments with sign-off, and submit in the required taxonomy. Throughout, lineage lets us trace any reported number back to source."

Q: "FATCA vs CRS?" A: "Both report financial-account information for tax purposes. FATCA is US-specific — identify and report US persons' accounts. CRS is the OECD multilateral standard covering all participating jurisdictions — you determine each holder's tax residencies and report to their home authorities. In India both run on customer self-certification and indicia checks, filed to the income-tax department via Form 61B."

ATS keywords to add

Regulatory reporting, Basel III, Basel IV, CAR, CRAR, CET1, RWA, risk-weighted assets, LCR, NSFR, liquidity reporting, capital adequacy, COREP, FINREP, Pillar 3, FATCA, CRS, Form 61B, RBI returns, DSB returns, RBS, CIMS, SEBI reporting, FEMA, FC-GPR, FC-TRS, ECB reporting, AxiomSL, OneSumX, Regnology, Moody's, OFSAA, data lineage, data mapping, reconciliation, statutory reporting

AML/KYC & Financial-Crime Tooling: World-Check, Actimize, SAS, Quantexa, Napier

The gap

The career bundle decoded *what* a KYC/AML analyst role is and why banks hire for it. What it does **not** teach is the actual **tooling and casework** — the screening engines, transaction-monitoring platforms, alert and case managers, and the regulatory filing chain that every JD names by product. When Luxoft asks for "NICE Actimize, SAS AML, Oracle FCCM, Quantexa, Napier AI, ComplyAdvantage, Refinitiv World-Check" and Citi asks for "screening, negative news, ACAMS," they are asking whether you can *operate the machinery*, not whether you understand the concept. That machinery is the gap.

Why companies ask for it

> Real posting (Luxoft, Bangalore): "AML Transaction Monitoring, CDD, KYC, Sanctions Screening, Fraud Detection, Case Management, Customer Risk Rating." Named tools: "NICE Actimize, FICO TONBELLER, SAS AML, Quantexa, Oracle FCCM, Napier AI, ComplyAdvantage, Refinitiv World-Check."
>
> Real posting (Citi, KYC): "screening, negative news, ACAMS."

These roles sit in three buckets: (1) **KYC/CDD analysts** at banks and GCCs (Citi, HSBC, Deutsche, Standard Chartered's Chennai/Bangalore hubs) who onboard and periodically review customers; (2) **AML transaction-monitoring / investigations analysts** who work alerts and file suspicious-transaction reports; and (3) **financial-crime technology / RegTech** roles (Luxoft, Cognizant, TCS BaNCS) who *configure and tune* the detection engines rather than clear alerts. India is the global back-office for all three — most Tier-1 banks run their financial-crime operations from GCCs here.

What "proficient" looks like

An employer tests whether you can:

- Run a **name screen** against a sanctions/PEP list, read a hit, and clear it as a true or false positive with a documented rationale (fuzzy-match logic, secondary identifiers like DOB/nationality).
- Take a **transaction-monitoring alert**, pull the customer's profile and transaction history, decide "clear vs escalate," and write a defensible investigation narrative.
- Build a **Customer Risk Rating (CRR)** from the standard factors: geography, product, channel, customer type, PEP status.
- Know the **CDD → EDD** trigger points and the **SAR/STR filing** chain end-to-end.
- Speak the vocabulary of at least one named platform (Actimize, SAS, FCCM) — screens, alert queues, case lifecycle.

How to actually learn/do it

1. The CDD/EDD spine (RBI, free). Read the **RBI Master Direction – KYC (2016, updated 2024)**. Learn the three tiers of due diligence: - **CDD** — identity, beneficial ownership, purpose of relationship, on every customer. - **EDD** — extra scrutiny for high-risk: PEPs, high-risk geographies, correspondent banking, complex ownership. Triggered by CRR or a red flag. - **Ongoing monitoring** — periodic review, frequency driven by risk band (high-risk yearly, low-risk every 8–10 yrs).

2. Sanctions & PEP screening — the logic. Screening tools (**Refinitiv World-Check**, **Dow Jones Risk & Compliance**, **FircoSoft/Fircosoft Continuity**) hold curated lists: OFAC SDN, UN, EU, UK HMT, MHA India, plus PEP and adverse-media databases. The engine does **fuzzy matching** — phonetic (Soundex/Metaphone), edit-distance, transliteration — so "Mohammed" matches "Muhamad." Your job on a hit: compare **secondary identifiers** (DOB, nationality, passport) to discount false positives. Worked example: an alert fires on customer *Rajesh Kumar* against a World-Check PEP *Rajesh Kumar* — you check DOB (1978 vs 1955) and country (India vs Fiji) → **discount as false positive**, document, close.

3. Transaction monitoring. Engines (**NICE Actimize SAM**, **SAS AML**, **Oracle FCCM/Mantas**, **Quantexa**, **Napier AI**, **ComplyAdvantage**) run **scenarios/rules** against transaction data: structuring (many sub-threshold cash deposits), rapid movement of funds, round-tripping, dormant-then-active accounts. Each hit becomes an **alert** in a queue. **Quantexa** and **Napier** add **entity resolution / network analytics** — linking accounts by shared phone/address/device to surface hidden networks, the "next-gen" pitch vs rule-based legacy. Your workflow: pick up alert → review triggering transactions + customer KYC → decide **clear / escalate to case** → if escalated, investigate and recommend a filing.

4. Case management & filing. Escalated alerts become **cases**. In India, a suspicious transaction goes as an **STR (Suspicious Transaction Report)** to **FIU-IND** (Financial Intelligence Unit) via the **FINnet/FINGate** portal, under the **PMLA 2002**. Also know **CTR** (cash > ₹10 lakh) and **CCR** (counterfeit currency). Globally the equivalent is a **SAR** to FinCEN (US) or the NCA (UK). Learn the **narrative discipline**: who, what, when, how much, why suspicious, what action recommended.

5. Free ways to practise. - **FATF** 40 Recommendations + the India Mutual Evaluation Report (2024) — the global rulebook, free. - **RBI KYC Master Direction** and **FIU-IND** website (STR/CTR formats, red-flag indicators) — free. - **ACAMS** publishes free webinars and a glossary; the **CAMS** certification (~USD 1,995) is the resume gold standard — self-study the syllabus even if you delay the exam. - **ComplyAdvantage** and **Napier** run free blogs/webinars that walk their screens — good for vocabulary. - Build a mock CRR scorecard in Excel (you already know Excel) — weight geography/product/channel/customer, output Low/Med/High.

How it shows up in interviews

Q: "You get a sanctions screening hit on a customer. Walk me through what you do." A: "First I confirm it's a *potential* match, not a confirmed one — screening is fuzzy. I compare secondary identifiers: full name, date of birth, nationality, and any ID numbers against the list entry. If they diverge — different DOB, different country — I discount it as a false positive with a documented rationale and close it. If they align, I don't clear it; I escalate to L2/compliance, freeze or hold the transaction per policy, and it may lead to an STR. The golden rule is never clear a true sanctions hit at analyst level."

Q: "Difference between CDD and EDD, and what triggers EDD?" A: "CDD is the baseline done on every customer — verifying identity, beneficial ownership, and purpose. EDD is deeper scrutiny for higher-risk relationships: source of funds/wealth, senior-management sign-off, more frequent review. It's triggered by the customer risk rating — PEP status, high-risk jurisdiction, correspondent banking, cash-intensive business, or complex/opaque ownership structures."

Q: "What's a false positive and why do they matter in AML?" A: "A false positive is an alert or screening hit that turns out not to be genuinely suspicious. They matter because monitoring systems generate huge volumes — often 90%+ of alerts are false positives — so the operational challenge is tuning scenarios and thresholds to cut noise without missing true risk. That's where entity-resolution tools like Quantexa or Napier add value over pure rules."

ATS keywords to add

KYC, CDD, EDD, AML, sanctions screening, PEP screening, adverse media / negative news, transaction monitoring, Customer Risk Rating (CRR), name screening, false-positive reduction, alert investigation, case management, SAR, STR, CTR, FIU-IND, PMLA, FATF, RBI KYC Master Direction, OFAC, NICE Actimize, SAS AML, Oracle FCCM, Quantexa, Napier AI, ComplyAdvantage, Refinitiv World-Check, Dow Jones Risk & Compliance, FircoSoft, entity resolution, ACAMS / CAMS.

ESG & Sustainability Reporting: BRSR, GRI, TCFD, CSRD

The gap

ESG reporting is one of the fastest-growing 2026 finance asks in India, and it is **completely absent** from the six bundles — they teach Ind AS, Schedule III, GST and modelling, but nothing about the parallel **non-financial disclosure regime** that listed companies, Big-4 assurance teams and rating houses now staff for. This gap is real because the mandate is real: SEBI requires the **top 1,000 listed companies by market cap** to file the **BRSR** (Business Responsibility and Sustainability Report), and from FY24 the **BRSR Core** carries **mandatory reasonable assurance** on a phased basis. A finance grad who can read a BRSR and speak GRI/TCFD is immediately useful to teams that are hiring faster than they can train.

Why companies ask for it

> Real posting (Dentsu Financial Control, Bangalore): finance controllers now own "KPI dashboards" and external-audit support that increasingly extend to sustainability metrics; and across 2026, Big-4 and listed-company teams have opened dedicated **ESG / sustainability reporting** and **ESG assurance** roles.

The hirers cluster into four groups: (1) **Big 4 ESG / sustainability assurance** practices (EY, Deloitte, PwC, KPMG) — the biggest volume, doing BRSR assurance and readiness; (2) **listed-company sustainability / ESG reporting teams** inside the CFO or company-secretary function, who compile the BRSR; (3) **rating & analytics** shops (MSCI ESG, Sustainalytics, CRISIL/CareEdge ESG, ICRA) who score companies; and (4) **consulting / carbon-accounting** advisory. For a commerce/finance background this is a rare *open door* — the field is young, so the barrier is knowledge of the frameworks, not years of experience.

What "proficient" looks like

An employer tests whether you can:

- Explain **what the BRSR is, who must file, and its structure** (9 principles of the NGRBC, three sections).
- Distinguish **BRSR vs BRSR Core** and know what **assurance** means for each.
- Map the **global alphabet soup** — GRI, SASB, TCFD, ISSB (IFRS S1/S2), EU CSRD — and how they relate.
- Understand **Scope 1/2/3 emissions** and basic **carbon accounting** (activity data × emission factor).
- Read an **ESG score** (MSCI, Sustainalytics) and explain what drives it and what **greenwashing** risk looks like.

How to actually learn/do it

1. BRSR — the India core (free, do this first). Download the **SEBI BRSR format** (LODR circular) and one real filed BRSR from a large company (Infosys, Reliance, HUL — all on their investor sites). Learn the structure: - **Section A — General disclosures** (entity details, employees, CSR, holdings). - **Section B — Management & process** (policies mapped to the **9 NGRBC principles** — ethics, product safety, employee wellbeing, stakeholders, human rights, environment, policy advocacy, inclusive growth, consumer value). - **Section C — Principle-wise performance** (the quantitative KPIs — energy, water, emissions, waste, diversity, safety).

2. BRSR Core & assurance. BRSR Core is a subset of ~**9 key ESG attributes** with defined **KPIs and intensity ratios** (e.g. GHG intensity per rupee of turnover) that must carry **reasonable assurance** by an independent assurance provider — phased from the top 150 companies (FY24) widening down the top 1,000. This is what the Big-4 assurance roles execute: gathering evidence, testing data lineage, issuing the assurance statement. Also know **value-chain disclosure** (BRSR Core extends to top upstream/downstream partners).

3. Global frameworks — the map.

Framework	Owner	What it is	Focus
GRI	Global Reporting Initiative	Most-used voluntary standard	Impact on world (double materiality)
SASB	now under ISSB	Industry-specific financial-materiality metrics	Investor-focused
TCFD	FSB (now folded into ISSB)	Climate risk in 4 pillars	Governance/Strategy/Risk/Metrics
ISSB (IFRS S1/S2)	IFRS Foundation	Global baseline; S1 general, S2 climate	Financial materiality
EU CSRD / ESRS	EU	Mandatory EU + large non-EU subsidiaries	Double materiality, assured

Key relationships: **TCFD's four pillars** live on inside **IFRS S2**; **ISSB** is becoming the global baseline that BRSR and CSRD interoperate with; **CSRD** catches Indian companies with material EU operations, so exporters care.

4. Carbon accounting basics. The **GHG Protocol** splits emissions into **Scope 1** (direct — own boilers, vehicles), **Scope 2** (purchased electricity), **Scope 3** (value chain — the biggest and hardest). Core formula: **emissions = activity data × emission factor** (e.g. kWh × grid emission factor from CEA India). Tiny worked example: 1,000,000 kWh grid power × 0.71 tCO_2e/MWh ≈ **710 tCO_2e** Scope 2.

5. Scores & greenwashing. MSCI ESG rates AAA–CCC; **Sustainalytics** gives a *risk* score (lower = better, unmanaged risk). Both are largely **disclosure- and controversy-driven**. **Greenwashing** = claims unsupported by data; SEBI and the ASCI now police it. Learn to spot vague claims ("carbon neutral" with no scope defined, no baseline, no assurance).

6. Free ways to learn + certifications. Free: **SEBI BRSR circulars**, **GRI Standards** (free download), **GHG Protocol** corporate standard, **TCFD final recommendations**, **IFRS S1/S2** basis for conclusions. Certifications that carry weight: **GRI Certified Professional**, **CFA Institute Certificate in ESG Investing** (the strongest single credential for Indian finance grads, ~USD 790), **SASB/FSA credential**, and Big-4 ESG academies. Build a portfolio piece: take one company's BRSR and write a 2-page critique mapping its Section C KPIs to GRI and flagging any greenwashing.

How it shows up in interviews

Q: "What is the BRSR and who has to file it?" A: "The Business Responsibility and Sustainability Report is SEBI's mandatory ESG disclosure for the **top 1,000 listed companies by market capitalisation**, filed as part of the annual report. It's built on the nine NGRBC principles and has three sections — general disclosures, management approach, and principle-wise quantitative performance. A subset called **BRSR Core** — nine key attributes with defined KPIs — requires **reasonable assurance**, phased in from the largest companies."

Q: "Explain Scope 1, 2 and 3 emissions." A: "Scope 1 is direct emissions from sources a company owns or controls — company vehicles, on-site fuel. Scope 2 is indirect from purchased energy, mainly electricity. Scope 3 is all other value-chain emissions — purchased goods, business travel, use of sold products — usually the largest and hardest to measure because it needs supplier data. BRSR Core and ISSB S2 push companies toward Scope 3 disclosure."

Q: "How do GRI, TCFD and ISSB relate?" A: "GRI is impact-focused with double materiality — how the company affects the world. TCFD is climate-specific, structured in four pillars, and has now been absorbed into the ISSB's IFRS S2. ISSB (S1 and S2) is the emerging global baseline focused on financial materiality for investors. In practice companies report against GRI for stakeholders and ISSB/BRSR for regulators and investors, and the frameworks are converging."

ATS keywords to add

BRSR, BRSR Core, SEBI LODR, NGRBC, ESG reporting, sustainability reporting, GRI Standards, SASB, TCFD, ISSB, IFRS S1, IFRS S2, EU CSRD, ESRS, double materiality, GHG Protocol, Scope 1/2/3 emissions, carbon accounting, emission factors, ESG assurance, reasonable assurance, MSCI ESG, Sustainalytics, greenwashing, materiality assessment, CFA Certificate in ESG Investing, GRI Certified Professional.

AI & GenAI in Finance (2026): Copilots, LLMs, Agents, Governance

The gap

The bundles cover "AI & automation" at a general level and teach Python/pandas automation. What they do **not** cover is the **2026 GenAI-in-finance reality** that JDs now explicitly demand: the **Copilots** embedded in the tools you already use (Excel, Power BI, M365), **LLMs** used daily for research, commentary and code, **agentic automation** (Genpact's "AI Gigafactory," Accenture, Citi), the **prompt skill** that separates useful from dangerous output, and — most importantly for a finance role — the **governance, model-risk and hallucination controls** without which no bank lets you touch this. This is the gap because "used ChatGPT" is not a skill; *operating GenAI safely on financial data with controls* is.

Why companies ask for it

> Real posting (Genpact, FP&A/R2R): a company-wide push on **"AI Gigafactory / agentic AI."**
>
> Earlier 2026 JDs: Accenture and Citi emphasise **agentic AI** and GenAI copilots; "multiple 2026 JDs emphasise AI/GenAI and GCC shared-services."

Every finance function is being asked to do more with the same headcount, and GenAI is the lever. The roles that name it: **FP&A analysts** (faster commentary, variance narratives), **R2R/controllers** (reconciliation triage, journal narratives), **transformation / finance-tech** teams building agents, and **GCC delivery** roles where "productivity via AI" is now a KPI. Employers are not looking for prompt engineers — they want finance people who **use these tools competently and know the guardrails.**

What "proficient" looks like

An employer tests whether you can:

- Use **Copilot inside Excel and Power BI** to generate formulas, DAX, summaries and charts from a natural-language ask — and **verify** the output.
- Use an **LLM** to draft variance commentary, write/debug **SQL and DAX**, summarise long documents, and structure analysis — with disciplined prompting.
- Explain **agentic automation** — the difference between a chatbot, a copilot, and an autonomous agent that chains steps and calls tools.
- Articulate **AI governance**: hallucination risk, data-confidentiality rules, human-in-the-loop review, model risk, and why you never paste client data into a public model.

How to actually learn/do it

1. Copilots in the tools you already know. - **Excel Copilot (M365 Copilot):** in a table, open the Copilot pane and type "add a column flagging variances over 10%," "summarise this data," or "suggest a PivotTable." It writes the formula/PivotTable — you **check it**. Great for boilerplate; wrong often enough that verification is mandatory. - **Power BI Copilot:** in the report view, "create a page analysing sales by region," or ask it to

write a DAX measure ("YoY revenue growth %") or **explain an existing measure**. It also drafts narrative summaries of a visual. - **M365 Copilot for finance:** summarise a 40-page board pack, draft an email from a variance table, generate a first-cut PowerPoint from an Excel model. - **Free alternatives:** you don't need a paid Copilot licence to build the skill. Use **ChatGPT / Claude / Gemini free tiers** to draft the same DAX/SQL/formulas, then paste into desktop Power BI / Excel. The skill transfers.

2. LLMs for real finance tasks — with good prompting. The prompt pattern that works: **Role + Context + Task + Format + Constraints.** Worked example for FP&A commentary:

> "You are an FP&A analyst. Here is the Q2 variance table [paste]. Write 4 bullet points of management commentary explaining the biggest drivers of the unfavourable opex variance. Be specific, use the numbers, no speculation beyond the data."

Other daily uses: **write SQL** ("join these two tables, monthly revenue by customer"), **debug DAX**, **explain a regulation** in plain English, **reconciliation triage** (paste two lists, ask for likely mismatches), **build an Excel formula** from a description. Always: **give it the data structure, ask for its assumptions, and verify.**

3. Agentic automation (the 2026 buzzword decoded). - **Chatbot** = answers questions. - **Copilot** = assists inside an app, human drives. - **Agent** = given a goal, it **plans steps, calls tools/APIs, and acts** with limited human checkpoints. Genpact's "AI Gigafactory" and Accenture's agentic pitch mean: an agent that, say, pulls the trial balance, runs reconciliations, drafts the journal, and flags exceptions for a human to approve. You don't have to build these, but you must **explain the concept and where human-in-the-loop sits.** Free way to grasp it: read about **Microsoft Copilot Studio agents** and **LangChain/AutoGen** concepts (no need to code them).

4. Governance, model risk & hallucination controls — the part that gets you hired. This is where finance credibility lives: - **Never paste confidential/client/PII data into a public LLM.** Enterprises use walled deployments (Azure OpenAI, private endpoints) precisely for this. - **Hallucination:** LLMs fabricate plausible numbers and citations. Rule: **the model drafts, the human owns.** Every figure is traced to source. - **Human-in-the-loop:** any agent action with financial impact needs a review/approval gate — tie it to your **SOX/internal-controls** knowledge (four-eyes principle). - **Model risk:** connect to model-validation vocabulary (the Acuity Model Risk JD) — versioning, testing, monitoring for drift, documentation. - **Auditability:** prompts and outputs logged; explainability for regulators.

5. What to put on a resume — honestly. Do **not** write "AI/ML engineer." Do write, truthfully: "Used **Excel/Power BI Copilot** and LLMs to automate variance commentary and DAX/SQL generation, cutting reporting time by X%, with human review controls." Claim *use with judgment*, not model-building.

How it shows up in interviews

Q: "How have you used GenAI in a finance task?" A: "I use it as a fast first-drafter with verification. For monthly reporting I feed the variance table to an LLM with a structured prompt — role, the actual numbers, the format I want — to draft commentary, which I then edit and fact-check against source. I also use it to write and debug DAX and SQL. The productivity gain is real, but I treat every output as a draft I own, never a final answer."

Q: "What are the risks of using LLMs on financial data, and how do you control them?" A: "Three main risks: **confidentiality** — never put client or PII data into a public model, use an enterprise walled deployment; **hallucination** — models invent plausible-but-wrong figures, so every number must trace to source and a human signs off; and **auditability** — in a controlled environment prompts and outputs should be logged. It maps cleanly onto existing SOX controls — the model is like a junior analyst whose work you always review under a four-eyes principle."

Q: "What does 'agentic AI' mean and where's the risk?" A: "An agent is given a goal and autonomously plans and executes steps — calling tools and APIs — rather than just answering. In finance that might be pulling data, running a reconciliation, and drafting journals. The risk is autonomous action without oversight, so the control is human-in-the-loop approval gates on anything with financial impact, plus logging and clear ownership. The value is throughput; the discipline is governance."

ATS keywords to add

GenAI, generative AI, LLM, Microsoft 365 Copilot, Excel Copilot, Power BI Copilot, Copilot Studio, prompt engineering, ChatGPT / Claude / Gemini, Azure OpenAI, agentic AI, AI agents, human-in-the-loop, AI governance, model risk, hallucination controls, responsible AI, RAG (retrieval-augmented generation), finance automation, AI-assisted reporting, natural-language querying, DAX/SQL generation, data confidentiality, auditability.

How GCC/Shared-Services Finance Actually Runs: R2R/P2P/O2C, WD-Close, SLAs, RPA, SOPs

The gap

Most India finance jobs in 2026 sit inside a **GCC** (Global Capability Centre) or **BPO/GBS** (Global Business Services) shared-services centre — Genpact, Accenture, HP, Cromwell, Dentsu, and hundreds of captive centres in Bangalore, Hyderabad, Gurugram, Pune. These run finance as a **factory** organised into *process towers* with *service-level agreements*, *working-day close calendars*, *ticketing queues*, and *desktop procedures*. Your bundles teach the accounting (Ind AS, month-end, reconciliations) but not the **operating model** the accounting runs inside. Interviewers screen hard on this vocabulary because it tells them whether you'll survive the floor from day one.

Why companies ask for it

> Real posting (HP, Bangalore R2R): "R2R, AR & P2P … Ensure compliance with internal & SOX controls … Automate data workflows."
>
> Real posting (Genpact, FP&A/R2R): "Record-to-Report" delivery inside a shared-services engagement, with a company-wide push on "AI Gigafactory / agentic AI."

Every captive and BPO finance role — R2R analyst, P2P/AP specialist, O2C/collections analyst, general-ledger accountant, close lead, process SME, transition manager — is defined by which **tower** it belongs to and which **SLAs** it owns. Get the model and you speak their language in the first five minutes.

What "proficient" looks like

The bar is that you can, unprompted, do the following:

- Name the three core towers and what each **owns end-to-end**.
- Explain a **WD1–WD5+ close calendar** and where a given task lands.
- Distinguish an **SLA** (a promise, e.g. 98% invoices posted in 2 days) from a **KPI** (a measured metric, e.g. days-to-close) and quote a couple of each.
- Describe how **SOP / DTP** documents are structured and why they matter for audit and transition.
- Explain a **transition/migration** (as-is → to-be, knowledge transfer, parallel run, go-live, hypercare).
- Say where **RPA** (UiPath, Automation Anywhere, Blue Prism) and **ticketing** (ServiceNow) fit.

How to actually learn/do it

The three process towers. Memorise these cold.

Tower	Full name	Owns end-to-end	Core sub-processes
R2R	Record-to-Report	The general ledger and the financial statements	Journals, accruals/prepayments, intercompany, fixed assets, bank & balance-sheet **reconciliations**, month-end close, MIS/reporting, SOX
P2P	Procure-to-Pay (a.k.a. Purchase-to-Pay, AP)	Buying and paying suppliers	Requisition → PO → goods receipt → invoice → **3-way match** → payment run → vendor master, aging
O2C	Order-to-Cash (a.k.a. Quote-to-Cash, AR)	Selling and collecting cash	Order → credit check → billing/invoice → **cash application** → collections/dunning → dispute/deduction → DSO

Two supporting towers you should also name: **FP&A** (budget/forecast/variance) and **Treasury** (cash, banking, FX). "Hire-to-Retire" (H2R, payroll) sometimes sits in finance too.

The working-day close calendar. The close is run against *working days*, not calendar dates, so it survives weekends/holidays. WD0 is the last day of the month. A stylised R2R calendar:

Day	Activity
WD1	Sub-ledgers cut off; AP/AR post final invoices; FX rates loaded
WD2	Accruals & prepayments; intercompany matching; fixed-asset depreciation run
WD3	**Balance-sheet reconciliations**; flux/variance analysis
WD4	Review, sign-offs, **commentary** for the BS/close call
WD5	Ledger close, consolidation, MIS pack issued

Learn to answer "what happens on WD2?" instantly — it is a classic screen.

SLAs vs KPIs. Practise a few numbers you can defend: invoice posting SLA 95–98% within 48 hrs; PO-backed invoice touchless rate; close in WD5; unapplied-cash %; DSO/DPO; recon completeness and **aged open items > 90 days**; SLA **green/amber/red** RAG status reported weekly.

SOP / DTP. An SOP (Standard Operating Procedure) is the high-level "what/why"; a **DTP (Desktop Procedure)** is the click-by-click "how" — screenshots of the exact SAP/Oracle screens, T-codes, who approves, what the control is. When work moves to a GCC it *cannot* migrate without DTPs. Free practice: write a one-page DTP for a task you know (e.g. "post a manual accrual journal") with purpose, frequency, inputs, step-by-step screens, control point, and RACI.

Transitions/migrations. The lifecycle: *as-is study → to-be design → Knowledge Transfer (KT) → parallel run/shadow → go-live → hypercare (30–90 days of extra support) → steady state (BAU)*. Deliverables: process maps, DTPs, a **RACI**, a cutover plan. This is the single most valued phrase-set for anyone above analyst.

RPA in finance. You don't need to code a bot, but know the shape. A **UiPath** bot logs into SAP, downloads a report, opens Excel, reformats, and emails it — replacing a "swivel-chair" manual task. Vendors: **UiPath, Automation Anywhere, Blue Prism**. Good candidates: bank-statement download, recon prep, invoice data entry, report distribution. Terms: *attended vs unattended bot, orchestrator, bot runner, human-in-the-loop*. Free practice: the **UiPath Community Edition** and free Academy give a real certificate; build one bot that reads an Excel and writes a summary.

Ticketing & controls. Work arrives as **tickets/cases** in **ServiceNow** (or Jira). Learn queue, priority (P1–P4), SLA clock, and *first-time-right*. Controls: **SOX / J-SOX** control testing, **maker-checker (four-eyes)**, segregation of duties, and the **RCM** (Risk & Control Matrix).

How it shows up in interviews

Q: "Walk me through the P2P process end-to-end and where the key control is." "Requisition raised and approved → PO issued → goods/services received and a GRN posted → supplier invoice arrives → the system performs a **3-way match** of PO, GRN and invoice within tolerance → if matched it's parked for payment, if not it's routed to a resolution queue → payment run releases it, and I update the vendor aging. The critical control is the 3-way match plus **maker-checker** on the payment run, which is a SOX control because it prevents duplicate or fraudulent payments."

Q: "It's WD3 and a balance-sheet recon won't tie — a ₹4 lakh unreconciled item. What do you do?" "I quantify and age it, check whether it's timing (in-transit, unposted accrual) or a genuine difference, trace it to source, and post a correcting or accrual journal with backup. If I can't clear it by cut-off I log it on the recon with an owner and a resolution date, flag it in the WD4 commentary, and escalate anything above the materiality threshold so the BS call isn't surprised."

Q: "What makes a transition successful?" "Complete DTPs and process maps before KT, a proper parallel run so we catch gaps while the retained team still owns it, a clear RACI, defined SLAs from go-live, and a real hypercare window. Success is measured by SLA attainment and error rate reaching steady state without the client re-absorbing work."

ATS keywords to add

Record-to-Report (R2R), Procure-to-Pay (P2P), Order-to-Cash (O2C), General Ledger, month-end close, working-day close calendar (WD1–WD5), balance-sheet reconciliations, three-way match, cash application, DSO/DPO, SLA/KPI management, RAG reporting, SOP/DTP documentation, transitions and migrations, knowledge transfer (KT), hypercare, RACI, Global Capability Centre (GCC), shared services / GBS, RPA (UiPath, Automation Anywhere, Blue Prism), ServiceNow, SOX/J-SOX controls, maker-checker, Risk & Control Matrix (RCM), process improvement, first-time-right.

Treasury & Cash Tech: TMS (Kyriba/SAP TRM), FX Hedging, Liquidity, SWIFT/Settlements

The gap

Your bundles decode *what a treasury role is*; they don't teach the **plumbing** treasury runs on. Corporate and bank treasury JDs in 2026 want the **systems** (a Treasury Management System — Kyriba, SAP TRM, FIS), the **FX-hedging mechanics** (forwards, swaps, and enough **hedge accounting** to survive an audit), **liquidity/cash positioning**, and the **bank connectivity** layer (SWIFT, MT/MX messages, settlements and confirmations). None of that is in DCF/modelling or the treasury career decode — it's operational treasury tech, and it's a gap.

Why companies ask for it

> Real posting (Dentsu, Bangalore Financial Control): "… treasury, Insurance, **Hedging FX exposure** …"
>
> Real posting (Intel, Treasury): "settlements, **TMS/SAP HANA**, KYC/AML, money markets."

Roles: corporate treasury analyst/manager, GCC treasury-ops, bank middle/back office, treasury tech/implementation (Luxoft-style), and FP&A roles that own FX. JPMorgan/Citi/Intel-type treasury desks and every GCC treasury tower expect this.

What "proficient" looks like

You can produce a **daily cash position**, decide a short-term investment or borrowing, explain why a company hedges a specific FX exposure and how a **forward** neutralises it, describe what a **TMS** automates versus spreadsheets, and trace a payment from instruction to settlement via **SWIFT**. You know the vocabulary of **hedge accounting** (cash-flow vs fair-value hedge, hedge effectiveness, OCI) without pretending to be an IFRS-9 specialist.

How to actually learn/do it

The daily cash position. The core treasury deliverable. Pull opening bank balances (via bank portal or SWIFT statement), layer expected inflows (AR collections) and outflows (payroll, AP runs, tax, debt service), and compute the **closing position per currency per bank**. Surplus → invest (money-market fund, fixed deposit, commercial paper); deficit → draw on a revolving credit facility or intercompany loan. Free practice: build a 5-bank, 3-currency cash-position sheet in Excel with an opening balance, dated flows, and a target minimum buffer.

Liquidity structures & the in-house bank. Learn **cash pooling**: *physical/zero-balancing* (funds physically swept to a header account nightly) vs *notional pooling* (balances offset for interest without moving cash). An **in-house bank (IHB)** makes one treasury entity act as banker to all subsidiaries — running **intercompany loans**, netting, and a **payment factory** ("**POBO/COBO**" — payments/collections on behalf of). These are the exact phrases treasury-transformation JDs use.

Treasury Management Systems. A TMS is the system of record for cash, debt, investments, and hedges. Know the leaders and what they do:

TMS	Notes
Kyriba	Cloud market leader — cash management, payments hub, bank connectivity, risk
SAP TRM / S/4HANA Treasury	SAP shops; deep GL integration; "TRM-HANA" in the Intel JD
FIS Quantum / Integrity	Large corporates and banks
ION / Reval, GTreasury	Also common

What a TMS actually does that a spreadsheet can't: auto-imports bank statements, forecasts cash, books and revalues deals, generates **hedge-accounting** entries, connects to banks for payments, and gives an audit trail. Free/low-cost practice: watch vendor product demos and read Kyriba/SAP TRM datasheets so you can *speak the modules* (Cash Management, Payments, FX/Risk, In-House Banking).

FX hedging mechanics. The building blocks:

- **Forward contract** — lock a rate today for a future date. If you'll receive USD 1m in 90 days and fear the rupee strengthening, you *sell USD forward*; the forward rate reflects the interest-rate differential (**forward points**), not a forecast.
- **FX swap** — spot leg + offsetting forward leg; used to roll positions and manage funding across currencies.
- **Option** — right not obligation; pay a premium for downside protection with upside retained.
- **Natural hedge / netting** — offset a USD payable against a USD receivable before hedging the residual.

Tiny worked example: exporter expects **USD 1,000,000 in 90 days**, spot 83.00, 90-day forward 83.60. Selling forward locks ₹8.36 crore regardless of where spot lands. If spot falls to 82.00 at maturity, the hedge saved ₹1.6m versus being unhedged; if spot rises to 84.50, you "lost" upside — but treasury's job is *certainty*, not speculation.

Hedge accounting basics (enough to not fail an audit). Under **IFRS 9 / Ind AS 109**: a **cash-flow hedge** (hedging a forecast transaction) parks the effective portion of the derivative's gain/loss in **OCI** and recycles it to P&L when the hedged item hits; a **fair-value hedge** runs both through P&L. You must document **hedge designation** and test **effectiveness**. You don't need to build the model — you need to say those words correctly.

Money markets. Know the short-end instruments treasury touches: **T-bills, commercial paper (CP), certificates of deposit (CD), repos, money-market funds**, and India's overnight benchmarks — **MIBOR** and the tri-party repo (**TREPS**). Globally, **SOFR** replaced LIBOR.

Bank connectivity & settlements. Payments and statements move over **SWIFT**. Legacy **MT** messages are migrating to **ISO 20022 MX** (the 2025 CBPR+ cutover): **MT103** (single customer payment) → **pacs.008**; **MT202** (bank-to-bank) → **pacs.009**; **MT940/MT942** (end-of-day/intraday statements) feed the TMS. India's rails: **RTGS/NEFT** and **UPI**. **Settlement** = the actual movement of funds on value date; a **confirmation** (via SWIFT or platforms like MarkitWire/DTCC) is the two counterparties agreeing trade terms — the middle/back-office matching step. **Nostro/vostro** accounts and **reconciliation** of them is core back-office work. **Bank Account Management (BAM)** — opening/closing accounts, **KYC** refresh, and maintaining signatories — is increasingly its own JD line.

How it shows up in interviews

Q: "An exporter will receive USD 1m in three months and is worried about the rupee. How do you hedge?" "Sell USD 1m forward for 90 days, which locks the rupee value at the forward rate — spot adjusted for the interest-rate differential. That removes uncertainty; we're not taking a view on direction. I'd first net any USD payables in that window and only hedge the residual exposure, per the hedging policy."

Q: "What does a TMS give you that Excel doesn't?" "Automated bank-statement import via SWIFT, a real-time multi-bank multi-currency cash position, deal capture with revaluation, straight-through payments, auto-generated hedge-accounting entries, and a full audit trail with segregation of duties. Excel breaks on control, scale, and connectivity — exactly what auditors and SOX care about."

Q: "Cash-flow hedge vs fair-value hedge?" "A cash-flow hedge protects a future forecast cash flow — the effective portion sits in OCI and recycles to P&L when the hedged item is recognised. A fair-value hedge protects the value of an existing asset/liability and both sides go through P&L. Either way I document the hedge relationship and test effectiveness under IFRS 9 / Ind AS 109."

Certification

The gold standard is the **CTP (Certified Treasury Professional)** from the AFP — the treasury equivalent of the CFA for corporate treasury, and it's named on senior treasury JDs. **ACT (Association of Corporate Treasurers)** qualifications are the UK/global route. For the tech side, Kyriba and SAP offer product certifications valued by treasury-transformation/implementation employers.

ATS keywords to add

Treasury Management System (TMS), Kyriba, SAP TRM / S/4HANA Treasury, FIS, cash positioning, liquidity management, cash pooling (physical/notional), in-house bank, payment factory (POBO/COBO), intercompany funding, FX hedging, forwards/swaps/options, natural hedge/netting, hedge accounting (IFRS 9 / Ind AS 109), cash-flow hedge, hedge effectiveness, money markets, commercial paper, repo/TREPS, MIBOR/SOFR, SWIFT, ISO 20022, MT103/MT940/pacs.008, RTGS/NEFT, settlements, confirmations, nostro/vostro reconciliation, Bank Account Management (BAM), KYC, CTP.

The Soft Skills JDs Really Test: Business Partnering, Credible Challenge, Exec Comms

The gap

Every senior finance JD lists "business partnering," "stakeholder management," "storytelling," and "commentary" — and candidates skim past them as fluff. They aren't. Above analyst level, these are the **primary screen**: two candidates have identical modelling skills, and the offer goes to the one who can influence a business head, challenge a bad number without a title, and turn a variance into a one-paragraph story an executive acts on. Your bundles teach the analysis; nobody taught you to **land** it. This chapter gives concrete frameworks — not vibes.

Why companies ask for it

> Real posting (Citi, KYC/Controls): expects officers to provide **"credible challenge"** to the business.
>
> Real posting (Dentsu, Bangalore): "Balance-sheet reconciliations & **commentary** for BS calls … KPI dashboards … external audit support."

Roles: FP&A business partner, financial controller, commercial finance, model-risk/2nd-line, and any GCC role that faces the client or a "BS call." "Credible challenge" is now literal regulatory language — 2nd-line functions are *required* to push back, and interviewers test whether you can.

What "proficient" looks like

You can walk into a review with a business owner who outranks you, disagree on their forecast, and leave with them agreeing — without a fight. You write a variance commentary that says **what, so-what, now-what** in three sentences, not a data dump. You can compress a 20-slide analysis into a one-page exec summary and a 4-line email. You can stand in a close/BS call and explain a movement crisply under questioning. That's the bar.

How to actually learn/do it

1. Structure every message top-down — the Pyramid Principle. Barbara Minto's rule: **answer first, then support.** Executives don't want your journey; they want the conclusion, then 3 grouped reasons, then detail on demand. Bad: "In April volumes rose, then FX moved, and after checking the ledger…". Good: "**Margin missed budget by ₹42 lakh, driven by FX (₹30L) and freight (₹12L); both reverse in Q3.**" Practice: take any analysis you've done and rewrite the opener as a single-sentence answer.

2. Frame the setup with SCQA. For any narrative or email opener: **Situation** (agreed context) → **Complication** (what changed/what's wrong) → **Question** (the implicit ask) → **Answer** (your recommendation). Example: "We budgeted 18% EBITDA *(S)*. April came in at 14% *(C)*. Why, and is it structural? *(Q)* It's a one-off FX and freight spike that reverses in Q3; no action needed beyond a hedge review *(A)*." SCQA is how you open a board narrative or a partnering conversation.

3. Apply the "so-what" test to every line. A number is not an insight. "Sales are ₹2 cr below budget" is data. "Sales are ₹2cr below budget *because two enterprise deals slipped to Q3, so full-year guidance still holds but Q2 cash is tight — recommend delaying the capex draw*" is an insight. Rule: if a sentence doesn't change what someone *does*, cut it or add the so-what.

4. Write commentary in the WWW pattern. For variance/BS commentary: **What** moved (quantified) → **Why** (the driver, not the accounting) → **What next** (action/owner/timing). One flux line: "*Accruals up ₹18L MoM — Q1 marketing invoices received late; clears in May, no P&L impact.*" That single line survives an audit and a BS call.

5. Influence without authority — business partnering. You rarely have power over the person whose number you're challenging. Levers: (a) **lead with their goal**, not finance's ("this protects your margin target"); (b) **bring the data, not the verdict** — let the number make the argument; (c) **ask, don't assert** ("help me understand the 20% uplift assumption"); (d) **give them the win** in public, the challenge in private. The mental model: you're the co-pilot who keeps the business owner off the rocks, not the auditor who says no.

6. Credible challenge — the regulated version. In 2nd-line/controls/KYC, "credible challenge" means you must formally question the 1st line and be able to evidence it. Do it with: a specific fact, a named standard or policy, and a documented outcome. "I'm challenging this customer risk rating: the screening flagged adverse media the file doesn't address; policy X requires it be dispositioned before approval; I've logged it and returned the case." That is credible (fact + standard) and it's *challenge* (you stopped the process), and it's recorded.

7. Structure an exec email / one-pager. Format: **subject line = the answer** ("Q2 forecast held at ₹18% despite April miss"); first line = ask/decision needed; then 3 bullets of why; then "detail below/attached." Under 150 words above the fold. Executives read subject + first line and decide whether to read on — earn the rest.

8. Handle the BS-review / close call. These calls interrogate balance-sheet movements. Prep: know your **top 5 movements** by value and their **one-line why**; know your **aged open items** and a resolution date for each; never say "I'll check" for a number you own — bring it. Answer in WWW, pause, and let the reviewer ask down. Composure under questioning *is* the skill being tested.

9. Executive presence. It's mostly three habits: be **concise** (say the headline, stop), be **calm under challenge** (a pushback is a question, not an attack), and **own the number** (don't hedge with "I think maybe"). Practice by summarising any analysis out loud in 30 seconds, answer-first.

Free practice: take last month's P&L or a public company's results, write the 3-sentence CFO commentary and a one-page exec summary; record yourself delivering it in 60 seconds; cut every sentence that fails the so-what test.

How it shows up in interviews

Q: "Tell me about a time you influenced a decision without authority." "The sales head wanted to book a deal in Q2 that hadn't met revenue-recognition criteria. I didn't say 'no' — I framed it around his goal, showed the Ind AS 115 criteria and what would happen if the auditor reversed it mid-year, and proposed recognising it in Q3 when it qualified cleanly. He agreed because I protected *his* credibility, not just the ledger. That's partnering: same outcome, no conflict."

Q: "Your variance report goes to the CFO — how do you structure it?" "Answer first: the one-line headline of the result versus plan. Then the two or three drivers, each quantified with a so-what — is it timing or structural, does it reverse, what's the action. Then detail as an appendix. Pyramid principle: the CFO gets the decision in ten seconds and drills only where they want."

Q: "What does 'credible challenge' mean to you?" "Questioning the first line with evidence, not opinion — a specific fact, the policy or standard it breaches, and a documented outcome. It's credible because it's grounded and it's challenge because it actually changes or stops the process, and it's on the record so the control is demonstrable."

ATS keywords to add

Business partnering, finance business partner, stakeholder management, influence without authority, credible challenge, storytelling with data, executive communication, board/CFO commentary, variance commentary, management commentary, Pyramid Principle, SCQA, executive summary / one-pager, balance-sheet review calls, close-call presentation, cross-functional collaboration, commercial finance, executive presence, data-driven decision support.

The Master Gap Checklist: Certifications & ATS Keywords to Add

This closes the guide. One place to see **every gap × who needs it × your priority**, a **certification decoder**, a **paste-ready ATS keyword bank**, and a **60-day plan** tuned to your profile: MBA-Finance + NISM + trading-desk experience + CA-Inter.

The master gap map

#	Gap (chapter)	Which roles demand it	Priority for YOU
2	**ERP at depth — SAP FICO / S4HANA, Oracle** (T-codes, tables, live posting)	Almost every R2R/P2P/O2C, FP&A, controller role (HP, Genpact, Accenture, Dentsu)	**P1 — do first**
3	**US GAAP + IFRS dual-standard** & SOX/J-SOX controls	HP, Dentsu, Luxoft, all GCC controllership	**P1**
4	**EPM/consolidation — BPC, Hyperion, Anaplan, OneStream**	Dentsu (BPC), Accenture (Hyperion/Anaplan), FP&A	**P2**
5	**Reconciliation & close tooling — Blackline**	Dentsu, most controllership	**P2**
6	**Advanced automation — Alteryx, VBA, Power Automate**	Franklin Templeton, FP&A/FA roles	**P2 — your Python helps**
7	**Regulatory reporting & Basel — AxiomSL, OneSumX, Regnology**	Luxoft, bank finance-tech	P3 (banking only)
8	**Financial-crime — KYC/AML, Actimize, ACAMS, World-Check**	Citi, Luxoft, Intel, all bank ops	**P2 — pairs with NISM**
9	**Market data terminals — Bloomberg, CapIQ, Refinitiv, FactSet**	Street Neon, Acuity, research/IB	**P1 — matches trading desk**
10	**Quant/model risk — VaR, model validation, SAS/R/MATLAB**	Acuity model risk, FRM-track	P3 (specialist)
11	**GCC operating model — R2R/P2P/O2C, WD-close, RPA, SOPs**	*Every* GCC/BPO finance role	**P1 — cheap, universal**
12	**Treasury & cash tech — TMS, FX hedging, SWIFT**	Intel, Dentsu, JPM, treasury towers	**P2 — builds on markets**
13	**Soft skills — partnering, credible challenge, exec comms**	Every role above analyst	**P1 — free, decisive**
—	**AI/GenAI literacy in finance** (agentic AI, copilots)	Genpact "AI Gigafactory", most 2026 JDs	**P1 — the 2026 differentiator**

Read the priority column as *your* sequence, given you already have markets/valuation, Python, and Excel.

Certification decoder for the gaps

Cert	Covers which gap	Cost (INR, approx)	Worth it for you?
SAP FICO (S/4HANA) certification	ERP depth (ch. 2)	₹35k–50k self-paced; more via partner	**Yes** — the single biggest keyword; even a course + sandbox counts
Blackline (free vendor cert / U)	Recon tooling (ch. 5)	Free–low	**Yes** — quick, named on JDs
Alteryx Designer Core	Automation (ch. 6)	Exam ~$0–low; free training	**Yes** — fast, resume-visible
Bloomberg Market Concepts (BMC)	Terminals (ch. 9)	~$149; free at many campuses/libraries	**Yes** — 8–10 hrs, certificate, matches trading background
ACAMS (CAMS)	Fin-crime (ch. 8)	~₹1.1–1.4 lakh	Later — gold standard AML; do after a fin-crime role bite
CTP (Certified Treasury Professional)	Treasury (ch. 12)	~₹1 lakh + AFP membership	Only if you commit to treasury
FRM (GARP)	Quant/risk (ch. 7,10)	~₹1.5–2 lakh full	Strong with your NISM/markets bent; medium-term
ESG / CFA ESG certificate	ESG reporting/BRSR	~₹60–70k	Optional edge; India BRSR is rising
CFA (you may already be eyeing)	Markets/valuation depth	High, multi-year	Long game; complements everything

Rule of thumb: **free/short certs first** (BMC, Blackline, Alteryx Core, UiPath) — they add keywords in weeks. Reserve the ₹1 lakh+ certs (ACAMS, CTP, FRM) for when a specific role stream is chosen.

The big ATS keyword bank (paste-ready, grouped)

Drop the clusters that match your target role into your resume Skills section and LinkedIn.

ERP & core systems: SAP FICO, SAP S/4HANA, SAP FI, SAP CO, Oracle Financials, Oracle Fusion, Workday Financials, T-codes (FB50, FBL3N, F-02, GR55), sub-ledger, chart of accounts.

Standards & controls: US GAAP, IFRS, Ind AS, dual-GAAP reporting, SOX, J-SOX, internal controls, Risk & Control Matrix (RCM), segregation of duties, maker-checker, external audit support.

Close & reconciliation: Record-to-Report (R2R), month-end close, working-day close (WD1–WD5), balance-sheet reconciliations, Blackline, intercompany, flux/variance commentary.

EPM / consolidation / FP&A: SAP BPC, Oracle Hyperion (HFM/Essbase), Anaplan, OneStream, consolidation, budgeting, forecasting, reforecast, driver-based planning, KPI dashboards.

Automation: Alteryx, VBA macros, Power Automate, UiPath, Automation Anywhere, Blue Prism, RPA, Power Query, workflow automation, ServiceNow.

Shared services / GCC: Global Capability Centre (GCC), shared services / GBS, P2P / Procure-to-Pay, O2C / Order-to-Cash, three-way match, cash application, DSO/DPO, SLA/KPI, SOP/DTP, transitions & migrations, knowledge transfer, hypercare, RACI.

Banking reg & risk: regulatory reporting, Basel III/IV, AxiomSL, OneSumX, Regnology, liquidity/capital reporting, VaR, model validation, model risk, SAS, R, MATLAB.

Financial crime: KYC, CDD/EDD, AML, transaction monitoring, sanctions screening, NICE Actimize, World-Check, ComplyAdvantage, customer risk rating, negative news, ACAMS/CAMS.

Market data & research: Bloomberg Terminal, Bloomberg BMC, Capital IQ, Refinitiv Eikon/Workspace, FactSet, financial databases, comps, screening.

Treasury: Treasury Management System (TMS), Kyriba, SAP TRM, FX hedging, forwards/swaps, hedge accounting (IFRS 9/Ind AS 109), cash positioning, liquidity, SWIFT, ISO 20022, settlements, CTP.

Soft / partnering: business partnering, credible challenge, stakeholder management, storytelling with data, executive communication, board/CFO commentary, Pyramid Principle, SCQA.

2026 signal: GenAI in finance, agentic AI, AI-enabled automation, finance copilots, prompt engineering for analysis.

Your 60-day "plug the top gaps" plan

Tuned to MBA-Finance + NISM + trading-desk + CA-Inter — you already own markets, Python, and Excel, so we skip those and buy the highest-leverage keywords fast.

Days 1–15 — universal, free, resume-visible. - Finish **Bloomberg BMC** (8–10 hrs) — certificate + terminal fluency that maps straight to your trading experience. *(ch. 9)* - Memorise the **GCC operating model** cold — towers, WD-close, SLAs, DTP; write one real DTP and one variance commentary in WWW format. *(ch. 11, 13)* - Draft a one-page **exec summary** of any analysis using SCQA + Pyramid; record a 60-second delivery. *(ch. 13)*

Days 16–35 — the P1 ERP + standards keyword. - Start a **SAP FICO / S/4HANA** course with a sandbox; learn 15 core T-codes and post a journal, run FBL3N, do a recon. Put "SAP FICO (in progress)" on the resume honestly. *(ch. 2)* - Do a **US GAAP vs IFRS vs Ind AS** difference sheet (revenue, leases, financial instruments) so you can speak dual-standard. *(ch. 3)* - Knock out **Alteryx Designer Core** free training + exam. *(ch. 6)*

Days 36–50 — pick ONE specialisation stream that fits you. - *If markets/research:* deepen **Capital IQ / Refinitiv**, start **FRM Part 1** reading. *(ch. 9, 10)* - *If banking ops:* do a free **AML/KYC** MOOC, learn the Actimize/World-Check workflow, plan **ACAMS**. Your NISM + trading knowledge makes fin-crime a natural bridge. *(ch. 8)* - *If corporate/GCC finance:* learn **Blackline** recon flow and **SAP BPC** consolidation basics. *(ch. 4, 5)*

Days 51–60 — package and prove. - Rebuild resume + LinkedIn from the **keyword bank** above, matched to 3 target JDs; mirror their exact phrases. - Add one **AI-in-finance** line (a real example: a UiPath bot, or a GenAI-assisted analysis) — the 2026 differentiator. *(ch. 11, intro)* - Prep the interview answers from chapters 11–13 out loud until they're automatic.

Sequence logic: free/fast keywords (BMC, GCC model, exec comms) buy interviews in two weeks; SAP + dual-GAAP is the one paid investment that unlocks the most JDs; then one specialisation makes you *the* candidate for a lane instead of a generalist. You finish 60 days with 4–5 new resume-grade keywords, one certificate in hand, one in progress, and answers rehearsed.

Regulatory & Statutory Reporting (Basel, FATCA, RBI/SEBI)

Hands-On Complete-Knowledge Deep-Dive (India, 2026)

Do-the-task drills: worked examples, entries, interview drills & free practice

Contents

The Regulatory Reporting Landscape

What you'll be able to do

After this chapter you can walk into a reg-reporting interview and correctly answer "who regulates whom, and what do they want filed?" You will be able to draw the four-layer reporting stack (prudential, statistical, transaction, tax), name the actual return/filing that lives in each layer for an Indian bank or NBFC, map the same layer to its global equivalent (US, UK, EU), and explain in one clean sentence why a bank spends crores on this function instead of treating it as a back-office afterthought. You will also know where the jobs are, what they pay in India in 2026, and the certifications that move your CV to the top of the pile.

The essentials

Regulatory reporting is the machinery by which a regulated financial firm proves — on a fixed calendar, in a fixed format — that it is solvent, liquid, honest about its transactions, and compliant with tax-information rules. It is not accounting. Accounting answers "what did we earn?"; reg reporting answers "are you safe, and are you telling the state everything it is entitled to know?"

Who regulates whom in India (2026):

Regulator	Regulates	Core reporting concern
RBI (Reserve Bank of India)	Banks, NBFCs, payment banks, ARCs, AD dealers	Capital, liquidity, asset quality, statistical returns
SEBI	Stock exchanges, brokers, MFs, AIFs, PMS, RIAs, merchant bankers	Investor protection, conduct, systemic risk
IRDAI	Life/general/health insurers, reinsurers, brokers	Solvency margin, policyholder protection
PFRDA	NPS, pension funds, points of presence	Pension corpus safety, subscriber reporting
IFSCA	All financial activity inside GIFT City IFSC	Unified regulator for the IFSC zone

RBI, SEBI, IRDAI, PFRDA and IFSCA sit under a coordinating body, the FSDC (Financial Stability and Development Council), chaired by the Finance Minister. FIU-IND (under the Finance Ministry) is the anti-money-laundering reporting hub — CTRs, STRs, CCRs under the PMLA.

Global counterparts (you'll meet these in any GCC/global bank in India):

Region	Prudential	Markets/conduct	Central bank / statistical
US	Fed (FR Y-9C, FFIEC 031/041 Call Report), OCC	SEC, FINRA, CFTC	Federal Reserve
UK	PRA (COREP/FINREP under UK rules)	FCA	Bank of England
EU	ECB / EBA (COREP, FINREP)	ESMA	ECB, national central banks

The four-layer reporting stack — memorise this; it is the spine of the whole domain:

1. **Prudential** — capital adequacy and liquidity. "Are you strong enough to absorb losses?" Basel III/IV: CAR, CET1, LCR, NSFR, leverage ratio. Filed to RBI (in India), reported via COREP in Europe.
2. **Statistical / supervisory** — granular data the central bank uses to run monetary policy and supervise. RBI's DSB returns, ADF (Automated Data Flow), sectoral credit, BSR (Basic Statistical Returns), CRR/SLR maintenance.
3. **Transaction reporting** — trade-by-trade or account-by-account feeds. Securities transactions (MiFID II / EMIR in EU, CReMS/trade repositories in India), CRILC for large credit exposures, FIU CTR/STR.
4. **Tax information reporting** — FATCA (US), CRS (OECD), TDS/TCS statements, GST returns, SFT (Statement of Financial Transactions, Form 61A).

A single instrument touches several layers at once. A ₹50 crore term loan to a corporate hits prudential (RWA/capital), statistical (sectoral credit return), transaction (CRILC if aggregate exposure ≥ ₹5 crore), and tax (interest TDS). That overlap is precisely why the function is hard and well-paid.

Hands-on — step by step

Let's build the mental model with a worked mini-example: a small commercial bank, "Meridian Bank," with a ₹1,000 crore balance sheet. Trace one week's reporting obligations.

1. **Identify the regulator.** Meridian is a scheduled commercial bank → RBI is primary. Its treasury also deals in G-secs and forex → SEBI/FEMA touchpoints and RBI's FED.
2. **Map each layer to a concrete deliverable.** - Prudential: quarterly CAR/RWA return (RBS/Tranche II data), monthly LCR (Form on liquidity), NSFR quarterly. - Statistical: fortnightly Form A (CRR/SLR — Section 42), monthly sectoral deployment of credit, quarterly BSR. - Transaction: CRILC (large exposures ≥ ₹5 cr, reported quarterly + weekly for SMA-2/default), FIU CTR by 15th of next month. - Tax: quarterly TDS return (26Q), annual SFT (Form 61A) by 31 May, FATCA/CRS by 31 May.
3. **Attach an owner and a deadline to each.** In a real bank this is a "reporting calendar" — a spreadsheet with 200-plus line items, each with regulation reference, frequency, cut-off, maker, checker, and submission portal (RBI's e-Kuber / XBRL / CIMS; SEBI's SI Portal; income-tax reporting portal).
4. **Trace data lineage for one number.** Take LCR's "cash outflows." It pulls retail deposits from the core banking system (CBS), applies run-off factors, and sums. You must be able to say which source table each figure came from — regulators audit lineage.
5. **Reconcile to the GL.** Every prudential number must tie back to the audited general ledger. If RWA-bearing assets in the capital return don't reconcile to loans-and-advances in the balance sheet, the return is wrong.

The output

A regulator does not want prose; it wants a structured file. The finished artefact of this chapter is a **reporting inventory** — the one document every analyst is handed on day one:

```
MERIDIAN BANK — REGULATORY REPORTING INVENTORY (extract)
Layer          | Return           | Regulator | Freq        | Deadline         | Portal
Prudential     | Capital Adequacy | RBI       | Quarterly   | 21 days from qtr| CIMS/XBRL
Prudential     | LCR              | RBI       | Monthly     | 15th next month  | CIMS
Prudential     | NSFR             | RBI       | Quarterly   | 21 days          | CIMS
Statistical    | Form A (CRR/SLR) | RBI       | Fortnightly| 7 days           | e-Kuber
Statistical    | Sectoral credit  | RBI       | Monthly     | 10th next month  | CIMS
Transaction    | CRILC            | RBI       | Qtrly+event| 21 days / weekly| CRILC portal
Tax            | FATCA/CRS        | CBDT/IT   | Annual      | 31 May           | Reporting Portal
Tax            | SFT (61A)        | CBDT/IT   | Annual      | 31 May           | Reporting Portal
AML            | CTR              | FIU-IND   | Monthly     | 15th next month  | FINGATE
```

That inventory, kept current against circulars, IS the job's foundation.

Checks, gotchas & red flags

- **The GL is the source of truth.** Every prudential figure must reconcile to audited financials. A return that doesn't tie to the balance sheet is a finding.
- **Deadlines are statutory, not aspirational.** RBI penalises late/incorrect returns; SEBI issues administrative warnings and fines. "T+21 days" means 21 calendar days, not working days, unless the circular says otherwise — check.
- **One transaction, many returns.** The classic error is treating layers as independent. A loan restructuring changes RWA (prudential), asset classification (CRILC/DSB), and provisioning — update all, not one.
- **Circulars change the rules mid-year.** RBI Master Directions are living documents. The red flag is running last quarter's template without checking for an amending circular.
- **"Nil" is still a return.** Many returns require a nil filing when there's nothing to report; silence is a default.

Interview drill

Q: A retail deposit and a wholesale deposit of the same size — do they hit regulatory reports differently? A: Yes, materially. For LCR, retail/small-business deposits get a low run-off factor (5–10%) because they're "sticky," while unsecured wholesale funding from a financial counterparty gets up to 100% run-off. So the wholesale deposit consumes far more HQLA in the liquidity calculation. For capital they may be identical (deposits aren't risk-weighted assets), but for NSFR the retail deposit gets higher Available Stable Funding weighting. Same rupee value, very different regulatory footprint.

Q: Why do banks spend so heavily on reg reporting instead of automating it once and forgetting it? A: Three reasons. First, the rules change constantly — Basel endgame, RBI Master Direction updates, new FATCA/CRS schemas — so it's a maintenance problem, not a build-once problem. Second, penalties and reputational cost of a wrong return dwarf the cost of doing it well. Third, data lineage: the same number must reconcile across prudential, statistical and tax layers pulled from different systems, and keeping those tied requires ongoing controls, reconciliation, and skilled people.

Learn/practise (free)

- **RBI website → Notifications → Master Directions** (free): read the Master Direction on Financial Statements and the Basel III capital circular. This is the primary source; everything else is commentary.
- **RBI DBIE / CIMS public data portal** (free): browse the actual statistical returns banks file — you'll see the real formats.
- **BIS.org** (free): the Basel Framework consolidated text, searchable, no paywall.
- **SEBI Intermediaries Portal circulars** and **Income-tax Reporting Portal FATCA/CRS guidance notes** (free PDFs).
- Rehearse by building your own reporting inventory (as above) for a fictional bank in Excel, one row per return, sourced from real RBI circulars. This single artefact demonstrates domain fluency better than any certificate.

Career/pay angle (India, 2026): Reg-reporting analysts sit in bank finance, GCC captive centres (JPMorgan, Deutsche, Nomura, UBS in Bengaluru/Mumbai/Pune), and Big-4 risk advisory. Entry analyst: ₹6–11 lakh; 3–5 yr with COREP/Basel exposure: ₹14–24 lakh; AVP/manager: ₹25–45 lakh. The differentiators that raise pay: hands-on COREP/FINREP or RBI ADF experience, Axiom/Vermeg/OneSumX tooling, and the ability to reason about a number's lineage. FRM and the RBI/IIBF certifications help; SQL + a prudential mind help more.

Basel III/IV: Capital & Liquidity (RWA, CAR, CET1, LCR, NSFR)

What you'll be able to do

You will be able to take a simple bank balance sheet and compute, by hand, the four ratios every prudential regulator cares about: the Capital Adequacy Ratio (CAR), the Common Equity Tier 1 (CET1) ratio, the Liquidity Coverage Ratio (LCR), and the Net Stable Funding Ratio (NSFR). You'll know what goes in each capital tier, how risk-weighted assets (RWA) are built, which run-off and haircut factors to apply, and — crucially — what the analyst actually hands over: a capital return and a liquidity return that reconcile to the GL and clear the regulatory minimums.

The essentials

Basel III/IV is the global bank-capital rulebook from the Basel Committee (BIS). India implements it through RBI's Master Circular on Basel III Capital Regulations. "Basel IV" (the 2017 finalisation — output floor, revised standardised approaches for credit/operational risk) is phasing in globally through 2025–2028; RBI is adopting elements progressively.

Capital tiers — capital is ranked by loss-absorbing quality:

Tier	What it is	Loss absorption
CET1 (Common Equity Tier 1)	Paid-up equity + retained earnings + disclosed reserves − regulatory deductions (goodwill, DTA, intangibles)	Highest — first to absorb losses, going concern
AT1 (Additional Tier 1)	Perpetual non-cumulative instruments (e.g. AT1 bonds) with loss-absorption triggers	Going concern
Tier 2	Subordinated debt (min 5-yr), general provisions (capped)	Gone concern — absorbs on liquidation

Total Capital = CET1 + AT1 + Tier 2.

The regulatory minimums (RBI, 2026):

Ratio	Basel min	RBI min (incl. CCB)
CET1	4.5%	5.5% + 2.5% CCB = 8.0%
Tier 1	6.0%	7.0%
Total CAR	8.0%	9.0% + 2.5% CCB = 11.5%
Leverage ratio	3.0%	3.5% (4% for D-SIBs)
LCR	100%	100%
NSFR	100%	100%

CCB = Capital Conservation Buffer. D-SIBs (SBI, HDFC Bank, ICICI) carry an additional surcharge.

RWA — assets weighted by riskiness. Cash and sovereign (G-sec) = 0%; home loans ~35–50%; corporate loans 20–150% by rating; unrated corporate 100%. RWA = Σ(exposure × risk weight). Total RWA = credit RWA + market RWA + operational RWA.

CAR = Total Capital / Total RWA. CET1 ratio = CET1 / Total RWA.

LCR = Stock of HQLA / Total net cash outflows over 30 days ≥ 100%. HQLA: Level 1 (cash, G-secs, at 100% value) and Level 2 (high-grade corporate/covered bonds, haircut, capped). Net outflows = stressed outflows − min(inflows, 75% of outflows).

NSFR = Available Stable Funding / Required Stable Funding ≥ 100%. ASF weights funding by stability (capital 100%, stable retail deposits 95%, wholesale <1yr lower). RSF weights assets by how much stable funding they need to hold (cash 0%, loans >1yr 85–100%).

Hands-on — step by step

Take **Meridian Bank**. Simplified balance sheet (₹ crore):

Assets: Cash 50 · G-secs 200 · Home loans 300 · Corporate loans (unrated) 400 · Fixed assets 50 = **1,000**. Liabilities: Equity (paid-up + reserves) 80 · AT1 bonds 10 · Tier-2 sub-debt 20 · Retail deposits 700 · Wholesale deposits (financial cpty) 190 = **1,000**.

Step 1 — Capital. CET1 = 80 (assume no deductions). AT1 = 10 → Tier 1 = 90. Tier 2 = 20. Total Capital = 110.

Step 2 — Credit RWA. - Cash: 50 × 0% = 0 - G-secs: 200 × 0% = 0 - Home loans: 300 × 35% = 105 - Corporate (unrated): 400 × 100% = 400 - Fixed assets: 50 × 100% = 50 - Credit RWA = **555**. Add market + operational RWA, say 45 → **Total RWA = 600**.

Step 3 — Ratios. - CAR = 110 / 600 = **18.33%** (≥ 11.5% ✓) - CET1 ratio = 80 / 600 = **13.33%** (≥ 8.0% ✓) - Tier 1 = 90 / 600 = 15.0% (✓)

Step 4 — LCR. HQLA = Cash 50 (L1, 100%) + G-secs 200 (L1, 100%) = **250**. Outflows (30-day stress): Retail deposits 700 × 5% = 35; Wholesale 190 × 100% = 190. Total outflows = **225**. Inflows: assume contractual inflows of 40; capped at 75% of outflows = 168, so use 40. Net outflows = 225 − 40 = **185**. LCR = 250 / 185 = **135.1%** (≥ 100% ✓).

Step 5 — NSFR. ASF: Equity+AT1+T2 = 110 × 100% = 110; Retail deposits 700 × 95% = 665; Wholesale <1yr 190 × 0% (or low) = 0. ASF = **775**. RSF: Cash 50 × 0% = 0; G-secs 200 × 5% = 10; Home loans 300 × 65% = 195; Corporate loans 400 × 85% = 340; Fixed assets 50 × 100% = 50. RSF = **595**. NSFR = 775 / 595 = **130.3%** (≥ 100% ✓).

The output

The analyst produces a **capital-and-liquidity dashboard** that goes to the CFO and into the RBI return:

```
MERIDIAN BANK — PRUDENTIAL DASHBOARD (₹ cr)   Q1 FY27
CAPITAL
  CET1                     80      CET1 ratio     13.33%   (min 8.00%)  ✓
  Tier 1                   90      Tier 1 ratio   15.00%   (min 7.00%)  ✓
  Total capital           110      Total CAR      18.33%   (min 11.50%) ✓
  Total RWA               600
    of which credit RWA   555
LIQUIDITY
  HQLA                    250      LCR           135.1%    (min 100%)   ✓
  Net 30-day outflows     185
  ASF                     775      NSFR          130.3%    (min 100%)   ✓
  RSF                     595
Leverage: Tier1 90 / exposure 1000 = 9.0%       (min 3.5%)   ✓
```

Checks, gotchas & red flags

- **CET1 deductions are where errors hide.** Goodwill, intangibles, deferred tax assets that rely on future profitability, and investments in own shares must be deducted from CET1. Forgetting them overstates capital — a serious finding.
- **RWA must reconcile to the balance sheet.** Total exposures feeding credit RWA should tie to gross advances + investments. If they don't, the risk weights are being applied to the wrong base.
- **LCR is a 30-day stress, not a snapshot of today's cash.** Apply run-off factors; don't just count deposits. And remember the inflow cap: inflows can offset at most 75% of outflows, so you always hold some HQLA.
- **HQLA Level 2 caps.** Level 2 assets can't exceed 40% of total HQLA (Level 2B capped at 15%), and carry haircuts (15% for 2A). Loading up on corporate bonds doesn't rescue a weak LCR.
- **NSFR and LCR pull in opposite directions on tenor.** Short wholesale funding is cheap but hurts both ratios. Analysts flag maturity mismatches, not just point ratios.
- **Undrawn commitments create outflows.** Committed credit/liquidity lines generate LCR outflows even though nothing has been drawn — easy to miss.

Interview drill

Q: A bank swaps ₹100 cr of unrated corporate loans for ₹100 cr of G-secs. What happens to CAR and LCR? A: CAR improves: G-secs carry 0% risk weight vs 100% for unrated corporates, so RWA falls by ₹100 cr, raising the ratio (same capital / smaller denominator). LCR also improves: G-secs are Level 1 HQLA at 100% value, so HQLA rises by ₹100 cr while corporate loans weren't HQLA at all. It's a classic "de-risking" trade — but NII (interest income) drops because G-secs yield less than corporate loans. Capital and liquidity strength bought at the cost of profitability.

Q: Why is CET1 more important than Total CAR to a regulator? A: Because CET1 is going-concern, permanent, fully loss-absorbing equity — it protects the bank while it's still operating. Tier 2 only absorbs losses in liquidation (gone-concern), by which point depositors may already be hurt. A bank can have a healthy Total CAR propped up by sub-debt yet a thin CET1, which is fragile. That's why post-2008 Basel III raised the CET1 minimum specifically and made it the binding constraint.

Learn/practise (free)

- **BIS Basel Framework** (bis.org, free): the CAP, LCR (LCR30) and NSFR (NSF) chapters give exact factors — the authoritative source.
- **RBI Master Circular — Basel III Capital Regulations** and the LCR/NSFR Master Directions (free PDFs) for the India-specific weights.
- Build the Meridian model in Excel: one tab for RWA (exposure × risk weight), one for LCR (outflow factors), one for NSFR (ASF/RSF weights). Stress-test it — halve retail deposits, watch LCR break. This is exactly what an analyst does.
- Any listed Indian bank's **Basel III Pillar 3 disclosure** (on its investor-relations page, free) shows a real capital and RWA table — reverse-engineer it against your model.

FATCA, CRS & Cross-Border Reporting

What you'll be able to do

You will be able to take a real customer onboarding pack, classify the account holder and the entity, decide whether the account is "reportable," identify the reportable jurisdiction(s), run the due-diligence tests, and assemble the fields that go into the annual reporting file. You'll know the difference between FATCA and CRS, when US withholding bites, and how the Indian rules (Income-tax Rules 114F, 114G, 114H) map onto the global framework. You'll finish with a worked classification of a genuinely tricky entity account.

The essentials

FATCA (Foreign Account Tax Compliance Act, US, 2010) forces non-US financial institutions to identify accounts held by **US persons** and report them — via their local tax authority under an Inter-Governmental Agreement (IGA) — to the IRS. India signed a Model 1 IGA: Indian FIs report to the CBDT, which passes data to the IRS. Non-compliance risks 30% US withholding on US-source income.

CRS (Common Reporting Standard, OECD, 2014) is the multilateral cousin — over 100 jurisdictions automatically exchange financial-account information about each other's tax residents. There is no single "CRS country"; you report an account to *every* jurisdiction where the holder is tax-resident (other than India). No withholding mechanism — it's pure information exchange.

Feature	FATCA	CRS
Origin	US law	OECD multilateral
Who's reported	US persons	Tax residents of any partner jurisdiction
Threshold	Pre-existing individual accounts < US$50,000 may be exempt	No de-minimis for new accounts; limited for pre-existing
Enforcement	30% withholding	Peer pressure / local penalties
India rule	Rule 114F–H	Rule 114F–H (same machinery)

India's legal hook: Income-tax Rules **114F** (definitions — Financial Institution, Financial Account, Reportable Account), **114G** (information to be maintained and reported — Form 61B), **114H** (due-diligence procedures). Reporting Financial Institutions file **Form 61B** annually by **31 May** on the income-tax Reporting Portal.

Entity classification is the hard part. Every account holder is either an **individual** or an **entity**. Entities split into: - **Financial Institutions (FIs):** depository, custodial, investment entity, or specified insurance company. Generally not reportable themselves (they report their own accounts). - **Non-Financial Entities (NFEs):** - **Active NFE** — mostly operating business (<50% passive income and <50% passive assets), or listed/govt/etc. Only the entity's own residence matters. - **Passive NFE** — everything else (holding companies, family investment vehicles). Here you must **look through** to the **controlling persons** (typically ≥25% beneficial owners) and test *their* residence.

Due diligence differs by account: - **New accounts:** collect a **self-certification** at onboarding (residence, TIN). Must be reasonable vs other KYC. - **Pre-existing accounts:** apply **indicia** searches — for individuals, look for US/foreign place of birth, address, phone, standing instructions, power of attorney, "hold mail" address. High-value pre-existing accounts get an enhanced relationship-manager enquiry.

Hands-on — step by step

Scenario: "Sunrise Holdings Pvt Ltd" opens a demat + custody account with an Indian broker (a Reporting FI). Onboarding facts: - Sunrise is India-incorporated, unlisted. - 90% of its income last year was dividends and capital gains (it's an investment holding company). - Shareholders: Mr A (India-resident, 40%), Ms B (US citizen resident in Dubai, 35%), a trust (25%) whose settlor is UK-resident.

Step 1 — Is the holder an entity? Yes, Sunrise is an entity, not an individual.

Step 2 — FI or NFE? Sunrise doesn't accept deposits, hold assets for others, or act as an investment manager for clients — it invests its own money. It's an **NFE**, not an FI. (If it were professionally managed by another FI, it could be an "investment entity"; here assume self-managed by directors → NFE.)

Step 3 — Active or Passive NFE? >50% of income is passive (dividends, gains) → **Passive NFE**. This is the trigger to look through.

Step 4 — Identify controlling persons (≥25% or control). - Mr A, 40% — India-resident → not reportable. - Ms B, 35% — US citizen (FATCA person) and Dubai (UAE) tax-resident (CRS) → reportable under **both** FATCA (US) and CRS (UAE). - Trust, 25% — look through to controlling persons of the trust: settlor is UK-resident → **UK is a reportable jurisdiction** under CRS.

Step 5 — Collect self-certifications and TINs. Ms B's US TIN (SSN/ITIN) for FATCA, UAE TIN for CRS; UK settlor's UK UTR. Validate reasonableness against passports/KYC.

Step 6 — Determine account balance / values. Report year-end account balance or value; for custody accounts also gross proceeds and income paid/credited during the year.

Step 7 — Assemble the report. Sunrise's account becomes a reportable account with **three** controlling-person reports: Ms B to the US (FATCA) and to the UAE (CRS), and the UK settlor to the UK (CRS). Mr A generates no report.

The output

The finished artefact is the **Form 61B / CRS-FATCA XML record** (shown here in readable form; the portal ingests schema-validated XML):

```
REPORTING FI: Sunrise's Broker (GIIN: XXXXXX.99999.SL.356)  Period: CY2025
ACCOUNT: Custody A/C 356-Sunrise Holdings Pvt Ltd
  Account Holder: Sunrise Holdings Pvt Ltd — Passive NFE
  Year-end balance: INR 4,20,00,000
  Controlling Person 1: Ms B
     Residence: US (FATCA) + AE/UAE (CRS)
     US TIN: 123-45-6789 | UAE TIN: 784-xxxx
     Reportable to: IRS (via CBDT), UAE tax authority
  Controlling Person 2: Trust — look-through settlor
     Residence: GB (UK)  | UK TIN (UTR): 1234567890
     Reportable to: HMRC (via CBDT)
  Controlling Person 3: Mr A — IN resident — NOT reported
  Payments during year: Dividends INR 22,00,000; Gross proceeds INR 1,10,00,000
```

The broker submits Form 61B by 31 May; CBDT routes each controlling-person record to the correct foreign authority.

Checks, gotchas & red flags

- **US citizenship = US person regardless of where they live.** Ms B lives in Dubai but her US citizenship makes her FATCA-reportable. This is the single most-missed rule.
- **Passive NFE ⇒ look through.** The commonest error is reporting only the entity's residence (India) and stopping. If it's a passive NFE, you must test the controlling persons — that's the whole point.
- **A person can be reportable to multiple jurisdictions.** Dual residence/citizenship means multiple records for the same person. Don't deduplicate away a valid second jurisdiction.
- **Self-certification must be reasonable.** If KYC shows a US birthplace but the self-cert says "no US person," you have an unresolved indicium — you cannot just accept the form.
- **Nil reporting is required.** If you have no reportable accounts, you still file a nil statement in India.
- **TIN missing ≠ skip.** Report with a documented reason; don't silently drop the record.
- **Investment entity vs passive NFE.** A professionally-managed investment vehicle in a non-participating jurisdiction can flip classification — check who manages the entity.

Interview drill

Q: An Indian resident holding a US green card opens an account. Reportable? Under what? A: Yes, under FATCA. A green-card holder is a US person for US tax purposes regardless of Indian residence, so the account is FATCA-reportable to the IRS via CBDT. It's generally not CRS-reportable to the US (the US isn't a CRS participant), and not reportable to any other jurisdiction unless she's also tax-resident elsewhere. So this is a FATCA-only case — a good test of whether you know the US sits outside CRS.

Q: What's the practical difference between an Active and a Passive NFE for reporting? A: For an Active NFE you only care about the entity's own tax residence — if it's India-resident and not otherwise reportable, you're done, no look-through. For a Passive NFE you must identify the controlling persons (typically ≥25% beneficial owners) and test each one's residence/citizenship, then report the account against every reportable controlling person. Misclassifying a passive holding company as active is the way real reporting failures happen, because it suppresses the look-through entirely.

Learn/practise (free)

- **OECD Automatic Exchange Portal** (oecd.org, free): the CRS Standard, the CRS-by-jurisdiction status table, and the official commentary with worked entity-classification examples.
- **IRS FATCA pages** (irs.gov, free): the IGA list, entity classification flowcharts, and the W-8BEN-E / W-9 forms you'll actually collect.
- **Income-tax India Reporting Portal → Resources** (free): the Form 61B schema, the Guidance Note on FATCA and CRS (a genuinely excellent 100-page free PDF with Indian examples), and Rules 114F–H.
- Rehearse by taking five fictional entities (a listed company, a family trust, a holding co, a fund, an individual with a US birthplace) and classifying each end-to-end. Build the decision tree once and the classifications become mechanical.

RBI & SEBI India Returns (Banks, NBFCs, Market Intermediaries)

What you'll be able to do

You will be able to name the returns an Indian bank, NBFC and SEBI-registered intermediary actually file, describe the RBS/DSB/ADF concept that underpins RBI's data collection, explain what CRILC is and when a weekly filing is triggered, and walk through a reg-reporting analyst's real day — from data extraction to maker-checker to portal submission. You'll produce a filled-in return extract and a reporting calendar so the abstractions become concrete.

The essentials

RBI's supervisory architecture. RBI moved from transaction-by-transaction inspection to **RBS — Risk-Based Supervision**, where the bank's own data feeds drive the supervisor's risk assessment. The data plumbing behind it:

- **DSB returns (Off-site Surveillance)** — the "Domestic Statutory and other returns" set that RBI's off-site monitoring uses. These carry capital adequacy, asset quality, large exposures, profitability. Historically named DSB-I, II, III etc.; now largely subsumed under the **RBS Tranche** data collection.
- **ADF (Automated Data Flow)** — RBI's mandate that returns be generated **straight from source systems** (CBS, treasury, GL) with **no manual intervention**, to guarantee data integrity. An ADF-compliant bank pulls the return from a central data repository, not from someone's spreadsheet.
- **CIMS (Centralised Information Management System)** — RBI's current data-receipt platform (successor to XBRL/e-Data), where most returns are now submitted.

Key RBI returns for a bank:

Return	What	Frequency
Form A (Section 42)	CRR/SLR maintenance	Fortnightly
Form VIII	SLR holdings	Monthly
RCA3 / Basel III capital	CAR, RWA, capital tiers	Quarterly
LCR / NSFR / LR	Liquidity & leverage	Monthly/Quarterly
DSB / RBS Tranche	Off-site risk data	Quarterly
CRILC	Large credit exposures	Quarterly + event
SLBC / sectoral credit	Priority-sector, deployment	Monthly/Quarterly
RLC / FTD	Forex, cross-border	Various

CRILC — Central Repository of Information on Large Credits. Banks report every borrower with **aggregate exposure ≥ ₹5 crore** quarterly. Critically, when an account becomes **SMA-2** (principal/interest overdue 61–90 days) or defaults, a **weekly** report is triggered, and RBI shares it across lenders — so no bank can hide a stressed borrower. SMA classification: SMA-0 (1–30 days overdue), SMA-1 (31–60), SMA-2 (61–90); beyond 90 days it's an NPA.

NBFC returns. NBFCs file on RBI's **CIMS/COSMOS** portal depending on layer (RBI's Scale-Based Regulation: Base, Middle, Upper, Top layers). Core returns: **DNBS-01** (financial details, quarterly for deposit-taking/large), **DNBS-02** (prudential norms — CRAR, provisioning), **DNBS-03** (important financial parameters), **DNBS-04A/B** (structural & dynamic liquidity / ALM), **DNBS-10** (statutory auditor certificate, annual), **DNBS-13** (overseas investment). NBFCs also feed CRILC if exposures qualify.

SEBI reporting for market intermediaries:

Entity	Key filings
Stock brokers	Enhanced supervision monthly (client funds/securities), quarterly internal audit, half-yearly net worth
Mutual funds (AMCs)	Monthly portfolio disclosure, half-yearly, risk-o-meter, expense-ratio, scheme reporting to SEBI
AIFs	Quarterly report to SEBI (per category), PPM audit annually, valuation reporting
PMS	Monthly reporting to SEBI, quarterly to clients, APMI reporting
RIAs	Half-yearly reporting, annual compliance audit
Merchant bankers/RTAs	Periodic + event-based (offer documents, complaints — SCORES)

SEBI filings go through the **SEBI Intermediary Portal (SI Portal)**, exchange platforms (NSE/BSE ENIT), and **SCORES** for grievances.

Hands-on — step by step

Task: file a quarter's CRILC for Meridian Bank. Walk the analyst workflow.

1. **Extract.** Pull all borrowers with aggregate fund-based + non-fund-based exposure ≥ ₹5 crore from the CBS as at quarter-end. Say 120 borrowers, total exposure ₹3,400 crore.
2. **Enrich.** For each: outstanding, sanctioned limit, asset classification (Standard/SMA-0/1/2/NPA), days-past-due, and any restructuring flag. Join borrower CIN/PAN for unique identification across banks.
3. **Apply SMA logic.** One borrower, "Zenith Auto," has interest overdue 68 days → **SMA-2**. This flags a **weekly** reporting obligation for Zenith until it cures or turns NPA.
4. **Reconcile.** Total CRILC exposure must tie to the advances subledger. If CRILC shows ₹3,400 cr but the GL advances (for ≥₹5 cr accounts) show ₹3,380 cr, find the ₹20 cr gap *before* filing — usually an unbooked disbursement or an excluded facility type.
5. **Maker-checker.** Maker prepares the return; an independent checker validates classification and totals; both are logged. This is a hard control, not optional.
6. **Submit.** Upload the schema-validated file to the CRILC module on the RBI portal within the deadline (T+21 days for quarterly; the SMA-2 weekly file every Friday).
7. **Archive & audit trail.** Store the submission acknowledgement, the source extract, and the reconciliation. Auditors and RBI inspection will ask for lineage.

A reg-reporting analyst's actual day: morning — run extraction jobs, check overnight data-load failures; mid-morning — reconcile returns to GL, chase breaks with business units; midday — maker-checker sign-offs; afternoon — submit due returns, handle RBI/SEBI queries on prior filings, update the reporting calendar for circular changes; ongoing — improve automation so more returns become ADF-compliant.

The output

The artefact is the **CRILC submission summary + a reporting calendar row**:

```
MERIDIAN BANK — CRILC QUARTERLY SUBMISSION  Q1 FY27
Total borrowers ≥ INR 5 cr:            120
Aggregate exposure:                INR 3,400 cr   (ties to GL advances ✓)
  Standard:                        INR 3,180 cr
  SMA-0/1:                         INR   150 cr
  SMA-2 (weekly trigger):          INR    40 cr   [Zenith Auto — 68 dpd]
  NPA:                             INR    30 cr
Submission: CIMS/CRILC module  |  Ack: CRILC-2027-Q1-004821  |  Filed: T+18 days ✓

REPORTING CALENDAR (extract)
Return    | Freq        | Cut-off      | Deadline    | Maker | Checker | Portal
CRILC     | Qtrly       | Qtr-end      | T+21 days   | R.Nair| S.Iyer  | CIMS
CRILC-wk  | Weekly(SMA2)| Every Friday | Same day    | R.Nair| S.Iyer  | CIMS
Form A    | Fortnightly | Alt Friday   | T+7 days    | K.Rao | S.Iyer  | e-Kuber
```

Checks, gotchas & red flags

- **CRILC ≥ ₹5 crore is aggregate, not per-facility.** A borrower with three ₹2 cr facilities (₹6 cr total) is in scope. Filtering per-facility understates the return.
- **SMA-2 triggers weekly, not quarterly.** Miss the weekly filing and you've breached a specific RBI requirement designed to catch inter-bank stress early.
- **ADF means no manual touch.** If an analyst edits a return in Excel after extraction, it's no longer ADF-compliant and the integrity claim breaks. Fix the source, not the output.
- **Asset classification must be consistent across returns.** The same account can't be Standard in DSB and SMA-2 in CRILC — RBI cross-checks and inconsistency is a red flag.
- **SEBI net-worth/segregation breaches are event-based.** A broker's client-funds shortfall isn't a "wait for month-end" item; enhanced supervision expects prompt reporting.
- **Nil and event returns still count.** Many SEBI/RBI returns require a nil filing; absence is treated as non-filing.
- **Deadlines are calendar days.** "T+21" almost always means calendar, and a portal outage on the last day is your problem, not the regulator's — file early.

Interview drill

Q: What exactly is the ADF mandate and why does RBI insist on it? A: Automated Data Flow requires banks to generate regulatory returns directly from source systems — core banking, treasury, GL — into a central repository and out to RBI, with zero manual intervention. RBI insists because manual, spreadsheet-built returns are error-prone and manipulable; if the number is pulled straight from the transaction system, RBI can trust its integrity and rely on it for risk-based supervision. Practically it means the reg-reporting team's job shifts from "keying numbers" to "building and controlling data pipelines and reconciliations."

Q: A ₹6 crore borrower goes 65 days overdue. Walk me through the CRILC consequence. A: At ≥₹5 cr aggregate the borrower is already in the quarterly CRILC. At 65 days overdue it's SMA-2 (the 61–90 day bucket). SMA-2 triggers a weekly CRILC report every Friday until the account either cures below SMA-2 or slips past 90 days into NPA. RBI shares that SMA-2 status with every other lender to the same borrower, so all banks see the stress simultaneously — that early-warning, no-hiding function is the whole purpose of CRILC.

Learn/practise (free)

- **RBI website → Regulatory Reporting / Master Directions** (free): the CRILC circular, the Scale-Based Regulation framework for NBFCs, and the list of returns with formats.
- **RBI CIMS portal public pages and the "Returns" master list** (free) show the actual return codes (DNBS series, RCA3, Form A).
- **SEBI Intermediaries section + APMI/AMFI circulars** (free) for broker, PMS, AIF and MF reporting formats; the SI Portal user manuals are public.
- Rehearse by downloading a real NBFC's annual report and mapping its disclosures to the DNBS returns that would have produced them; and by building the CRILC extract-reconcile-submit workflow in Excel with dummy data, including the SMA ageing logic (a simple days-past-due formula bucketing into SMA-0/1/2/NPA). That single spreadsheet demonstrates you understand both the rule and the data mechanics.

Reg-Reporting Platforms & Workflow: AxiomSL, OneSumX, Regnology

What you'll be able to do

By the end of this chapter you will be able to walk into an interview for a regulatory-reporting analyst role — the Luxoft / DXC / GCC "Reg Reporting COE" type of job — and talk credibly about **how the reporting platforms actually work end-to-end**: how source data is ingested, mapped to a return template, run through validation rules, reconciled to the general ledger (GL), signed off, and submitted to the regulator (RBI, PRA, EBA, MAS, HKMA, Fed). You'll know the names of the three market-leading engines — **AxiomSL (now part of Adenza / Nasdaq)**, **Wolters Kluwer OneSumW / OneSumX**, and **Regnology (the merged BearingPoint RegTech + Vizor)** — what each does, where they differ, and what an analyst's day on them looks like. You will also understand, honestly, that you **cannot get a personal login** to any of these; they are licensed to banks, so I'll give you the free way to build the exact same muscle.

The essentials

A regulatory reporting platform is essentially a **rules engine sitting on top of a data warehouse**. Its job: take granular bank data, transform it into the line-items a regulator's template demands, prove the numbers are internally consistent, and file them in the required electronic format (XBRL, XML, CSV, or the regulator's proprietary schema).

The three big engines, at a glance:

Platform	Owner (2026)	Strength	Typical filer
AxiomSL ControllerView	Adenza → Nasdaq	Data-integration depth, huge global taxonomy library, transparent lineage	Large global/US banks, foreign-bank branches
OneSumX for Regulatory Reporting	Wolters Kluwer	Regulatory Update Service (WK's own team maintains the rules), Basel/finance integration	European + APAC banks, insurers
Regnology (Rcloud / ABACUS)	Regnology	Strong on EBA/ECB granular reporting, AnaCredit, SaaS/cloud, regulator-side tooling	EU banks, and regulators themselves

Whatever the brand, the pipeline is the **same five stages**:

1. **Ingestion / data sourcing** — pull balances and transactions from the GL, sub-ledgers, risk systems, trade/position stores. Usually a nightly batch of flat files or a data-mart feed loaded to a staging area.
2. **Mapping to templates** — assign each source record to a regulatory line-item using dimensions (product, counterparty type, residual maturity, currency, risk weight, IFRS-9 stage). This is the "classification" step.
3. **Validation rules** — run the regulator's published edit checks (EBA calls them "validation rules", the Fed "edit checks"): intra-form arithmetic, cross-form consistency, sign checks, plausibility ranges.
4. **Reconciliation to GL** — prove the return ties back to audited financials (total assets on the return = balance-sheet total assets).

5. **Sign-off & submission** — four-eyes review, maker-checker, attestation by an accountable person, then filing in the regulator's channel.

The **Regulatory Update Service** concept matters: because rules change every quarter, banks pay the vendor to ship updated taxonomies (e.g. EBA DPM 3.x, RBI's revised ADF/RBS returns) so the analyst maps *once* and the engine applies the new logic.

Hands-on — step by step

Let's carry a small worked example through a OneSumX-style workflow, producing a COREP-style **Own Funds / capital line** and reconciling it. Numbers are ₹ crore for a fictional foreign-bank branch, "Meridian Bank India".

Step 1 — Source the data. The nightly batch lands three staging files: - `GL_BALANCES.csv` — every GL account with a closing balance. - `LOANS.csv` — loan-level: borrower, product, rating, exposure, IFRS-9 stage. - `CAPITAL.csv` — equity, reserves, AT1 instruments.

You load them into the platform's staging schema. In AxiomSL you'd point a "DataSource" object at the file; in OneSumX you use the "Data Integration Layer".

Step 2 — Map to the template. You build (or inherit) a mapping table. Example rows:

Source GL code	Description	Reg line-item	Bucket logic
3001	Paid-up equity	CET1 – Capital instruments	direct
3100	Retained earnings	CET1 – Retained earnings	direct
3400	AT1 perpetual bond	Additional Tier 1	direct
1200-1299	Corporate loans	Credit RWA – Corporates	×100% RW
1300-1399	Retail loans	Credit RWA – Retail	×75% RW

Step 3 — Compute risk-weighted assets and capital. Say the mapped totals are:

- CET1 capital = equity 800 + retained earnings 400 − intangibles 50 = **1,150**
- AT1 = **150** → Tier 1 = 1,300
- Tier 2 (sub-debt + eligible provisions) = **200** → Total capital = **1,500**
- Corporate exposure 6,000 × 100% = 6,000 RWA
- Retail exposure 2,000 × 75% = 1,500 RWA
- Operational + market RWA (given) = 2,500
- **Total RWA = 10,000**

Step 4 — Ratios (the engine fills these cells automatically): - CET1 ratio = 1,150 / 10,000 = **11.50%** - Tier 1 ratio = 1,300 / 10,000 = **13.00%** - Total Capital Ratio (CRAR) = 1,500 / 10,000 = **15.00%**

Step 5 — Run validation rules. The engine fires edit checks such as: - `v0001` : CET1 ≤ Tier 1 ≤ Total capital → 1,150 ≤ 1,300 ≤ 1,500 ✓ - `v0234` : Total RWA = Σ(credit + market + operational) → 6,000+1,500+2,500 = 10,000 ✓ - `v0570` : CRAR ≥ regulatory minimum (RBI 11.5% incl. CCB) → 15.0% ✓

Any failing rule throws a blocking error you must clear before submission.

Step 6 — Reconcile to GL. Pull "total assets" from the return and compare to the trial-balance total assets. Suppose return shows 9,850 but GL shows 9,900 — a **50 crore break**. You drill the lineage: the engine shows the break sits in "other assets", traced to GL account 1950 that was never mapped. You add the mapping row, re-run, break = 0. This drill-down is the platform's killer feature: **data lineage** from the reported cell back to the source transaction.

Step 7 — Sign-off & submit. The preparer (you) marks the return "Ready". A reviewer does four-eyes, checks the variance commentary ("RWA up 300 cr QoQ on new corporate lending"), and approves. The accountable executive attests. The engine generates the **XBRL instance** against the regulator's taxonomy and files it through the channel (for RBI, the CIMS/ADF portal; for EBA, the national competent authority's collection gateway).

The output

The finished artefact is the **validated, reconciled return package**:

```
MERIDIAN BANK INDIA — CAPITAL ADEQUACY RETURN (as at 30-Jun-2026)   ₹ crore
──────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────
CET1 capital ..............................  1,150
Additional Tier 1 .........................    150
Tier 1 capital ............................  1,300
Tier 2 capital ............................    200
TOTAL CAPITAL (eligible) ..................  1,500
Credit risk RWA ...........................  7,500
Market risk RWA ...........................    900
Operational risk RWA ......................  1,600
TOTAL RWA .................................  10,000
──────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────
CET1 ratio ........ 11.50%   Tier 1 ....... 13.00%   CRAR ...... 15.00%
Validation: 412 rules run, 0 failures.  GL recon: NIL break.
Preparer: A.Analyst  Reviewer: B.Manager  Attested: C.CFO  Status: SUBMITTED
```

Attached: variance commentary, validation log, and GL reconciliation showing return total assets = GL total assets = 9,900.

Checks, gotchas & red flags

- **GL must tie exactly.** A return that doesn't reconcile to audited financials is the fastest way to a regulator query. Zero tolerance on the balance-sheet total; document any timing differences.
- **Unmapped accounts** silently drop numbers. Always run a "completeness" check: Σ(mapped source) = Σ(total GL). Any residual = an unmapped bucket.
- **Sign conventions.** Regulators expect provisions/contra-assets in specific signs; a flipped sign passes arithmetic but fails a plausibility rule.
- **Taxonomy version drift.** Filing last quarter's DPM against this quarter's gateway = rejected instance. Confirm the Regulatory Update Service is applied.

- **Manual overrides ("adjustments").** Every top-side journal in the reporting layer needs an audit trail and reviewer sign-off — auditors hunt these.
- **Double counting across returns.** Same exposure feeding CRAR and LCR must be consistent; cross-form validation rules exist precisely to catch this.

Interview drill

Q1. "Walk me through what happens between the GL closing and a return being filed." *Answer:* Nightly the GL and sub-ledgers feed staging; the engine maps each record to reg line-items using product/counterparty/maturity dimensions; it computes the return, runs the regulator's validation rules, and I reconcile the return back to the trial balance. Breaks are drilled via data lineage to source, fixed in mapping, and re-run. Then maker-checker sign-off, attestation, and submission as XBRL/XML through the regulator's channel.

Q2. "You find total assets on the return is 50 crore below the GL. What do you do?" *Answer:* Run the completeness check to locate the bucket, use lineage to drill from the failing cell to source, and I'd expect an unmapped or mis-mapped GL account. I add/correct the mapping, re-run, confirm the break is nil, and document the fix in the recon file — I never plug the difference.

Q3. "What's the difference between AxiomSL and OneSumX in practice?" *Answer:* Both are rules engines with lineage. AxiomSL (now Nasdaq/Adenza) is prized for deep data integration and transparent, user-configurable logic — you can see and change the calc. OneSumX leans on Wolters Kluwer's Regulatory Update Service, where WK's own regulatory team maintains the rule content, so it's more "managed". Regnology is strongest on EBA granular reporting like AnaCredit and is increasingly cloud/SaaS.

Learn/practise (free)

You cannot license these engines personally — they're bank-only. Build the identical skill for free:

- **Rebuild the pipeline in Excel/Power Query + Python.** Take a fake GL CSV, write a mapping table, use `merge` / `XLOOKUP` to classify, compute RWA and ratios, then code the validation rules as boolean asserts and a GL-recon check. This *is* the platform in miniature.
- **Read the actual templates.** EBA "reporting frameworks" (COREP/FINREP) and their **validation rules** lists are published free; download a COREP template and its rules and reproduce the arithmetic.
- **RBI**: read the ADF/RBS return formats and the CIMS documentation on the RBI website; map a sample trial balance to Form A / capital-adequacy return.
- **XBRL**: install the free **Arelle** open-source XBRL processor and validate a sample EBA instance to see taxonomy-based validation first-hand.
- **Vendor learning**: Wolters Kluwer, Nasdaq/Adenza and Regnology publish free webinars, product docs and demo videos — watch them to learn the exact menu/vocabulary ("ControllerView", "Data Integration Layer", "Rcloud").

Reg-Reporting Interview Drills + Calendar & Cheat-Sheet

What you'll be able to do

This chapter turns everything from the reg-reporting module into **exam-ready recall**. After it you'll be able to: compute CAR/CRAR, LCR and NSFR live on a whiteboard with the numbers tying out; explain any major return (COREP, FINREP, LCR, RBI Form A, DSB III) in two clean sentences; describe **data lineage** and why it matters; and rattle off the key ratios, thresholds, return names, filing frequencies and platform vendors without notes. It doubles as a one-page cheat-sheet you can revise the morning of the interview.

The essentials

Interviewers for GCC / Luxoft-type reg-reporting seats test three things: **(1) do the arithmetic** — can you actually compute the ratios; **(2) do you understand the return** — what it captures and why; **(3) do you get the control** — lineage, reconciliation, four-eyes, taxonomy. Below are the drills with model answers, then the cheat-sheet.

Hands-on — step by step (the drills)

Drill 1 — Compute CAR / CRAR

Given: CET1 = ₹1,150 cr, AT1 = ₹150 cr, Tier 2 = ₹200 cr; Credit RWA = 7,500, Market RWA = 900, Operational RWA = 1,600.

Work it: - Tier 1 = CET1 + AT1 = 1,150 + 150 = **1,300** - Total capital = Tier 1 + Tier 2 = 1,300 + 200 = **1,500** - Total RWA = 7,500 + 900 + 1,600 = **10,000** - **CET1 ratio** = 1,150 / 10,000 = **11.50%** - **Tier 1 ratio** = 1,300 / 10,000 = **13.00%** - **CRAR (Total)** = 1,500 / 10,000 = **15.00%**

Say this: "CRAR is total regulatory capital over risk-weighted assets. RBI's minimum is 9%, plus a 2.5% capital-conservation buffer, so effectively **11.5%**; CET1 min is 5.5% + CCB. At 15% CRAR and 11.5% CET1 this bank is comfortably above requirement, with ~3.5% headroom on total capital."

Drill 2 — Compute LCR

Given: HQLA = ₹4,000 cr (all Level 1). Stressed outflows over 30 days: retail deposits 20,000 × 5% = 1,000; operational wholesale 8,000 × 25% = 2,000; non-operational wholesale 5,000 × 40% = 2,000. Stressed inflows: contractual loan inflows 3,000 × 50% = 1,500.

Work it: - Total outflows = 1,000 + 2,000 + 2,000 = **5,000** - Total inflows = **1,500**, capped at 75% of outflows = 3,750 → 1,500 stands - **Net cash outflows** = 5,000 − 1,500 = **3,500** - **LCR** = HQLA / net outflows = 4,000 / 3,500 = **114.3%**

Say this: "LCR ensures 30 days of survival in stress. Minimum is **100%**. At 114% we hold enough HQLA to cover a month of net stressed outflows. Note the **inflow cap at 75% of outflows** — a bank can't rely on more than 75% of outflows being met by inflows, so it must always hold some buffer."

Drill 3 — NSFR (quick)

Given: Available Stable Funding (ASF) = ₹9,000 cr, Required Stable Funding (RSF) = ₹8,200 cr. **NSFR** = ASF/RSF = 9,000/8,200 = **109.8%**, min 100%. Structural, one-year horizon vs LCR's 30-day. Both must be ≥100%.

Drill 4 — Explain a return

Prompt: "What is COREP?" — "COREP (Common Reporting) is the EBA's harmonised prudential return: own funds, capital ratios, credit/market/operational RWA, large exposures, leverage ratio and the LCR/NSFR liquidity templates. Its sister is **FINREP** (Financial Reporting) — IFRS balance-sheet, P&L and asset-quality data. COREP = capital & risk; FINREP = financial statements. Both filed as XBRL against the EBA taxonomy, usually quarterly."

Prompt: "RBI Form A?" — "Form A is the fortnightly return of a bank's liabilities and assets in India used to compute **CRR and SLR** compliance — demand and time liabilities (NDTL) against cash and SLR securities held."

Drill 5 — Explain data lineage

Say this: "Data lineage is the documented path from a reported cell back to the source transaction and system. If a regulator questions 'other assets = 340 cr', lineage lets me drill: reported cell → reg line-item mapping → GL account 1950 → sub-ledger entry → originating trade. It's essential for **reconciliation** (prove the return ties to the GL), **audit** (evidence every number), and **error resolution** (find where a break enters). No lineage = you can't defend a number."

The output

The finished artefact is the cheat-sheet — memorise it:

Key ratios & thresholds (Basel III / RBI 2026)

Ratio	Formula	Minimum
CET1	CET1 capital / RWA	4.5% (RBI 5.5%) + 2.5% CCB
Tier 1	Tier 1 / RWA	6% (RBI 7%)
CRAR / CAR	Total capital / RWA	8% (RBI 9%) + 2.5% CCB → 11.5%
Leverage ratio	Tier 1 / total exposure	3% (RBI 3.5–4%)
LCR	HQLA / 30-day net stressed outflows	≥100%
NSFR	Available SF / Required SF	≥100%
Large exposure	to single counterparty	≤25% of Tier 1

Key returns & who files what

Return	Regulator	Covers	Frequency
COREP	EBA / PRA	Own funds, RWA, LR, LCR, NSFR, large exposures	Quarterly
FINREP	EBA / PRA	IFRS B/S, P&L, asset quality	Quarterly
AnaCredit	ECB	Loan-level credit data	Monthly
FR Y-9C / FFIEC 031	US Fed / FFIEC	Bank holding co. financials / Call Report	Quarterly
Form A	RBI	NDTL for CRR/SLR	Fortnightly
RLC / LCR return	RBI	Liquidity coverage	Monthly
DSB III / RBS	RBI	Risk-based supervision data	Quarterly/Annual
CIMS returns	RBI	Centralised Information Mgmt System filings	Various

Filing calendar (typical)

Frequency	Examples	Timing after period-end
Fortnightly	RBI Form A	~7 days
Monthly	LCR, AnaCredit	~15–30 days
Quarterly	COREP, FINREP, Call Report	~30–45 days
Annual	Pillar 3, RBS	3–6 months

Platforms & vendors

Platform	Vendor (2026)	Note
ControllerView	AxiomSL → Adenza → **Nasdaq**	Deep data integration, configurable logic
OneSumX	**Wolters Kluwer**	Managed Regulatory Update Service
Rcloud / ABACUS	**Regnology**	EBA granular, AnaCredit, cloud/SaaS
Vermeg / AGILE	Vermeg	Also used in EU

The five-stage workflow (one line)

Source → Map → Validate → Reconcile to GL → Sign-off & submit (XBRL).

Checks, gotchas & red flags

- **LCR inflow cap** — always cap inflows at 75% of outflows before dividing.
- **Buffers on top of minimums** — quote 11.5% CRAR (9% + 2.5% CCB) for RBI, not the bare 9%; interviewers listen for the buffer.
- **CET1 ≤ Tier 1 ≤ Total capital** — if your numbers break this ordering you've made an error.
- **Return ties to GL** — if asked about a break, never "plug" it; drill lineage.

- **XBRL taxonomy version** — filing against the wrong DPM/taxonomy = rejection.
- **Don't confuse LCR (30-day, liquidity stress) with NSFR (1-year, structural)** or FINREP (financials) with COREP (capital).

Interview drill

Q1. "A bank's CRAR is 15% but CET1 is only 6%. Is that a problem?" *Answer:* "CET1 at 6% is above the 4.5% Basel minimum but, after the 2.5% CCB, the effective CET1 requirement is ~7% (RBI 8%). So despite a healthy 15% total CRAR, the bank may be **breaching its CET1 buffer** and could face distributable-profit restrictions. Total capital adequacy can mask weak core capital — always look at CET1 separately."

Q2. "Why do regulators want granular / loan-level data like AnaCredit instead of just totals?" *Answer:* "Granular data lets the regulator run its own analytics — concentration, sector risk, IFRS-9 staging — rather than trusting bank-computed aggregates, and it enables consistency checks across banks. It shifts the calculation burden and reduces the room for classification games. The trade-off is far heavier data-quality and lineage demands on the bank."

Q3. "How do you know a return is correct before you submit?" *Answer:* "Three gates: the engine runs the regulator's validation rules with zero blocking failures; the return reconciles exactly to the trial balance/audited financials with any timing differences documented; and four-eyes maker-checker sign-off with variance commentary explaining material QoQ movements. Only then is the XBRL instance generated and filed."

Learn/practise (free)

- **Drill the ratios cold** with random inputs until CAR, LCR and NSFR are reflexive — 10 minutes a day with flashcards.
- **BIS Basel III framework** (bis.org) — the definitive free source for capital and liquidity rules; read the LCR and NSFR standards.
- **EBA reporting frameworks** — download real COREP/FINREP templates and validation-rule lists; reproduce them in Excel.
- **RBI Master Directions** on capital adequacy, LCR and returns — the primary source for the India-specific numbers and forms.
- **Arelle (free XBRL tool)** — validate a sample EBA instance to feel taxonomy-based validation.
- **Mock the interview**: record yourself computing a ratio out loud in under 90 seconds — fluency under time pressure is what actually gets tested.

Financial Crime: AML/KYC/Sanctions/Fraud — Hands-On

Hands-On Complete-Knowledge Deep-Dive (India, 2026)

Do-the-task drills: worked examples, entries, interview drills & free practice

Contents

The AML Framework & Regulation: FATF, PMLA, RBI KYC Direction, 3 Lines of Defence

What you'll be able to do

Explain, from memory, how the global-to-India AML rulebook stacks up — FATF → PMLA → RBI Master Direction — and translate that into an operating model: who does KYC, who owns the risk, who files the STR, and who the regulator holds personally accountable. You'll be able to draw the compliance org chart, name the statutory roles (Principal Officer, Designated Director, MLRO), state the exact reporting timelines to FIU-IND, and answer "walk me through your AML framework" in an interview without reaching for notes. This is the map every AML/GCC compliance analyst is assumed to carry.

The essentials

The money-laundering cycle — three stages:

Stage	What happens	Typical India example
Placement	Dirty cash enters the financial system	Structured cash deposits below ₹50,000 to dodge PAN; buying pre-paid instruments
Layering	Transactions obscure the trail	Shell-company invoicing, round-tripping via Mauritius/Dubai, rapid fund movement across accounts
Integration	"Clean" money re-enters as legitimate wealth	Real-estate purchase, share buy-backs, loans to self

FATF — the Financial Action Task Force (Paris, inter-governmental). It sets **40 Recommendations** (the global AML/CFT/CPF standard, last major revision incorporating virtual assets and beneficial ownership). It does **not** regulate you directly; it evaluates countries via **Mutual Evaluations** and maintains the **grey list** (increased monitoring) and **black list** (Iran, DPRK, Myanmar as of 2026). India underwent its Mutual Evaluation and is a full FATF member; the 2024 assessment placed India in **regular follow-up** — the top-tier outcome. Key Recommendations to know: R.10 (CDD), R.12 (PEPs), R.16 (wire transfers / "travel rule"), R.20 (STR reporting), R.24/25 (beneficial ownership of legal persons/arrangements).

PMLA 2002 — the Prevention of Money Laundering Act is India's primary statute. Section 3 defines the offence; Section 4 sets punishment (rigorous imprisonment 3–7 years, up to 10 for scheduled offences). **Section 12** is the operative compliance obligation: every "reporting entity" (banks, NBFCs, brokers, insurers, payment operators, crypto/VDA providers) must **maintain records, verify identity, identify beneficial owners, and furnish information to FIU-IND**. The **Enforcement Directorate (ED)** investigates and attaches proceeds of crime; **FIU-IND** (Financial Intelligence Unit) receives reports.

Reports to FIU-IND (via the FINnet 2.0 gateway):

Report	Trigger	Timeline
CTR	Cash transactions > ₹10 lakh (or series integrally connected in a month)	15th of following month
STR	Suspicion of ML/TF — **no threshold**	Within 7 working days of establishing suspicion
CCR	Counterfeit currency	15th of following month
NTR	Non-profit org receipts > ₹10 lakh	15th of following month
CBWTR	Cross-border wire transfers > ₹5 lakh	15th of following month

RBI Master Direction – KYC (2016, as amended through 2025) operationalises PMLA for RBI-regulated entities. It mandates a Board-approved **KYC policy** with four pillars: Customer Acceptance Policy, Risk Management, Customer Identification Procedures (CIP), and ongoing **Transaction Monitoring**. It defines **OVDs** (Officially Valid Documents — passport, driving licence, Voter ID, Aadhaar, NREGA card), **V-CIP** (video-KYC), **CKYC** (Central KYC Registry — a 14-digit KYC identifier), and periodic re-KYC cadence (high risk every 2 years, medium 8, low 10).

Risk-Based Approach (RBA) — the spine of modern AML. You don't apply the same friction to everyone; you allocate scrutiny in proportion to risk across four vectors: **customer, product/service, geography, and delivery channel**. Low risk → Simplified Due Diligence; high risk → Enhanced Due Diligence.

Three Lines of Defence (3LoD):

Line	Who	Owns
1st	Business / front office / operations	Owns and manages the risk; does KYC at onboarding, first-level alert review
2nd	Compliance / AML function (MLRO)	Sets policy, independent oversight, files STRs, advises
3rd	Internal Audit	Independent assurance the first two work

External auditors and the regulator sit outside as a notional "4th line."

Roles: The **Principal Officer (PO)** is the PMLA-designated person responsible for filing reports to FIU-IND. The **Designated Director** is Board-level, personally liable under PMLA. Globally the equivalent title is **MLRO** (Money Laundering Reporting Officer) — the person to whom internal suspicion reports flow and who decides whether to file to the FIU. In a GCC you'll often see PO/MLRO combined.

Hands-on — step by step

Scenario: You're building the AML operating model for "Meridian Capital," a new India-based broker-dealer within a GCC.

1. **Register as a reporting entity** with FIU-IND on FINnet 2.0; obtain the entity's registration and set up user credentials for report submission.
2. **Draft the Board-approved KYC/AML policy** covering the four RBI pillars. Get the Board to formally **appoint a Designated Director and a Principal Officer** — record the resolution; these names are filed with FIU-IND.

3. **Map the RBA.** Build a customer-risk model (see Chapter 2), classify products (a margin trading account is higher risk than a cash equity account), tag geographies against FATF grey/black lists and India's own high-risk list.
4. **Wire the 3LoD.** Front office runs onboarding KYC in the system; a 2nd-line AML analyst independently reviews high-risk onboardings and all screening/TM alerts; Internal Audit schedules an annual AML review.
5. **Set the reporting workflow.** Any staff suspicion → internal Suspicious Activity Report → MLRO/PO reviews → decide file/no-file → if file, submit STR on FINnet within **7 working days**, and **do not tip off** the customer (Section 8 / general prohibition; tipping-off is an offence).
6. **Set cadence:** monthly CTR by the 15th; periodic re-KYC per risk band; annual policy refresh and staff training.

Worked timing example: A client deposits ₹4 lakh cash on 3 July, ₹4 lakh on 10 July, ₹3.5 lakh on 20 July into the same account. Individually each is below ₹10 lakh, but they are **integrally connected** and aggregate to ₹11.5 lakh in a calendar month → **CTR triggered**, file by **15 August**. The structuring pattern itself also raises suspicion → assess for **STR** independently.

The output

A one-page **AML Operating Model**:

```
BOARD ── appoints ── Designated Director (personally liable, PMLA)
   │
   └── Principal Officer / MLRO ── files STR/CTR ──► FIU-IND (FINnet 2.0)

LINE 1  Business & Ops      → onboarding KYC, L1 alert review
LINE 2  AML Compliance/MLRO → policy, screening, TM, STR decision
LINE 3  Internal Audit      → independent assurance

RBA lens: Customer × Product × Geography × Channel → Low/Med/High
Reports: CTR ₹10L (15th) | STR no-threshold (7 wd) | CCR | NTR | CBWTR ₹5L
```

Checks, gotchas & red flags

- **STR has NO monetary threshold** — a ₹5,000 transaction can trigger one. Candidates who say "STR above ₹10 lakh" fail instantly; that's the **CTR** threshold.
- **7 working days** for STR vs **15th of next month** for CTR — don't swap them.
- **Tipping-off** the customer that an STR was filed is itself an offence — never tell the client.
- FATF **grey list ≠ black list**: grey = increased monitoring (do EDD), black = countermeasures (India: Iran, DPRK, Myanmar).
- The **Designated Director is personally liable** — this is why AML is a Board matter, not a back-office chore.
- RBA is not an excuse to do *less* — it's proportionate; high-risk customers still need EDD, not a waiver.

Interview drill

Q1: Difference between a CTR and an STR? A CTR is objective and threshold-driven — any cash transaction over ₹10 lakh (or connected series in a month), filed by the 15th of the following month regardless of suspicion. An STR is subjective and threshold-free — filed within 7 working days of forming a suspicion of money laundering or terror financing, at any value. One is a bright-line rule; the other is judgement.

Q2: Explain the three lines of defence and who files the STR. First line is the business — they own the risk and do onboarding KYC and first-level alert review. Second line is AML Compliance, headed by the MLRO/Principal Officer, who sets policy and independently oversees. Third line is Internal Audit, providing assurance. The STR is filed by the Principal Officer/MLRO in the second line — the business flags internally, but only the PO decides and files to FIU-IND.

Q3: What is the risk-based approach and why does FATF mandate it? RBA means allocating AML resources in proportion to assessed risk across customer, product, geography, and channel — Simplified DD for low risk, EDD for high risk. FATF mandates it (R.1) because uniform controls waste resources on low-risk clients while under-scrutinising genuine threats; risk-weighting concentrates scrutiny where laundering is actually likely.

Learn/practise (free)

- **FATF** website — read the 40 Recommendations and India's 2024 Mutual Evaluation Report (free PDFs).
- **FIU-IND** site — the FINnet 2.0 user guides, STR/CTR formats and XML schemas are public; download and read a blank STR to see the actual fields.
- **RBI Master Direction on KYC** — read it end-to-end once; it's the single most-quoted document in Indian AML interviews.
- **PMLA bare act** — Sections 3, 4, 12, and the definition of "reporting entity."
- Free training: ACAMS "Today" articles, the Egmont Group typology papers, and the ICAI/IIBF AML modules. Rehearse by writing the operating-model diagram above from a blank page until it's automatic.

KYC / CDD / EDD Hands-On

What you'll be able to do

Onboard a customer end-to-end: verify identity against Officially Valid Documents, unwind an ownership structure to find the true **beneficial owner (UBO)**, run a **customer risk-rating model** that produces a numeric score and a Low/Medium/High band, know exactly when **Enhanced Due Diligence (EDD)** kicks in, document **source of funds/wealth**, and schedule the next periodic review. You'll carry a worked scoring spreadsheet you can rebuild in Excel in five minutes — the single most useful artefact an AML analyst brings to an interview.

The essentials

KYC vs CDD vs EDD:

Term	What it is
KYC	The whole "Know Your Customer" programme — identify + verify + risk-rate + monitor
CDD	Customer Due Diligence — the standard baseline: identify the customer & UBO, understand purpose/nature, monitor
SDD	Simplified DD — reduced measures for demonstrably low-risk customers (e.g., a salaried resident with a small savings account)
EDD	Enhanced DD — extra scrutiny for high-risk: SoW/SoF evidence, senior sign-off, closer monitoring

CIP (Customer Identification Procedure) for an individual in India: name, address, PAN (mandatory for most financial relationships), and an **OVD** — Aadhaar, passport, driving licence, Voter ID, or NREGA card. **V-CIP** (video KYC) is RBI-permitted for remote onboarding. Records go to the **CKYC Registry** (14-digit KYC Identifier).

Beneficial Owner (UBO) — the natural person who ultimately owns or controls the customer. RBI/PMLA thresholds:

Entity type	UBO threshold (ownership/control)
Company	> 10% shares or controlling interest
Partnership / LLP	> 10% of capital or profits
Trust	Author, trustee, beneficiaries with ≥10% interest, and any controlling person

You must **look through** layers. If Client Ltd is 60% owned by Holdco, and Holdco is 80% owned by Mr X, then Mr X's effective stake = 60% × 80% = **48% > 10% → Mr X is a UBO.**

EDD triggers: PEP (Politically Exposed Person) or their family/close associate; customer from a FATF grey/black-list or high-risk jurisdiction; complex/opaque ownership; correspondent banking; high-risk products (private banking, bearer instruments, crypto); adverse media; non-face-to-face onboarding without adequate controls; unusually large or unexplained wealth.

Source of Funds (SoF) = origin of the specific money in this transaction (salary credit, sale of property, loan). **Source of Wealth (SoW)** = origin of the customer's total net worth (inherited business, decades of professional income). EDD needs both, with evidence (bank statements, sale deed, tax returns, audited accounts).

Periodic review cadence (RBI): High every **2 years**, Medium **8**, Low **10** — or sooner on a trigger event (adverse media, transaction anomaly, PEP status change).

Hands-on — step by step

Case: Onboarding **Sunrise Trading Pvt Ltd** for a broking account.

Step 1 — Identify the entity. Collect Certificate of Incorporation, PAN, GST registration, board resolution authorising account opening, and list of directors/authorised signatories. Verify PAN on the income-tax portal and CIN on the MCA21 master data.

Step 2 — Unwind ownership for UBO. Shareholding: Mr Rao 55%, Meridian Holdings LLP 45%. Meridian LLP profit-share: Mr Rao 30%, Ms Iyer 70%. - Mr Rao effective = 55% + (45% × 30%) = 55% + 13.5% = **68.5% → UBO**. - Ms Iyer effective = 45% × 70% = **31.5% > 10% → UBO**. Record both UBOs, verify each with PAN + OVD, and screen both names (Chapter 3).

Step 3 — Screen. Run entity + both UBOs + directors through sanctions/PEP/adverse-media lists. Assume Ms Iyer returns a **PEP** hit — she's on a state-level statutory board. → **EDD triggered.**

Step 4 — Risk-rate. Build the scoring model. Each factor scored 1 (low) / 2 (med) / 3 (high), multiplied by a weight; sum = weighted score.

Factor	Weight	Assessment	Raw (1-3)	Weighted
Customer type	25%	Pvt Ltd, has a PEP UBO	3	0.75
Geography	20%	India (domestic), no high-risk link	1	0.20
Product/service	20%	Margin trading account	2	0.40
Channel	15%	Non-face-to-face (V-CIP)	2	0.30
Occupation/business	20%	Commodity trading (cash-intensive)	2	0.40
Total	100%			**2.05**

Banding: 1.00–1.66 = Low, 1.67–2.33 = Medium, 2.34–3.00 = High. Score **2.05** → **Medium** by model — **but the PEP UBO is an automatic override to High.** Overrides always beat the arithmetic.

Step 5 — Apply EDD (because High / PEP): obtain **senior management approval** to onboard; document **SoW** (Ms Iyer's wealth from a family textile business — obtain audited accounts + IT returns) and **SoF** (₹50 lakh initial funding traced to Sunrise's audited turnover); set **enhanced transaction monitoring** thresholds; schedule review in **2 years**.

Step 6 — Record & register. File CKYC records, store the UBO declaration, the risk score sheet, EDD approvals, and SoW/SoF evidence in the customer file.

The output

Customer Risk Assessment — Sunrise Trading Pvt Ltd

```
Entity PAN/CIN: verified (MCA21, IT portal)
UBOs: Mr Rao 68.5% (verified, no hits)
      Ms Iyer 31.5% (verified, PEP – state board)
Screening: 1 PEP hit confirmed; no sanctions/adverse media
Model score: 2.05  → model band MEDIUM
Override: PEP UBO → FINAL RATING: HIGH
EDD: Senior approval [signed], SoW [audited a/cs], SoF [turnover trace]
Enhanced TM: ON | Next review: 2 years (Jul 2028)
Decision: ACCEPT with EDD
```

Checks, gotchas & red flags

- **Effective ownership, not direct** — multiply through the chain. Missing an indirect UBO is the classic UBO failure.
- **Overrides beat scores** — a PEP, a sanctions near-match, or a high-risk-country nexus forces High regardless of the weighted number.
- **SoF ≠ SoW.** Confusing them is a frequent interview slip: funds = this money; wealth = overall net worth.
- Don't treat **V-CIP / non-face-to-face** as automatically fine — it's a higher-risk *channel* and scores accordingly.
- **PEP status doesn't mean criminal** — it means higher risk, so EDD, not refusal (unless policy says decline).
- The UBO **10% threshold** is control *or* ownership — someone with 5% shares but a controlling agreement is still a UBO.
- Periodic review is **risk-driven** (2/8/10 yrs) but any trigger event resets it immediately.

Interview drill

Q1: Walk me through identifying the UBO of a company owned by other companies. Start with the immediate shareholder register, then look through each corporate shareholder to the natural persons behind it, multiplying stakes down each chain. Anyone whose *effective* ownership exceeds 10%, or who exercises control by other means (voting agreements, board control), is a UBO. If no natural person meets the threshold, you fall back to the senior managing official. You verify each identified UBO with PAN and an OVD and screen them.

Q2: When does CDD become EDD, and what extra do you actually do? EDD triggers on PEPs and their associates, high-risk jurisdictions, opaque structures, high-risk products, adverse media, or unexplained wealth. The extra measures are: senior management sign-off to onboard/continue, documented and evidenced Source of Wealth and Source of Funds, more frequent review (typically 2-yearly), and tighter transaction-monitoring thresholds.

Q3: Your model scores a client Medium but they're a PEP. Final rating? High. A qualitative override — PEP status, a sanctions nexus, or a high-risk-country link — supersedes the arithmetic score. The model is a floor for scrutiny, not a ceiling; you always take the more conservative outcome and apply EDD.

Learn/practise (free)

- Rebuild the weighted risk model above in **Excel or Google Sheets** — factors, weights, 1-3 scale, SUMPRODUCT, and IF-based banding with a PEP override flag. This is the single best portfolio piece.
- **RBI Master Direction on KYC** — the UBO thresholds, OVD list, and V-CIP rules are all there verbatim.
- **CKYC Registry** and **Wolfsberg Group** CDD/private-banking papers (free) for the global standard.
- Practise UBO look-through with public **MCA21** filings — pick any listed subsidiary and trace it up.
- Free courses: IIBF AML-KYC module, ACAMS free resources, and FATF guidance on PEPs (R.12) and beneficial ownership (R.24/25).

Sanctions & Name Screening

What you'll be able to do

Screen a name against sanctions, PEP and adverse-media lists; understand which lists bind an Indian entity and which bind a global GCC; read a **fuzzy-match** score and decide **true hit vs false positive**; write a clean **alert disposition** with a documented rationale; and know the **escalation path** when a real match surfaces. You'll work a live screening hit end-to-end — the exact task a Level-1 screening analyst does hundreds of times a day.

The essentials

The lists that matter:

List	Owner	Binds whom
OFAC SDN	US Treasury	Anyone touching USD/US persons/US nexus — de facto global
UN Consolidated	UN Security Council	All member states, incl. India (binding under UNSC resolutions)
EU Consolidated	European Union	EU nexus
UK OFSI	UK Treasury	UK nexus
MHA / UAPA lists	India Ministry of Home Affairs	India — designated terrorist individuals/orgs under UAPA
MEA / UNSC 1267	India via UN 1267 Committee	India — Al-Qaida/ISIL/Taliban regime

An India-based GCC serving US/EU clients must screen against **all** of these, not just Indian lists — because the *client's* jurisdiction reaches into your process (extraterritoriality, esp. OFAC).

PEP screening — flags Politically Exposed Persons (heads of state, ministers, senior judiciary/military, SOE executives, senior party officials) plus **family members and close associates (RCAs)**. PEP ≠ sanctioned; it's a risk flag driving EDD (Chapter 2).

Adverse media (negative news) — screening open-source/news for links to fraud, corruption, terrorism, trafficking. Automated tools categorise by crime type and recency.

Screening tools (paid):

Tool	Strength
Refinitiv World-Check One	The market-standard sanctions/PEP/adverse-media database; deep, well-curated records
Dow Jones Risk & Compliance	Strong PEP and adverse-media coverage, state-ownership data
FircoSoft (Accuity/LexisNexis)	Real-time **payment/transaction filtering** engine — screens SWIFT messages inline; strong fuzzy-matching
Bridger / LexisNexis, ComplyAdvantage	Real-time API screening, ComplyAdvantage strong on live data

Fuzzy matching — because names are transliterated, misspelled and reordered, screening can't be exact-match only. Engines use algorithms: **Levenshtein/edit distance**, **Jaro-Winkler**, **Soundex/Metaphone** (phonetic), plus token/n-gram scoring and secondary-identifier matching (DOB, nationality, passport). Each candidate gets a **match score (0–100%)**; a configurable **threshold** (say 85%) decides whether an alert generates. Lower threshold = more alerts = more false positives = fewer missed true hits (fewer false negatives). Tuning this trade-off is the whole game.

Hands-on — step by step

Scenario: You onboard **"Mohammed Ali Rahman"**, DOB 1979, nationality UAE, for a corporate account. Screening fires an alert.

Step 1 — Read the alert. The engine matched the customer to an OFAC SDN entry:

```
Customer:  Mohammed Ali Rahman | DOB 12-03-1979 | UAE
SDN hit:   Muhammad Ali RAHMAN  | DOB 1979       | UAE | SDGT program
Match score: 92%  | Matched on: name (fuzzy) + YOB + nationality
```

Step 2 — Compare identifiers (the "4-eyes" discipline). Don't stop at the name. Check every available secondary identifier: - Name: "Mohammed" vs "Muhammad", "Ali" vs "Ali", "Rahman" vs "RAHMAN" — a classic transliteration variant; phonetically identical. **Not discriminating.** - **DOB**: customer 12-March-1979; SDN "1979" (year only) — **consistent, not contradictory.** - **Nationality**: UAE = UAE — **consistent.** - Passport/ID number: customer has passport ending 4471; SDN record lists a passport ending 4471 → **strong corroboration.**

Step 3 — Decide. Name variant + matching DOB year + matching nationality + **matching passport number** = this is **not** a coincidental namesake. **True positive.**

Step 4 — Act (do NOT onboard / freeze). For a genuine sanctions match: - **Do not proceed** with the account or transaction; **freeze/hold** any funds. - **Escalate immediately** to the MLRO/sanctions officer — sanctions hits bypass normal L1 disposition. - File the required report: in India, report to **FIU-IND** and comply with **UAPA/MHA freezing** obligations; for OFAC nexus, a **blocking report** to OFAC. - **Do not tip off** the customer about the sanctions match/report.

Contrast — a false positive. Same customer, but the SDN record shows DOB 1955, nationality Yemen, different passport. Name matches 92% but **DOB, nationality and passport all contradict** → **false positive**. Disposition: "Name-only fuzzy match; DOB (1979 vs 1955), nationality (UAE vs Yemen) and passport all mismatch. Coincidental namesake. Cleared." Record rationale, close alert, whitelist the pair to suppress future re-alerts on the same entity.

The output

Screening Alert Disposition

```
Alert ID: SCR-2026-04412
Customer: Mohammed Ali Rahman | UAE | DOB 12-Mar-1979 | Passport …4471
List hit: OFAC SDN — Muhammad Ali RAHMAN | SDGT | passport …4471
Score: 92% (name fuzzy + YOB + nationality + passport)

Secondary-ID review:
  Name         MATCH (transliteration variant)
  DOB (year)   MATCH (1979)
  Nationality  MATCH (UAE)
  Passport     MATCH (…4471)  ← decisive

DISPOSITION: TRUE POSITIVE — confirmed sanctions match
ACTION: Account NOT opened; funds blocked; escalated to MLRO;
        blocking/STR filed; customer NOT tipped off.
Analyst: [id]  Reviewer (4-eyes): [id]  Date: 15-Jul-2026
```

Checks, gotchas & red flags

- **Never clear on name alone** — always work the secondary identifiers (DOB, nationality, passport, place).
- **Passport/ID match is decisive** — a matching document number turns a "maybe" into a true positive fast.
- A **year-only DOB** on the list that's consistent with your customer is **not** exculpatory — absence of contradiction ≠ evidence of difference.
- **Sanctions hits escalate immediately** and freeze — they do not sit in a routine L1 queue like a PEP alert.
- **Do not tip off** — freezing/reporting is confidential.
- Threshold tuning is a governed change: lowering it floods false positives, raising it risks **false negatives** (missed true hits) — the dangerous error. Document any change.
- **Whitelisting** must be per specific customer-vs-record pair, time-stamped and reviewed — never a blanket name suppression.
- OFAC's **50% Rule**: an entity ≥50% owned by SDN parties is itself blocked even if not separately listed — screen ownership, not just the named entity.

Interview drill

Q1: You get a 95% name match to an SDN entry. Is it a hit? Not yet — 95% is only the name-similarity score. I compare secondary identifiers: date of birth, nationality, place of birth, and any passport/ID number. If those corroborate (especially a matching passport number), it's a true positive — I stop the transaction, freeze, and escalate to the MLRO. If DOB and nationality clearly contradict, it's a coincidental namesake and I clear it with a documented rationale.

Q2: Which is worse in screening — a false positive or a false negative, and how does threshold setting relate? A false negative — a genuine sanctioned party passing through — is far worse; it's a direct sanctions breach with legal and reputational consequences. False positives are costly in analyst time but safe. Lowering the match threshold reduces false negatives at the cost of more false positives; raising it does the reverse. You tune to keep false negatives near zero while managing false-positive volume, and you document the trade-off.

Q3: An India-based team screens a US client's payment. Which lists apply? All relevant ones: UN and India's MHA/UAPA and UNSC-1267 lists bind us domestically, and because there's a US and USD nexus, OFAC SDN applies extraterritorially; EU/UK lists apply if there's an EU/UK leg. Sanctions screening follows the transaction's jurisdictional touchpoints, not just the screening team's home country.

Learn/practise (free)

- **OFAC Sanctions List Search** (free web tool) — screen real names against the live SDN list and see the record fields.
- **UN Consolidated List**, **EU Consolidated List**, **UK OFSI list**, and India's **MHA UAPA** designated lists — all free downloads; practise manual matching.
- Refinitiv/Dow Jones publish free methodology papers on fuzzy matching and PEP definitions.
- Build a mini screening engine in **Python** (`fuzzywuzzy` / `rapidfuzz`, `jellyfish` for Jaro-Winkler/Soundex) to score a customer list against the OFAC CSV — the best way to *feel* how thresholds behave.
- **Wolfsberg Group** guidance on sanctions screening and the ACAMS sanctions primers (free).

Transaction Monitoring & Tooling (Actimize, SAS, Oracle FCCM, Quantexa, Napier)

What you'll be able to do

Explain how a transaction-monitoring (TM) system turns raw transactions into investigable alerts; name the standard **typologies/scenarios** and the **rules and thresholds** that detect them; know what each major tool is good at; **triage and score an alert**; understand **tuning** and the false-positive problem; and use **network/entity analytics** to see risk a single-account rule misses. You'll work a real alert-triage example to a documented decision — the daily job of a TM investigator.

The essentials

What TM does: ingests transactions (deposits, wires, trades, card activity), runs them against **scenarios** (rules encoding known laundering behaviour), and generates **alerts** when thresholds trip. An analyst triages each alert → close as false positive, or escalate to a **case** → potentially an **STR**.

Core typologies & the rule that catches them:

Typology	Rule logic (illustrative)
Structuring / smurfing	Multiple cash deposits just under ₹10 lakh / ₹50,000 PAN limit within N days
Rapid movement of funds	Credit followed by near-total debit within 24–48h ("pass-through"/flow-through)
Round-tripping	Funds out and back via related parties/jurisdictions
High-risk geography	Wires to/from FATF grey/black-list countries
Unusual for profile	Activity ≫ expected turnover declared at KYC (deviation from peer/self baseline)
Dormant-then-active	Long-inactive account suddenly high-volume
Mule activity	Many inbound credits from unrelated parties, quick cash-out
Trade-based ML	Over/under-invoicing, mismatched shipment values

Rules vs thresholds vs scenarios: a **scenario** is the pattern (e.g., "rapid movement"); the **rule** is the codified logic; the **threshold** is the tunable number (amount, count, days, %). Thresholds are calibrated by segment — a corporate treasury and a retail savings account can't share the same limit.

The tools:

Tool	Best at
NICE Actimize	Market-leading, broad AML suite (SAM for TM, WLF for screening, actone case mgmt); strong out-of-the-box scenarios, widely used in banks/GCCs
SAS AML	Powerful analytics/statistics, strong scenario tuning and ML-based detection; good where data-science depth matters
Oracle FCCM (Mantas)	Enterprise-scale, deeply configurable behaviour-detection scenarios; heavy but very common in large banks
Quantexa	**Entity resolution + network analytics** — connects data into a graph to reveal hidden relationships; contextual, low-false-positive, "big-picture" risk
Napier	Modern, cloud-native, AI-driven; fast deployment, strong for fintechs/mid-tier; configurable rules + ML

Actimize/Oracle/SAS = the incumbents (rule-heavy). Quantexa/Napier = the new wave (network + ML, aiming at the false-positive problem).

The false-positive problem: rules-based TM typically produces **90–98% false positives** — most alerts are legitimate activity. This drives huge analyst cost, so **tuning** (adjusting thresholds via Above/Below-the-Line testing) and **ML risk-scoring** (ranking alerts by probability of being genuine) are central. **Network analytics** cuts false positives by adding context — a lone "large wire" alert looks different once you see the counterparty is a known mule cluster.

Hands-on — step by step

Alert: Account of **"Kiran Textiles"** (KYC: declared annual turnover ₹2 crore, retail garment trader). TM scenario **"High-velocity pass-through"** fires.

Step 1 — Read the alert.

```
Scenario: Rapid movement of funds (pass-through)
Trigger:  Inbound ₹18,50,000 (5 credits) then ₹18,20,000 debited within 36h
Period:   1–3 July 2026 | Alert score: 78/100
```

Step 2 — Gather context (the triage checklist): - **KYC/profile:** declared turnover ₹2 cr/yr ⇒ ~₹16.6 lakh/month expected. This is ₹18.5 lakh in **3 days** — a large deviation. - **Counterparties:** 5 inbound credits from *individuals* (not trade debtors); outbound single wire to a **new payee** in a different state. - **History:** account previously ran ₹3–5 lakh/month steady; this is a spike. - **Cash vs transfer:** all electronic (rules out simple structuring but fits **mule/pass-through**).

Step 3 — Score & hypothesise. Deviation from profile + inbound from unrelated individuals + near-total same-week sweep to a new payee = classic **flow-through / possible mule** pattern. Alert score 78 plus contextual red flags → **escalate to case**, do not auto-close.

Step 4 — Investigate the network. Pull the entity graph: the new outbound payee also receives from **three other flagged accounts** → a **fan-in/fan-out mule ring**. Network analytics converts a single ambiguous alert into a strong typology.

Step 5 — Request info / decide. Raise an RFI to the business for supporting invoices for the ₹18.5 lakh. Inadequate/absent commercial rationale + ring linkage → **file STR** within 7 working days (Chapter 1), continue enhanced monitoring, and consider exit per policy. **Do not tip off.**

Step 6 — Feed back to tuning. Log the disposition. Confirmed-suspicious outcomes validate the scenario; if this segment throws many *false* positives, propose a threshold review (e.g., raise velocity floor for genuine wholesale traders) through governed **ATL/BTL testing** — never ad-hoc.

The output

TM Case Summary — Kiran Textiles

```
Alert: SAM-2026-77120 | Scenario: Rapid movement / pass-through | Score 78
Profile: garment trader, declared ₹2cr/yr (~₹16.6L/mo)
Observed: ₹18.5L in over 3 days (5 unrelated individuals) → ₹18.2L swept
          to new out-of-state payee in 36h
Red flags: profile deviation; unrelated inbound; new payee; near-total sweep
Network: outbound payee linked to 3 other flagged accounts → mule ring
RFI: invoices requested – none provided
DECISION: Escalate → STR filed (7 wd) → enhanced monitoring → exit review
Tuning note: scenario validated; no threshold change for this segment
Investigator: [id] | QA: [id] | 15-Jul-2026
```

Checks, gotchas & red flags

- **An alert is not a conclusion** — it's a question. Investigate against KYC profile before disposing.
- **Profile deviation is the strongest single signal** — always compare activity to declared turnover/expected behaviour.
- **Electronic ≠ clean** — pass-through/mule laundering is all transfers; don't dismiss just because there's no cash.
- **Never auto-close a high-score alert** without documented rationale; equally, don't escalate everything (alert fatigue hides real ones).
- **Tuning is governed** — thresholds change only via ATL/BTL testing with sign-off; silently loosening a rule to cut volume can create **false negatives** (missed laundering) and is an audit finding.
- **Look at the network**, not just the account — mule rings are invisible one account at a time.
- **STR timeline (7 working days)** starts when suspicion is *established*, not when the alert first fires — but don't sit on it.
- **Don't tip off** the customer while investigating or after filing.

Interview drill

Q1: Why do rules-based TM systems generate so many false positives, and how do you reduce them?
Rules are deliberately broad to avoid missing genuine cases, so they flag lots of legitimate activity — typically 90%+ of alerts are false positives. You reduce them by segmenting customers and tuning thresholds per segment via Above/Below-the-Line testing, by layering ML risk-scoring to rank alerts, and by adding

network/entity context so an alert is judged against relationships, not in isolation — which is exactly what tools like Quantexa target.

Q2: Walk me through triaging a "rapid movement of funds" alert. I compare the activity to the customer's KYC profile and expected turnover, examine the counterparties (are inbound credits from known trade parties or unrelated individuals?), check the account's history for deviation, and look at whether funds were swept out almost immediately to a new payee. Then I pull the network to see if counterparties link to other flagged accounts. If there's no commercial rationale and the pattern fits mule/pass-through, I escalate to a case and, if suspicion holds, file an STR — without tipping off.

Q3: What's the risk of tightening thresholds to cut alert volume? False negatives — genuine laundering slipping through undetected, which is a regulatory and reputational failure far worse than false-positive cost. That's why threshold changes go through governed Below-the-Line testing to prove you're not suppressing true alerts, with documentation and sign-off, rather than being tuned informally to make queues smaller.

Learn/practise (free)

- **NICE Actimize, SAS, Oracle FCCM, Quantexa, Napier** all publish free product docs, scenario catalogues and webinars — read a scenario library to learn real rule logic.
- Build a **toy TM engine in Python/SQL**: generate synthetic transactions, code structuring, pass-through and velocity rules with thresholds, and count your own false-positive rate — invaluable intuition.
- **NetworkX** (Python) to build a counterparty graph and visualise a mule ring — mimics entity/network analytics for free.
- **FATF** and **Egmont Group** typology reports — the authoritative source for real laundering patterns to encode.
- **Wolfsberg Group** statement on effective monitoring, and ACAMS/IIBF TM modules for the investigator workflow and STR-writing practice.

Investigations, SAR/STR & Case Management

What you'll be able to do

Take a system-generated AML alert (or a law-enforcement/internal referral), work it end-to-end into a documented investigation, decide whether it is a false positive or a genuine suspicion, and — if suspicious — **draft and file a Suspicious Transaction Report (STR) to FIU-IND** using the FINnet 2.0 portal with a defensible narrative. You'll manage the case inside a case-management system (CMS) with the right evidence, disposition codes, and SLAs, and you'll recognise the three typologies interviewers always test: **structuring, layering, and trade-based money laundering (TBML)**.

The essentials

An **alert** is a machine hit (rule or model). It is *not* suspicion — it is a prompt to look. Investigation is the human process that converts alerts and referrals into a **reasoned disposition**: *close (no further action)*, *escalate/keep monitoring*, or *file an STR*.

India-specific mechanics you must know:

Item	India (PMLA / FIU-IND)
Regulator/intelligence unit	**FIU-IND** (Financial Intelligence Unit – India), under Dept. of Revenue
Governing law	Prevention of Money Laundering Act, 2002 (PMLA) + PML (Maintenance of Records) Rules, 2005
Report type for suspicion	**STR** (Suspicious Transaction Report) — the Indian equivalent of a SAR
Other prescribed reports	CTR (cash > ₹10 lakh/month aggregated), CCR (counterfeit currency), NTR (non-profit), CBWTR (cross-border wire ≥ ₹5 lakh)
Filing timeline	STR **within 7 working days** of a Principal Officer forming suspicion
Portal	**FINnet 2.0** (replaced FINGate); XML/structured upload
"No threshold" rule	STR has **no minimum amount** — an attempted transaction that never completes is still reportable
Tipping-off	Prohibited — you must **not** tell the customer an STR was filed
Record retention	5 years from transaction / end of relationship

"SAR" is the US/UK term (filed to FinCEN / the NCA). The user's roles are India-first, so the deliverable is an **STR**, but interviewers use "SAR" and "STR" interchangeably — know both.

The three exam-critical typologies:

- **Structuring (smurfing):** breaking one large transaction into many small ones to dodge a reporting threshold — e.g. nine cash deposits of ₹95,000 to stay under the ₹10 lakh CTR aggregate and the ₹50,000 PAN/ID trigger.
- **Layering:** the middle stage of laundering — moving placed funds through many accounts, entities, jurisdictions and instruments to break the audit trail.

- **Trade-based ML (TBML):** moving value through trade by **mis-invoicing** — over/under-invoicing, over/under-shipment, multiple invoicing of the same goods, or phantom shipments.

Hands-on — step by step

Worked example. Alert fires on *Ravi Textiles Pvt Ltd*, a current account at a Mumbai branch. Rule: "structuring — multiple sub-threshold cash deposits." Period under review: 1–30 Jun 2026.

Step 1 — Triage and scope. Read the alert. Note the rule logic, the trigger amount, the account, and the look-back window. Set your review period a little wider than the alert (say 90 days) to see pattern vs. one-off.

Step 2 — Pull the evidence. Assemble in the CMS: - KYC/CDD file: incorporation docs, PAN, GST registration, declared business (readymade garments), declared turnover (~₹3 cr/yr), expected cash intensity. - Transaction dump for Mar–Jun 2026. - Prior alerts/STRs on this customer or connected parties. - Adverse-media / sanctions / PEP screening refresh.

Step 3 — Analyse the transactions. In the dump you find, in June alone:

Date	Type	Amount (₹)
03 Jun	Cash deposit	49,000
05 Jun	Cash deposit	48,500
09 Jun	Cash deposit	49,500
14 Jun	Cash deposit	48,000
19 Jun	Cash deposit	49,000
24 Jun	Cash deposit	48,500
26 Jun	Outward RTGS to *Gemstar FZE, Dubai*	2,80,000

Six cash deposits totalling **₹2,92,500**, each just under the ₹50,000 ID/PAN trigger, followed by a near-full sweep out to a UAE entity. Two red flags stacked: **structuring** on the way in, and a **cross-border wire to a free-zone entity** with no trade documents on file — a classic **layering + potential TBML** hop.

Step 4 — Compare to expected behaviour. A garment wholesaler *would* see cash, but you'd expect it deposited in normal lots and paired with supplier payments inside India, GST-matched sales, and inventory. Here the cash is engineered under thresholds and immediately exported to a related-looking overseas party with **no invoice, no bill of lading, no LC**. Behaviour is inconsistent with the declared profile.

Step 5 — Resolve open questions (RFI). Raise a documented Request-For-Information to the relationship manager: source of cash, purpose of the Dubai remittance, supporting trade docs. Suppose the RM returns vague answers and no documents. That *strengthens* suspicion.

Step 6 — Decide. Reasonable grounds to suspect that funds may represent proceeds of crime / value being moved abroad. Disposition = **File STR**. (Had the RM produced genuine invoices and the deposits matched daily till takings, disposition would be **false positive — close with rationale**.)

Step 7 — Draft the narrative. Use the **5W + 1H** discipline and the **who/what/when/where/why-suspicious/what-next** skeleton (see output).

Step 8 — File on FINnet 2.0. Principal Officer reviews, approves, and uploads the STR in the prescribed XML schema through the FINnet 2.0 portal within **7 working days** of forming suspicion. Log the acknowledgement number in the CMS.

Step 9 — Close the case. Record disposition, attach the filed STR and ack, apply post-filing action (enhanced monitoring / exit review), and set a review tickler. **Do not tip off the customer.**

The output

STR narrative (the finished artefact):

> **Subject:** Ravi Textiles Pvt Ltd — Current A/c 0091xxxx1234, Mumbai (Andheri) branch. Director: Mr R. K. Sharma (PAN ABCDE1234F).
>
> **Reason for report / typology:** Structuring of cash deposits followed by an unsupported cross-border remittance — suspected layering / trade-based money laundering.
>
> **Activity (What/When/Where):** Between 03 Jun and 24 Jun 2026, six cash deposits of ₹48,000–₹49,500 (aggregate ₹2,92,500) were made into the account, each individually below the ₹50,000 identity-capture threshold. On 26 Jun 2026, ₹2,80,000 (95.7% of deposits) was remitted by RTGS/SWIFT to Gemstar FZE, a UAE free-zone entity, with **no invoice, shipping or LC documentation** on file.
>
> **Why suspicious:** The deposit pattern is consistent with deliberate structuring to avoid ID/reporting thresholds. The value is not consumed in the declared domestic garment trade but swept overseas to an entity for which no trade nexus is evidenced. On RFI, the customer provided no source-of-funds or purpose documentation. The behaviour is inconsistent with the KYC-declared profile (domestic wholesale, ~₹3 cr turnover).
>
> **Amount involved:** ₹2,92,500 in / ₹2,80,000 out. **Period:** 03–26 Jun 2026.
>
> **Action taken:** STR filed to FIU-IND via FINnet 2.0 (Ack. FINnetXXXXXXXX). Account placed under enhanced monitoring; exit review initiated. No disclosure made to the customer.

Checks, gotchas & red flags

- **Alert ≠ suspicion.** Never file "just because it alerted," and never close without a written rationale — your disposition must survive a regulator's file review.
- **STR has no threshold** and covers **attempted** transactions. A remittance the bank *declined* is still reportable.
- **7 working days** runs from when the Principal Officer forms suspicion, not from the transaction date — don't let cases age in the queue.
- **Tipping-off is an offence.** Keep STR existence out of any customer-facing note or RFI wording.
- **Narrative must stand alone** — a reader with no access to your screens must understand who, what, how much, and why suspicious. Vague ("transactions looked odd") gets rejected in QA.
- **Tie-outs:** amounts in the narrative must equal the transaction schedule; the subject's ID must match KYC; the typology label must match the facts.
- Watch **round-tripping** and **connected parties** — investigate the counterparty, not just your customer.

Interview drill

Q1. Walk me from alert to STR. "Triage and scope the alert; pull KYC and a wider transaction history; analyse behaviour against the customer's expected profile; raise an RFI to close gaps; reach a documented disposition. If suspicion is reasonable, I draft a stand-alone 5W narrative, the Principal Officer approves, and we file to FIU-IND on FINnet 2.0 within 7 working days — no tipping-off, then enhanced monitoring."

Q2. Difference between structuring and layering? "Structuring is *placement-stage* — deliberately breaking transactions below reporting/ID thresholds. Layering is the *next stage* — moving already-placed funds through multiple accounts, entities and jurisdictions to obscure the trail. My worked case had both: sub-₹50,000 cash deposits (structuring) swept to a UAE entity with no trade docs (layering, possibly TBML)."

Q3. What makes a good SAR/STR narrative? "It answers who, what, when, where, how much, and *why it's suspicious*, plus action taken — and it reads coherently without any attachments. Facts and figures tie to the transaction schedule, the typology is named, and speculation is avoided. Regulators judge the file on the narrative."

Learn/practise (free)

- **FIU-IND website** — read the PMLA, PML Rules, and the STR/CTR reporting-format guides; the FINnet 2.0 user manuals are public.
- **FATF typologies reports** and **Egmont Group** case studies — free, and the source of most interview scenarios.
- **Wolfsberg Group** FAQs and the **ACAMS** free resource library / webinars for narrative-writing templates.
- **Practise without a live CMS:** take any anonymised bank-statement CSV, invent a red-flag pattern in Excel, and write the full STR narrative to the skeleton above. Rehearse the 7-day-clock and no-tipping-off rules until they're reflexive.

Financial-Crime Interview Drills + ACAMS & Cheat-Sheet

What you'll be able to do

Walk into an AML/financial-crime interview (analyst, GCC KYC/transaction-monitoring, compliance, treasury-facing) and answer the questions that actually get asked — CDD vs EDD, red-flag case reasoning, why an alert is a false positive, the SAR/STR lifecycle — with crisp, structured answers. You'll also know the **ACAMS/CAMS** certification pathway and its India relevance, and you'll have a one-page cheat-sheet of terms, lists, tools and the SAR process to revise the night before.

The essentials — the ACAMS/CAMS pathway

ACAMS (Association of Certified Anti-Money Laundering Specialists) runs **CAMS** — the most widely-requested AML credential in GCC and Indian bank job posts.

Item	Detail (mid-2026)
Flagship cert	**CAMS** (Certified Anti-Money Laundering Specialist)
Eligibility	Points system: education + AML/related work experience (~40 qualifying credits)
Exam	~120 multiple-choice, 3.5 hrs, computer-based (Pearson VUE) or online-proctored
Cost	~USD 1,000–1,700 (member vs non-member bundle); ACAMS membership ~USD 300/yr
Renewal	Recertify every 3 years via CAMS credits (CPE)
Other ACAMS certs	**CGSS** (sanctions), **CKYCA** (KYC), **CTMA** (transaction monitoring), **CCAS** (crypto)
India-relevant alternatives	**IIBF** AML/KYC certificate (cheap, bank-recognised), NISM, ICA (UK) diplomas

Positioning tip for the user: with MBA-Finance + NISM RA + trading-desk experience, **CKYCA or CTMA** are faster, cheaper wins that map directly to GCC KYC/monitoring roles; **CAMS** is the resume centrepiece to target once you have AML work credits. Mention IIBF as the low-cost India-domestic signal.

Hands-on — interview drills with model answers

Drill 1 — "Explain CDD vs EDD."

> "CDD — Customer Due Diligence — is the baseline every customer gets: verify identity with reliable documents, identify the beneficial owner, understand the nature and purpose of the relationship, and monitor ongoing. **EDD — Enhanced Due Diligence — is CDD-plus for higher-risk customers**: PEPs, high-risk jurisdictions, correspondent banking, complex ownership, or cash-intensive businesses. EDD adds source-of-funds and source-of-wealth verification, senior-management sign-off, and more frequent review. The opposite end is **SDD (simplified)** for low-risk, e.g. a salaried resident with a small savings account. It's a **risk-based approach** — you spend diligence where the risk is."

Drill 2 — "Give me a red-flag case and how you'd handle it."

> "A garment wholesaler makes six cash deposits of ~₹49,000 each in a month — all just under the ₹50,000 ID trigger — then sweeps 95% out to a UAE free-zone entity with no invoice or shipping docs. Red flags: **structuring** on the way in, an **unsupported cross-border wire**, and behaviour inconsistent with the declared profile — signs of layering, possibly trade-based ML. I'd pull KYC and 90 days of history, compare to expected activity, raise an RFI for source-of-funds and trade docs, and if unresolved, escalate to the Principal Officer to file an STR to FIU-IND within 7 working days — no tipping-off, then enhanced monitoring."

Drill 3 — "Why might an alert be a false positive?"

> "Because rule-based monitoring is deliberately over-sensitive — it flags patterns, not intent. A large round-number transfer might be a genuine property purchase; repeated same-amount payments might be a legitimate EMI or salary; a 'new counterparty' alert might just be a customer paying a new but legitimate vendor. It's a false positive when, after review, the activity is **consistent with the customer's KYC profile and supported by documentation** — a salaried customer's ₹5 lakh transfer matched to a home-loan disbursement, say. I'd still document the rationale and close it; and if I see the same benign pattern flooding the queue, I'd recommend **tuning the rule threshold** so analysts spend time on real risk. Typical AML false-positive rates run 90%+, which is exactly why disposition quality and tuning matter."

Drill 4 — "What's the difference between an STR and a CTR?"

> "A **CTR** is threshold-driven and objective — in India, cash transactions aggregating over ₹10 lakh in a month get reported automatically, no suspicion needed. An **STR** is suspicion-driven — any amount, including attempted transactions, when there are reasonable grounds to suspect proceeds of crime. CTR is a filter; STR is a judgement."

Drill 5 — "Walk me through the three stages of money laundering."

> "**Placement** — getting dirty cash into the system (structured deposits, casinos, cash-heavy fronts). **Layering** — moving it through many accounts, entities and jurisdictions to break the trail. **Integration** — bringing it back as apparently clean wealth (property, luxury goods, business investment). Detection is easiest at placement, hardest at integration."

The output — one-page cheat-sheet

Acronyms - AML / CFT — Anti-Money Laundering / Countering Financing of Terrorism - KYC / CDD / EDD / SDD — Know Your Customer / Customer, Enhanced, Simplified Due Diligence - UBO — Ultimate Beneficial Owner (usually ≥10% or ≥25% ownership/control) - PEP — Politically Exposed Person - STR / SAR — Suspicious Transaction / Activity Report - CTR / CCR / NTR / CBWTR — Cash / Counterfeit-currency / Non-profit / Cross-Border-Wire Transaction Report - TBML — Trade-Based Money Laundering - RBA — Risk-Based Approach

Key India facts - Law: **PMLA 2002** + PML (Maintenance of Records) Rules 2005 - Intelligence unit: **FIU-IND**; portal: **FINnet 2.0**; regulator (banks): **RBI Master Direction on KYC** - STR: **any amount, file within 7 working days** of forming suspicion - CTR: cash **> ₹10 lakh/month** aggregated; ID/PAN trigger commonly at **₹50,000** - Record retention: **5 years**; **tipping-off prohibited**

Global bodies & lists - **FATF** — 40 Recommendations, grey/black lists; **Egmont Group** — FIU network - **Wolfsberg Group** — industry standards; **OFAC** (US), **UN**, **EU**, **UK HMT/OFSI**, **MHA/UAPA** (India) — sanctions lists

The three typologies: Structuring · Layering · TBML (mis-invoicing / over-under shipment / phantom shipment)

SAR/STR process (memorise): 1. Alert / referral → **triage & scope** 2. Gather **KYC + transaction history + screening** 3. **Analyse** vs expected profile → raise **RFI** 4. **Disposition:** close (false positive, with rationale) OR escalate 5. If suspicious → draft **5W narrative** → Principal Officer approval 6. **File to FIU-IND on FINnet 2.0** (≤7 working days) 7. **No tipping-off** → enhanced monitoring / exit → record & retain 5 yrs

Tools you may be asked about: Actimize (NICE), SAS AML, Oracle Mantas/FCCM, Verafin, Napier, ComplyAdvantage, Refinitiv World-Check / LSEG, Dow Jones RiskCenter (screening); ServiceNow / bespoke CMS for case management.

Checks, gotchas & red flags

- Don't confuse **STR (suspicion, any amount)** with **CTR (threshold, automatic)** — the single most common slip.
- **EDD is not "more documents for everyone"** — it's triggered by risk; say "risk-based approach" and you signal maturity.
- Naming **tipping-off** and the **7-working-day** clock unprompted marks you as India-fluent.
- For false positives, always add the **tuning** point — interviewers want to hear you improve the system, not just clear the queue.
- Don't overclaim CAMS if you haven't sat it — say "targeting CAMS; CKYCA/IIBF in progress."

Interview drill

Q1. Which AML cert should someone with your background pursue and why? "CAMS is the market standard for GCC and Indian bank compliance roles, but it needs qualifying AML credits. Given my finance and monitoring exposure, I'd start with ACAMS **CKYCA/CTMA** or the low-cost **IIBF KYC/AML** certificate for immediate India signal, then target **CAMS** as I accumulate AML work experience for recertifiable, globally-recognised weight."

Q2. A PEP wants to open an account — what happens? "PEPs are inherently higher-risk, so **mandatory EDD**: verify identity and beneficial ownership, establish **source of funds and source of wealth**, screen against sanctions and adverse media, obtain **senior-management approval** to onboard, and set enhanced ongoing monitoring with more frequent review. Being a PEP isn't a reason to refuse — it's a reason to look harder."

Q3. How would you reduce a flood of false positives without missing real risk? "Measure it first — bucket alerts by rule and disposition. Where a rule generates high volume and near-zero true positives, **tune the threshold or add segmentation** (e.g. different limits for cash-intensive vs salaried customers), pilot the change on historical data to confirm no known STRs would have been missed, document it, and get model-governance sign-off. The goal is fewer alerts, same detection."

Learn/practise (free)

- **ACAMS free resources** — Today's AML news, webinars, sample CAMS questions; the **CAMS study guide** table of contents shows the exam scope even before you buy.
- **FATF** 40 Recommendations and typologies reports; **Wolfsberg** FAQs — free and authoritative.
- **FIU-IND** and **RBI KYC Master Direction** — read the actual Indian rules once, end to end.
- **IIBF** AML/KYC exam syllabus — cheap, India-recognised, good structured revision.
- **Rehearse out loud:** record yourself answering each drill above in under 90 seconds, structured (definition → example → what you'd do). Build a personal deck of 10 red-flag scenarios and practise reaching a disposition and narrative for each.